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Hill, Jonathan David

WAKUENAI SOCIETY: A PROCESSUAL-STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS OF INDIGENOUS CULTURAL LIFE IN THE UPPER RIO NEGRO REGION OF VENEZUELA

Indiana University PH.D. 1983

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WAKUENAI SOCIETY: A PROCESSUAL-STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS OF INDIGENOUS CULTURAL LIFE IN THE UPPER RIO NEGRO REGION OF VENEZUELA

SUBMITTED TO
THE FACULTY OF THE GRADUATE SCHOOL
IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS
FOR THE DEGREE OF DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY
IN THE DEPARTMENT OF ANTHROPOLOGY,
INDIANA UNIVERSITY

by
Jonathan David Hill
January, 1983

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Accepted by the faculty of the Graduate School in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy in the Department of Anthropology, Indiana University.

Research Committee:

Dr. Emilio F. Moran, Chairman

Dr. Ivan Karp

Dr. Anthony Seeger

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Acknowledgements

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I am very thankful to the Venezuelan Education Ministry, Division of Indian Affairs, for granting me permission to reside in Wakuénai villages along the lower Guainía. Dra. Nelly Arvelo-Jímenez of the Department of Anthropology, Instituto Venezolano de Investigaciones Científicas (IVIC), taught me a great deal about indigenous affairs in Venezuela as a whole and helped me to bring this wider perspective to bear on my specific research interests in Arawakan societies of the Upper Rio Negro Region. As a Professional in Training in Dra. Arvelo's Laboratory of Ethnology, my work benefited from periodic discussions with Dra. Arvelo and several other anthropologists at IVIC, including Paul Valentine, Erika Wagner, Alberta Zucchi, Dieter Hienen, and Kay Tarble, among others. Rebecca Holmes, a 1980 graduate of the masters program in anthropology at IVIC, was an extremely kind friend and made many significant contributions to my research.

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In addition to the Department of Anthropology at IVIC, the Center of Ecology provided invaluable technical assistance by helping me to transport personal necessities and scientific equipment between Caracas and the field. Dr. Rafael Herrera and Dr. Ernesto Medina, co-directors of the Man and the Biosphere Project No.1 in Tropical Ecology at IVIC and in San Carlos de Rio Negro, have helped me in numerous ways. I can only hope that my research has had, and will continue to have, a positive effect on the increasingly fruitful dialogue and collaboration between ecologists and anthropologists in IVIC and in Venezuela as a whole. I am particularly thankful to Andrea Nemitt, Dr. Howard Clark and his wife, Kate, Carl Jordan, Chris Uhl, and others from IVIC and the Institute of Ecology at the University of Georgia for all their practical help and advice and their general open-mindedness toward anthropological research that by its very nature is not always clearly related to the objectives of the ecological sciences.

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Jose Jorge de Carvalho, Ronny Velasquez, Yolanda de Lecuna, and other members of INIDEF's impressive and growing number of Latin American scholars.

Hernando Camico, his brother, and their families in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán and the Adzanéni village of Punta Bella are the Wakuénai people who most directly contributed to the success of my research. For their protection, I do not use their real names or the actual names of their villages in this dissertation. I am deeply grateful for their warm-hearted willingness to teach me about their culture and to share their way of life with me. I would be delighted to have the opportunity to live and study among them again in the future. The Wakuénai have endured a multitude of outside attacks on their cultural identity and integrity, and yet their way of life prevails as the most sensible and human means of coming to terms with basic problems of existence in the equatorial, riverine environment which they inhabit. This dissertation is dedicated to the humanness and sensibility of the Wakuénai people and their culture and to the future of these qualities in their lives and, hopefully, in our own lives as well.

It is with great sadness that I no longer benefit from the intellectual and personal guidance of Dr. Alan P. Merriam, the late ethnomusicologist and Indiana University professor of anthropology who had served as my principal advisor throughout the three years of my graduate studies that led up to my field research in Venezuela among the Wakuénai. Dr. Merriam's death in 1980 came as a shock to me and also to my Venezuelan colleagues in

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anthropology, ethnomusicology, and folklore. His teaching and personal advice greatly contributed to the development of my research project and would no doubt have been equally valuable in bringing the project to completion.

Professor Emilio Moran deserves special thanks for setting up initial contacts for me with Venezuelan scientists at IVIC and thus providing my first opportunity to actually experience life in the Amazon Basin and in Venezuela as a whole. Professor Moran took the time to read copies of my field notes and sent me comments in the mail, a favor that has paid off in the long run by helping smooth the difficult, yet creative, transition from the fieldwork to the write-up phase of the project.

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Chapter 1:

"Cultural Analysis and Processual Structuralism"

Introduction

The main purpose of this study is to investigate the musical performance system of the Wakuénai[1] as a concrete meta-symbolic code for the interpretation of social behavior. The analysis will demonstrate how the Wakuénai Indians of the Upper Rio Negro in Venezuela use musical performance as a special kind of symbolism, or meta-symbolism, in the transformation of subjective experience into collective, objectified experience and in the organization and integration of categories of collective experience into a flexible yet lasting, cultural model for social behavior. The choice of musical performances as the main subject of the investigation is dictated by both substantive and theoretical considerations.

On the one hand, emphasis on musical performance reflects the great importance that indigenous Amazonian peoples themselves place on music in ceremonial and everyday social life (Goldman 1963; Maybury-Lewis 1967; Murphy and Murphy 1974; Seeger 1981; Wagley 1977, among others). In this sense, the present study forms part of a growing body of ethnographic literature on musical performance in indigenous Amazonian societies (Avery 1977; Bastos 1976; Hill 1979; Seeger 1979). The common denominator of all these studies is

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their intensive focus on musical performances in specific indigenous societies, thus abandoning the assumption that music is an isolable cultural phenomenon that can be understood through extensive surveys of entire regions (Silva 1961a, 1961b; Cameu 1963).

On the other hand, the decision to focus on musical performance is a response to the theoretical interest in the efficacy of symbolic structures (Gell 1975; Munn 1969; Murray 1977; Whitten 1978). While the abstraction of underlying conceptual systems embodied in myths and other varieties of speech communication is an essential part of any cultural analysis, the real challenge for an interpretive anthropology is to investigate the processes through which the application of symbolic structures to individual and collective experience becomes intelligible.

The study of Wakuénai music is, as Seeger (1979:374) has also noted for the study of Suya music, a difficult task that requires a great deal of persistence. What musical performance does for the Wakuénai and how it does so cannot be answered without a basic ability to understand Wakuénai language, the dynamics of local group organization and internal politics, the specialized vocabulary of ritual music, mythology, and cosmology. As if this were not enough, the questions also demand an ability to listen carefully to Wakuénai music and, whenever feasible, to learn how the Wakuénai make music through participation. I do not wish to convey an impression that my level of understanding in these

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various topics is in any way complete, since what I have learned was rather hastily gleaned from about ten months of fieldwork in two Wakuénai villages on the lower Guainía River in Venezuela over a period of almost two years.

The analysis of sacred musical performances of the Wakuénai that forms the core of this dissertation is not based on a exhaustive study of the many diverse performances that make up each genre. Instead, I have concentrated only on a representative sample (Merriam 1964:54-57) that allows me to make a preliminary analysis of sacred musical performance genres, how they fit together, and how they create an interpretive framework within which the application of mythical and cosmological concepts to the experience of individuals, or groups of individuals, makes sense. My analysis of ceremonial musical performances is more limited, since I did not succeed in recording a fully representative sample of one of the two main genres of ceremonial musical performances for practical reasons having to do with access to the field. Nevertheless, I learned enough about these two ceremonial genres to reach a basic understanding of how they are interrelated. A detailed description and analysis of ceremonial musical performances and the festive activities associated with them will not be attempted in this dissertation. In order not to diverge any more than necessary from my central purpose, I will limit myself to demonstrating as briefly as possible how ceremonial performance genres fit into and augment the meta-symbolic framework constructed through sacred

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musical performances.

Fieldwork and the Phenomenon of Strange Loops

Studying the music of a native South American Indian society is a learning process that, to use a favorite analogy of Geertz (1973;1976) , is like the explication of a literary text. Like the reader of a Faulkner novel, the fieldworker follows his subject in an inward spiral of ever-increasing complexity and detail until at last, returning for the Nth time to an initial point of departure, the text becomes intelligible. To use a musical analogy more appropriate to the present study, the fieldworker is like the interpreter of a Bach fugue or a Schubert sonata in which the division of the octave into equal parts serves as the basis for a scheme of modulation. Isomorphic reproductions of the same melody and harmonic accompaniment take the interpreter farther and farther away from the original key until at last, just when disorientation and chaos seem inevitable, the music moves smoothly back into the tonic. Hofstadter (1979:10) calls this musical process "the phenomenon of Strange Loops" and goes on to find parallel processes in Esher's paintings, Godel's theorem, and artificial intelligence.

The study of Wakuénai patrilineal groups and their organization into phratries (see Chapter 2) is a good example of 'Strange Loops' which I encountered in the field. Near the beginning of my fieldwork, I wrote down the names of more than twenty Wakuénai groups. Later, I worked with bilingual speakers of lingua geral and Wáku in order to compare the

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list I had with the one published in lingua geral (Galvão and Oliveira 1973). Still later in the year, I wrote down the story of the patrilineal groups' emergence from the ground in mythical times (cf. Nimuendajú 1950[1927]; Wright 1981). However, I turned up no evidence to support the claim (Galvão and Oliveira 1973:30) that the named patrilineal groups are hierarchically organized into phratries. Finally, on a day not too long before my departure from the field, I decided to read the entire list of totemic names out loud to the Dzáwinai headman of Gavilán, Hernando Camico, to check on the correctness of my spellings and translations. As I pronounced the name Kadáwpúrirri, I heard only silence and began to think that Hernando did not know the meaning of the name. Before going on to the next name, however, I looked up and saw an expression in his eyes that told me to wait for a reply. "That's my family name," he said after a brief pause. I was puzzled by his answer, since for many weeks I had believed his family name to be Dzáwinai (Owners of the Jaguar). It turns out that Dzáwinai is Hernando's phratric name, and that Kadáwpúrirri, the totemic name of his patrilineal group, is the second-ranked group in the Dzáwinai phratry. The only published source on Wakuénai named groups and phratries (Galvão and Oliveira 1973) had omitted mention of a very important bit of information: the phratric name is the name of the highest-ranked group in the phratry and also the most common term of self-reference used in everyday speech by all other groups in the phratry. Along the lower Guainía in

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Venezuela, at least, the use of specific totemic names in reference to local groups is restricted to chants, songs, and prayers performed by shamans and other ritual specialists.

Anthropologists enter the field not only with a load of information about their subjects that is more or less accurate but also with a quantity of intellectual freight. Theory and methodology are to the field anthropologist what harmony and counterpoint are to the interpreter of a musical work: analytical tools that help the interpreter to enter into a closer relationship to the sound and meaning of the subject. The importance of theory and methodology in anthropological fieldwork does not in any way imply that they provide discovery procedures that can be mechanically and objectively applied to diverse social and cultural contexts[2]. Contrary to the assumptions that support the positivist 'myth' of fieldwork, theory and methodology in cultural anthropology do not constitute a set of universal, culture-free yardsticks for studying meaningful or causal relationships. Theory and methodology are important primarily because they influence the shape and substance of intersubjective relations between the fieldworker and the people whose culture he or she has chosen to study. The theory and methodology that the fieldworker brings to his study is implicitly revealed to his hosts through the kind of questions he asks and his other activities. In return, the kinds of answers that the hosts give to a fieldworker reveal an underlying sense of their attitudes about the fieldworker and the

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kinds of questioning and other activities that the fieldwork sets in motion. Thus, although total objectivity is a false, even unethical, goal for anthropological fieldwork, the alternative is not an unbridled subjectivity in the style of Castaneda (1968, 1971) but "a mature dialogical anthropology that establishes a world of discourse or dialogue between the observer and the observed (these terms observer and observed are no longer quite appropriate)"(Rose in press), a self-monitored process of intersubjective relatedness (see Karp and Kendall 1980).

Theory and Methodology

Theory and methodology also play an important role in the communication of new knowledge within an academic community of scientists by placing it in the context of current and historical trends in the development of anthropology and related disciplines such as linguistics, folklore, and sociology. This dissertation addresses the theoretical problem of the efficacy of symbolic structures through combining processual and structural methods of analysis into a single approach to cultural communication which I call 'processual structuralism'.

Through processual analysis, I will explore individual musical performances as temporal series of events that have a number of contextual dimensions: cosmological, mythological, musical, linguistic, social, and in some cases, ecological. The goal here is to examine the hypothesis that musical performances, seen as isolated events, play a pivotal role in

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imbuing individual and/or collective experience with a related set of cultural meanings.

Through comparative structural analysis of a number of different musical performances, I will analyze relations among musical patterns in conjunction with relationships among various contextual dimensions of musical events seen as performative processes. The immediate goal is to search for meta-symbolic devices in music that operate on a number of differentiated structural levels in the performance system as a whole. Central to this endeavor is the idea of music as a code that can be understood on more than one level: as performances of music and as performances about performances of music. This coding trick is possible only if patterns of musical sound and meaning can be made to stand for musical performances seen as complex processes that operate in a number of contextual dimensions. The ultimate goal of processual structuralist analysis is to demonstrate how meta-symbolic devices in music, once identified, function together as a concrete meta-symbolic code for the interpretation of social behavior by providing a conceptual framework within which the application of cultural meanings to individual and collective experience can be understood.

In the broadest historical sense, the method of processual structuralism which I employ in my analysis of Wakuénai musical performances forms part of a tradition of skeptical philosophy dating back to Montesquieu in the 18th Century and to Herder and Kant in the late 18th Century. Skeptical

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philosophy rejects the positivist notion that the observer is in the first place an outsider who imposes his own order on the subject in order to arrive at objectively deduced statements of causation. The anthropologist as skeptic looks primarily to the ways in which people create relative truths through their interactions and only on this basis seeks to generalize about meaningful or causal relations.

The most well-known proponents of a skeptical philosophical outlook in modern anthropology were Malinowski, Boas, and students of theirs such as Gluckman and Kroeber. Boas was perhaps the more faithful to a skeptical perspective and never indulged in the kinds of over-generalization and determinism to which Malinowski resorted in his Scientific Theory of Culture (1944). In spite of a weakness for biological determinism in his theoretical writings, Malinowski's writings on Trobriand myths (1926, 1935) are recognized by recent theorists of oral narrative (Ben-Amos and Goldstein 1975) as the original attempt to study cultural texts in terms of their social, situational meanings. Malinowski's contribution to social and linguistic theory is all the more remarkable in view of its contemporaneity and competition with structural linguistics (Saussure 1966 [1915]). In fact, Malinowski's situational analysis of myth influenced theoretical developments in the philosophy of language almost as much as in social anthropology insofar as Wittgenstein and other contemporaries drew support for a theory of language use (parole) from Malinowski's studies of Trobriand myths

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(Rose 1980). Malinowski's writings on Trobriand myths, the baloma spirits of the dead (1916), tribal law (1926), and the kula ring (1922) have largely endured several decades of anthropological scrutiny and are still among the finest examples of empirically-oriented, inductive ethnography[3].

In social anthropology, Gluckman (1940), V. Turner (1957,1967), van Velsen (1967), and other members of the Manchester school made extensive use of situational analysis in African and South Asian societies. Turner emerges as a pivotal figure in the transformation of situational analysis into processual analysis , as this term is currently understood in the social sciences (see below, pp.11-12). His works on Ritual Process (1969) and dramaturgical analysis (1974) illustrate the transition taking place in the late 1960s and early 1970s. On the one hand, Turner's analyses of ritual process and social drama, in spite of their strongly actor-oriented approach, maintain at least some sense of the basic assumptions of earlier situational analyses (van Velsen 1967) that social structure is a given framework within which actors make alternative decisions and that behavior which does not fit into this framework creates a divergence between norm and reality. On the other hand, Turner's transitional works of the late 1960s and early 1970s also border on the current use of processual analysis as a way of approaching the dynamic character of cultural performance and its emergent properties.

Meanwhile, ethnomethodologists such as Garfinkel (1967)

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and R. Turner (1974) were opening the way for a more rigorously interactionist approach to situational analysis by expanding Austin's (1962) theory of performative speech to include all social exchanges of speech utterances. This development concurred with sociological studies of everyday social interaction as performative processes (Goffman 1958, 1974; Berger and Luckman 1967) as well as a new interest in ordinary language as an interpretive medium (Labov 1966; Labov and Waletzky 1967; Hymes and Gumperz 1972; Fillmore 1974). A parallel interest in the social usage of speech varieties has guided anthropological linguists specializing in the ethnography of speaking (Hymes 1962; Bauman and Sherzer 1974), folklorists studying verbal art forms (Abrahams 1968; Bauman 1975a, 1975b), and scholars of literature searching for a theory of literary discourse based on a theory of everyday speech acts (Grice 1967; Ohmann 1971; Pratt 1977)[4].

Ethnomusicologists have also demonstrated an interest in extending the concept of performative speech varieties to musical forms and genres (Herndon 1971; Herndon and Brunyate 1975; Seeger 1976). These studies emphasize the importance of speech act or performative speech theory for the study of musical performances in terms of interpretation, creativity, and the interplay between tradition and the emergence of new forms.

Processual Structuralism

The concept of culture as an interaction among processes

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of structuration has great potential for explaining the ambiguities and complexities of social behavior because it can demonstrate how these phenomena arise from contradictions among conflicting processes of structuration that all operate as a single system rather than a divergence between ideal and real behaviors. My use of the terms `system' and `sub-system' in reference to Wakuénai musical performances is intended to denote relatively determinate ways of ordering that give structure and meaning to the continuous flow of individual and collective experience. The processes of structuration in Wakuénai musical performances do not operate simply through symbolically representing social rules that create order in everyday situations but by intentionally using opposition, paradox, and ambiguity to construct a symbolic space that lies outside the sphere of everyday social life.

Although processual structuralism is new in the sense that its application to specific cultures is still in the early stages, its importance as a theoretical orientation in anthropology was already recognized by Levi-Strauss when he showed how totemism could be understood as a specific case of a general problem, "viz., how to make opposition, instead of being an obstacle to integration, serve rather to produce it"(1963b: 89). In essence, the methodology of processual structuralism as a means for studying musical performances is clearly outlined in Blacking's discussion of cultural analysis:

> ". . . melodic patterns became intelligible on-

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> ly in the context of other patterns of sound in Venda culture, and the relationships between situations in which the music is performed and between the status of performers"(1971: 93).

Blacking's method of cultural analysis is based on a structuralist interpretation of the primacy of interrelational meaning (Levi-Strauss 1963a: 210) but applies this concept with equal rigor to both social-situational contexts of musical performance and the musical context of `other patterns of sound' in the culture under analysis. His method is also processual insofar as it concerns how music becomes intelligible rather than the intelligibility, meaning, or structure of music seen as a static entity.

Blacking's method of cultural analysis closely approximates the methodology upon which my analysis of the Wakuénai musical performance system is based. However, it lacks a clear definition of structural levels at which interrelations operate in the construction of a coherent performance system that can integrate a number of communicative orders into a meta-symbolic code for social behavior[5]. T. Turner's definition of a structural level as "a type of relationship between categories generated by a specific type of operation"(1977: 57) provides a way of refining my earlier statement that levels of a performance system come about through the coding device of making patterns of musical sound and meaning stand for other performances. At the lowest level, individual musical performances represent distinct

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patterns of relations, groups, and categories. At intermediate levels, individual musical performances are grouped into categories or genres through classificatory operations, such as binary opposition, or transformational operations, such as inversion or reversal. At the highest level, the various genres of musical performance are themselves organized into a culturally prescribed pattern of correlation among transformations through a series of coordinating operations, such as the juxtaposition of binary oppositions or other operations that are separately represented at lower levels of the performance system. A processual structuralism approaches the study of symbolic structures as processes of structuration which can conflict with or even negate one another at lower or intermediate levels of the performance system and yet use such contradiction and opposition as the basis for integration at higher levels.

The attempt to compare lowland South American Indian societies on the basis of musical performance systems seen as complex sets of interacting processes of structuration that have a number of contextual dimensions and that operate at a number of hierarchical levels can provide a firmer basis for generalization than an approach that singles out any particular cultural or social domain as the exclusive focus of analysis. Levi-Strauss's keen ability for discerning binary oppositions in South American Indian myths (1964) demonstrates that oppositional processes and their transformations and juxtapositions operate at least in the

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mythology of many South American Indian societies. However, the work is not written in a form acceptable to most anthropologists, and Levi-Strauss compounds the difficulty of anyone who wants to understand his endeavor by claiming that

> ". . . it is in the last resort immaterial whether in this book the thought processes of South American Indians take shape through the medium of my thought, or whether mine take place through the medium of theirs"(1969: 13).

Such a radical break from the traditional distinction between observer and observed is unacceptable because it leaves open the possibility of a dissolution of the ethnographic process into a completely subjective phenomenon which other scientists are incapable of even approximately duplicating or verifying. The main problem here is Levi-Strauss's over-emphasis on mental processes that are manifested only in mythical texts from a variety of native American societies and some very interesting asides on West European classical and folk culture. There is little or no sense of myth as a behavioral process, as performance, or as "a hard-working, extremely important cultural force"(Malinowski 1926:97). The same intellectualism is evident in Levi-Strauss's view that mythology forms a mediating category between "two diametrically opposed types of sign systems -- musical language on the one hand and articulate speech on the other"(1969: 27). Nowhere in The Raw and the Cooked or the other three volumes of the Mythologiques (1966, 1968, 1971) does Levi-Strauss

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directly deal with either `musical language' or `articulate speech' among native American societies, so his attempt to assign mythology a mediating function between the two sign systems makes little sense except in terms of his own interests, which obviously center around mythology.

However, my criticism of Levi-Strauss's overly mentalist approach to the study of myth is not intended as a denial of his basic premise that empirical categories such as the raw and the cooked, or the fresh and the decayed, can serve as a means for the elaboration and combination of abstract ideas in the form of logical propositions (1969:1)[6]. That myth, ritual language, chant, and song make use of empirical categories in the formation of logical propositions is hardly irreconcilable with the pragmatic, illocutionary force that they bring to bear on peoples' beliefs. Although Malinowski emphasized the importance of performative force in myth and ritual language, he did not say that they had no intellectual function:

> "The deep philosophic query propounded by Faust, as to the primacy of the word or the deed, appears to us fallacious. The beginning of man is the beginning of articulate thought and of thought put into action"(Malinowski 1926:147).

In more recent years, critics of structuralism and other theories of myth have unfortunately exaggerated Malinowski's tendency to see the strengthening of social tradition as the

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primary function of myth and to correspondingly reduce or deny its cognitive functions. Thus, Fontenrose cites "Malinowski's conclusion (1926:35-59) that myth has a justifying or validating rather than explanatory function" to support his own view that "myths have social power in inverse ratio to the amount of intellectual curiosity present in a society" (1966: 57). In the same manner, but for different reasons, Bloch sets out to strip myth and all other varieties of formalized language of their capacity to carry logical, propositional meanings:

> ". . . formalized language rules out the two prerequisites of logic, the potential of one statement to be followed by a large number of others and the possibility of contradiction" (1974: 66).

Bloch claims that the formal languages of myth, music, and ritual are totally fixed and rigid prescriptions for action that abandon the power of logical, propositional meaning at the same time as they take on greater performative force. "What I am arguing is that with increasing formalisation propositional force decreases, and illocutionary force increases, in other words that the two types of meaning vary inversely" (Bloch 1974: 67). This hypothesis makes the highly deterministic assumption that cultural symbols are only a reflection of the rules that govern everyday social behavior. For if the formalized languages of myth, music, and ritual are nothing more than the attachment of performative force to

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the rules that support relations of traditional authority in a society, then they truly have abandoned, as Bloch claims, the capacity for contradiction based on logical meaning.

The idea that performative force and the capacity to carry logical, propositional meanings are inversely related is a sweeping generalization that harks back to Durkheim's view (1954) that collective representations are nothing more than transformations of everyday social rules into sacred ones that appear powerful and external to the individual. Rather than assume that the logic of myth, musical performance, and ritual behavior is simply a restricted code for everyday social norms, I view the interrelations between performative force and logical, propositional meaning as problematic and prefer to give equal attention to both. Rappaport (1979: 206) takes a similar approach to the study of ritual communication by insisting that 'performative' and 'liturgical' meanings both play important roles in the efficacy of symbolic structures and that the two types of meaning intimately condition one another.

The power of logical, propositional meaning in ritual communication does not derive simply from the fact that it is combined with performative force but is also dependent on the capacity to use logical propositions to comment on other logical propositions (or even on the same proposition) and the ways in which such propositions make sense. In other words, ritual communication both imbues experience with meaning and says something about the meaning of that meaning.

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Ritual communication is meta-communicative insofar as it brings into play performative force on more than one structural level and can comment on and influence not only the system of everyday social rules but also the way it is itself organized into logical, flexible, yet stable framework within which the application of cultural meanings to individual and collective experience makes sense. This coding process is as important as the performative force that underlies all human ritual communication.

Bloch's characterization of ritual uses of language, music, and dance as rigid prescriptions that lack creativity and that reinforce traditional authority implies that such manifestations of expressive culture must necessarily disappear when the social group that believes in their efficacy undergoes irreversible and profound social changes. The present study of the Wakuénai musical performance system contrasts with Bloch's view of culture as a static amalgamation of beliefs and practices. In fact, the outline of a processual structuralist method of cultural analysis in this chapter is useful not only for synchronic analyses of metasymbolism but can also serve to identify historical processes in which culture orders events and is in turn reordered through participation in historical processes. Applied along these lines, processual structuralism might be called historical structuralism, and its theoretical focus would center around the question, "How does the reproduction of a structure become its transformation?" (Sahlins 1981: 8). The

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view of culture as a set of rigid prescriptions for action that leaves no room for individual creativity through manipulation of logical propositions fails to explain the capacity of cultural models to transpose processes of categorization, transformation, and coordination to many different domains, including new classes of situations that arise in the historical development of interethnic contact. A static model of culture has even less value for showing how a transposition of traditional cultural processes of structuration can over time lead to a transformation of the indigenous cultural model.

Brief Outline of Dissertation

Prior to embarking upon an analysis of Wakuénai musical performances, I will briefly focus on social organization and cultural ecology as ways of introducing rules and axioms that create order in everyday social life and the basic pattern of subsistence activities among the Wakuénai. Even the most sacred musical performances are to some degree rooted in the secular realities of everyday life. The level of musico-religious specialization in Wakuénai society, although quite high by the standards of Amazonian societies, does not allow even the most exceptional and talented individuals to escape certain basic social duties and the daily routine of subsistence activities common to the whole society.

The Wakuénai social order of phratries and sibs is a unique variant of a type of organization that is widespread throughout the Northwest Amazon region (see Goldman 1963;

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Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971; Hugh-Jones 1979). My analysis of traditional Wakuénai social organization is largely a reconstruction based on informants' statements and myths, since Wakuénai society has been greatly transformed through a long history of contacts with other indigenous societies and non-indigenous peoples who have entered the region. However, myths that explain the origin of Wakuénai society are not idle tales referring only to past beliefs and customs but keys to understanding the basic assumptions and rules of everyday social life (see Chapter 2). When conflicts erupt in Wakuénai villages, they most often unfold along exactly the same social lines of fission that are the focus of conflicts in myths between the trickster- creator and his enemies. These myths, and the social processes and institutions which they implicitly explain, are essential elements making up

> ". . . whatever it is one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its a society's members, and do so in any role that they accept for any one of themselves" (Goodenough 1964 [1957] :36).

This basic social ideology is well-known to all members of Wakuénai society, including women and children as well as adult men, and is therefore a logical starting point for the analysis of more restricted forms of ritual and ceremonial knowledge.

Like other indigenous societies of the Northwest Amazon region, the Wakuénai are essentially riverine in their

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ecological orientation. Rivers are important to the Wakuénai as the habitat of fish and aquatic animals, their main source of animal protein. Villages are invariably situated on the banks of one of the region's major rivers (the Isana and the Guainía) or their tributaries. The riverine orientation of Wakuénai society is clearly reflected not only in daily subsistence activities and settlement patterns but also in the demarcation of territories belonging to each phratry and in the religious cosmology underlying sacred and ceremonial musical performances. Nevertheless, fishing activities and the riverine orientation which they entail are not more important for the Wakuénai than swidden agricultural activities and the linkage between social groups and ancestral lands. Both agricultural and fishing activities are equally valued, whether in belief or in practice, and the balance between these two types of activity becomes an object of symbolic thought and performance in pudáli exchange ceremonies (see Chapters 3 and 9). The combined emphasis on fishing and agriculture in Wakuénai ecology is shared also among the Baniwa, Guarequena, Puinave, and other Northern Arawak-speaking societies, but is not shared by Tukano-speaking societies in which agriculture is considered inferior to hunting and fishing (Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971:220-ff).

Wakuénai religious cosmology is largely encoded in the cycle of myths about the primordial human mother and son, Amáru and Kuwái (or Jurupari in lingua geral). In From Honey to Ashes, Levi-Strauss (1973:272) cites the extreme complex-

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ity and artificiality of the Juruparí myths as a basis for setting them apart in a special genre, distinct from the relatively homogeneous 'popular tales' upon which he rests his analyses in the Mythologiques. The special status which Levi-Strauss gives to the Kuwái (or Juruparí) myths is in strict accordance with indigenous Wakuénai beliefs and practices. The Kuwái myth cycle is more socially restricted than the myths about the distant past, and it contains a richer variety of sexual and religious symbolism. For the present thesis, the Kuwái myth cycle serves as an introduction to Wakuénai beliefs in the creative, transformative, and restorative powers of musical sounds in the life cycle of individuals and, at the same time, in the musical 'cooking' (or classifying) of the natural world of social animals into a sacred, cultural order (see Chapter 4).

Musical performances at childbirth and initiation rituals apply the conceptual principles encoded in the Kuwái myth cycle to the life experiences of individuals and groups in Wakuénai society. Through a complex process of symbolic equations, the music of Kuwái (málikai) is made to stand directly for the personal, cultural identity of newborn infants or initiants, depending on the ritual context. The full meaning of the process becomes intelligible only when three distinct classes of phenomena are simultaneously comprehended:

1) the song or chant texts in which the ritual participant is equated with the mythical

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character of Kuwái;

2) the mythical episodes in which Kuwái's singing and humming are equated with the growth of the entire natural world to its present size and its filling with various species of animals, fish, birds, and plants; and
3) the structuring of musical sounds in ritual performances in which such dimensions as tonal movement, intensity, rhythm, and tempo act as models of both Kuwái and the ritual participant(s).

The first two equations are explicitly made by the Wakuénai themselves, whereas the third equation takes the emic explanation of ritual performances one step further by completing the third leg of a triangle of symbolic equations (see Figure 1.1). If A=B and B=C, then it follows that A=C. In Chapters 5 and 6 , much of the musicological analysis focuses upon this third, implicit symbolic equation between the structuring of musical sounds in málikai chants and the personal, cultural identities of ritual participants who are undergoing transitions in the life cycle.

Curing music of Wakuénai chant-owners (málikai limínali) and shamans (malírri) begins with the assumption that the sick individual (i.e., the victim or sorcery and/or witchcraft) has experienced a breakdown of the orderly processes of growth and development symbolized in musical performances at childbirth and initiation. The Wakuénai have well-

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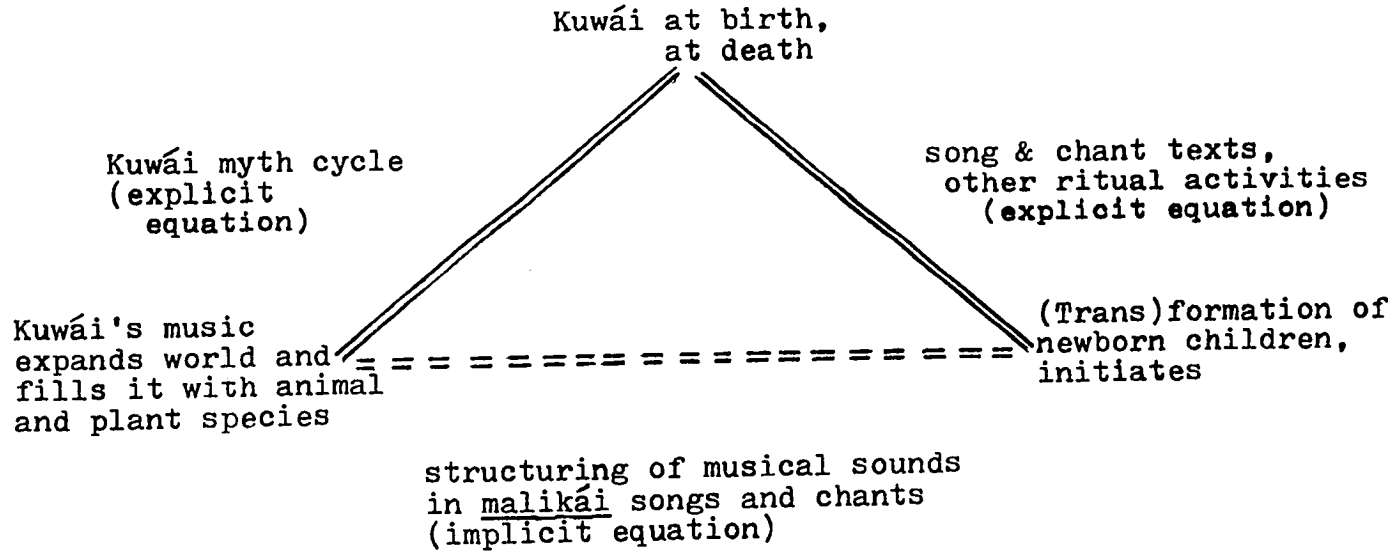


Figure 1.1. Triangular set of symbolic equations in which 2 sides are explicit and 3rd implicit.

developed concepts of the conscious and unconscious self, or soul, and the two genres of curing music aim at reliving the spiritual journeys of each part of the soul in sickness and after death. A detailed analysis of these two genres of curing songs and the complex web of mythical beliefs, myth texts, and cultural concepts which they bring into play forms the subject of Chapter 7.

In my analysis of Wakuénai sacred musical performances as a whole, the structuralist method of seeking systematic interrelations between empirical categories is not abandoned but transposed to an investigation of interrelations among empirical processes that act as models for the structuring of experience(see Chapter 8). At the lowest structural level, specific empirical processes are used to elaborate and apply conceptual principles that are implicit in myths. At an intermediate level, these performances fall into two opposing categories, or genres: musical "cooking" in childbirth and initiation rituals on the one hand and musical "rotting" in curing rituals on the other. My analysis supports Levi-Strauss's tentative definition of the social meaning of the cooking metaphor in "The Wedding", the last chapter of The Raw and the Cooked (1969 [1964]). ". . .the individuals who are "cooked" are those deeply involved in a physiological process: the newborn child, the woman who has just given birth, or the pubescent girl"(1969 [1964] :336). Symbolic "cooking" is a transformation of `raw', physiological or other natural processes into cultural processes of ordering

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and classifying. On the other hand, an opposite process of musical disintegration, or "rotting", is invoked in Wakuénai curing rituals whenever there has been a breakdown of orderly processes of growth and development. In Wakuénai society, sorcery and/or witchcraft are cultural means by which the connection between collective and individual parts of the human soul are partially or totally severed. Performances of musical "rotting" in curing rituals are a means of transforming cultural processes of sorcery, witchcraft, and related phenomena such as evil omens (hínimai) into natural processes of disintegration, honey production, and physiological recovery.

At the highest structural level, the opposition between performative categories of musical "cooking" and musical "rotting" is coordinated through an analogy between parallel musical processes (see Chapter 8). These musical transformations encompass a broad range of different parameters: tempo, pitch, volume, instrumentation, number of voices, and continuity. The analysis supports Levi-Strauss's view in From Honey to Ashes (1973 [1966]:25) that there is a whole domain of symbolism beyond cooking and rotting. Levi-Strauss looks for this `meta-culinary' system in myths of the origin of honey, tobacco, and associated cultural artifacts. However, the Wakuénai do not have a single, integrated myth text explaining how the processes of musical cooking and rotting converge at a higher level. In Wakuénai social life, musical performances and not myths act as the primary means for com-

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municating this higher level of structural unity.

Levi-Strauss's assertion that tobacco is the central theme around which the system of meta-culinary mythology revolves applies with equal accuracy to the system of Wakuénai sacred musical performances. The ritual blowing of tobacco smoke and musical naming of tobacco spirits are central features of all Wakuénai sacred musical performances. Blowing tobacco smoke in rituals is a cultural process of burning that brings the power of ancestral tobacco spirits to bear on living descendants in this world. In childbirth rituals, newborn infants are `given' the power of tobacco spirits, in initiation rituals this power of tobacco spirits is transformed, and in curing rituals it is restored to patients and employed in the fight against sickness.

Wakuénai sacred musical performances construct an hierarchical symbolic system, or science of the concrete, that elaborates and applies conceptual principles from a complex and diverse mythology. In order to generalize about the importance of myth in Wakuénai social life and ritual activities, it is important to stand back and take an overall view of Wakuénai myth and the distinct, yet interrelated, symbolic space-times which they describe. Wakuénai myths establish three basic space-times: 1)the distant, miniature world of Iñápirríkuli's creation, 2) the recent, life-sized world of Amáru and Kuwái, and 3) the reversible space-time of bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai) and recently- deceased persons (lidánam). The first creation was only a partially completed

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world in which male/female and human/animal distinctions were not yet present. There was no love, either sexual or emotional, since the social animals were pre-sexual and pre-human creatures capable of thinking only in terms of their survival. Nevertheless, social institutions and rules such as the phratry and patrilocal residence emerged in the distant space-time of Iñápirríkuli's creation.

The conception and birth of Kuwái marks the beginning of a more recent space-time in which the miniature world of the distant past grows to its present size. Amáru and Kuwái, the primordial mother and son, introduce human physiological processes of conception and birth and all the ensuing processes of growth, development, sexuality, and aging that form the basis of cultural differentiation in human society. The transition from social, thinking animals to human individuals capable of symbolizing as well as thinking centers around the physiological processes of the human body (see Drummond 1981). Human bodily processes, and natural processes in general, actually leave no viable alternative but the transition from social thought to cultural differentiation, transformation, and coordination. The Kuwái myth cycle demonstrates this dilemma in frighteningly clear terms: either use human bodily processes as a way of `taming' the social animal or allow the latter to be destroyed and devoured by these same processes.

Control over physiological processes through symbolization in myth and sacred music requires an adequate means for

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conceptualizing and communicating processes of change, re-ordering, and transformation. The Kuwái myth cycle provides a model for communicating these processes in the combined forces of Kuwái's musical humming and singing (i.e., málikai chants and songs in rites of passage) and cooking fire. These two forces join together to make musical "cooking", an ongoing process of musically re-creating `raw', uncontrolled life processes, putting them into a culturally prescribed order, and transforming them at puberty.

The third mythical space-time is a period of reversible disintegration, or "rotting", which human individuals experience in sickness. The myths of the origin of evil omens and the origin of honey for curing provide important insights into how the Wakuénai conceive of this reversible space-time. However, it is in musical performances in curing rituals that the mythical concept of reversibility is actually employed. Chant-owners undertake mythical journeys to the village of bee-spirits in their curing songs and, in doing so, enter a reversible space-time in which otherwise irreversible processes of alienation, rotting, and death can be symbolically counteracted. Shamans construct a reversible bridge across their patients' disintegration through repeated vomitting, a reversal of the "eating poisoned food -> bodily decay" process, and through going on mythical journeys to íyarudáti, the home of recently-deceased persons (lidánam).

Senior men who `own', or control, sacred musical performances are also leaders of secular activities in Wakuénai

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society. The correlation between sacred and secular power speaks to the importance of myth in Wakuénai society. In the relatively traditional village of Gavilán on the lower Guainía river in Venezuela, the collective identity of the village converges in the person of Hernando Camico, the headman and also an owner of sacred chants. The social influence of this headman is largely, but not entirely, due to acceptance of his superior intellectual and musical abilities. The level of intellectual curiosity in Wakuénai society is quite high, and this cultural attitude directly correlates with the social power of myths as embodied in village leaders (cf. Bloch 1974; Fontenrose 1966). Villages such as Gavilán represent vestiges of what in pre-Columbian times was most probably a genuine Amazonian civilization led by "schools of sages and learned men"(Levi-Strauss 1973 [1966] :272). Leadership in Wakuénai society was traditionally granted, and in some villages still is, to those senior men who had(have) acquired a thorough knowledge of mythology and who have demonstrated their abilities to interpret, teach, and apply this knowledge in sacred musical performances that benefit both the collective order of the village and its constituent individual identities.

The Wakuénai have two genres of ceremonial dance-music that correspond to the two types of food exchange ceremony known as <u>pudáli</u> and <u>kwépani</u> (dance of Kuwái). The dance-music of <u>pudáli</u>, called <u>mádzerunái</u>, outlines a discontinuous process of breaking down the collective opposition between

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hosts and guests (or kin and affine). The process is parallel to the musical journeys of shamans in curing rituals, only in pudáli ceremonies it operates on a collective scale. An opposite process of continuous (ex-)change operates in kwépani ceremonies and the corresponding genre of dance-music known as líaka. Although kwépani ceremonies superficially resemble initiation rituals due to the use of whips in both contexts, the ceremonial process is actually focused upon symbolization of bodily processes of conception, birth, and childhood growth as models for continuous processes of change. The opposition between dance-music of pudáli and kwépani ceremonies, however, does not proceed without resolution at a higher structural level. This coordinating process takes the concrete form of the natural process of metamorphosis as embodied in the miraculous transformation of white ceje-palm grubs (mútsi) into black, adult déetu bugs (see Chapter 9).

A secondary purpose of this study is to relate the analysis of processes of structuration that operate within Wakuénai society through the musical performance system to historical processes of interethnic contact with other indigenous groups of the Northwest Amazon region and with non-indigenous peoples who have entered the region. I will focus specifically upon cultural processes of categorization which the Wakuénai have developed and expanded to account for new technological and environmental phenomena but without disrupting the continuity of categorization as a mode of interpretation and ritual action (see Chapter 10). Musical per-

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formances act as a lens for viewing historical change within a traditional interpretive framework and help the Wakuénai to maintain a sense of control over the direction of externally-induced processes of change. The notion of autonomy through control over indigenously-defined sources of power is immensely important for the cultural survival of the Wakuénai. At the same time as cultural categorization provides a degree of continuity and stability, it has also brought about a transformation of the Wakuénai musical performance system insofar as the repeated application of traditional categories in new situations and in novel ways eventually changes the traditional system. Here I will focus on the participation of non-Wakuénai (Baniwa and Guarequena) individuals and groups in Wakuénai musical performances at childbirth, in curing rites, and in collective ceremonies as a transformation of the traditional performance system into the conceptual and interactional medium for the emergence of a pan-Arawakan, cultural entity in the Venezuelan Amazon.

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1. The terms Baniwa and Curripaco have been used to refer to the Wakuénai. Nimuendajú registered his suspicion that "Baniwa" was an outside term of reference for the Wakuénai rather than an indigenous term of self-reference when he wrote of the "so-called Baniwa of the Isana River" (Os chamados Baniwa deste ultimo rio)(1950[1927]: 164). The Wakuénai of the Isana and its tributaries in Brazil could accept the name "Baniwa" without causing any great confusion since the real Baniwa lived across two international borders in Venezuela. In the lower Guainía region today, Wakuénai and Baniwa live in neighboring villages, and the distinction between them is made for the social reason that the Wakuénai are considered to be immigrants whereas the Baniwa are not. In Chapter 2 I deal with this terminological problem in greater detail.
2. Karp and Kendall (1981) discuss the origins of the fallacy of mechanical discovery procedures in anthropological fieldwork and also some of the negative consequences that the fallacy can have for those who believe in it.
3. Malinowski's Trobriand ethnographies have survived relatively well in comparison with Radcliffe-Brown's study (1933) of the Andaman Islanders, a work that is rarely discussed in anthropology today. In fact, if Needham's sharp criticisms (1971) are admitted, there

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is virtually nothing original and of lasting importance in the entire bibliography of Radcliffe-Brown, in spite of its enormous impact on anthropology and related disciplines.

4. Rose (in press) has written a social and intellectual history of event analysis in anthropology, sociology, and a number of related disciplines. The description covers both American and English branches of event analysis and includes a useful survey of all the diverse terminology that researchers in various fields have developed for the analysis of events and processes. Rose completes his history with a valuable critique of recent efforts to construct a scientific theory (paradigm) solely on the basis of event analysis.

5. Blacking made use of a Chomskian 'deep and surface' structural model in his analysis of Venda songs and was not entirely successful in combining it with a situational method of analysis. Chomsky's linguistic models, from the point of view of an ethnographer of musical performance, are far less useful than either Levi-Straussian structuralism or the post-Levi-Straussian structuralism of Beidelman (1981) or T. Turner (1977). Chomsky's concepts of deep and surface structures in language are overly concerned with an ideal of linguistic competence and have almost no real bearing on actual performances and uses of language in social

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life.

6. Although I set out in my fieldwork and dissertation with a strongly critical view of Levi-Strauss's structuralism as it has developed in the Mythologiques, the processes of fieldwork and writing have empirically convinced me of the veracity of Levi-Strauss's basic assumptions and conclusions. I still find his method of myth analysis to be opaque and largely unfathomable, but his focus upon the empirical categories of raw, cooked, and rotten (1964) and honey and tobacco (1966) turned out to be of equal importance for the analysis of Wakuénai musical performances (see Chapters 5-8). In anticipation of charges that my analysis of Wakuénai musical performances is too heavily Levi-Straussian in its conclusions, I point out that it is the Wakuénai themselves who conscientiously practice musical 'cooking' of newborn infants, their parents, and young men and women undergoing initiation rituals.

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Chapter 2:

"Wakuénai Ethnography"

Introduction

The Wakuénai are an Arawak-speaking group of the Northwest Amazon region whose native territory encompasses the lands along the Isana and Guainía Rivers and their tributaries. They include speakers of five distinct, yet mutually intelligible, dialects of the language called Wáku: Curripaco, Curricarro, Oh-hon, Eh-hen, and Náme. The name Wakuénai comes from the term Wáku (lit., "we speak") and -énai, a suffix derived from the word náiki (patrilineal group or sib). All five dialects of Waku are spoken along the Guainía River in Venezuela, but the Curripaco dialect is the most common in the region. Partly for this reason, all Wakuénai villages of the region are referred to by non-Wakuénai as Curripaco. Another reason is that Sophia Muller, an American Protestant missionary, has published a translation of the New Testament in Curripaco (1976), and native speakers of all five dialects are learning to read in the Curripaco dialect.

A cluster of Northern Arawakan (Key 1979), or Maipuran (Lathrap 1970), societies today centers around the Upper Rio Negro, the Casiquiare, and several rivers draining into the Orinoco above the Ature Rapids. At the time of earliest contact with Europeans, this family of languages extended from

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the Manao Indians in the Central Amazon floodplains near the mouth of the Rio Negro all the way to the Achagua and Maipure peoples along the Guaviare and middle Orinoco rivers. On the basis of linguistic and archeological data, Lathrap (1970:72-76) hypothesizes that Maipuran-speaking Arawakan groups migrated out of ancestral lands on the Central Amazon floodplain between 1000 and 500 BC in search of agricultural lands. They continued on through the Casiquiare to settle on more fertile lands along the Orinoco. According to this view, the Arawakan groups of the Upper Rio Negro region today are descended from this ancient migratory wave of Maipuran-speakers who settled in areas of restricted alluvial lands located between more fertile floodplains to the north and to the southeast.

Wakuénai living across the border in Brazil along the Isana and its tributaries have come to be known as the "Baniwa". To the Wakuénai of Venezuela, the Baniwa are a neighboring people who speak an unintelligible language and who live in Maroa and three small villages on the Lower Guainía. The Wakuénai of Venezuela, many of whom have traveled along the Isana in Brazil to visit relatives or are themselves immigrants from that area, vigorously deny the existence of any Baniwa kinsmen in Brazil. After much questioning on this subject, I finally learned that "Baniwa" is the generic term for all the Wakuénai among speakers of Yeral, or lingua geral, the old trade language of Jesuit missionaries spoken throughout the Northwest Amazon region. In a recent disserta-

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tion on the ethnohistory of the Wakuénai living in Brazil, Wright (1981) shows that for over two centuries the Isana has been called "the River of the Baniwas". The fact that anthropologists (Koch-Gruenberg 1909; Nimuendajú 1950[1927]; Galvão 1959; Galvão and Oliveira 1973; Oliveira 1975; Wright 1981) have consistently written about the Wakuénai living in Brazil as "Baniwa" indicates that the Wakuénai in Brazil have probably come to accept this name as their own. Galvão and Oliveira were aware that "These clans, originally named in Arawakan language, were renamed in "lingua geral"" (1973: 35). However, the authors did not extend this line of reasoning to question whether or not the term "Baniwa" did not also form part of the renaming process from Arawakan dialects to Yeral. Both Nimuendajú (1950 1927 : 164) and Wright (1981: 5) indicate an awareness that the term "Baniwa" is a cover term used by outsiders. My work among the Wakuénai of Venezuela both justifies their suspicion that "Baniwa" is an outside term and identifies the Yeral-speakers' process of renaming Arawakan groups as the source of terminological confusion.

The Wakuénai are sub-divided into twenty or more exogamous, patrilineal groups (náiki), each one named after an animal, bird, or fish species that represents the group's collective ancestral spirit (líwarúna). Iñápirríkuli, the mythical creator and transformer of the world, is believed to have created all the náiki by pulling the totemic ancestors out of a hole in the earth near Hípana, a village on the Rio

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Aiarí in Brazil[1]. The mythical creator lifted out four or five fraternal spirits at a time, naming each one, assigning it a rank in relation to the other brothers, and giving male and female Tobacco Spirits to each. The descendants of these groups of totemic ancestors have become phratries of four or five patrilineal sibs that are hierarchically ranked. The Wakuénai totemic system of exogamous phratries and sibs is better understood along the lower Guainía in Venezuela today as a naming system that is organized according to certain rules of style and usage than as a kinship system composed of lineages and segments. Accordingly, I will begin with an examination of the naming system currently in use among the Wakuénai of Venezuela before going on to a description and analysis of the pattern of social organization that characterized past historical periods.

Sib and Phratric Names: Style and Usage

The Wakuénai of the lower Guainía River do not use sib names either as terms of address or as terms of reference in everyday social contexts[2]. In response to my questions on the subject, they told me the myth of emergence or simply listed as many sib names as they knew. However, they showed a great deal of reluctance to say which sib names referred to which individuals and families in the village or in neighboring communities. They were less hesitant about telling me sib names of families who lived in far away villages in Colombia or Brazil where I had never visited. In ritual contexts such as shamans' curing songs and the málikai music performed in

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childbirth and initiation rites, ritual specialists sing the names of Tobacco Spirits and other supernatural beings and places which are closely associated with the principal totemic spirit-names of patrilineal sibs to which ritual participants belong. Only after I had studied the uses of these related spirit-names in sacred musical performances was I able to learn the names of sibs to which specific families belonged. The totemic sib names are powerful elements in a ritual naming system that is not discussed in everyday social contexts but which is centrally important in sacred musical performances. The Wakuénai would not specify which sib names belonged to which groups of people so long as I was only able to ask for that information in an everyday social context and speech style. Once I had experienced a number of the sacred musical uses of names related to the sib names, I was able to ask questions within the framework of a ritual context and style, and they were no longer so reluctant to answer my questions.

The avoidance of sib names in everyday social contexts is also evident in the practice of addressing members of the other sibs of one's own phratry with the kinship terms for older and younger siblings, depending on their higher or lower rank in the phratry. I observed this only a few times while traveling over long distances, since the sibs making up a phratry on the lower Guainía live interspersed with sibs associated with other phratries and with non-Wakuénai groups such as the Baniwa, Guarequena, and Yeral (see below, p.43).

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Along the Aiarí in Brazil, the sibs of a single phratry inhabit a contiguous stretch of land almost 60km long, and members of the highest-ranking sib are normally addressed by other phratry members with the terms for elder siblings (Wright 1981: 39).

In contrast to the avoidance of sib names as terms of address and reference in everyday social contexts, the Wakuénai freely and openly use the names of phratries in reference to themselves and others. The name of each phratry is identical with the name of the highest-ranked sib in the phratry. This ambiguity in the naming of phratries and sibs needs to be emphasized, since it has led other field observers to conclude that the phratries have no names and to interpret the names of phratries as sib names. Galvão and Oliveira (1973: 31) interviewed the inhabitants of Nazaré, a village on the Isana River, and were told that the men of the village represented two 'clans', Tatú and Siucí [3]. From this information, they concluded that their informants were referring to two of the highest-ranking patrilineal sibs. That they were actually using these terms in reference to phratries (Ádzanéni and Waríperídakéna, respectively) is far more probable, given the general avoidance of sib names in social usage and the relatively short duration of Galvão and Oliveira's stay in the field.

The names of phratries are commonly used as terms of self-reference and as a way of differentiating between other people who are marriageable and those who are not. All

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members of the four or five sibs making up each phratry are addressed by the kinship terms for siblings, thus ruling out any intermarriages within a phratry as incestuous. Although addressed as elder or younger siblings, the members of a phratry who are not also members of the same patrilineal sib (náiki) are thought of as parallel cousins mythically related through the father's brother who all form a single, exogamous group of kinsmen (nukítsinápe). The social usage of phratric names as a simple, effective means for marking the minimal amount of social distance that will allow intermarriage is probably the main reason that they have remained so important as terms of self-reference in everyday social usage. Wakuénai myths and ceremonies attest to the great social importance of the kin vs. affine dichotomy in their cultural life (see below,47-ff). On a brief visit to one village, I asked the headman for the name of the náiki to which he and his kinsmen belonged, and he replied that "We men are Ádzanéni from a place near the headwaters of the Guainía, and our wives are Waríperídakéna like those of the [Dzáwinai] men with whom you came here." The headman's willingness to use phratric names as terms of reference in discussing his own social identity and that of his affines is in stark contrast to the reluctance to use sib names in everyday social contexts, especially when talking with a total stranger.

Figure 2.1 shows how the patrilineal sibs of two phratries are ranked. In addition to these two phratries, there are a number of other sibs for which the exact ordering

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Phratry	Sib name, rank	English gloss	Yeral name
Dzáwinai	Dzáwinai, 1	Owners of the jaguar	Iauaretê
Dzáwinai	Kadáwpúrirri, 2	People of the fish species called kadáw	Pixuna or Mutum-Tapuya
Dzáwinai	Makérrinái, 3	Owners of the macaw	Arara
Dzáwinai	Kwíčidakéna, 4	Grandchildren of the yellow curassow	?
Dzáwinai	Hírridakéna, 5	Grandchildren of the rat	?
Waríperídakéna	Waríperídakéna, 1	Grandchildren of the Pleiades	Siucí
Waríperídakéna	Túmiéni, 2	Children of the leaf-cutter ant	?
Waríperídakéna	Kutérruéni, 3	Children of a species of small bee (kutérru)	Irá
Waríperídakéna	Makúliéni, 4	Children of the Makú or "workers"	?

Figure 2.1. Complete listing of sib names for the Dzáwinai and Waríperídakéna phratries, also showing English translation and Yeral equivalent (if known) for each name.

Patrilineal name	English gloss	Yeral name
Ádzanéni	Children of the large armadillo	Tatú
Kúmadámnainái	Owners of the duck	Pato or Ipecu
Hohódeni	Children of the wild chicken	Inambu
Tuirímnainái	Owners of the conoto bird	?
Tokédakéna	Grandchildren of the firefly	Gagalona
Móriwéni	Children of the anaconda	Sucuriú
Kapitimnainai	Owners of the coatamundi	Koati
Máuriéni	Children of a species of large wasp	Cáua
Kuwáidakéna	Grandchildren of Kuwái, an important mythical character	Yurupari
Wádzurídakéna	Grandchildren of the vulture	Urubú
Parátana	People of the algojón fish	?

Figure 2.1(cont.). Various patrilineal names recorded along the lower Guainía; phratric affliliation and rank unknown

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was impossible to determine among the Wakuénai of the lower Guainía. The left-hand column shows the indigenous name of each sib in the Curricarro dialect of Wáku and its rank within a phratry. The middle column gives an English translation for each name, and the third column lists the names' equivalents in Yeral where these are known with certainty to correspond to the names published by Galvão and Oliveira (1973).

Based on the criteria of use versus avoidance, I can assert that the term Ádzanéni is a phratric name in addition to being the name of the highest-ranking sib of a phratry through my observation of the name's usage along the lower Guainía. The term Ádzanéni (or Ayanén in the Curripaco dialect) is the most commonly used social reference term in many villages along the lower Guainía and is said to be the name of all Wakuénai groups living along the upper Guainía in Colombia. To interpret the name Ádzanéni as a sib name would mean each village or local group would have to be considered as a 'sub-sib' (Wright 1981: 40). Since I know of ten Ádzanéni villages on the lower Guainía and am led to believe that an even greater number of Ádzanéni villages are located on the upper Guainía, the probability of all these local groups constituting sub-sibs of the Ádzanéni sib is highly unlikely.

The system of sib name usage which Wright found among the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River in Brazil is distinctly different from the one I am describing here. Wright's census

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(1981:44) of Hohódeni villages on the Aiarí identifies almost 200 descent group members spread out in eight villages, and the name Hohódeni is one of the first 'social facts' (1981:37) made known upon entering any of the villages. Wright's documentation of the Hohódeni sib's reconstitution on ancestral lands after a period of forced removal in the early 19th Century is sufficient grounds for viewing the Hohódeni as a special historical development that has diverged somewhat from the system of sib and phratric naming practiced by other Wakuénai groups. The Hohódeni consider themselves to be the third-ranked, or middle, sib in a phratry of five 'sibs'. The fourth-ranked group in this phratry is referred to as Ádzanéni. As I have shown, Ádzanéni is used as a phratric name referring to a number of sibs living along the Guainía River in Venezuela and Colombia. The Ádzanéni 'sib' that is today affiliated with the Hohódeni of Brazil probably migrated out of the Guainía region in the 1920s or 30s, a time of warfare in that area (Galvão and Olveira 1973:34) and later merged with their Hohódeni neighbors, thus reconstructing the indigenous model of phratries composed of four or five ranked sibs.

In addition to Dzáwinai, Waríperídakéna, and Ádzanéni, there are at least two other names which are probably also phratric names. The Wakuénai of the lower Guainía say that the Kúmadámnainái are the top-ranked patrilineal sib of a phratry that bears the same name and that includes two other sibs, the Kúmadéni (Children of the Duck) and the Kúmadakéna

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(Grandchildren of the Duck). If this information is correct, then it is the only example to my knowledge that supports the hypothesis that the suffixes -mnainái, -éni, and -dakéna represent descending order of rank within a phratry (Galvão and Oliveira 1973: 36). A glance at the list of phratric and sib names in Figure 1 is sufficient to deny the validity of such an hypothesis as a general rule[5]. A second name,Tuirímnainái, is perhaps the name of a diminished phratry that once lived along the lower and middle Guainía river near Maroa but that is today represented only by one large patrilineal sib in Victorino, a village that marks the end of Venezuelan territory on the Guainía River. I suspect that there were other sibs associated with the Tuirímnainái because they are the only speakers of the Êh-hen dialect in the region and, according to Matos Arvelo (1912: 40), there were formerly many more Êh-hen speakers in the vicinity of Maroa. My notes indicate a strong correlation between phratries and dialect groups: Curripaco with Ádzanéni, Curricarro with Dzáwinai, and Óh-hon with Waríperídakéna. On the basis of this tendency for each of the Wakuénai phratries to be strongly associated with a particular dialect, I suggest that Tuirímnainái is also a phratric name for several Êh-hen speaking sibs who once lived on the middle Guainía in Venezuela, even though I have no direct evidence either through observation of the name's social usage or from informants' statements.

Phratry and Sib Organization Prior to Dislocation

In their traditional setting, Wakuénai phratries ex-

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ercised political control over fish and other aquatic resources along a clearly defined stretch of river. This principle of territorial control has been severely weakened among the Wakuénai along the lower Guainía in Venezuela. These groups, including sibs or fragments of sibs mainly from the Ádzanéni, Dzáwinai, and Waríperídakéna phratries, have migrated to the lower Guainía over the past twenty years, and the association between each phratry and a contiguous territory has given way to a new pattern in which members of all three phratries are interspersed in a single territory. The Wakuénai share this territory with the few remaining Baniwa and are currently expanding into the uninhabited lands along the Casiquiare River as well as the Guarequena lands along the Caño San Miguel (see Map 2.1). The following account of traditional territorial rights of phratries and their constituent patrilineal sibs is a reconstruction based on accounts by Dzáwinai and Waríperídakéna informants.

The four or five patrilineal sibs of each phratry shared control over the fish and other aquatic resources along a clearly defined stretch of one of the region's rivers (see Map 2.2). The chief resources that were in nigh demand, but short supply, were flooded areas, lakes, and streams that contained relatively abundant fish and aquatic animals. For example, the five Dzáwinai sibs inhabited the middle Isana River from Tonowí up to the rapids known as Raudal Araña, the site of petroglyphs showing the construction and dimensions of sacred ancestor flutes played in male initiation rituals

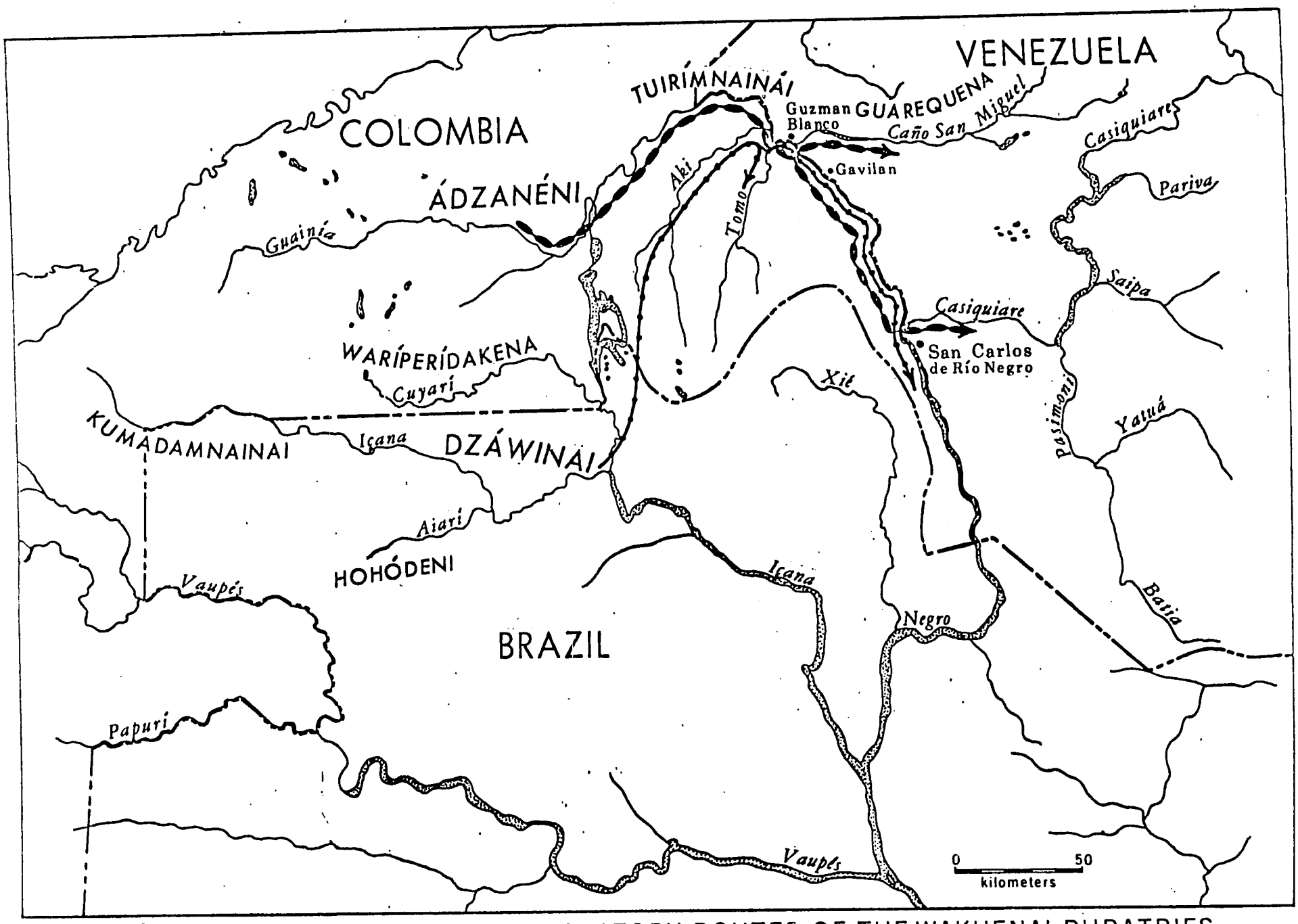
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MAP 2.1. WAKUÉNAI PHRATRIES ALONG THE LOWER GUAINÍA

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MAP 2.2 TERRITORIES AND MIGRATORY ROUTES OF THE WAKUENAI PHRATRIES

by all Wakuénai. Within this area, members of any one of the five Dzáwinai sibs could make a base camp from which to hunt and fish. Anyone other than a Dzáwinai had to ask for and receive permission from the Dzáwinai elders before using either terrestrial or aquatic resources. Failure to do so meant warfare. Likewise, the Dzáwinai could not fish or hunt along the upper Isana above Raudal Araña without getting permission from the Kúmadámnainái. In practice, neighboring phratries could negotiate trades to make up for imbalances in the resources of their territory. Wright documents such a trade between Waríperídakéna of the lower Aiarí and Hohódeni of the upper Aiarí. The former had an abundance of aquatic resources but a serious shortage of garden lands and arranged for permission to cut gardens in Hohódeni territory by allowing the Hohódeni to send fishing expeditions to the lower Aiarí (1981: 18).

Each patrilineal sib identified specific areas within its phratry's territory for use as agricultural lands and as sacred lands where no one was permitted to hunt. The Kadáwpúrirri, for example, lived near Tonowí and cleared gardens from a large forest of móri (mahogany) trees that stood on fertile, yellowish tierra firma not far from their village. They called their garden lands Káaliwári, the rib cage of Káali, a younger brother of the mythical creator, Iñápirríkuli, and owner of all cultivated plant species. Each patrilineal sib also considered a different area within its phratry's territory to be the home of the spirits of

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recently-deceased members (lidánam) of the sib. These spiritual houses are believed to exist in a separate spiritual reality known as íyarudáti, a place of eternal night. The dark netherworld also includes the spiritual home (máliwéko) of animal and bird species (éenunai and képinai) that can cause sickness and death to the living. Although the lidánam, éenunai, and képinai spirits are visible only to shamans (malírri) and master shamans (dzáwináitairi), the exact physical location of the spirits' houses in this world (hekwápiríko) is common knowledge. Thus, the house of Kadáwpúrirri lidánam spirits, called Paícipe, is said to be located in a large dune of white sand on the banks of the Isana near Raudal Araña. No hunting was permitted in this area, and to kill animals that were reputed to abound in the surrounding forest was considered extremely dangerous.

The general pattern that emerges from this discussion of Wakuénai phratries and sibs is one that replicates the oppositional process between patrilineal names for the phratries and sibs. The phratry as a whole acted to collectively control an entire region vis-a-vis other phratries. The use of resources within the territory of another phratry was forbidden, and a violation could provoke warfare between two phratries. However, the resources controlled by another phratry were also accessible through a process of economic bargaining with senior members of the local phratry. In short, the phratries represented basic political and economic divisions of everyday social life. On the other hand, in-

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dividual sibs were linked to specific microenvironments through the sacred, ritual bonding of the ancestral spirits with the lands that their descendants, both living and dead, inhabited. The sacred ties between individual sibs and discrete parcels of land were supported primarily by ritual and supernatural rather than political and economic sanctions, although the latter might have been present to a greater degree in the past when each sib was still localized on its sacred ancestral lands.

The structural ambiguity of the rule equating phratric and highest- ranking sib names is transposed in the organization of phratries and sibs to the collective control over the river and its aquatic resources. Unlike lands and terrestrial resources which are clearly divided up among the sibs of a phratry according to sacred criteria, the river belongs to both the phratry as a whole and to the individual sibs. The ambiguous structural position of rivers in Wakuénai political organization is analogous to the concept of sibs among the Tukano- speaking Cubeo as having a relationship of 'linkage-autonomy' (Goldman 1963: 274) within the phratry. In Cubeo symbolism, this political ambiguity is conceptualized as a giant anaconda spirit that represents both the river along which the sibs are located and the segmentary organization of phratries into a number of discrete, yet interconnected, sibs. While the Wakuénai do not see such a direct homology between anacondas, rivers, and the political organization of phratries and sibs, they do believe that the anaconda is the

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spiritual owner of all spirit-names of fish and aquatic animal species. Furthermore, the anaconda (umáwari) class of spirits occupies a very ambiguous position in Wakuénai cosmology, whereas the classes of forest animal (éenunai) and bird (képinai) spirits are more definitely classified[6]. This theme will be explored in greater detail in later chapters on Wakuénai chants and prayers (málikai) performed in childbirth and initiation rituals, since these sacred musical performances are where the significance of various classes of spirit-names reaches its fullest development and widest application.

Marriage Customs

Wakuénai marriage customs have changed over the past three decades in response to social and religious interventions by a group of fundamentalist missionaries working for the New Tribes Mission, an American Protestant organization. The destabilization and dislocation of Wakuénai phratries and sibs that have accompanied the termination of brideservice, cross-cousin marriage, and other customs will be briefly discussed in the concluding chapter of this dissertation and are treated in greater detail in a recent publication (Hill and Moran, in press). Although patrilocal residence is still the stated norm, many villages along the lower Guainía in Venezuela show a type of reorganization in which uxorilocal residence is becoming centrally important. Permanent uxorilocal residence has the effect of maintaining the authority of fathers-in-law, a role traditionally guaranteed

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by the custom of brideservice.

Figures 2.2 and 2.3 illustrate the importance of uxorilocal residence in the two Wakuénai villages where I carried out intensive fieldwork in 1980-81. In the Ádzanéni village of Punta Bella, a small village of six families with a population of 28, uxorilocal residence is the dominant form of marriage. Kracke reports on the same process of group formation around the father-in-law among the Tupí-speaking Kagwahív of the Rio Madeira in Brazil. "If the father-in-law is the headman and at all persuasive, however, the result tends to be permanent uxorilocal residence"(1978:14). On the other hand, uxorilocal residence is not the dominant form of marriage in Gavilán, a village of seven Dzáwinai and Waríperídakéna families with a population of 36. Instead, uxorilocal residence forms a peripheral ring of affinally related men around a central core of patrilocal, Dzáwinai men and uxorilocal, Dzáwinai women. In Gavilán, uxorilocality reflects the personal preferences of young women to continue living in their fathers' village (or nearby) after marriage rather than the persuasiveness of the father-in-law. The two senior men of Gavilán are ritual specialists, and their leadership in rites of passage, curing rituals, and ceremonies carries over into the everyday social and economic activities of the village.

Phratric names continue to act as markers of the division between kinsmen and affinal relatives in current social practice. In contrast to the inclusive term,

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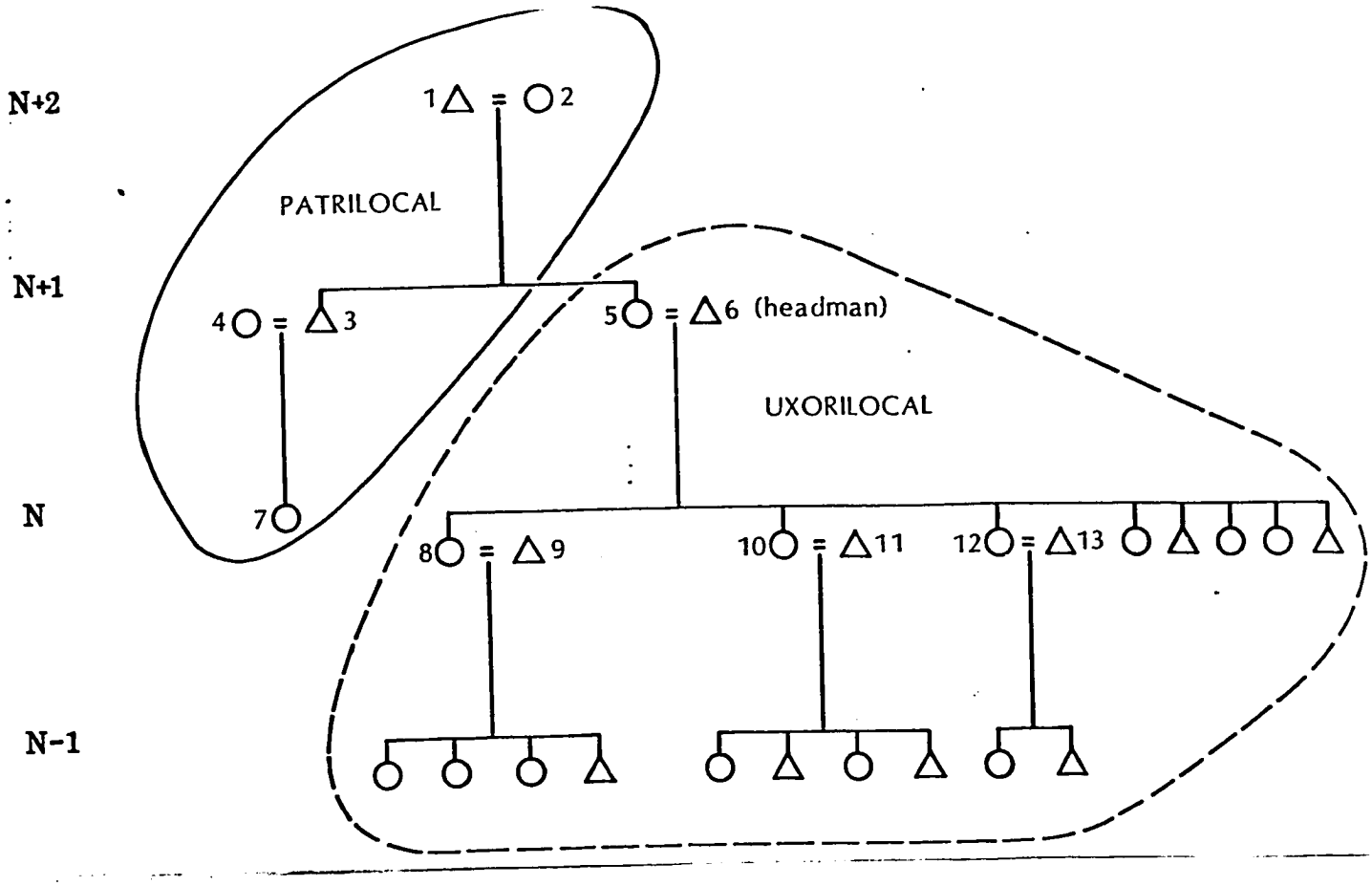


Figure 2.2. Kinship chart of the Ádzanéni village of Punta Bella showing predominance of uxorilocal marriages (5=6,8=9, 10=11, and 12=13).

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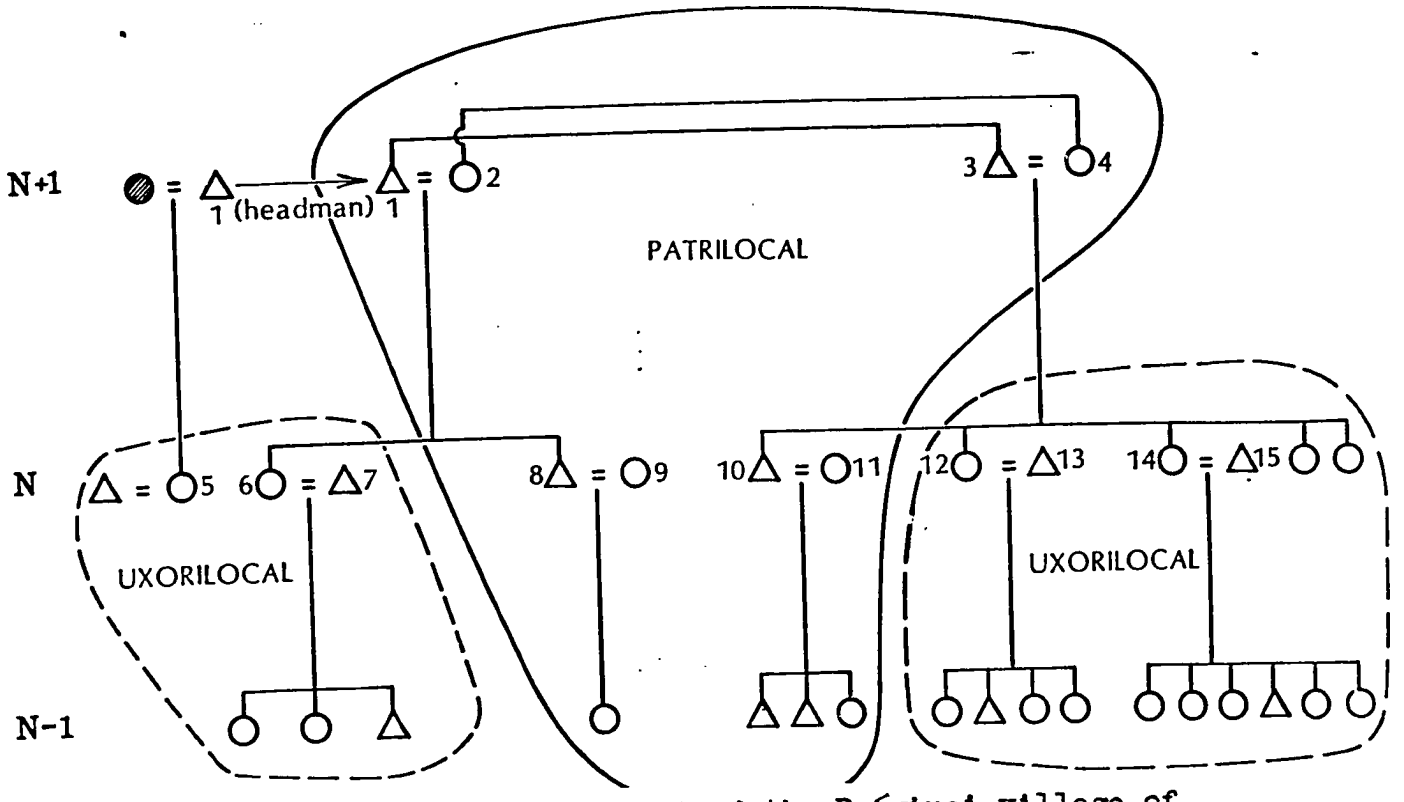


Figure 2.3. Kinship chart of the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán showing how uxorilocal marriages center around a patrilocal core (1=2, 3=4, 8=9, and 10=11).

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nukítsinápe, or "my kinsmen", with which the Wakuénai refer to the members of their own phratry, the term for members of affinally related phratries is simply apána, or "other people". In fact, the distinction between "my kinsmen" and "others" is the most important social phenomenon to consider when seeking to understand Wakuénai social organization.

Affinal alliances among phratries formed a system of indirect, generalized exchange based on rules of patrilocal residence and patrilineal inheritance of sib and phratric names. Although marriage with either category of cross-cousin was acceptable, a general rule against marriages with women of the mother's or maternal grandmother's sibs made the father's sister's daughter (FZD) a more preferable choice than the mother's brother's daughter. This preference is implicitly marked in Wakuénai kinship terminology by a special term, nukuírru, for father's sister. The term was changed from nukuírru (FZ) to nuhiérru, or mother-in-law, at marriage. Other terms for the siblings of parents all consist of combinations of the terms for mother, father, and older or younger siblings.[7] The preference for marriage with the FZD helped to create a wide range of affinal alliances among different phratries and to keep the overall system of alliances from breaking down into a number of sub-systems based on direct exchanges between two sibs of different phratries. Neither is there any evidence of unidirectional exchanges of women among phratries that could have supported a system of ranking based on wife-giver to wife-taker relations. Although

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internally differentiated into ranked sibs according to a mythical birth order, the phratries all were of equal status in their external relations among themselves.

Prior to missionary intervention, Wakuénai marriages were arranged by the parents of the bride and bridegroom. In the case of FZD marriages, the father of the boy would consult his sister (FZ) to see if she were inclined to allow her daughter to marry his son. The girl's father (FZH) could always intervene and cancel the marriage plans, an act that occasionally led to sorcery against him and his family by the rejected nephew or brother-in-law. If the prospective son-in-law were not a wife's brother's son (WBS) of the girl's father, the arrangements were initiated by the boy's father going to speak with the girl's father. Not only did the girl's father always have the right to reject a potential son-in-law but he could also force his daughter to accept a marriage partner that he had arranged for her. If the girl balked during the ceremonial offering of the bridewealth payment, her father would take her by the arm and literally force her to leave the village with her new spouse.

Arranged marriages between classificatory, patrilateral cross-cousins and the custom of brideservice played key roles in the formation of affinal alliances among the sibs of different phratries. The brideservice was a period of temporary uxorilocal residence in which the father-in-law/ uncle (FZH) had the right to accept or reject the marriage of his wife's brother's son (WBS) to one of his daughters on the basis of

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the young man's performance of agricultural and other duties. Young men had to cut, burn, plant, and weed manioc swiddens for their fathers-in-law. The harvest formed part of a bridewealth payment that usually included other valuable items such as dug-out canoes and newly-thatched roofs for the fathers-in-law. The Adzanéni are particularly insistent about the importance that the young men's performance of agricultural duties had in determining the attitudes of their wives' senior kinsmen. Fathers-in-law had the right to send young men away empty-handed if they detected any signs of incompetence or idleness in the way they were carrying out gardening activities[8]. The Dzáwinai lay greater emphasis on the importance of other activities, such as canoe building and house thatching, in their statements about traditional brideservice. All agreed on the social importance of brideservice as a period of temporary uxorilocal residence in which young men of "the other people's" phratry underwent a difficult process of scrutiny and evaluation in the eyes of their wives' senior kinsmen[9].

The traditional Wakuénai custom of brideservice was eminently sensible in view of the central importance of swidden agriculture in social life. After marriage, the domestic household is an autonomous production unit that must raise enough manioc and other garden products to feed all its own members and have some left over to contribute to communal meals or offer drinks (pacáka) to visitors.

"Viability of the conjugal family is very much

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> defined by this economic capability with respect to gardens: without someone to process manioc into bread, or someone to cut trees for a garden, a family would "suffer" a great deal"(Wright 1981: 48).

A household must also have its own canoe(s) so that women can transport heavy loads of manioc from the garden to the village and a house in good repair where they can process manioc while sheltered from the equatorial sun or tropical rains. Thus, the purpose of the brideservice was to develop a sense of trust among a woman's kinsmen that her future husband would not make her suffer for lack of the basic necessities: a garden, a canoe, and a house.

Marriage and Affinal Relations in Mythic Thought

In an ideal Wakuénai marriage, the father arranged for his son's marriage to his sister's daughter, and the father's sister's husband (FZH) had the authority to accept or reject his daughter's marriage to one of his wife's brother's sons (WBS). The FZH-WBS relationship is the focus of an important Wakuénai myth on the origin of Iñápirríkuli, the mythical creator and transformer of the world. The conflict between FZH and Iñápirríkuli (WBS) and, more generally, that between Iñápirríkuli's kinsmen and the "other people", his affinal relatives, is a mythical model for the division of Wakuénai society into exogamous phratries. Within the framework of conflict between affines, the Wakuénai explain the origin of malaria, death, evil omens, and a number of distinctive

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features of animal and fish species. The myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli is perhaps the most important of the whole corpus, since it symbolically encodes the Wakuénai life cycle through the critical transition of brideservice, a marginal period of uxorilocal residence in which young men are challenged by their in-laws. The myth of Iñápirríkuli's origin portrays the origin of human society as part of a primordial, cosmogonic process of conflict between kin and affines. The priority of the kin/affine distinction in myth parallels the primary importance of the division between phratries in everyday social behavior. The myth of Iñápirríkuli's origin epitomizes Malinowski's definition (1926) of myth as a hard-working cultural force, and it was the first myth that the Wakuénai men chose to tell me in both the Ádzanéni village of Punta Bella and the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán. The two variants that I collected in 1980-81 contain a number of contrasting details but concur on the basic structure of kinship and affinal relations among the myth's protagonists and their enemies[10].

The myth of Iñápirríkuli's origin is set in the distant past when animals had human powers of speech and the universe consisted of a closed, miniature world, a solitary island of tierra firma surrounded by rivers and flooded forests. In the beginning, there were three principal beings: a man, his wife, and his wife's brother. The man, sometimes referred to as Kunáhwerrim, or grandfather of malaria (kunám), murders his wife's brother. The sister's husband's (ZH) act of

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violence against his wife's brother (WB) is said to represent a larger state of warfare between two enemy factions: the human-like animals led by Kunáhwerrim (ZH) and the kinsmen of WB. Kunáhwerrim and the animals completely wipe out WB and his kinsmen, leaving Kunáhwerrim's wife (WB's sister) as the only surviving member of WB's group of kinsmen.

The woman gathers up her dead brother's bones and puts them inside of a basket which she carries with her everywhere. One day she forgets to take the basket with her to the manioc garden, and the bones turn into two crickets, Iñápirríkuli and another nephew (WBS). The name Iñápirríkuli comes from his mythical creation out of (-<u>rríkuli</u>) his father's bones (<u>ináapi</u>). Kunáhwerrim (FZH) hears the crickets inside the covered basket. He opens the basket, takes out the two crickets, and throws them on the ground so hard that their stomachs burst open. Kunáhwerrim leaves them for dead, but the two nephews sew up each other's stomachs with strings and wait for their aunt to return home. The next three episodes focus on the conflict between Kunáhwerrim (FZH) and Iñápirríkuli (WBS). FZH repeatedly tries to kill Iñápirríkuli, but the latter always knows beforehand what his evil FZH is planning and invents clever ways of escaping. In one episode, FZH asks WBS to go into the center of a manioc garden and dance while playing a <u>maváku</u> whistle made out of cecropia. Meanwhile, FZH sets fire to the entire perimeter of the garden, hoping to kill WBS in an enormous fire. Iñápirríkuli (WBS) sees what FZH is doing and spits into the hollow

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whistle before turning himself into a leaf-cutter ant and tunneling out to safety in the surrounding forest. FZH hears the boiling spit and popping cecropia wood of the whistle and mistakenly assumes that the sounds are the burning and splitting open of his nephew's body. On his way back to the village, FZH is unpleasantly surprized to find WBS swimming and playing in a stream. The myth ends with an episode in which Iñápirríkuli takes revenge against Kunáhwerrim by killing one of his wives (not FZ) and leaving her chopped up body to boil in a pot inside Kunáhwerrim's house. Kunáhwerrim returns home later and eats his wife's body thinking that it is lapa meat.

In later myths, Iñápirríkuli lives separately in his own village with a number of kinsmen, but there is always a series of hostile interactions with Kunáhwerrim and his followers, the affinal relatives of Iñápirríkuli and his brothers. In the myth of the origin of death, Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen go to a pudáli ceremony in Kunáhwerrim's village and are all given poison (mahnéti) to drink. As usual, Iñápirríkuli knew in advance of his evil uncle's plans and ordered his aunt (FZ) to take along a special remedy against the sorcerer's poison. The aunt's remedy saved everyone except for Kuwáikanérri, a younger brother of Iñápirríkuli who becomes the first person to die. In another myth, Kunáhwerrim's sons kill another of Iñápirríkuli's brothers, but this action proves to be the downfall of Kunáhwerrim. Iñápirríkuli cooks the heart of his slain brother three times on a manioc griddle, and each time it turns into a larger bird until

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reaching the size and form of a giant eagle. The eagle flies to Kunáhwerrim's village, takes him away in its claws, and drops him to his death into a river that turns dirty-white color and causes malaria to all who live nearby. In the myth of the origin of evil omens, Kunáhwerrim's children conspire to kill Iñápirríkuli to revenge their father's death through an elaborate plot of seduction and betrayal, but Iñápirríkuli outsmarts them and kills two of the sons. In the process, he invents evil omens (hínimai) in a playful, sporting manner that terrifies the daughter of Kunáhwerrim, the seductress who had set out to kill him.

All these myths about Iñápirríkuli center around the theme of conflict between kinsmen and affinal relatives. When asked why Kunáhwerrim wanted so badly to kill Iñápirríkuli, the Wakuénai readily answer that Kunáhwerrim did not want Iñápirríkuli to marry his daughter. However, they cannot say anything more specific about Kunáhwerrim's warfare against his wife's brother than, "It was that way from the beginning."

There are many other myths about the revenge of Iñápirríkuli against particular animal and fish species who had helped Kunáhwerrim in the fighting that annihilated all the senior kinsmen of Iñápirríkuli except for his father's sister. Some are short, humorous stories that are told as jokes, whereas others take up a full hour or more to narrate. The myths of Iñápirríkuli are told openly and publicly, often as a form of entertainment among adults but also as a means

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of educating children about the society they live in. The most common setting in which the myths are narrated is the headman's house after the communal evening meal, but they are also told while fishing or during breaks from working in the manioc gardens. The myths are always told by men, but women and children are free to listen, and anyone can interject comments or add details that the narrator has forgotten or chosen not to include. The best narrators embellish myths with expressive sound effects and gestures that enhance their performance. The men take great pleasure in telling myth episodes in which Iñápirríkuli cleverly outwits his antagonists by knowing in advance exactly how they are planning to kill him.

The myth of the vulture is a member of the corpus of myths about Iñápirríkuli, even though it directly concerns an unnamed younger brother rather than Iñápirríkuli himself. In the initial setting, a young man sees several vulture-women come down out of the sky into his mother's manioc garden and watches them steal hot peppers (<u>áati</u>). The vulture women take off their feathered coats and go naked in the garden, and the young man captures a beautiful young vulture-woman by hiding her `clothes' so that she cannot return home with the others. He brings her home as his bride and asks her to help his mother with her gardening work. After a couple of years, the vulture-woman tells her husband that she must return to her father's house in the sky, and her husband agrees to go with her. He is able to adjust to his new life except for the

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vulture-people's habit of eating rotten meat and maggots. His father-in-law/vulture helps him to get along, at first by giving him fresh meat to eat and later by putting a special substance into his eyes that makes rotten meat appear to be fresh. Before he can take up permanent residence in his vulture-wife's village, the man has to build a canoe and weave a hammock for his father- in-law's father. The old grandfather-vulture threatens to kill him if he cannot fulfill these two wishes and so frightens the young man that he almost returns to his mother's house in the surface world below. However, the young man's brother-in-law uses his magical powers to help the young man make the canoe and weave the hammock to please the grandfather, and in the end the young man stays to live with his vulture in-laws.

In the myth of the vulture, the normal process of brideservice and marriage is symbolically inverted. Instead of a young man living in temporary uxorilocal residence, the initial setting of the myth establishes exactly the opposite situation: a young woman living for a temporary period of patrilocal residence. In the myth, a young woman works for her mother-in-law in the manioc gardens, whereas in the traditional custom of brideservice a young man worked for his father- in-law in the manioc gardens. After the ascension to the vultures' village in the sky, the father-in-law and brother-in-law help rather than hinder the young man as he struggles to adjust to their way of life, an inversion of the conflict between affinal relatives that characterizes the

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myths of Iñápirríkuli. The net result of the myth of the vulture is to equate permanent uxorilocal residence with the eating of rotten meat, thus indirectly supporting the rule of patrilocal residence by attaching a negative quality, rottenness, to its opposite, uxorilocal residence.

The closed mythical cosmos of Iñápirríkuli is like a mirror that reflects the basic dynamics of Wakuénai social life, but the reflected image is greatly exaggerated and magnified. Everyday social situations are given gigantic dimensions and herculean force in the mythical cosmos of Iñápirríkuli. Thus, the normal experience of a son-in-law (nephew) who prepares a manioc garden for his father-in-law (uncle) is portrayed in myth as a life and death struggle in which the young man must always be conscious of his father-in-law's intentions and actions if he is to turn adversity to his own advantage. The element of social truth within this mythical exaggeration is that brideservice, while not exactly a threat to the young man's physical survival, does reinforce a relationship of authority that can have dire social consequences. For a rejected son-in-law undergoes a sort of social death, a phenomenon well-documented in many stories and legends about young men who went insane and withdrew from everyday social life after being rejected by their wives' families. The myths of Iñápirríkuli also exaggerate the division between affinally- related phratries into a state of perpetual warfare, revenge, and counter-revenge depicted as a received tradition that has existed since the beginning of

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time. Here again, the mythical exaggeration is based on an element of actual social practice insofar as the phratries are (or were) defensive units that held political control over a given territory and could go to war with "others" who intruded on that territory without first receiving permission.

The myths of Iñápirríkuli are hard-working social narratives that focus on basic rules and axioms that organize everyday social experience. They are like a microscope with which the Wakuénai study their own social institutions and customs on the small scale of Iñápirríkuli's closed, miniature cosmos, where actions that seem small and commonplace in everyday social experience are made huge and extraordinary. Through the myths of Iñápirríkuli, the Wakuénai reach a sociological understanding of their own society.

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1. Wakuénai emergence myths contrast with Tukanoan origin myths in which the origin of social groups is attributed to ancestral anacondas that "are supposed to have journeyed in mythical times from outside the Vaupés region"(Wright 1981: 33). The contrast between autochthonous and non-autochthonous origins in myth correlates well with Nimuendajú's view (1950 [1927] : 165) that the Arawakan groups of the Northwest Amazon region had inhabited the area for many centuries prior to the immigration of Tukanoan groups.

2. The only occasion on which I heard a person address another with sib names was when an elderly woman severely scolded her son-in-law, the village headman, for his behavior in a dispute that had nearly caused a total breakdown of local social relations. The old woman angrily shouted out the phratric and sib names of her son-in-law as a way of shaming him for not behaving in a manner seen as appropriate for a village headman.

3. I follow Wright in using the term sib instead of clan because the term sib more accurately describes the relatively small groups of brothers and their descendants making up Wakuénai patrilineal groups. Also, the term clan implies political functions and powers, whereas Wakuénai sibs are primarily based on ritual, mythical, and social unity.

4. Speaking of the phratry to which the Hohódeni sib is

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affiliated, Wright comments that "this phratry has no specific name"(1981: 31).

5. The hypothesis by Galvão and Oliveira is interesting because it calls attention to the tri-generational structure of the kinship terms used as suffixes in sib and phratric names. Wakuénai kinship terminology and mythology are also based on an underlying structure of three generations.

6. The highly ambiguous position of rivers in the political and conceptual organization of both Tukanoan and Arawakan groups of the Northwest Amazon region and the corresponding ambiguity of riverine spirits has carried over into the folklore and social organization of Yeral, Spanish, and Portuguese-speaking mestizos of the region. The criollos, or caboclos, use the cover term "Mauari" for supernatural spirits, a word that is derived from the Wakuénai term umáwari, or anaconda. Matos Arvelo (1912) confused the criollo term `Mauari' for the indigenous Wakuénai mythical character named Kuwái, also referred to as Yuruparí in Yeral.

7. See Oliveira's article (1975) for a complete list of Wakuénai kinship terms.

8. Matos Arvelo (1912: 44) described the importance of manioc gardens in Wakuénai brideservice in the following terms: "La mujer es adquirida por la fuerza del conuco" ("A woman is acquired by the quality of a

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manioc swidden", translation mine).

9. My description of brideservice in Wakuénai society does not necessarily conflict with Wright's assertion (1981: 47-48) that sister-exchange is the preferred norm among the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River in Brazil, since he also mentions that many Hohódeni are married to Cubeo. Thus, the importance of sister- exchange along the Aiarí River is probably a Tukanoan social influence. Among the Tukanoan Cubeo, for example, cross-cousin marriage is preferred, and wherever possible brother-sister exchange. "Although a brideprice is acceptable in lieu of an exchange, it is regarded as undesirable, because it does not make for marital stability"(Goldman 1948: 783).

10. Saake's variant (1980 1968 :237-40), although quite different from the two variants which I collected along the Guainía river, essentially upholds the argument I make here about the myth's importance as a model for the division of Wakuénai society into opposing phratries of kinsmen and affinal relatives.

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Chapter 3:

"Wakuénai Ecology"

Introduction

The most distinctive feature of Wakuénai ecology is its dual emphasis on fishing and agriculture. For the Wakuénai, fishing is a basic source of protein and other nutrients that complements agricultural activities but that does not surpass them in importance. Hunting and the collection of wild fruits are occasional activities that add to the variety of local diets during some seasons, but they do not serve as a steady, reliable food source on a year-round basis in the same way as fishing and agriculture.

The equal importance of fishing and agriculture in Wakuénai ecology contrasts with the ecological orientation of Tukanoan-speaking groups of the Northwest Amazon region towards only one of the three basic subsistence activities, hunting, fishing, or agriculture. The Tukanoan groups classify themselves according to this tri-fold scheme of subsistence activities, even though all groups practice a mixture of the three.

> "The classification, from the point of view of the Desana, is as follows: The Desana are hunters; the Pira-Tapuya, Uanano, Tukano, and Siriano are fishermen; the Tuyuka, Miriti-Tapuya, Karapana, and all Arawakan groups are

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horticulturists"(Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971: 17).

The Wakuénai do not classify sibs and phratries according to subsistence activities in this fashion. There are some minor economic specializations among Wakuénai phratries and sibs, such as the reputation of Waríperídakéna sibs as makers of the finest manioc grater boards and that of Ádzanéni sibs as the best ceramists. However, fishing and agriculture are everywhere of equal importance among the Wakuénai and no attempt is made to evaluate either one or the other of these two types of activity as more important.

The Blackwater Ecosystem of the Upper Rio Negro Region

The Wakuénai groups of the lower Guainía inhabit a blackwater ecosystem that is exceedingly nutrient-poor and acidic, even by Amazonian standards. The entire Upper Rio Negro region of Venezuela, Colombia, and Brazil is drained by blackwater rivers and forms the westernmost part of the geologically ancient Guayana Shield. Rain forests in this oligotrophic (nutrient-poor) region do not generally grow larger than 25 to 30 m in height and 27.8 m^2/ha in mean basal area (Jordan and Uhl 1978), and the diversity of forest species is lower than that of comparable forests at the same humidity and temperature. The relatively small size and low diversity of species in Upper Rio Negro forests is perhaps an evolutionary adaptation of plant species that makes lower demands upon the restricted amounts of nutrients in the soil (Uhl 1980).

Forest types are roughly divisible into three categories

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that correspond to differences in soil type, terrain, and flooding conditions. Amazonian caatinga, or heath forest, is a type of low, scrubby vegetation that grows in podzols, a whitish, sandy type of soil that is almost entirely useless for agriculture. Although caatinga is most commonly found in low-lying areas along streams and rivers that flood each year during the wet season(s), pockets of podzols supporting scrub vegetation are also located at slightly higher elevations (above 20 m). Terra firma forests are richer in species and considerably taller than caatinga. The main soil types associated with terra firma forests in the Upper Rio Negro region are oxisols with occasional patches of ultisols. These soils are never flooded and provide the most usable soils for indigenous slash-and-burn agriculture. They vary in quality depending upon specific climatic and vegetational history. Between caatinga and terra firma forests there is an intermediate forest type that is found in periodically flooded areas. Intermediate forests contain a mixture of flood resistant, caatinga plants such as Epurua leucantha and taller trees like yebaro (Epurua purpurea) common in terra firma forests.

In the Upper Rio Negro region of Venezuela, research on nutrient-cycling in terra firma forests has demonstrated the important role played by thick layers (5-40 cm) of root mat on the surface of the ground in capturing all available nutrients from falling plant debris, rainfall, and animals (Jordan 1979). Only a fraction of 1% of free nutrients ever

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reaches the soil beneath the root mat (Herrera *et al*. 1978). That feeder roots as well as microrhizomes making up the root mat are also located above the soil surface is another indication that the forest feeds on itself in tightly closed nutrient cycles. In addition, plant species in the forest reduce herbivore pressure through production of secondary substances (mainly humic acids, such as tanin and alkaloids) and have symbiotic associations with epiphytic organisms (Herrera *et al*. 1978). These mechanisms are found also in blackwater forests of Borneo, Sarawak, and other regions of the world. The accumulation of humic acids acts as a means of interspecies competition among plants that is naturally more intense due to the scarcity of nutrients. Unlike the nutrients that are absorbed by root mats before entering in the soil, humic acids and other secondary substances given off by forest species are washed into the sandy soils in great quantities. At a depth of 2 to 3 m, these substances run against an impermeable *capa negra*, and from there flow underground into the nearest stream or river. This constant flow of secondary plant substances is probably the main reason for the black color and high acidity of blackwater rivers (Janzen 1974).

Rivers and streams that drain the oligotrophic forests of the region contain both low levels of nutrients and low *in situ* production of phytoplankton. Fish and aquatic animal species are therefore highly dependent upon external sources of food along river margins: animal matter such as worms, in-

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sects, larvae, and crustaceans or plant products such as flowers, seeds, fruits, leaves, and microflora. The rivers overflow their banks in the wet season(s) and create large areas of flooded forest, allowing fish to enter a semi-terrestrial, semi-aquatic environment that is richer in nutrient sources than the main channel of the river. Many species of fish in blackwater rivers are capable of storing energy surpluses in the form of fatty tissues by exploiting the enhanced food supply of flooded forests (Welcomme 1979). In addition, flooded lands also serve as spawning grounds for some of the more important fish species of the region (e.g., the various subspecies of bocachico, or Leporinus sp.; see below, pp.78-79).

> "In blackwater areas, floodplains are not replenished annually by flooding, as they are on whitewater rivers. Instead, through flooding, the aquatic system is replenished by the forest" (Chernela 1982:18).

Like the trees and other plants of the forests, fish and aquatic animals depend on tightly closed nutrient cycles of the forest for their growth and reproduction.

Indigenous peoples of the Upper Rio Negro region are acutely aware of the interdependency of fish species of the river and plant species of the river margins. When fishing becomes extremely poor at the height of the wet season, Wakuénai men say that it is because the fish have all entered the forest to mate and feed. The Uanano, a Tukano-speaking

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group of the Vaupes River in Brazil, are still more explicit in their recognition that forests along the rivers provide the food for the fish upon which people depend.

> "Forests along rivers are never cultivated because they are considered part of the aquatic system. . . . Apart from small clearings for habitation, they prohibit deforestation at the river margin because they fear a subsequent reduction in the fish population" (Chernela 1982:17).

In practice, Wakuénai groups of the lower Guainía follow the same general rule of clearing gardens only at some distance from river margins except in cases where missionaries or government agents have encouraged them to deforest the lands adjacent to their villages (see Hill and Moran, in press). Although the Wakuénai are somewhat less explicit than the Uanano about the interdependency of aquatic life forms and terrestrial plant growth, their subsistence economy centers around the balancing of human activities that rely upon these two kinds of natural resource.

Daily Subsistence Activities

Agricultural and fishing activities take up roughly equal amounts of time in daily life, and the products of agriculture and fishing form the basis of the daily diet. Early in the morning, men go fishing to catch some meat for the mid-morning communal meal. Women arise even earlier to start cooking fires and prepare hot yucuta (hámuka, or `hot'

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in Wáku; mingáu, Yeral), a type of manioc porridge made by dissolving manioc flat breads in boiling water. The women sometimes leave with their infant children and unmarried daughters to get an early start on their work in the manioc gardens but in general wait for the men to return with the morning catch of fish so that they can work on fuller stomachs. By mid-morning, women have finished cooking the fish brought in by their husbands, and each family contributes some fish or, in its absence, some manioc flat breads to the communal meal. Participation in the communal meals is an important expression of unity in the village. Anyone who does not share his family's food with the rest of the village is quickly labeled as stingy. Conversely, refusal to share in communal meals in the headman's house is a highly visible and tangible way of stating discontentment with the village leadership or with the community as a whole. The spatial arrangements of communal meals highlights the unity of household headmen in the village. The adult men sit or squat in a circle around a large bowl of hot- peppered, boiled fish near the center of the house, while women and children do the same at the rear of the house or around the periphery. At the end of the meal, the men often spend a few minutes smoking, discussing daily activities, and telling stories or myths.

In spite of the intense heat of the late morning and noon hours, this part of the day is when men and women are most likely to work in their manioc swiddens. Fishing becomes very unproductive in the hottest hours of the day, so the men

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usually wait to fish again until mid to late afternoon. Women process manioc and other foods, clean house, and care for infants during the late afternoon hours. They prepare a second communal meal in the early evening, just after sunset. Another, usually longer round of smoking and conversation follows the evening communal meal before everyone returns to their separate family dwellings to sleep for the night. Nowadays, men occasionally go fishing or hunting forest animals from their canoes at night with flashlights and headlamps.

Everyday social life for the Wakuénai revolves around the productive activities of cultivating and processing manioc and fishing and the economic activities of consuming, sharing, and exchanging manioc and fish products. Hunting, gathering wild forest products, communal work parties, house construction, craft and tool making, sexual intercourse, social visiting[1], and all other daily activities elaborate upon this simple pattern of agricultural and fishing activities. The dual emphasis on fishing and agriculture in Wakuénai ecology provides a fairly broad range of viability within which individual families can engage in other activities without jeopardizing their own well-being. The ideals of sharing and reciprocity augment this adaptive flexibility by allowing generous individuals to temporarily rely on other families for basic nutritional needs while engaging in other activities[2]. A household headman who chooses not to participate in the ideology and practice of food

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sharing and exchanging or who gives the impression of taking more than giving loses adaptive flexibility that accrues to those who more faithfully honor the principle of reciprocity.

Ceremonial Food Exchanges

The exchange of fish and manioc products is also central to the cluster of Wakuénai ceremonial activities known as pudáli (see Chapter 9 for greater detail on Wakuénai ceremonies). Pudáli ceremonies are no longer important as food exchanges because migration and social changes engineered by missionaries have greatly altered the traditional pattern of relations among sibs and phratries. Nevertheless, many Wakuénai continue to perform music of the mádzerunái (dance-music of pudáli) genre, and older people still remember the sequence of events that made up traditional pudáli ceremonies. Viewed strictly in terms of food exchanges, pudáli was an exchange between two local groups of smoked fish in return for manioc products. The exchange of fish for manioc was ideally realized between affinal relatives, although in practice any two local groups could agree to hold a pudáli together. In the formal speech of offering the smoked fish to the hosts, the headman of the visitors, called the owner of the ceremony (púdalímnali), addressed the host headman's wife as `my younger sister' (nuwédua), regardless of whether or not she actually stood in such a relationship to him[3]. The gift of fish had to be repaid with gifts of grated manioc pulp in a subsequent pudáli ceremony in which the roles of guest and host were reversed. The owner

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of the second ceremony was the woman (púdalímnaru) who had formally received fish from her 'older brother' (rupérri) during the first pudáli.

Sexual Division of Labor

The pudáli ceremony gave expression not only to the balanced importance of agricultural and fishing activities in Wakuénai ecology but also to the complementarity of male and female roles in maintaining both kinds of subsistence activity within viable ranges[4]. In everyday social life, the division of labor between the sexes with respect to agricultural and fishing activities is one of complementarity and interlocking sets rather than a rigid distinction between male and female roles. Men are responsible for cutting and burning new gardens, both men and women participate in planting and weeding, and women harvest, replant, and process manioc and other crops (see Figure 3.1). Unlike many other Amazonian societies, the Wakuénai do not place a higher value on fishing, hunting, and other predominantly male subsistence activities than on agricultural activities. In fact, men are still judged in their capacities as household headmen by their execution of agricultural activities, in spite of the demise of the traditional custom of brideservice.

On first look, fishing appears to be more sharply divided between male and female roles than agriculture. Men capture and kill the fish, whereas women cook and distribute it within the family and the village. Yet even here the division of labor is blurred, since girls prior to initia-

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Type of activity	Cutting	Burning	Planting	Weeding	Harvesting	Processing
Male, female, or both	Male	Male	Both male & female	Both male & female	Female	Female

Figure 3.1. The sexual division of labor in agricultural activities among the Wakuénai

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tion, widows, and women past menopause often do some fishing with hooks and lines, although not with traps, spears, or bows and arrows. Also, fishing with poison in the dry season is a cooperative activity in which both men and women harvest the stunned fish floating on the water's surface (see Figure 3.2). "In general, fishing is an activity for both men and women, though youths and men are more likely to spend whole days at it than women" (Wright 1981: 22). The extra time that men spend fishing balances the amount of time that women devote to processing manioc and cooking fish. In summary, both men and women provide significant labor inputs into the activities of fishing and agriculture, although men tend to spend more time on fishing and women on agriculture. No rigid boundaries divide male and female roles in fishing and agriculture, and both kinds of subsistence activity are equally valued for their contribution to domestic and public economic domains.

Seasonality

Fishing and agricultural activities are also complementary in terms of the annual succession of wet and dry seasons. The heaviest inputs of male labor into agriculture consist of cutting, burning, and planting, activities that take place during the short dry season of September to November, the long dry season of January through March, or just at the end of the long dry season in early April. These three periods are also when fish are relatively abundant, and men can catch sufficient amounts of fish to feed their

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Type of activity	Fishing with traps	Fishing with spears, bow and arrows	Fishing with hook and line	Fishing with poison	Smoking, salting, boiling fish
Male, female, or both	Male	Male	Both male & female	Both male & female	Female

Figure 3.2. The sexual division of labor in fishing activities among the Wakuénai

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families and to share at communal meals in far less time than they need to spend on fishing in the wet seasons (cf. Stocks 1982). Average monthly rainfall (see Figure 3.3) and the height of the river are key ecological variables for agriculture and fishing, respectively. Total annual rainfall in the Upper Rio Negro region of Venezuela is approximately 3600 mm, and it is distributed fairly evenly throughout the twelve months of the year. In some years, the amount of rainfall in `dry' season months can be equal to or even greater than rainfall in the wet season months (K. Clark, personal communication). The Wakuénai refer to such natural anomalies as `bad years' or 'years without dry seasons'[5], and they are keenly aware of the problems that such years pose for their subsistence activities.

Wakuénai men cut new gardens during the short September to November dry season so that the felled trees will have as much time as possible to dry out prior to burning and planting at the end of the long dry season. A variety of criteria help the Wakuénai to determine the appropriate time to begin cutting new gardens. The water level of the river, which reaches a peak in late July, remains fairly high throughout August and early September, a period of frequent thunderstorms. Around the middle of September, the river begins to steadily recede for two months. The level may go down almost 4 m, about half of the 7 m vertical drop between highest and lowest annual levels. The drop in river level is perhaps the most important natural indicator that the summer

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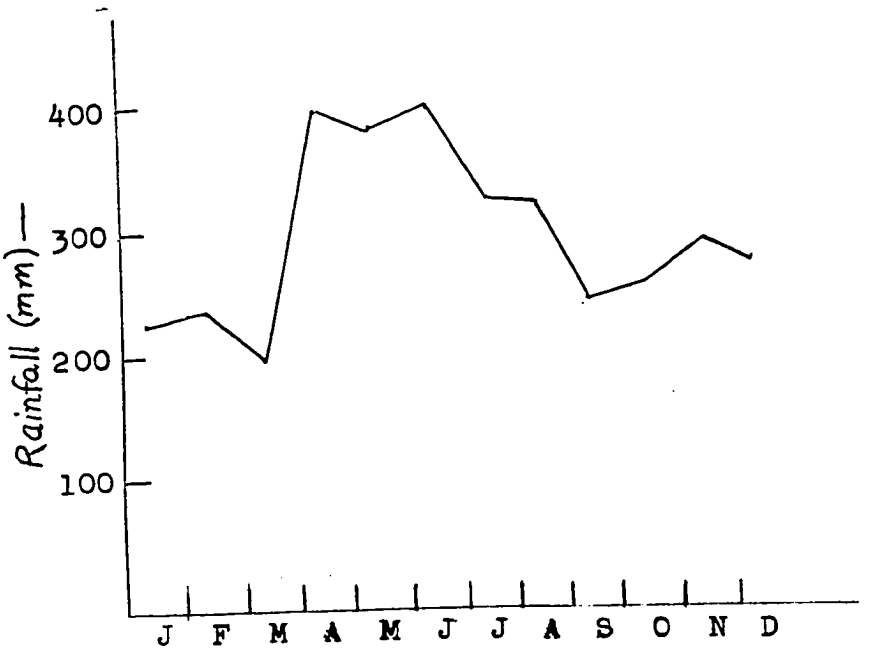


Figure 3.3. Pattern of rainfall in San Carlos de Río Negro (from Herrera et al. 1978:225).

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(kamuíka) has arrived, and the greatly improved fishing that accompanies the drop in river level allows men to devote more time and energy to agriculture. Two constellations are associated with the short dry season: Mákwapidánia (untranslatable) and Kéwedápani ("Big Head" of an anaconda; Scorpio[6]). Gusty winds that often accompany the relatively dry weather of these two months are another indication that it is time to cut new gardens. According to myth, the winds are a manifestation of Káali, a younger brother of Iñápirríkuli and originator of gardens and all cultivated plant species, who arrives during Mákwapidánia to help the men knock down the forest. Although strong or sudden winds can in practice be very dangerous by blowing down partially cut trees on top of a man working on the forest floor, the Wakuénai men believe that the work of cutting proceeds more safely and with less effort if they work in synchrony with Káali during the short dry season rather than postpone the work of cutting until the long dry season.

The importance of the drop in river level, constellations, and gusty winds as signs of the proper time for cutting new gardens is perhaps greater than in the past for Wakuénai groups living along the lower Guainía in Venezuela, since the most important natural phenomenon traditionally used to indicate the proper time for agricultural activities throughout the year is a species of frog (molítu) which is said to abound along the Isana and upper Guainía but which does not exist along the lower Guainía. The molítu frog is

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referred to as one of Káali's children (Káaliéni) and is also the name of an important musical instrument played in kwépani ceremonies (see Chapter 9)[7]. The high-pitched singing of the molítu frogs provided the Wakuénai with a year-round schedule for agricultural activities. It sings in September and October, 'telling' the men to go cut new gardens. It stops singing in November and does not start up again until late March and April, when it is believed to tell people to go burn and plant in the gardens. It stops singing during the heavy rains of late April and May until the slightly drier months of June and July, when it is interpreted as telling people to go weed and clean their gardens. In August, the molítu frogs stop singing until the beginning of the short dry season in middle or late September. According to traditional beliefs, when people work in synchrony with the 'orders' of Káali's son, their agricultural activities proceed smoothly and quickly, but if they ignore the mythical calendar of the molítu frog's singing their labor is slow and difficult.

Selection and Preparation of Garden Lands

With migration to the lower Guainía of Venezuela, the Wakuénai not only lost the timing clock for clearing but they also lost the most important plant-soil association for deciding which soils to cultivate. The large trees known as móri (unidentified) that grow in pockets of relatively fertile, yellowish soils along the middle Isana and upper Guainía do not grow in any of the soils along the lower

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Guainía in Venezuela. The preferred soils for manioc cultivation along the lower Guainía are black (e.g., 10 R/1.3/1.8, Japanese Soil Color Chart) or brownish black (e.g., 7.5 YR/2.2/1.7) in color and are composed of sand mixed with some clay and a high percentage of organic matter[8]. Prior to cutting, these blackish soils support 30 m tall stands of yebaro (Epurea purpurea) and other hardwoods. After clearing and burning, these soils are suitable for the cultivation of bitter manioc (Manihot Escuelenta), pineapple (Ananas sp.), hot pepper (Capsicum frutescens), tupiro (Physalis pubescens), mapuey (Dioscorea trifida), cashews (Anarcadium rhinocarpus), and in some cases sweet manioc (Manihot dulcis) and auyama (Cucurbita maxima). However, other crops which the Wakuénai formerly cultivated on their native lands grow either poorly or not at all in the highly acidic, nutrient-poor soils located along the lower Guainía. Such crops include maize (Zea mays), watermelon (Citrullus vulgaris), squash (Lagenaria siceraria), potato (Ipomea batatas), yam (Discorea alata), and beans (Phaseolus vulgaris). Village clearings are cultivated with plantains (Musa paradisiaca), lemons (Citrus limonum), temari (unidentified), papaya (Carica papaya), guama (Inga edulis), pijiguao (Giulielma gasipaes), cucurito (Maximiliana regis), and a number of other fruits.

After choosing and cutting new garden sites during the short dry season, there is a temporary lull in agricultural activities during the short, one-month wet season. This period of relative inactivity (roughly mid-November through

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mid-December) is named after the constellation of the white heron (máari, Curri.; Casmerodius albus egrettus), called Máarinai. The name also refers to the flocks of migratory white herons which begin to fly south down the Rio Negro during the short rainy season. The river level returns to within a meter or two of its highest annual level during Maarinai, and fishing becomes less and less productive, requiring greater labor inputs for smaller returns.

The long dry season begins in late December as the river level begins to steadily and more rapidly decline and the constellation called Zúrunai appears in the evening sky. The second half of the long dry season is marked by the appearance of a constellation called Dzáaka (crayfish) and lasts from early February through mid-March. The Zurunai-Dzaaka months are a period of relative abundance in fishing, and whole villages often travel up the Casiquiare River or the Caño San Miguel to fish with spears, hook and line, or barbascu (Piper piscatorum) fish poison. Although new gardens are most often cut during the short dry season, they are sometimes cut in January at the beginning of the long dry season. More frequently, men cut extensions of old gardens at this time of year, since these smaller clearings naturally tend to dry out faster because of their greater exposure to sunlight than new gardens surrounded by high forest.

Main Planting and Fish Spawning Runs

Both agriculture and fishing activities come to an annual climax during the period known as Waríperíhnúme (the

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mouth of Waríperí; the period immediately preceding the Pleiades). Waríperíhnúme lasts from late March to mid-April and is the time of the main planting, an activity in which all adult men and women of each village participate either collectively or as separate husband-wife teams. In their native territories along the Isana and upper Guainía, the Wakuénai performed spells in newly-cleared and burned gardens prior to the main planting.

> "Well before the heavy rains begin (in the time of the Pleiades), an elder (father or mother of the garden-owners) begins planting a small patch of manioc in the garden middle, turning the earth and reciting spells, invoking Káali (who began manioc) who will ensure the growth of the new gardens" (Wright 1981: 19).

The Wakuénai groups living along the lower Guainía in Venezuela no longer practice ritual spells at planting time as well as other magical techniques designed to increase garden productivity through the association of human agricultural labor with the mythical power of Káali[9]. Migration into an extremely poor, oligotrophic environment which lacked certain natural phenomena seen as manifestations of Káali (or his children) and removal from sacred ancestral homelands must be counted as primary `emic' factors that have contributed to the secularization of Wakuénai agriculture along the lower Guainía.

The main planting that takes place in Waríperíhnúme re-

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quires the harvesting of large amounts of manioc tubers from one or two-year old gardens in order to accumlate a sufficient number of manioc shoots for planting in new gardens. In an agricultural cycle dominated by bitter manioc cultivation[10], the time of main planting is also when the largest harvest is reaped. Waríperí (the Pleiades), the period in April and early May immediately following the main planting, is considered the ideal time to hold traditional pudáli cermonies. However, since harvesting and replanting manioc is a continuous activity throughout most of the year, pudáli ceremonies can also be held at other seasons when fish are relatively abundant. Pudáli ceremonies are most clearly associated with agriculture through the story of the origin of mádzerunái, the genre of dance-music performed in pudáli. In the myth, Káali trains the youngest of his sons (Káaliéni) to be the first master musician (mádzeru) so that he would know how to properly ask for food and drink through singing, dancing, and playing the various musical instruments of the mádzerunái genre. Thus, in one sense, pudáli celebrated a periodic abundance of manioc following the main planting as a consequence of the synchronization of human productive and economic activities with the mythical timing of Káali and his children.

Pudáli also celebrated the abundant supply of fish that begins in the Zúrunai-Dzáaka dry season and culminates in the spectacular spawning migrations of bocachico (Leporinus sp.) fish species in the transition from dry to wet seasons. The

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rivers usually begin to rise in late March during Waríperí-hnúme, and the first wave of migrating fish arrives soon after the rising waters flood over to form shallow lakes along streams. The first species to migrate is the red-tailed bocachico (dúpari), followed by the spotted bocachico (dúme) and later by the white bocachico (táari) during the period of Waríperí. The timing of bocachico migrations usually proceeds according to this order but is susceptible to changes in years when river level rises too abruptly or when the dry season has been unusually rainy. The locations of bocachico spawning grounds are highly site- specific and regular. On the lower Guainía, bocachico spawn in a shallow lake along a stream called `Bocachico'. The mouth of the stream is blocked off with large cacuri fish traps after a wave of fish has passed into the lakes upstream. Swarms of fish are captured when they attempt to return to the river's main channel on the following day. Bocachico are the most highly- prized fish for eating because of their high fat content and excellent flavor, and the Wakuénai who live near the Caño Bocachico gorge themselve on the surplus of fish. In addition, they prepare for the long wet season by smoking, salting, and grinding surplus fish with a mortar and pestle.

Fish Runs in Ceremonial Symbolism

In pudáli ceremonies where male owners (púdalímnali) offered large quantities of smoked fish, the Wakuénai performed a series of dances named after the three main species of bocachico. The dances are performed to the accompaniment of

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large, trumpet-like instruments known as kúlirína which make a deep, bass sound that is believed to recreate the sound of a stream filled to the brim with bocachico fish. The guest men and women performed the three bocachico dances (táari, dúme, and dúpari) during the early stages of pudáli while the heap of smoked fish was still out on the village plaza prior to its ceremonial offering to the hosts' headman and his wife (pantímnali and pantímnaru, "house-owners"). The construction of kúlirína trumpets and the symbolism of their usage in pudáli dances is a complex subject worthy of independent attention in another context (see Chapter 9). Here I want only to point out those features of kúlirína construction and performance that most directly contribute to an understanding of Wakuénai ecology and its uniqueness within the Northwest Amazon region.

The kúlirína trumpets, known as surubí in Yeral, are named after a species of large catfish (kulírri, Curri.; Brachyplatystoma sp.) that is referred to in Spanish as raiao (striped) because of the large black band that runs down the sides of the fish. The tubular, slightly bell-shaped resonators (see Figure 3.4) are made by weaving strips of tirita (pwáapwa, Curri.; Ischnosiphon obliquus) around a balsawood frame and then covering the exterior with a melted resin (máini, Curri.; combination of resins from Monorobea montana and Mimusops bidentata) to seal off airholes. A short tube made of mavi (máwi, Curri.; Astrostudium schomburgkii) palmwood is inserted into the barrel by lashing it into a rim

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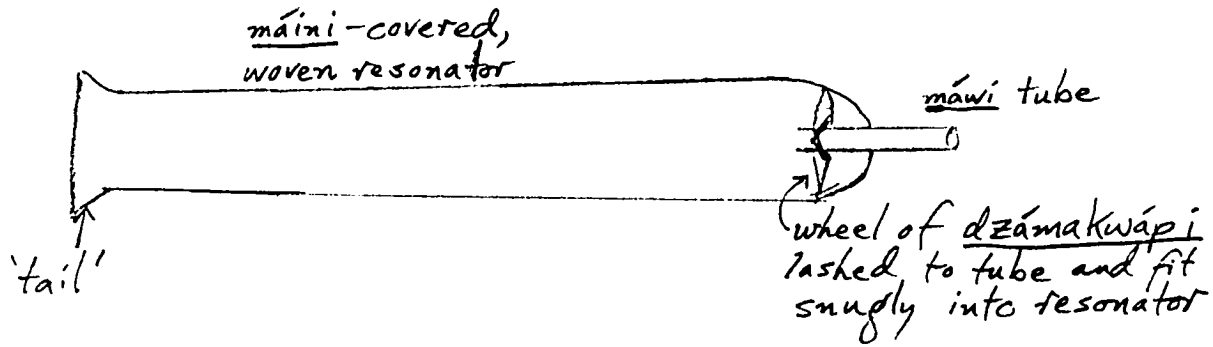


Figure 3.4. Sketch showing construction of kúlirrína trumpets

of vine (dzámakuápi, Curri.; unidentified) that fits snugly into the interior walls of the woven barrel. The closing of the head or mouth of kúlirína trumpets is a sight forbidden to women, since the Wakuénai believe that to witness this process of sealing and closing could cause women to die in childbirth. The union of male and female elements in the construction of kúlirína trumpets (see Chapter 9) is paralleled in the bocachico dances by the formation of chains of male trumpet- players and female dancers. Upon the completion of construction, the kúlirína is a shiny black instrument shaped rather like a large catfish with a long, projecting mouth or proboscis. The men decorate them with red and white paint and feathers. On the white areas representing the belly of the catfish, two types of design are painted in red color made from kérawídzu (Curri.; unidentified, not same as onoto, Bixa orellana), a cultivated plant: 1) an emblem standing for the phratric name of the instrument's maker (nowadays the phratric name is written out in capital letters; e.g., DZAWINAI) and 2) the pattern of lines sketched on manioc grater boards that serves as a guide for the insertion of the stone teeth (Figure 3.5). At the end of pudáli, the guest men who had offered a display of smoked fish to the hosts gave their kúlirína trumpets to the hosts. No other class of musical instrument or ceremonial regalia were exchanged during pudáli. The emblem of the phratric name of the instrument's maker and the manioc grater board designs acted as symbols of the hosts' duty to return the offering of fish in

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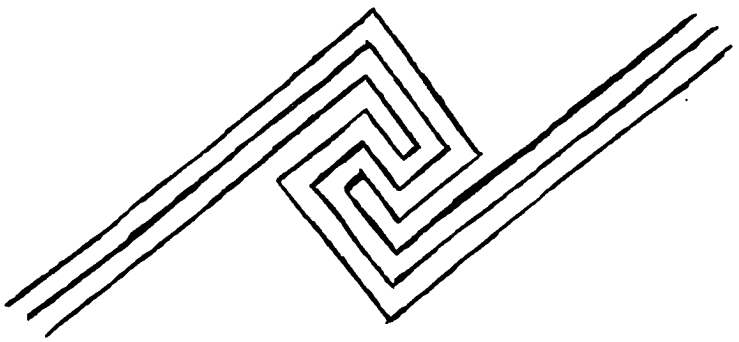


Figure 3.5. Pattern of lines painted on manioc grater boards and kulirrina

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a later pudáli in the form of manioc products.

Kúlirína: A Paradigm of Wakuénai Ecology

The kúlirína trumpets are quintessentially Wakuénai artifiacts and symbolize in highly condensed form the interconnectedness of fishing and agricultural activities in Wakuénai ecology as well as the interdependency of male and female in the maintenance of these subsistence activities. Nimuendajú intuitively grasped the cultural importance of kúlirína trumpets among the `Baniwa' of the Isana River and cited them as one of the most distinctive differences between Tukanoan and Arawakan groups of the Northwest Amazon region.

> ". . . the large "surubí flutes" and the high development of ceramic arts is only found among the Baniwa of the Isana; the masked dances and manufacture of low benches characterizes the Tukanoan family"(Nimuendajú 1950 [1927] : 164-65, translation mine).

Kúlirína performances and the larger ceremonial context of pudáli have all but disappeared in the wake of missionary interventions aimed at the obliteration of indigenous culture and the disruptive effects of forced migration out of native territories along the Isana and upper Guainía. The construction of kúlirína trumpets requires far more time and energy than any of the other traditional instruments of the mádzerunái genre, and this fact probably contributed to the discontinuation of kúlirína dances.

In response to my curiosity about traditional pudáli

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ceremonies, the headman of one village decided to construct a set of five kúlirína trumpets. Although originally designed as a demonstration for the anthropologist, the trumpets became a topic of general interest to young men in the village and to a large number of people in the region who had heard about the instruments but had never actually seen how they are made and used. By the time the local men had finished constructing and decorating the kúlirína, a number of young men and visitors had learned how to make kúlirína trumpets and over 150 visitors from five villages had assembled to observe the bocachico dances. The visiting parties included members of other Arawak-speaking groups such as Baniwa, Guarequena, and Yeral[11], in addition to Wakuénai from nearby villages. This spontaneous outpouring of interest in kúlirína trumpets testifies to the instruments' importance in traditional Arawakan cultures of the Northwest Amazon region and their potential value as a focal point in cultural revitalization.

The Long Wet Season: Scarcity

Agricultural and fishing activities simultaneously culminate in the annual main planting of new gardens and the trapping of migrating schools of bocachico during the Waríperíhnúme-Waríperí period. The double abundance of food resources in the early wet season is in stark contrast with the period of increasing scarcity that begins in May and continues until the river reaches its annual peak in late July. The Wakuénai divide the long wet season into three sections

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following the commencement of heavy rains and the rising of the river in Waríperí: Úpitsína (a constellation resembling the type of small conical fish traps called upítsi), Kákudzúdi (a bright star first seen in July), and Iñéwia (the constellation of the otter, Pteroneura brasilensis). Fishing becomes extremely poor in these months and only slightly improves during the August-September month called Umáinai (constellation of the pirana fish; úmai, Curri.; Serrasalmus notatus). Everyone looks forward to the beginning of summer in Mákwapidánia. In Figure 3.6, I set out the entire calendar of Wakuénai 'months' together with parallel seasonal changes in weather, river level, the relative abundance of fish, the singing/silence of molítu frogs, and the major agricultural activities.

Hunting and Wild Fruit Collection

The importance of hunting and wild fruit collection in subsistence is secondary to that of fishing and agriculture. Game is scarce near main rivers, probably due to overhunting since the introduction of shotguns coupled with the low natural productivity of the region. Nowadays, all adult men among the Wakuénai own shotguns in the majority of villages along the lower Guainía in Venezuela. Hunting with bow and arrows is no longer practiced, and the use of blowguns for hunting birds, monkeys, and other arboreal animals is rapidly disappearing. The high costs of shotgun shells, lead shot, powder, and detonators sometimes prevent Wakuénai men from hunting. Nevertheless, the Wakuénai are avid hunters and

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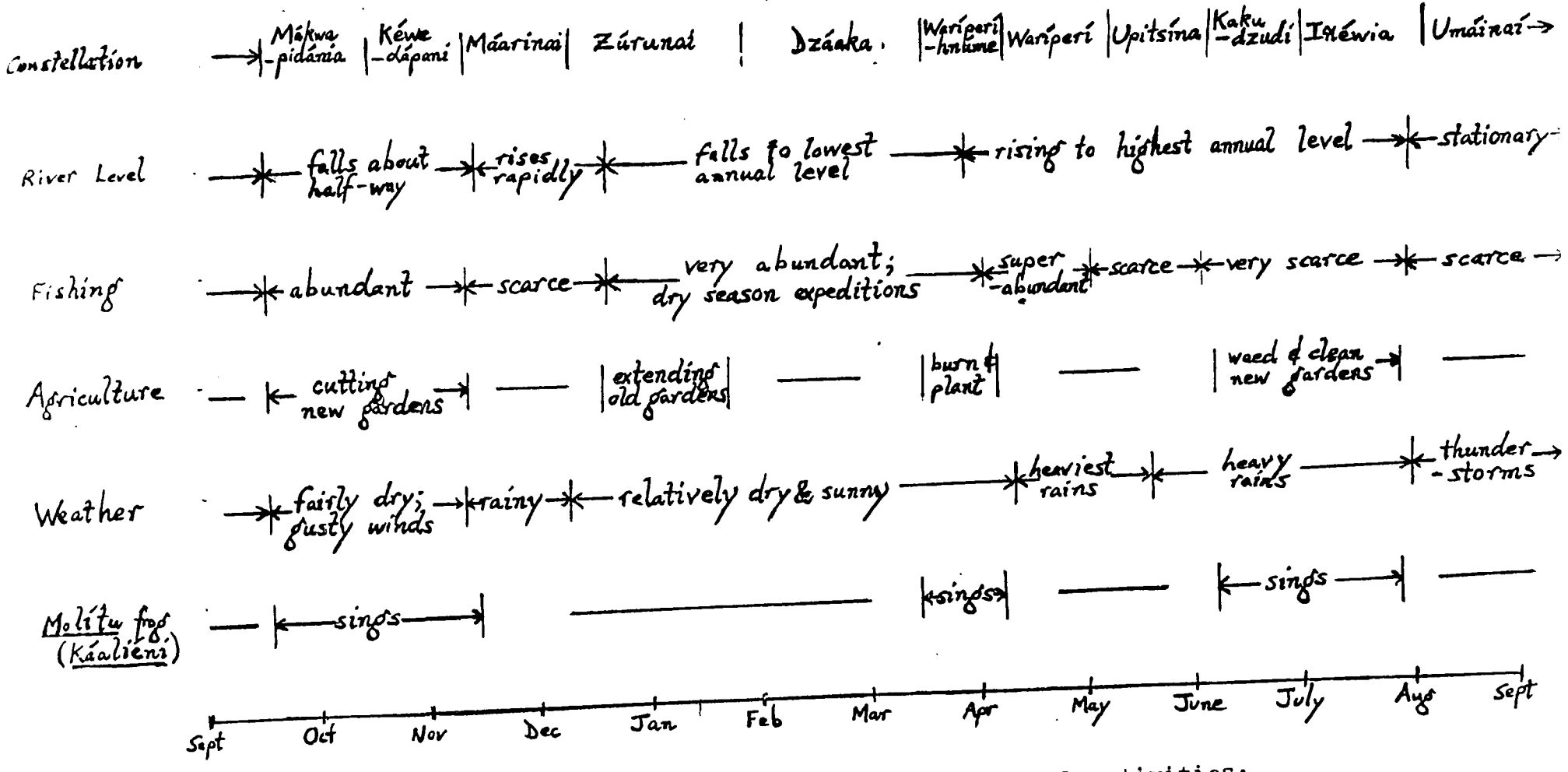


Figure 3.6. Annual cycle of fishing and agricultural activities; seasonal changes of important natural phenomena

spend whole days tracking animals through the forest if given the opportunity.

Two species of peccary, the white-lipped (apídza, Curri.; Tayassu pecari) and white-collared (dzámurito, Curri.; Pecari tajacu), are the most highly sought after game animals and are the only large forest animals that are killed with any regularity at all. Small groups of men sometimes track herds of peccary with the aid of dogs. Peccary herds of a hundred or more animals travel over great distances in the forest and leave a very evident trail of diggings, footprints, feces, and chewed vegetation. Most hunters are opportunistic and prefer to wait until a herd is spotted in the area of their village rather than spend days in pursuit of a distant herd. Peccary herds generally stay well clear of main rivers where there are human settlements except at the end of the long rainy season. When the rivers stop rising, the herds move closer to the water's edge and on occasion within easy range of hunters. In August, 1980, for example, a herd came down to the water within a village clearing and the men clubbed to death seventeen animals that were in shallow water. In August, 1981, the men of another village captured two young peccaries that were swimming in the main channel of the river. In most cases, however, hunting peccary is a far more time-consuming pursuit that requires a good deal of tiresome walking and running through the forests. Adult peccaries weigh 30 kg or more, so the job of carrying slain animals back to a canoe is hard work.

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The only other animal for which Wakuénai men hunt in a semi-organized manner is lapa (dápa, Curri.;Cuniculus paca). They kill these large rodents at night from their canoes, especially in the dry seasons when the animals come down to eat mossy plants that grow along the banks of streams. Aside from peccaries and lapa, hunters occasionally kill deer (Mazama americana), tapir (Tapirus terrestris), monkeys (Cebus sp., Alouatta seniculus, Pithecia chiropotes, Ateles belzebuth), anteaters (Tamandua tetradactyla, Myrmecophaga tridactyla), jaguar (Panthera onca mayor), puma (Puma concolor anthony), ocelot (Leopardus pardalis malanarus), armadillo (Dasypus novemcinctus, Priodontes giganteus), alligator (Caiman latirostris), small rodents (Dasyprocta aguti, Mesosciurus griseogena), curassows (Pauxi pauxi), and other birds (Nothocrax urumutum, Jabiru mycteria). A hunter who kills any animal of substantial size is obligated to share the meat with other families in the village. Smaller animals and birds are not usually shared in this manner but are eaten by the individual hunter and his family. However, in extremely lean periods, even these smaller prey are boiled into a soup which everyone shares in a communal meal.

Unlike the Tukano- speaking Desana who invest hunting activities with a great deal of sexual and religious meaning (Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971), the Wakuénai do not focus much ritual attention upon hunting[12]. The replacement of traditional hunting technology with shotguns might have slightly contributed to the relatively pragmatic attitudes and be-

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havior of Wakuénai hunters, since there were a number of dietary prohibitions that surrounded the preparation of curare poison for hunting with bow and arrows and blowguns. Already in the early years of this century (Matos Arvelo 1912: 95), the traditional taboo against killing and eating animals of the totemic species of the local group had not been observed for many years among the Wakuénai, Baniwa, and Guarequena of the lower Guainía. Although hunting was more firmly embedded in dietary taboos in the past than it is today, the Wakuénai have apparently never developed a system of sexual and dietary restrictions for hunting activities that approaches the magnitude and complexity of such systems among the Tukano-speaking groups of the Northwest Amazon region.

The collection of wild fruits is most heavily practiced in the long wet season, a period when many tree species flower and bear fruit as the rivers and streams overflow their banks to form large areas of flooded forest. Beginning in the time of the Pleiades, the Wakuénai harvest several species of wild fruit. Among the most common of these fruits are manaca (manáake, Curri.; Enterpe oleracea), seje grueso (punáma, Curri.; Jessenia bataua), chique chique (maráma, Curri.; Leopoldina piassaba), yuku (hínirri,Curri.;unidentified), guaco (awíya), and yuri (dumárri). Most fruits are made into manioc drinks, but some are boiled (cucuritu) or roasted (guaco and yuri) and eaten separately. Due to the phenomenon of mast fruiting (see Jansen 1974), the

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trees of the entire region fail to bear fruit every third or fourth year. Such barren years contribute to the general scarcity of food during the long wet season, but the Wakuénai do not speak of hunger as directly resulting from a lack of wild fruits. Instead, they bemoan the effects of the lack of wild fruits on hunting, since they perceive a direct connection between the abundance of wild fruits and the stock of game animals.

While most species of edible wild fruits ripen in the long wet season, a few bear fruit in the dry seasons. The hardwood tree called jaboa (dzápura) flowers during the early part of the short dry season (Mákwapidánia) and bears fruit later in the same season. During the long dry season, the palm fruits known as seje finito (púperri) ripen. The ripening of wild fruit species tends to follow the general schedule outlined here, and the Wakuénai associate different points in this schedule with definite constellations in their annual calendar. However, the timing of wild fruit species does not always and everywhere conform to this ideal pattern, and there is a good deal of local variation due to microenvironmental differences. At a time when no particular species of wild fruit is ripe along the rivers, a relatively abundant supply of seje or manaca might be ripening in some remote area of the forest. Wakuénai hunters observe such local variation, and if they come across a grove of ripening fruit trees while hunting and are unsuccessful in their pursuit of game animals, they harvest the fruits before returning to

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their village so as not to come home empty-handed.

Both hunting and wild fruit collection are exclusively male activities, but in myth and ritual it is the activity of wild fruit collection rather than that of hunting which serves as the model for the division of labor between the sexes. The symbolic value of wild fruit collection rests on a high/low distinction that is in turn applied to the male/female opposition in ritual contexts. Only men climb high trees to harvest wild fruits. Women can only harvest low-lying fruits that they can reach from the ground or cultivated plant species, such as hot peppers (*áati*) and bitter manioc (*káini*) , that grow either close to the surface of the ground or below it. The symbolism of wild fruit collection and the male/female opposition are intricately wound up in Wakuénai initiation rituals and *kwépani* ceremonies. Without an abundance of wild fruits to harvest, the Wakuénai say that they cannot hold any of these sacred rituals or ceremonies. However, there is no immediately clear connection between the everyday activity of wild fruit collection and its symbolic value in ritual and ceremonial contexts.

Earlier in this chapter, I have shown how the double abundances of manioc products and smoked fish are directly represented in traditional *pudáli* ceremonies through musical instruments and performances, such as the *kúlirína* trumpets and their use in the bocachico dances, which are attributed to *Káali*, the mythical originator of gardens and cultivated plant species. In contrast to the *mádzerunái* genre of dance

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music performed in pudáli, the musical performances and instruments of kwépani ceremonies, male and female initiation, and other sacred rituals are not at all directly related to everyday subsistence activities but are based on sacred conceptual principles which I will describe in the next chapter and continue to elaborate upon throughout the dissertation.

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1. Matos Arvelo (1912: 184-85) describes a custom of mutual aid through long-term visiting that is not frequently practiced today. Visitors on long trips were given use of their relatives' manioc swiddens for several months. When the visitors saw that their hosts' garden was nearing depletion, they invited their hosts to return with them to their village where their own manioc plantings had had time to ripen.

2. The adaptive flexibility of sharing and exchanging surplus foods within the village is vulnerable to the effects of epidemic diseases that undermine the ability of entire villages to carry out daily subsistence activities. When the total adult population of a village is bedridden for weeks at a time, as was the case in many villages during the measles epidemic of early 1980, people are almost as likely to die from lack of food as from fever or other symptoms of the disease itself.

3. This practice suggests that pudáli ceremonies served to classify sibs of different phratries according to the kin/affine distinction. Such classification could have the effect of initiating affinal alliances between two groups which had not intermarried for the past two generations, the depth of genealogical relations among the Wakuénai. My interpretation here supports Matos Arvelo's observation that "The consequence of these

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dabucuris (Yeral term for pudáli or exchange ceremonies) is the friendly coming together of the tribes through this commercial and social contact and through the numerous marriages that always result from such visits" (1912: 163). Alternatively, the classification of guests and hosts as affinal relatives in pudáli could have the effect of confirming pre-existing ties of affinity.

4. Women are very active participants in dancing, drinking, and other ceremonial activities during pudáli, whereas their participation in other rituals and ceremonies is more restricted. The role of púdalímnaru, or female owner of pudáli, is the only formally recognized leadership role for women in Wakuénai society. Although I have never observed a traditional pudáli ceremony, I have seen women play very active roles in the organizing and staging of musical performances and dancing of the mádzerunái genre.

5. The Wakuénai term for year is pawária (Curripaco dialect). The term for wet season or winter (úniya) derives from the words for water (úni) and rain (íiya), whereas the term for dry season (kamuíka) derives from the word for sun (kamuí, Curripaco dialect).

6. My knowledge of astronomy is very limited, and I could identify only two of the eleven Wakuénai constellations with any certainty: Kéwedápani (Scorpio) and Waríperí

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(the Pleiades).

7. The molítu flute is unique among Wakuénai wind instruments insofar as it produces quasi-verbal messages instead of purely melodic sounds. Women who are secluded in a separate house during kwépani ceremonies ask the molítu player to tell his name, and the flute-player must name someone other than himself so as not to reveal his own identity. He 'speaks' the name through the flute, thus further disguising his identity from the women (see Chapter 9).

8. Dr. Rafael Herrera, a soil scientist at the Centro de Ecologia of the Instituto Venezolano de Investigaciones Cientificas (IVIC) and co-director of the MAB-UNESCO ecology project based at San Carlos de Rio Negro, believes that these black soils are anthropogenic and indicate previous settlement and/or cultivation dating back to prehistoric times.

9. In a myth about the origin of garden work, Káali used a fishing line to clear forest for new gardens and had special baskets which would go about the clearings and plant manioc shoots in the soil. These magical techniques for clearing forest and planting gardens cost Káali very little effort and almost no time. Some men and women grew curious to know how Káali could work so fast, so they spied on him and later tried to imitate his techniques. Not only did they fail, but Káali

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punished them for trying to steal his secrets. Since then, people have had to work slowly and with great effort in order to clear forests and plant new gardens.

10. By my estimation, roughly 95% of the total area in Wakuénai gardens is planted with bitter manioc.

11. The Yeral-speakers referred to here are included under the heading of "other Arawak-speaking groups" because they are mostly descendants of Wakuénai, Baniwa, or Guarequena. There are many Yeral-speakers in San Carlos de Rio Negro and farther downstream who are descendants of Tukano-speakers or non-indigenous caboclos (Amazonian mestizos), and I would not include them in the general category of Arawakan groups (see Chapter 10).

12. The only Wakuénai ritual that explicitly deals with hunting is a genre of shamanistic songs known as ỉyarudáti, also the name of the dark netherworld where both recently-deceased ancestral souls (lidánam) and the generic spirits of forest animals (éenunai) and birds (képinai) are believed to reside. The shaman travels to the home of animal and bird spirits in ỉyarudáti in order to let the animal and bird spirits outside. The shaman's music is said to cause wild tree species to flower and bear fruits that will in turn attract game animals and birds. Different versions of the same music are believed to have the opposite effect of locking up the animal and bird spirits so that people

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are denied access to game animals and birds.

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Chapter 4:

"Wakuénai Cosmology"

The Two Cycles of Wakuénai Myth

Wakuénai myths are divisible into two main cycles. The first cycle begins with the myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli and includes a number of myths about the kinsmen of Iñápirríkuli and their affinal enemies, the kinsmen of Kunáhwerrim. The second cycle focuses on the primordial mother and son, Amáru and Kuwái, and the differentiation of social animals into separate categories of natural species and human, cultural beings. The Kuwái myth cycle actually begins prior to his birth in the story of the origin of women's menstruation when Iñápirríkuli `shoots' Amáru in the groin with a type of dark red berries from the grass known as tsipátsi and causes blood to run from her vagina. After two alternate versions of Kuwái's conception, the next part of the cycle is the story of Kuwái's birth and immediate separation from his mother. Prior to Kuwái's birth, the world was closed and very small in size, including no more space than a single village. When Kuwái was alive in this world he opened it up to its present size, the area traditionally inhabited by the Wakuénai between the Vaupés, Inirida, Negro, and Guainía rivers. Kuwái flew through the sky above this area, filling the landscape with natural objects and with his singing, which could be heard everywhere. Kuwái was

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everything in this world in one being, except for fire. His singing represented all the animal, bird, and fish species of this world, and his body represented all wild plant species, all types of rock and soil, and all colors of water. Kuwái in this world is visualized as a hairy monster with ambiguously human and animal characteristics, a perfect example of the liminal monsters which, in Turner's words,

> "have the pedagogical function of stimulating the liminars' powers of analysis and revealing to them the building blocks from which their hitherto taken-for-granted world has been constructed"(1977: 69).

In short, Kuwái in this world represents a conceptual principle of "all things in one being" that forms one of the building blocks of Wakuénai cosmology.

Using the stories of Kuwái's conception and birth as the dividing point, Wakuénai myths fall into two distinct categories: the cycle of myths about Iñápirríkuli, Káali, and their kinsmen in the distant mythical past and the cycle of myths about Iñápirríkuli, Amáru, and Kuwái (hereafter referred to as the myth cycles of Iñápirríkuli and Kuwái, respectively)[1]. The myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli establishes a distant and closed symbolic space-time in which cosmogonic processes of creation unfolded within the framework of rules and axioms that give order to everyday social experience. The myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli and the myth of the vulture place the rule of patrilocal residence and the custom

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of brideservice at the beginning of Wakuénai cosmic history. The ideology of patrilineal descent receives expression in the myth of the emergence of totemic ancestral spirits and the perpetuation of their descendants' connection with a sacred territory through the mythical powers of Káali and his sons. The mádzerunái genre of music performed in pudáli ceremonies was the only music to come into existence during these ancient mythical times. In many ways, the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli describes a creation that is incomplete. There is no clear distinction in the myths between human beings and animals or between male and female beings. The distinction between "my kinsmen" and "the other people", although clearly and unmistakably evident from the very beginning of mythical time, is a source of constant and violent conflict that is without control or resolution.

The Kuwái myth cycle transforms this violent and incomplete space-time of the mythical past into the social, natural, and supernatural worlds in which the Wakuénai presently live. Two major changes accomplish this transformation of the cosmos: 1) the differentiation of male and female beings (along with the accompanying capacities of men and women to conceive children through sexual intercourse and of women to bear children) and 2) the musical singing and humming of Kuwái in his three different stages of existence. The Kuwái myth cycle begins by explaining the differentiation of male and female beings that leads up to the story of Kuwái's birth, but the majority of myths in the cycle center around

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the life, death, and afterlives of Kuwái. The differentiation of male and female beings is an act of creation by Iñápirríkuli prior to Kuwái's birth, and, taken in itself, it does not actually transform the cosmological order established in the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli so much as meet an important prerequisite for the radical changes that begin after Kuwái's birth. In other words, the musical singing and humming of Kuwái is the primary transformative agent in the completion of the creation that started in the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli.

The importance of music as a model for creation in the Kuwái myth cycle greatly contrasts with the secondary importance of music in the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli. In the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli, the invention of mádzerunái music was merely an offspin of the creative powers of Káali, a deity whose primary mythical function is that of originator and regulator of gardens and cultivated plant species. Music was clearly subordinate to the powerful beings responsible for its creation, and its invention did little or no good to dampen the violent conflicts that characterized relations between different descent groups. Music played a purely passive, instrumental role in social relations by providing a means for properly asking others for food and drink in the ceremonial context of pudáli. In the myth cycle of Kuwái, however, music becomes more powerful than the mythical heroes and in fact usurps from them the power of creation. The singing and humming of Kuwái create the animal, bird, and fish species of the world at the same time as they

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enlarge the physical environment into its present size.

Analysis of the Kuwái Myth Cycle

The Kuwái myth cycle contains a wealth of sexual, psychological, and religious symbolism that is open to an enormously wide range of analysis and interpretation. The Wakuénai are themselves aware of the diversity of symbolism in the Kuwái myth cycle and often use it as a conceptual vehicle for intellectual and philosophical speculations about natural, social, and supernatural relations. These speculations, or "folk explanations", are included in later chapters on Wakuénai sacred musical performances because they reveal some of the ways in which the Wakuénai think about the world and, through music, enact their thoughts in the world they inhabit and experience.

The diversity of symbolism in the Kuwái myth cycle also allows room for a wide range of interpretation from an anthropological or `etic' perspective. One approach that immediately comes to mind is Levi-Strauss's structural analysis of the Greek Oedipus myth.

> "The myth has to do with the inability, for a culture which holds the belief that mankind is autochthonous. . . to find a satisfactory transition between this theory and the knowledge that human beings are actually born from the union of man and woman" (1963a: 216).

The Kuwái myth cycle, in one sense, is about the transition from a mythical space-time in which ancestral spirits emerged

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from the ground to a second mythical space-time in which men and women procreate through sexual intercourse and women give birth to children. The Kuwái myth cycle is built upon this transition from autochthonous origins to sexual reproduction. However, the bulk of the Kuwái myth cycle and the portion in which really profound changes in the cosmological order take place focus upon what happens after the birth of Kuwái. The creative power of Kuwái's music comes to dominate all other mythical themes.

A different analytical perspective guides the ethnohistorical interpretation of the Kuwái myth cycle employed by Wright (1981). His primary motivation is to relate the myth's structure and meaning to historically documented messianic movements of the 19th Century.

> "The extraordinary faith and credibility Baniwa place in such mediatory experiences led me initially to ask what in their myths, shamans' practices and cosmology supports and gives this faith its foundation. The answer I am urging is found in one central myth that the Baniwa tell, the myth of Kuai" (1981: 354).

Wright gives an elaborate and detailed account of the Kuwái myth cycle, including a full translation and transcription of the version which he collected among the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River in Brazil. He also gives translations of two shorter versions of the Kuwái myth collected by Saake (1956) and Galvao (1959), translations of other myths which he col-

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lected in the field, and descriptions of Wakuénai (or `Baniwa´) rituals and ceremonies. Wright more than adequately demonstrates the importance of the Kuwái myth cycle for understanding `Baniwa´ faith in mediatory experiences and, in doing so, provides a wealth of valuable documentation on Wakuénai culture as well as some helpful insights into how the Kuwái myth cycle explains basic features of Wakuénai rituals.

My analysis of the Kuwái myth cycle does not enter into nearly the same depth of detail as Wright´s interpretation and concentrates on the prominence of beliefs in the efficacy of musical sounds as active, creative forces. The central importance of these beliefs only becomes apparent through the contrast of the Kuwái myth cycle with the more distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli. Whereas the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli is primarily about social institutions, warfare, and revenge killings between kin and affines, the Kuwái myth cycle is essentially about the creative power of musical sounds. Wakuénai beliefs in the extraordinary power of musical sounds to act upon natural, social, and supernatural phenomena are the explicit focus of the Kuwái myth cycle. My interest is in identifying certain underlying conceptual principles that the Kuwái myth cycle implicitly encodes and, in later chapters, demonstrating how these conceptual principles are made explicit and intelligible in sacred musical performances that apply the Kuwái myth cycle to the social experience of Wakuénai individuals and groups.

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The Kuwái myth cycle expresses the fundamental importance of beliefs in the efficacy of musical sounds in the transition from a distant mythical past in which basic social institutions were associated with unmitigated bloodshed and violence to the emergence of relatively peaceful and harmonious social relations. The Wakuénai are not the only South American Indian society to place such a heavy emphasis on the power of music to transform a violent and chaotic mythical past into a relatively safe and organized social present. Writing about the sacred COSHAMMATS music of the Arawak-speaking Amuesha in the Peruvian montaña, Chase-Smith observes that

> "Into this world of social chaos and troubled relations with the precocious solar divinity, the Amuesha say that COSHAMMATS music and its ritual celebration were introduced, an event which brought with it revolutionary changes in the Amuesha concept of social and cosmic order" (1981: 12-13).

The belief in the power of music to transform social chaos into social harmony goes a long way towards explaining why music is so important to the Amuesha and the Wakuénai.

The Kuwái Myth Cycle

The following summary of the Kuwái myth cycle is a synthesis of several myths which Hernando Camico, headman of the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán, narrated to me over a period of several months in 1981. Other men in the village gave in-

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terpretations of particular episodes or events in the myth cycle, but their contributions did not add up to a relatively complete cycle of myths about Kuwái comparable to the one related by Hernando. Stylistically, the Kuwái myth cycle resembles the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli insofar as narrators rarely if ever perform more than one myth on any given occasion but prefer rather to single out a specific myth within the cycle. However, one major difference between narrative performances of the two myth cycles is that the myths of Iñápirríkuli are frequently and openly told in everyday social situations, whereas the myths of Kuwái are ordinarily told only in ritual contexts. The situations in which I wrote down the Kuwái myths were private interviews with Hernando, but he did not show any reluctance to continue his narrations in the presence of other people provided that they were adult men or women. Whenever children came into the room, however, he would stop his narration of the Kuwái myths and wait for them to leave, which they usually did without having to be asked. On one occasion, a recently-initiated girl entered the room, sat down, and listened to a phrase or two of the narration, prompting the headman to order her to leave in a hurry. Thus, the Kuwái myth cycle is more restricted in social usage than the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli.

The myth cycle of Kuwái begins with the story of the origin of women's menstruation. As if to foreshadow the great enlargement of the world that is destined to take place after Kuwái's birth, the myth of the origin of women's menstruation

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is initially set at the mythical home of Amáru at the headwaters of a stream called Cano Waraná rather than the village of Iñápirríkuli on the Aiarí River. The mythical home of Amáru is a rock outcrop called Mútsipáni, a name derived from the words for seje palm grubs (mútsi) and dance (-páni). The rock is shaped roughly like a woman's body in reclining position, and the stream flows towards the east out of a crevice that is said to represent the vagina of Amáru. Below Mútsipáni, the stream has many sharp turns, and these curves, called Dzúkwarri, are the indigenous name for Cano Waraná. The rock is believed to be very dangerous for women and non-specialized men, and only shamans (malírri) and owners of sacred chants (málikai limínali) can safely go there[2]. Hernando Camico, an owner of sacred chants, and his brother, a shaman, claim to have climbed Mútsipáni and say that the singing of Kuwái (the deep hissing sound of the ancestor trumpets) was constantly audible at the top.

M1: "The Origin of Women's Menstruation"

> Amáru, one of Iñápirríkuli's aunts on the paternal side, had a shotgun[3], and Iñápirríkuli knew that Amáru was planning to shoot him with it to make into the first woman. If successful, Amáru would become the first man, the first to have a penis, and Iñápirríkuli did not want to let that happen. Thus, he devised a plan for stealing Amáru's shotgun by cutting a piece of balsawood and carving it into the form of a shotgun.
>
> Amáru came to shoot Iñápirríkuli with her `shot-

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gun', but Iñápirríkuli was ready with the real one and shot a load of tiny, dark red berries into her groin, causing blood to run down her legs. Amáru had to sit down and hide her condition from men. She also had to fast until the blood stopped running. If Iñápirríkuli had not changed shotguns with Amáru, men would now menstruate instead of women. Before Iñápirríkuli stole Amáru's shotgun and shot her with it, men and women both harvested manioc in gardens and processed it into flour and flat breads.

M2: "The Conception and Birth of Kuwái"

Iñápirríkuli secretly made love to Amáru many times until she became pregnant with Kuwái[4]. They were both very afraid to let anyone else know about their sexual intercourse because they were of the same patrilineal sib (náiki).

Amáru became pregnant with Iñápirríkuli's child, but she could not give birth to the child because she had no birth canal. Two brothers of Iñápirríkuli, Dzúli (the first owner of sacred chants and songs) and Dzulíhwerri (the first shaman), sent for various bird and fish species to try to open up a birth canal. At last, the mataguaru (adáru wawím, Curri.; unidentified) fish penetrated with the full length of its body. Amáru gave birth to Kuwái, a hairy, half-human, male creature, but she died in childbirth.

Iñápirríkuli, Dzúli, and Dzulíhwerri took Kuwái

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away from his mother immediately after his birth so that no one would know that Iñápirríkuli was the father. When Kuwái was born, the others called him Máhnekánari ("No one knows") or Hekwápi ikáina ("Sperm of this world") because nobody, not even Kuwái himself, knew who was his father. Iñápirríkuli and his brothers took Kuwái to live in the sky (Ẽenu) because they were ashamed that he had been born of an incestuous sexual relationship and they were afraid that he might harm the others.

After leaving Kuwái, Iñápirríkuli and his brothers returned to revive Amáru. The placenta and afterbirth had turned into a stingray (yámaru, Curri.; Potamotrygon hystrix), and the three men tried to convince Amáru that she had given birth to nothing else. However, Amáru knew that they were lying and had stolen her child from her. She warned them that she would steal Kuwái back someday.

M3: "Kuwái Opens the World"

For a long time, no one knew about Kuwái because Iñápirríkuli and his brothers kept him hidden in the sky. The singing and humming of Kuwái's voice did not reach the others because he always sang into a clay pitcher that muffled his voice. Kuwái grew very rapidly in his house in the sky. Even though he was still young, he appeared to be old.

One day, Iñápirríkuli's youngest brother, Hérri,

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and three of his nephews were out walking and saw Kuwái flying and singing in the sky. They asked Kuwái to come back to eat with their family, but Kuwái told them that he was fasting. The boys had to start fasting then, too, because they had seen Kuwái. The only food which they could safely eat was a manioc drink made from wild forest fruits. They lied to their parents whenever it came time to eat, saying that they were not hungry and only wanted to drink yucuta (pacáka, term for manioc beverages in general in Curricarro dialect) made from wild forest fruits.

Iñápirríkuli knew that the boys were lying and that they had seen Kuwái. He went to talk with Kuwái and invited him to come down to his village. There he could stay in a special hut in the forest that Iñápirríkuli would build for him. Kuwái said he would come to visit in the afternoon.

When Kuwái appeared in the sky above the village, the men and four boys greeted him on the village plaza with yucuta made by the women. Women and children stayed inside their houses where they could not see Kuwái. The singing and humming of Kuwái opened up the world, enlarging it for the first time. He began by singing the song of the lapa (dápa, Curri.; Cuniculus paca), and the world opened up somewhat. Then he flew to all regions and sang all the animal, bird, and fish species. He went as far as the Guaviare to the north

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and the Vaupés to the south and west, opening up the world everywhere and filling it with all living creatures. The people listened to Kuwái's voice from far away.

M4: "The Origin of Male Initiation and Death of Kuwái"

Kuwái landed in Iñápirríkuli's village and instructed the four boys to fast so that they would grow up strong and healthy. He took them to the special hut made of palm fronds and told them to go inside and begin their month-long fast. During this period, the boys were allowed to eat only manioc and fruit drinks which Kuwái had treated with special chants.

When the month was nearly over and the boys were very hungry, Kuwái picked some guaco (awíya, Curri.; Guazuma ulmifolia(?)) fruits from a tall tree and let them fall into the roofless hut where the boys were fasting. The three nephews of Iñápirríkuli (Máarinárièni, Menakwíwa, and Túp-híwa) ate some of the fruits, but Hérri, Iñápirríkuli's brother, did not eat any. Kuwái entered the hut later to see which of the boys had eaten the fruit. He opened their mouths to examine their teeth and found that the three newphews of Iñápirríkuli had indeed eaten some fruits. Only Hérri's mouth was completely clean and showed that he had not eaten any fruits.

Kuwái caused a storm with heavy rains which fell directly into the boys' hut. He came disguised as a

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rock to give them shelter. The rock had a large opening that led to a room the size of a house. This room was actually Kuwái's mouth. Iñápirríkuli's three nephews entered the rock to get out of the rain, but Hérri made a tiny shelter for himself with leaves of a seje palm and remained outside. When the rains were about to subside, Kuwái closed his giant mouth, killing and eating the three boys who had entered. Kuwái told Hérri that he would blow smoke and chant for him in three days so that he could break his fast.

Before leaving for his home in the sky, Kuwái came out of the forest where he had eaten the three boys and entered Iñápirríkuli's village in the late afternoon[5]. Iñápirríkuli had prepared four trays of wild fruits (awíya and punáma, Jessenia bataua) prior to Kuwái's arrival. Kuwái came to see the fruits in the village and returned to his hut in the forest. Then he flew up into the sky and made various aerial passes over the village until he was finally so high up that he went out of sight. Kuwái left because he knew that Iñápirríkuli was planning to kill him.

Iñápirríkuli collected some of the seje palm grubs and took them to Iñápirríkuli devised a plan to lure Kuwái back to the village with ceje palm grubs (mútsi). He sent the grubs up to Kuwái's home in the sky with a wasp-person named Kálimátu. After Kuwái had become intoxicated with the smell of the grubs, Kálimátu finally

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persuaded him to come down and sing so that Iñápirríkuli's brother, Herri, could break his ritual fast. Kuwái told Kálimátu that he could be killed only with fire, since his body contained all other objects and materials.

When the messenger returned to earth with his important news, Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen gathered firewood to make a great bonfire on the village plaza. As Kuwái flew over the village the next day, he sang the music of the small and large ancestors[6]. Only men were there to greet Kuwái at his arrival.

In the evening, Kuwái began to sing the long series of songs and chants of initiation and to blow tobacco smoke over the sacred food (káridzámai). Iñápirríkuli left to get fermented drinks from the women and missed his chance to learn all the music. However, his brother Dzúli memorized all of Kuwái's songs and chants. Occasionally, Kuwái took Iñápirríkuli and the other men outside to teach them how to sing and dance kápetiápani (dance-song with whips). When Kuwái had become totally drunk and had finished the last song of initiation, Iñápirríkuli pushed him into the fire and his body disappeared in smoke. Then Iñápirríkuli gave the hot-peppered káridzámai to Hérri.

M5:"The Origin of Kuwái's Sacred Flutes and Trumpets"

Iñápirríkuli returned to the site of Kuwái's death to see if anything remained of Kuwái's body, but he

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found only ashes and some charcoals. When Kuwái's body had started to burn, the world had begun to shrink until it was very small. Within a few days, the world was reduced in size to the same tiny dimensions as it had been prior to Kuwái's birth.

After a week or so, a small sprout of macanilla (púpa, Curri.; Socratea eschorrhiza) started to grow from the ashes where Kuwái had burned. In a single day, the sapling burst forth into a giant tree that grew until touching the sky. Iñápirríkuli was admiring the tree for its smoothness and beauty. He called a squirrel (madéeri, Curri.; Mesosciurus griseogena) and ordered it to `measure' the tree because it knew how to climb and measure.The squirrel ascended the macanilla tree, marking the trunk every meter or two until he reached the sky. When the squirrel had finished, Iñápirríkuli struck the giant tree at its base, and it fell into a heap of hollow logs. Iñápirríkuli blew through the logs and produced the sounds of the various animal, bird, and fish species that Kuwái had sung when he first returned to this world. These macanilla logs became mouthpieces for the various flutes and trumpets of Kuwái. Then Iñápirríkuli ordered the squirrel to cut the bark off a tall yebaro (púpa, Curri.; Epurea purpurea) tree. Using dzámakwápi vines that also grew from Kuwái's ashes, Iñápirríkuli tied yebaro-bark resonators onto the flutes and trumpets.

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M6: "Amáru Steals the Sacred Flutes and Kuwái's Music Opens the World for a Second Time"
(The Origin of Female Initiation)

Amáru stole the sacred flutes of Kuwái from Iñápirríkuli and took them back to her home at Mútsipáni ("dance of the ceje palm grubs"). Iñápirríkuli chased after Amáru and the women, but they eluded him for a long time and played Kuwái's flutes and trumpets in various parts of the world. As they did so, Kuwái's music opened up the world for a second time. When Amáru and the women held an initiation ritual for a pubescent girl, Iñápirríkuli snuck into their gathering but failed to recover Kuwái's instruments.

M7: "Iñápirríkuli and the Men Regain Kuwái"
(The Origin of Kwépani)

Iñápirríkuli gathered his kinsmen and announced that they would all go to Kuwái's flutes away from Amáru and the women. They disguised themselves as molitu frogs and went to attack the women at Mútsipáni, Amáru's home. When they arrived, Iñápirríkuli sent a lightning bolt down on Amáru and the other women, striking them all dead. Iñápirríkuli revived the women and told them that Kuwái's instruments, which were hidden from view, had all turned into animals, birds, and fish. Amáru was not convinced but left to go live in the place where the sun rises (Ẽenutánhi).

A long time later, Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen

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gathered wild fruits to hold a kwépani (dance of Kuwái). They invited Amáru to convince her that Kuwái's flutes and trumpets had indeed turned into animals, birds, and fish. They did so by decorating the instruments with fur, feathers, and fish skin and allowing Amáru to see only these decorations. Amáru was convinced, and since then, men have 'owned' Kuwái's musical instruments.

After dressing the animal flutes of Kuwái and giving them to the men, Iñápirríkuli showed the men how to insert molítu flutes into resonators made of yebaro bark with vines so that they could make the ancestor flutes of Kuwái (Dzáwinápa and Dzáwinápa-íhwerrúti[7]) to hold male initiation rituals. Then Iñápirríkuli left this world to go live in his celestial paradise (likáremi), the place of eternal sunlight.

Conceptual Principles in the Kuwái Myth Cycle

The Kuwái myth cycle is essentially about the creative and transformative powers of music in the completion of the ancient mythical world of Iñápirríkuli. Kuwái is the embodiment of a mysterious, sacred power which the Wakuénai attribute to music. The sacred power of Kuwái's music does not rest solely upon beliefs in the efficacy of musical sound but is also based upon the interaction of logical, conceptual principles that are implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle. Myths 2-4 describe Kuwái as a flying creature whose humming and singing fill the world with all species of animal, bird, and

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fish at the same time as they open up the world to its present size. In myth 4, Kuwái tells Kálimátu that he is everything in this world except for fire. In more abstract terms, Kuwái is saying that he represents a principle of "all things in one being".

Matos Arvelo, who claims to have been a participant-observer in a male initation ritual among the Curripaco-speakers of the Rio Guainía, emphasizes the importance of the indigenous view of `Máuari´ as a single being that has a myriad of different manifestations. He uses the regional Spanish term Máuari (from the Wakuénai word umáwari, or anaconda; Eunectes murinus gigas) instead of the Wakuénai term (Kuwái) or the Yeral term, Yurupari (see fn.6, Chapter 2).

> "Máuari is not a single spirit but a legion of spirits; like bats in the evening, they spread over all tribes, some in the air, some in the rivers, some in the forests, and others in the villages of men. Yet these spirits can also re-unite to form a single spirit"(Matos Arvelo 1912: 94).

These statements made seventy years ago by an observer not formally trained in anthropology are much closer to indigenous perspectives of the Kuwái myth cycle than the writing of such renowned anthropologists as Koch-Gruenberg (1909)[8] and Nimuendajú (1950 1927). Kuwái as an embodiment of the conceptual principle of "all things in one being" is the logical, structural basis of the extraordinary powers of Ku-

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wái's music in myths 2-4 of the cycle.

The conceptual principle of "all things in one being" undergoes an irreversible transformation in the second part of the Kuwái myth cycle. Iñápirríkuli kills Kuwái by pushing him into a fire while performing kápetiápani, a dance-song with whips. At that moment, the world closed back up again to its former size during the ancient mythical times of Iñápirríkuli. The next myth (M5) describes how Iñápirríkuli made the animal flutes and ancestor trumpets of Kuwái to reproduce the creative power of Kuwái's humming and singing. The animal flutes have a double meaning. On the one hand, the Wakuénai associate the sounds which the flutes produce and the flutes' shapes with animal, bird, and fish species. The names of these associated natural species serve as namesakes for the musical instruments and melodies. On the other hand, the Wakuénai have developed a theory of the instruments' construction that relates them to both the body of Kuwái and the body of male human beings who actually make and play the instruments. The white heron (máari, Curri.; Casmerodius albus egrettus) flutes, for example, are said to represent the thumb and index finger of Kuwái's right hand. The maker of the flutes measures a section of macanilla (púpa) according to the height of his chest (the topmost rib when standing up) and another piece two hands' width (8 fingers and 2 thumbs) shorter than the first. The longer and shorter flutes represent Kuwái's right index finger and thumb, respectively. At the same time, the two flutes are seen as a likeness of

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the white heron insofar as the shape of a man's thumb and index finger when clasped (both fully extended) resembles the shape of a white heron in flight.

The Wakuénai have many other animal flutes and trumpets of Kuwái that illustrate this double reference to parts of Kuwái's body and to species of animals, birds, and fish[9]. I do not intend to list all these instruments and their symbolic associations, since their number is almost limitless, and the Wakuénai can invent as many new instruments as there are animal, bird, and fish species using the same symbolic logic. This logic is what matters most in understanding the transformation of Kuwái after his firy mythical death at the hands of Iñápirríkuli.

When a number of the animal flutes of Kuwái are constructed (M5) and then performed in unison (M6-7), the body of Kuwái is then reconstituted in a new form. In this new configuration, a number of animal, bird, and fish species are joined together, each one representing a part of Kuwái's body. When men join together to play the animal flutes of Kuwái in rituals or ceremonies, they dramatize their unity as parts of one body. The totality of animal flutes represents Kuwái as the embodiment of the conceptual principle of "one being in all things". In other words, Kuwái's mythical death brings about a transformation of the conceptual principle of "all things in one being" into its opposite, "one being in all things". The former emphasizes generality and sameness, whereas the latter accentuates specificity and uniqueness.

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When Amáru and the women steal the animal flutes of Kuwái, the world opens up for a second time but according to the transformed conceptual principle of "one being in all things".

A third transformation of Kuwái is not apparent in the action sequence of the myth cycle but represents a level of meaning that runs throughout myths 4-7. I refer to three separate events in the myth cycle:

1) Kuwái sings the large and small ancestors (jaguars) as he enters Iñápirríkuli's village prior to his death (M4).
2) Iñápirríkuli creates the ancestor trumpets by inserting molítu flutes into large resonators of yebaro bark lashed on with dzámakwápi vines (M5)[10].
3) Before leaving for his celestial paradise (likáremi), Iñápirríkuli teaches men how to make the ancestor trumpets and leaves a diagram of their construction so that men cannot forget this knowledge (M7).

This third manifestation of Kuwái is not an independently creative or transformative force in the same manner as the two opposed principles discussed earlier. The song of the large and small ancestors in myth 4 merely completes the opening up of the world and its filling with animals which Kuwái as "all things in one being" has already accomplished. The construction of ancestor trumpets in myth 5 requires only

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the insertion of a molítu flute, a manifestation of Kuwái as "one being in all things", into a resonator that amplifies and deepens the sound (i.e., no new sound -producing mechanism is introduced). Finally, Iñápirríkuli's last action before leaving this world is to teach men how to make the ancestor trumpets of Kuwái, but this deed is a mere footnote to the powerful action of the animal flutes of Kuwái that opened up the world for a second time in the struggle between men and women for control over Kuwái (M6-7).

What exactly is this third transformation of Kuwái if it does not directly effect any great changes in the world in the course of the Kuwái myth cycle? An answer to this question lies in the continuous presence of Kuwái as ancestor song/trumpet (Dzáwinápa-íhwerrúti) in each of the three major stages of cosmic formation which the myth cycle describes. The song of Kuwái as ancestor co-exists with the conceptual principle of "all things in one being" as the world opens up for the first time (M4). The ancestor trumpets of Kuwái come into being in the intermittent period when the world has shrunk to its former size (M5). And the instruments are made known to men in the period when Kuwái as "one being in all things" opens up the world for a second time. In other words, Kuwái in his third transformation as the music of the ancestors represents the continuity of the cosmic creation process throughout the entire myth cycle. Whereas the conceptual principles of "all things in one being" and "one being in all things" are opposed to one another and strictly

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separated in myth by the great closing of the world that follows Kuwái's death, the continuous presence of Kuwái in his third transformation transcends this opposition and represents a paradoxical juxtaposition of both "all things in one being" and "one being in all things" (see Figure 4.1).

Kuwái as ancestor song/trumpet has no power to transform the cosmos independent of Kuwái as "all things in one being" and "one being in all things" because Kuwái as ancestor is the synthesis of these two opposed principles. Kuwái as ancestor does not act upon the cosmos but upon the two major principles that transform the cosmos by showing that no matter how fundamental is the opposition between them and how rigidly separated the myths portray them to be, the two opposed principles are ultimately different ways of perceiving the same conceptual principle. Thus, Kuwái represents the power of musical sound and meaning as a complex set of conceptual principles that can create and transform the cosmos into two opposing orders, one emphasizing sameness and the other uniqueness. On a higher structural level, Kuwái's music reveals these two opposing cosmic orders to be parts of a continuous process of the emergence of order out of chaos. The logical ambiguity of Kuwái is an essential paradox of Wakuénai culture, and later chapters on sacred musical performances will aim at showing how this paradox is applied to the organization of experience.

Wakuénai Cosmic History

In the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli, the

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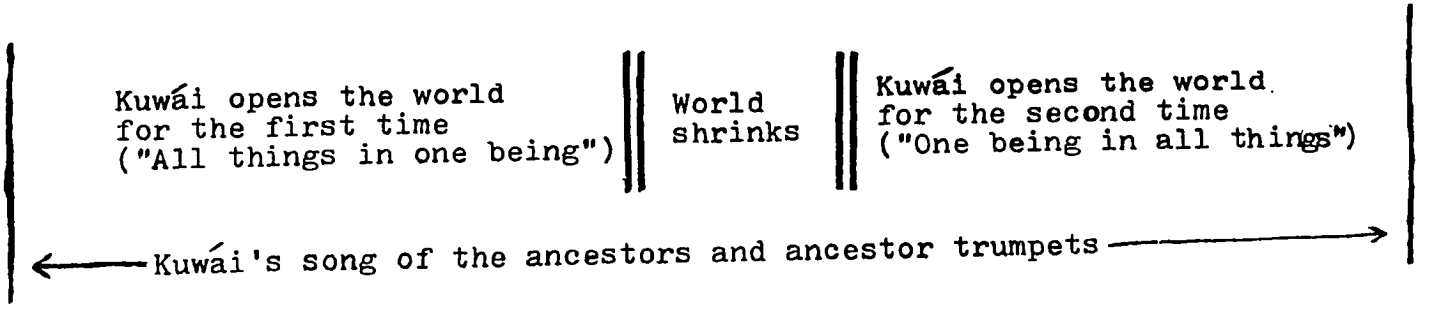


Figure 4.1. The continuous presence of Kuwái's third transformation

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cosmos bore the imprint of Wakuénai social institutions such as patrilocal residence, patrilineality, and brideservice and also of the daily subsistence activities that are of greatest importance to the Wakuénai, agriculture and fishing. Music played the relatively minor role of serving as an instrument of social communication in the ceremonial context of pudáli. Half-human, half-animal creatures lived in a semi-socialized world characterized by warfare and revenge killings that centered around a primordial split between kin (Iñápirríkuli and his brothers) and affines (Kunáhwerrim and his children). In those times, all creatures had the capacity to speak through language, but more often than not language served as a means for trickery, deceit, and lying instead of truthful communication. Iñápirríkuli was the most masterful trickster of all, always managing to fool his adversaries and knowing exactly what truths lay behind their miscommunications.

The birth and rebirth of Kuwái brought order to the unfinished mythical past through the elevation of musical sound and meaning from a minor, peripheral object to the basic creative force in the world. Kuwái as "all things in one being" opened up the world and filled it with all living creatures. However, the elevation of music into a sacred power that could transform the ancient mythical world of Iñápirríkuli was not in itself a sufficient transformation to bring order to the cosmos. For Kuwái in this world was not exactly "all things in one being" but "all except one thing in one being": Kuwái was "all things except fire in one

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being". Like music, fire had already been procured by Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen in the ancient mythical past, but the acquisition of fire did nothing to resolve the disorderly conduct of the mythical past[11]. However, in the Kuwái myth cycle, fire acts as an immensely important transformative power when it comes into contact with Kuwái. Fire negates the new cosmic order which Kuwái as "all things in one being" (except for fire) has created and sets the stage for the second cosmic order of Kuwái as "one being in all things". Looking broadly at the entire Kuwái myth cycle, the creation of order in the cosmos is a process that is driven first by music, then fire, and finally by music. However, Kuwái as the ancestor songs and trumpets places the entire process within the framework of a higher musical power.

Kuwái's music and fire are thus intertwined forces in the creation of cosmic order out of the disorder that characterized the distant mythical past. That Kuwái is everything in nature except fire illustrates a deep-rooted Wakuénai belief that fire stands apart from all material objects in nature inasmuch as it is a form of energy rather than a material object and can annihilate all materials in the world. Fire roasts animals and birds, boils water to cook fish, and most directly disintegrates plant materials into ash and charcoal. The myth of Kuwái's death (M4) demonstrates that fire can even disintegrate all material objects when these are integrated into a single being. Yet in the end, the ashes of Kuwái remain, and his music returns to create a se-

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cond order in the cosmos.

For the Wakuénai, just as fire is a form of energy that stands apart from all the material objects in nature, Kuwái's music is a type of meaningful power that stands apart from all other classes of communicative events in human society. Kuwái's music represents the power of communication that is completely devoid of manipulation, deceit, or trickery, the power of ultimately reliable information (see Rappaport 1979: 214ff). Nowhere is this power more clearly evident in the Kuwái myth cycle than in the episode of M4 in which Kuwái teaches the sacred songs and chants of initiation rituals to Dzúli. Kuwái repeatedly shows his concern that Iñápirríkuli is missing parts of the music and that someone must learn to sing and chant for initiants before his death. Dzúli heeds this advice and memorizes all the songs and chants[12]. The entire set of episodes leading up to Kuwái's death is characterized by Kuwái's seemingly irrational predilection for telling the truth. Kuwái tells Kálimátu that Iñápirríkuli can kill him with fire, and he even admits that he has devoured the three nephews of Iñápirríkuli. But Kuwái does not enter Iñápirríkuli's village to be killed in the fire until he has sung the music of the large and small ancestors that guarantees his continued existence even after burning to death. In short, Kuwái's death is his own decision. Even though his father, Iñápirríkuli, actually carries out the killing, the latter is only fulfilling his son's wish. Thus, Kuwái's death radically departs from the on-going series of

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intricately plotted killings that characterize the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli.

The close interrelations between Kuwái's music and fire as a transformative agents in the cosmic creation of order out of chaos is a theme that comes up over and over again in Wakuénai sacred musical performances. The tripartite structure of Wakuénai cosmology is implicitly present in the Kuwái myth cycle and is based upon the conceptual principles of sameness, uniqueness, and continuity which Kuwái embodies in the myths. However, to reach an understanding of how this tripartite cosmological structure develops out of conceptual principles implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle, I must first show how Wakuénai ritual specialists apply these principles through sacred musical performances.

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1. There are a number of animal fables which the Wakuénai tell as moral tales that express everyday social norms, such as monogamy, in a very direct manner. Because of their rather mundane level of meaning, I do not include these fables in the same category of narratives as myths.

2. Wright mentions that the rock called Mótipan on the Cano Waraná is said by the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River to be the sacred site of "statues" of Amáru but that "Motipan is never visited; it is said that whoever goes there will become fatally ill" (1981: 470).

3. Amáru is the mythical owner of shotguns (múkawa), machetes (matséta), other steel tools, and non-indigenous objects in general. The Amáru class of spirits provides the Wakuénai with a means of maintaining traditional processes of categorization even while applying these processes to new, foreign objects and situations. The meaning of the myth of origin of women's menstruation remains unchanged whether Amáru has a shotgun or simply throws objects at her target with her bare hands.

4. Some narrators claim that Iñápirríkuli made Amáru pregnant through "divine will" or simply through taking coca and thinking about Amáru. One narrator, the headman of an Ádzanéni village, even compared the conception of Kuwái through Iñápirríkuli's divine will with

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the Biblical story of Christ's Immaculate Conception. This notion of conception through thought or will is not supported by native explanations of the prayers and chants performed at childbirth in which the newborn is equated with the mythical character of Kuwái at birth. In this different, yet closely related, context, the view that conception of Kuwái came about through repeated sexual intercourse between Iñápirríkuli and Amáru sweeps aside the mythical version of Kuwái's conception as a thought process. I see this confusion as an example of how myth can vary according to external pressures such as missionary influences while music preserves the basic mythical messages in a more traditional sense (see Chapter 10).

5. On the upper Isana River in Brazil, there are rapids called Kuwái (or Yuruparí, in Yeral) at which certain rocks contain petroglyphs showing where Kuwái ate the three nephews of Iñápirríkuli and vomited them up before eating them again. According to Dzáwinai men of Gavilán, the rock paintings even show the awíya fruits inside the boys' bodies.

6. These songs are what later came to be reproduced on the two pairs of ancestor trumpets of Kuwái. These instruments make a deep, hissing sound that is associated with huge jaguars (dzáwi) and are named after these animals. The smaller pair of trumpets (Dzáwinápa,

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Jaguar's bone) is about two meters long. Three men play the Dzáwinápa trumpets, one blowing in the mouthpiece and the other two holding up the base end. The larger pair (Dzáwinápa-íhwerrúti, gigantic Jaguar's bone) is about 4 m long and requires three men to hold it up while a fourth blows into the mouthpiece. These great jaguar sounds represent the completion of Kuwái's creation of the world, the jaguar being seen as the last animal species which Kuwái created before his death.

7. After teaching the men how to construct the ancestor trumpets of Kuwái for male initiation rituals, Iñápirríkuli drew diagrams in a sandy beach along the Isana River adjacent to the rapids now called Aranha (spider, Port.). The beach was smooth and no one had walked on it yet. Before leaving for the sky, Iñápirríkuli turned the beach to stone so that his drawings would be preserved forever. Dzáwinai elders of Gavilán say that these petroglyphs show the exact dimensions and construction of the ancestor trumpets of Kuwái.

8. In fact, Wright (1981: xx) notes that Koch-Gruenberg's writings show little or no evidence that he was even aware of the importance of Kuwái in the myths and music which he documented among the `Baniwa' of the Isana River.

9. The trio of flutes called waliáduwa is the only exception insofar as it does not refer to an animal but only

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to the three outer fingers of Kuwái's right hand and to an unnamed old woman (see Chapter 9).

10. In connection with Levi-Strauss's analysis of the Oedipus myth, the construction of the ancestor trumpets of Kuwái in M5 is a symbolic resolution of the tension between autochthonous origins and sexual reproduction. The sexual metaphor in the ancestor trumpets' construction is evident in the insertion of the mouthpiece into the yebaro bark resonator and the closing of the latter around the former with vines (see discussion of kúlirína trumpet construction in Chapter 3). The mythical context of this sexual metaphor is also a powerful symbolic image of autochthonous origins, since Kuwái is reborn in the form of plants that shoot up out of the ground until they reach the sky.

11. In this discussion, I am referring to cooking fire and humanly controlled fire in general rather than natural forms of fire, such as lightning and the sun (see Chapters 7 and 8). In myth, Iñápirríkuli stole cooking fire from Yáwari even though he already knew how to make fire by rapidly spinning a stick over another piece of wood.

12. In this light, the eagerness of Wakuénai elders to have me tape record these sacred songs and chants while I was in the field is perfectly understandable.

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Chapter 5:

"Sacred Musical Performances (málikai) in Childbirth Rituals"

Introduction

The underlying conceptual principles of the Kuwái myth cycle and the accompanying belief in musical sounds as a transformative agent in creating order in the world provide the basis for ritual activities and musical performances through which the subjective, biological experience of childbirth is transformed into a social, objectified experience. The mythical power of Kuwái's music to organize the world according to certain principles is the model for intoning, rhythmical accentuation, and spirit naming in the málikai chants which Wakuénai ritual specialists, called málikai limínali (owners of málikai songs and chants), perform about a week after childbirth. Intoning, rhythmical accentuation, and spirit naming always go together in málikai, so I will refer to them collectively as `musical naming power'.

Munn (1969: 200) and Murray (1977: 218) have both pointed out the importance of ritual activities that equate participants with myth protagonists or that parallel key myth events for the analysis of the efficacy of symbolic structures. Studies of mythical belief systems (Levi-Strauss 1964) can reveal much about how men organize their thoughts, but they are incapable of demonstrating how men transform the

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world that they experience into one that they think through the application of mythical beliefs and concepts to social actors and activities in ritual contexts.

> ". . . myth may exhibit order in thought, but it is through ritual that this order is manipulated to produce order in action and in society at large" (S. Hugh-Jones 1979: 260).

Wakuénai childbirth rituals demonstrate the necessity of understanding myth and ritual as parts of a single myth-ritual nexus instead of independent cultural domains. Musical naming power (intonation, rhythmical accentuation, and spirit naming) is the primary means through which Wakuénai ritual specialists equate the newborn infant (kérramu) with the mythical character of Kuwái at birth. Other ritual activities having to do with the tools and weapons of the newborn's father, changes in the spatial arrangements of participants, and the sacred food (káridzámai) eaten by the newborn's parents provide visible parallels with key events of the Kuwái myth cycle (M2-3) and help to reinforce the equation of the newborn with Kuwái that is accomplished through musical naming power.

Musical naming power in málikai chants performed at childbirth rituals is modeled after the mythical belief in Kuwái's humming and singing as the creative force that opens up the closed mythical world of the distant past according to the conceptual principle of "all things in one being". Musical naming power equates the newborn infant with Kuwái at

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birth and thus establishes an analogy between childhood as a process in which life experiences of the individual are characterized by rapid growth and development and the mythical expansion of the world that Kuwái's music effected in the form of "all things in one being". The equation of the newborn infant with Kuwái also ensures that his symbolic identity (the two parts of his soul) will grow as part of his father's patrilineal sib rather than as a member of his nuclear family. Musical naming power in childbirth rituals disconnects the relationship of extremely intimate identity that binds the newborn infant with its parents in the period immediately following birth just as in myth the father (Iñápirríkuli) and father's brothers (Dzúli and Dzulíhwerri) take Kuwái away from his mother, Amáru, at his birth. The symbolic separation of the newborn infant from its parents and its subsequent integration with the collective ancestor spirit (líwarúna) of the father's sib place the experiences of childhood growth and development within the context of spiritual growth processes that are under the control of ritual specialists and other senior men of the local patrilineal sib. At the same time, the growth of children's identities in everyday social life and their basic needs for food, shelter, and training remain primarily their parents' and elder siblings' concerns.

In their explanations of the equation of newborn infants with Kuwái at birth, Wakuénai ritual specialists who 'own' the chants and their musical naming power say that the

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symbolic separation of the newborn infant from its parents is a necessary consequence of the feelings of shame held by Iñ-ápirríkuli and Amáru over their incestuous sexual relations prior to Kuwái's birth (M2). The association of childbirth with incest in myth and ritual is important for understanding how children's spiritual identities, or souls, are taken away from their biological parents and given to the collective ancestor spirit of the local sib. For childbirth in myth and ritual is seen as a result of sexual relations between a man and a woman who are both members of the same sib and who share the same ancestor spirit. In everyday social contexts, however, women never lose their natal ties to the "other people's" phratric and sib names, and their children are always produced through exogamous unions between men and women of sibs belonging to different phratries. The mythical and ritual equation of newborn infants with Kuwái at birth and his incestuous origins eliminates any doubts about whether the child's identity belongs to the paternal or maternal ancestor spirits, since both parents are ritually identified as members of the same patrilineal sib who share the same ancestor spirit[1]. This ritual collapsing of the kin/affine distinction also has important implications for understanding the effect of childbirth rituals over time on the social identities of women residing in their husbands' villages (see Chapter 6).

The performer, or 'owner', of málikai chants at childbirth rituals takes on the mythical role of Dzúli, the

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brother of Iñápirríkuli who helped take Kuwái away to live in the sky and who later on learned the málikai chants and songs for initiation rituals from Kuwái. The acquisition of musical naming power is a major means for demonstrating leadership in Wakuénai villages. In the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán, for example, the headman is an owner of málikai chants and songs, and his performances and explanations provided the basic data upon which my analysis of Wakuénai sacred musical performances rests. Interrelations between sacred authority tied to control of musical naming power in málikai songs and chants and political leadership in everyday social contexts are too complex to discuss here and must await consideration in a concluding section (see Chapter 8) on musical performances, ritual specialists, and leadership among the Wakuénai.

Description of Ritual Activities

The childbirth ritual which I observed in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán consisted of two distinctly different performances of málikai chants, one for allowing the father of the newborn to resume his normal work activities and the other for allowing both parents of the newborn to return to a normal adult diet of fish, game meat, and manioc bread. A Baniwa man and his Guarequena wife[2] brought their eighth child, a newborn son, to Gavilán from the predominantly Guarequena village of Sebucan, a few kilometers upstream. These three ritual participants arrived one afternoon in a large dugout canoe, accompanied by a number of children and

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an elderly grandfather. Hernando Camico, the headman of Gavilán, invited them to stay overnight in a guest house and dressed himself the next morning in the white shirt and pants that he always wore when performing málikai and blowing tobacco smoke. Other than Hernando's white clothes, there were only a few visual indications that an important ritual act was about to be performed: the shotgun and machete of the newborn's father that conspicuously lay on the center of the floor in the guest house, the inactivity and fasting of the newborn's parents, and the pack of PielRoja from which Hernando calmly took out a strong, filterless cigarette as he sat down, straddling the low-lying and empty hammock a few feet away from another hammock where the mother nursed her newborn son. By their very commonness and simplicity, the shotgun, the machete, the tobacco , and the nursing mother set in relief the complex web of mythical symbolism that the childbirth ritual was about to bring to bear on the performer (Dzúli) and the three principal actors (Kuwái, Iñápirríkuli, and Amáru). Accentuating the ritual status of the newborn and his parents are special terms used to refer to them. The father is kinénerri instead of the usual hnúnirri, the mother is kinédua instead of hnúdua, and the newborn is kérramu.

After lighting a cigarette and blowing a few puffs of smoke into the air, Hernando began to chant in a relentlessly fast and continuous flow of words, filling the silent room with a scarcely audible and low-pitched humming sound. He subtly raised the intonation of his voice through a series of

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almost indiscernibly small intervals until he had gone a full major third higher than the deep bass tone on which he had started. The volume of his voice and the velocity of his speech also increased by infinitessimally small gradations. Short pauses for breaths of air punctuated at irregular intervals the otherwise constant, and increasingly tense, flow of chanting and humming. Hernando kept raising the loudness and tempo for a couple of minutes but without elevating the tone any higher. Suddenly he reached a point of repose and let his voice trail off, sliding back down over the series of microtonal intervals upon which he had interwoven his chanting and humming. Lighting up another cigarette, he squatted down over the shotgun and machete of the newborn's father and exhaled a thick veil of smoke over each of the two objects[3]. Seconds later, he sat down again in his hammock, blew smoke into his package of cigarettes, and began to hum the same tone on which he had finished the last chant.

Hernando chanted louder than before and at about the same speed, his breaths continuing to mark off irregular phrase lengths. This time he only raised the tone of his humming and chanting by a chromatic half-step before signalling that he was ready to blow smoke again by letting his voice fade out. Again he lit a cigarette and blew clouds of smoke over the shotgun and machete of the newborn's father. The third and last chant lasted little more than two minutes and resumed the chromatic raising of pitch by another half-step from where the second chant had ended. After blowing smoke on

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the shotgun and machete, Hernando stood up and walked over to the hammock where the mother (kinédua) was nursing her baby (kérramu). There he blew smoke twice on each of their heads. Turning to the father, he explained that the spirits of all the weapons, tools, and objects of his work activities had been named so that he could now return to his everyday activities.

The father left to go hunting and returned to the village with a small rodent (píci, Curri.; Dasyprocta aguti lunaris) in the late afternoon. The newborn's mother boiled a small pot of the meat in hot peppers (áati). Hernando took the pot of meat, walked across the village plaza, and sat down in his own house, placing the pot of meat on the floor at his feet. No one else was present as he lit up a cigarette and started to chant for the sacred food (káridzámai). Some women sat outside the house within hearing range, weaving baskets and talking among themselves. The laughter of children playing on the village plaza came through the open windows from time to time. The kinénerri, kinédua, and kérramu stayed inside their house throughout the hour-long performance for the káridzámai with which they would end their week of fasting on manioc flour mixed with water. Everyone knew that Hernando was performing the málikai chants inside his house, but nobody came inside to listen.

The chants for káridzámai sounded completely different from those performed for the weapons, tools, and objects of the kinénerri's work activities. The chants' owner intoned

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them in a voice that was more song-like than the humming and rapid speech of the málikai chants for kinénerri's work activities. The performer of chants for káridzámai imposed a strict, binary rhythm on the text so that the flow of his speech was actually quite a bit slower than the flow of everyday speech. The pitch rose only about one half-step during the entire performance, and the tempo and loudness both remained constant from beginning to end. Hernando stopped on five occasions to light a cigarette and blow smoke into the pot of hot peppers and boiled meat. At the end of the sixth and last chant, he blew smoke one more time into the pot of food, covered it with a lid, and carried it back across the village plaza to the guest house where the newborn's parents awaited him. Upon eating the káridzámai, the parents ceased to be kinénerri and kinédua and returned to their normal statuses as father (hnúnirri) and mother (hnúdua). The newborn (kérramu), receiving the effect of the food through his mother's milk, now became a child (yénpiti).

Ritual Parallels with the Kuwái Myth Cycle (M1-2)

The equation of the newborn with Kuwái at birth and many other meaningful interrelations among mythical and musical dimensions of the childbirth ritual are only accessible through an analysis of musical naming power. This phenomena, as I have already mentioned, is a complex vocal process in which intonation, rhythmical accentuation, and spirit naming are inextricably intertwined, at least from the performer's point of view. However, the ritual participants do not neces-

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sarily understand the precise meanings of the various spirit-names which the performer invokes in the course of his chanting. In fact, almost the entire text of the chants is cast in an altered speech form that bears only a partial resemblance in terms of content to the vocabulary of everyday speech. The altered speech forms of málikai chants will form the subject of a detailed analysis in the next section. I am concerned here only to point out some parallels between ritual activities, including the musical sounds of the chants' owner's voice, that are accessible to non-specialists who participate in the ritual but whose main interest lies in the effectiveness of the chants and only secondarily in their meanings.

Prior to the childbirth ritual, the newborn's parents must fast on manioc mixed with water and avoid practicing everyday subsistence activities outside their house. Both fasting and avoidance of activities outside the house associate the newborn infant and his parents with events in the Kuwái myth cycle. The practice of fasting originated with Kuwái and is first mentioned in the episode where the four young kinsmen of Iñápirríkuli saw Kuwái flying in the sky and talked to him (M3). Kuwái told them that he was fasting, and from that time on they, too, had to fast on manioc drinks because they had seen and heard Kuwái. The fasting and seclusion of Iñápirríkuli's young kinsmen in a special hut outside the domain of everyday social life in their village became central themes in the next part of the Kuwái myth cycle

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(M4). Thus, the fasting and avoidance of everyday activities which the newborn infant's parents practice in the week following parturition are grounded in the myth cycle of Kuwái.

Ritual attention given to the shotgun and machete of the newborn's father relates the first part of the childbirth ritual to the beginning of the Kuwái myth cycle (M1). Even without knowing that the spirit-names of shotguns and machetes belong to the category of Amáru's spirits, the ritual participants and observers can readily perceive a connection between the shotgun in ritual and myth. In ritual, the shotgun is a symbol of the extremely intimate ties that bind together kinénerri, kinédua, and kérramu in the period immediately following childbirth. In myth, the shotgun is a symbol of the origin of anatomical and physiological differences between men and women. Specifically, Amáru's shotgun is the origin of menstruation as well as the different sexual organs of men and women that are necessarily prior to conception and birth.

In the second part of the childbirth ritual, the parallels between ritual activities and key events in the Kuwái myth cycle are discernible in the performer's removal of the pot of hot-peppered, boiled meat from the house of the three ritual participants to his own house. This shift in the location of ritual activities refers to Dzúli's removal of Kuwái from his mother in myth (M3). Iñápirríkuli and Dzúli put a clay pot over Kuwái's mouth before leaving him in the sky, far away from the village of his mother (Mútsipáni). The per-

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former of málikai chants for the sacred food of a newborn infant's parents implicitly reproduces the mythical condition of Kuwái when he was removed from his mother and the others and his voice could not be heard by them because it had been muffled. In the ritual performance of chants, no one else enters the house where the performer chants and blows smoke into the pot of sacred food. Furthermore, chanting over and blowing smoke into the pot of sacred food are ritual equivalents of the muffling of Kuwái's humming and singing with a clay pot in the myth.

The parallels between childbirth rituals and the Kuwái myth cycle that are implicit in fasting, inactivity, the shotgun, and the removal of sacred food to another location are all overshadowed by the interconnections between ritual activities and mythical events which musical performances effect. Just as the belief in the efficacy of Kuwái's music as a power that transforms the world is of central importance in the Kuwái myth cycle from the moment of his birth, so also the performance of málikai chants is the most important ritual activity in childbirth rituals. The Kuwái myth cycle is basically about the creative power of Kuwái's musical sounds as embodiments of conceptual principles. The childbirth ritual is essentially a series of sacred musical performances that are adorned by a small number of ritual symbols and activities. In both myth and ritual, music is a fundamental power around which all actors and events are organized. In this sense, musical performances in childbirth

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rituals are not only a means for equating the newborn infant with the mythical character of Kuwái at birth but a medium for making musical sounds and rhythms directly stand for the mythical character of Kuwái at birth and implicitly for the newborn (kérramu) as well.

The rising tones, accelerating tempo, and increasing loudness of the málikai chants for the work activities of the newborn's father are a musical metaphor that connects the mythical expansion of the world in Kuwái's childhood with the processes of rapid growth which the newborn child personifies. The rather chaotic, irregular rhythmical accentuation and phrase lengths of the first set of málikai chants to be performed in childbirth rituals adds an element of disorder to the musical symbolism and suggests that childhood growth, whether in myth or in ritual, is at first an uncontrolled process that only later begins to unfold according to an organized principle. In myth, the separation of Kuwái from his mother and the muffling of his voice with a clay pot is the first step toward imposing order on the creative power in Kuwái's music. In ritual, the owner of málikai chants symbolically separates the newborn from his parents when he accepts the pot of hot-peppered, boiled meat and goes to the other side of the village to chant over and blow tobacco smoke into the pot of food. The imposition of order on the creative power of Kuwái's music (and also implicitly on the growth of the newborn) is readily apparent in the sound and rhythmic structure of the second set of chants performed in

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childbirth rituals. Holding aside for now any consideration of the conceptual principles embedded in the system of spirit-names and the rest of the texts of these chants, the imposition of order through musical symbolism alone manifests itself in a binary rhythmic structure, an unchanging tempo (106 beats/minute), a minimum of changes in pitch[4], and a totally stationary level of loudness. Through a nearly total lack of change and a clear division of time into binary units, the music expresses a static order and evokes a sense of stability, permanence, and eternity. In spite of the apparent motionlessness of the musical organization of these chants, they also effect a profound change through musical naming power, a phenomena which I will examine in detail in later sections (see below, pp. 125-41).

Looking at the childbirth ritual as a whole event that has a beginning, a middle, and an end, changes in musical symbolism describe a movement from chaotic growth and expansion toward an orderly process of change and transformation. The first set of chants recognizes no clear boundaries in the temporal or tonal organization of musical sounds. The chant's owner begins a movement toward orderly and controlled transformation by taking the pot of sacred food across the village plaza and completes the action by performing a second set of chants at a distance from the three ritual participants. In these chants, both tonal and rhythmical organization are extremely rigid and unchanging.

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Spirit-Naming in Malikai Chants for the Weapons, Tools, and Objects of the Father's Work Activities

Spirit-naming in the first set of málikai chants performed in childbirth rituals is primarily concerned with protection of the newborn infant against potentially harmful effects of his father's everyday work activities. Ritual attention is focused on the child's umbilical cord as a symbol of the overly close ties between the newborn and parents. The physical, biological connection between the mother and baby at childbirth is only partially severed by the cutting and tying of the umbilical cord, since an ugly black stub remains on the child's navel for about a week. After this vestige of the umbilical cord falls off is the proper time to ask a málikai chant-owner to begin the childbirth ritual. Attention now shifts to the spiritual, internal umbilical cord that is believed to run from the navel to the tip of the toes inside the newborn's body and to be spiritually connected to the activities of the newborn's father.

Hernando, the chants' owner, explained to me the various ways in which the father's work activities can cause harm to the internal umbilical cord. In the most general sense, the father's return to work can frighten the baby, causing it to kick out with its feet and tear or break the umbilical cord inside its body. A general theme that runs throughout the set of three chants is the search for the tobacco spirits of the child's ancestors with which the chants' owner can prevent the child from becoming frightened or otherwise hurt by the

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father's work activities. The spirit-names of these tobacco spirits are not invoked until the chants are almost over and the search has nearly ended. From the very beginning, however, the chant-owner asks for the tobacco spirits with the general term for tobacco (dzéema).

Núwaka lidákewa dzéema
I give for his body tobacco

mapéda dakátsa mátukwákatsa hiépule.
so that he does not break to his umbilical cord.

These lines run throughout the entire set of chants like a refrain and form the background upon which various classes of potentially dangerous spirit-names are highlighted.

The first class of dangerous spirit-names which the chant-owner invokes is the category of Amáru's spirits. Fittingly, the very first spirit-name refers to Amáru's shotgun (tsímukápi Amáru). After asking again for the tobacco spirits of the child's ancestors, the chant-owner names the spirit of Amáru's machete (tsímukáita Amáru). Next he asks the tobacco spirits to embrace the child like the sloth (wámu, Curri.; Bradypus tridactylus) who clutches its newborn securely in its arms even while climbing trees.

Hlípaka líkerrámuli matsiá númaka
Hold onto the newborn son well I ask

lidzátsi nakwákada éenunai.
like the sloth.

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Finally, he names the spirit of Amáru's motor (tsímukáda Amáru).

In general, the category of Amáru's spirits are considered to be dangerous to the newborn by virtue of their heat. Shotguns, machetes, and motors are made from metal that must be melted and molded into shape at very high temperatures. The spirit-names of these metal objects convey the idea of hotness through the prefix tsímu-, a morpheme related to the word for hot (hlímukáni) in everyday speech. The category of Amáru spirits are a set of variations on the theme of hot (tsímu- or hlímukáni). For this reason, they are believed to be a potential cause of fever in the newborn, and after finishing with the third of Amáru's spirit-names, the chant-owner asks for the tobacco spirits so that the child's body does not get hot.

In addition, each of the Amáru spirit-names can cause harm to the newborn infant through the father's use of the objects that incarnate the spirit-names. If the father fires his shotgun, the loud noise of the explosion (no matter how far away from the village and the child) frightens the newborn infant so that it begins to cry and kick with its feet, thus damaging the umbilical cord within its body and causing the navel to bleed. The father's use of machetes, steel knives, axes, or any other sharp tools for cutting can frighten the newborn by making noise. The father's cutting activities are also thought to have a direct cutting action on the newborn's umbilical cord if the spirit-name of Amáru's

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machete is not properly 'asked' in málikai chants. The last spirit-name belonging to Amáru covers all types of motors and machinery that make loud noises and that contain sharp, moving pieces (e.g., gears, fans, and pistons). For the Wakuénai of Venezuela, such motors include outboard motors, gasoline-powered manioc graters, and diesel electric generators which the Venezuelan government has donated over the last ten years. In the childbirth ritual which I observed, the naming of Amáru's motor was considered especially important because the newborn's father was the operator of the electric power generator in his village.

In the remainder of the first chant, the chant-owner names the spirits of fishhooks and a number of wild plant species that provide raw materials for building houses, making traps, weaving baskets, and other uses. I will focus on the spirit-names themselves and leave out the refrain sections in between names in which the chant-owner searches for the tobacco spirits of the child's ancestors and asks them to prevent the child from becoming afraid or hurt when the father returns to work. The importance of the refrain is to surround the naming of potentially dangerous spirits and thereby minimize their harmful effects. The chant-owner continues to ask for tobacco (dzéema) before each new spirit-name which he invokes in the course of the chants.

The spirit-name of fishhooks, taken from the words for hand (ikápi), finger (wánam), and hook (híti), does not belong to the category of Amáru's spirits even though fish-

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hooks are made from metal. The piercing, jerking movement of the father as he sets the hook in the mouth of a fish is considered to have a similar effect on the internal umbilical cord of the newborn if the spirit-name of fishhooks is not included in the chants. The hand and curved finger which the spirit- name denotes are thought to be of enormous proportions, but the identity of the hand and finger remained unclear after questioning on the subject[5].

In the last section of the first chant, the chants' owner focuses on spirit-names of useful plant species that are seen as potentially dangerous to the newborn's health through the father's uses of them in his daily activities. The first of these spirit-names refers simultaneously to the leaf of plantanilla trees (derríp-he, Curri.; Heliconia cannoidea) and to Ëeri, the younger brother of Iñápirríkuli who was killed by the sons of his arch-enemy, Kunáhwerrim. The full name is kárrupím Ëeri, "The plate of Ëeri". The leaves of plantanilla trees are shaped like cultivated plantain and banana tree leaves but have a waxy coating that makes them ideal for use as a plate for cutting open pineapples or other fruits when walking through the forest or working in the manioc gardens. When plantanilla leaves are cut, they ooze out sap and fibers that resemble guts hanging outside a body. Specifically, the cut leaves of the plantanilla tree are said to look like the stub of a newborn infant's umbilical cord that remains on the navel for about a week after childbirth. The chant-owner must include the spirit-name of plantanilla

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so that the newborn infant does not develop bleeding or infection of the navel when and if the father cuts leaves of a plantanilla tree.

The spirit-name of the palmwood species (pwáapwa, Curri.; Ischnosiphon obliquus) that is used for weaving baskets and other products is a member of the category of éenu spirits. In everyday speech, éenu means sky, but in málikai chants it refers to a class of dangerous spirits which the Wakuénai associate with poisonous snakes. Most edible wild fruit species that are important in initiation rituals and kwépani ceremonies are also classified as éenu spirits. The spirit-name of pwáapwa palms (límatukíku éenu) refers to the tearing, ripping sound produced when the outer bark is peeled off to make long, thin strips of weaving material. The sound and motion of peeling bark off pwaapwa is roughly equivalent to that of sawgrass that causes bleeding when it peels loose from the skin. This peeling motion and sound are what makes the father's use of pwáapwa potentially dangerous to his newborn child. Pwáapwa also has strong mythical and ritual overtones, since Kuwái first used pwáapwa to make a guapa (dupítsi, Curri.; circular tray for carrying stacks of round manioc flat breads) to cover the pot of sacred food (káridzámai) at the first initiation ritual (M4).

The spirit-name of chique-chique palms (maráma, Curri.; Leopoldina piassaba) is a member of the category of umáwari spirits. Umáwari literally means anaconda but in chants refers to a type of dangerous forest monster (áwakarúda, in

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stories and everyday speech). These monsters of the forest are generally believed to be very hairy, semi-human creatures, much like Kuwái at birth. The hairy appearance of chique-chique palms is what makes them potentially dangerous and frightening to a newborn infant, and the spirit-name (umáwari pátsikurénali) emphasizes hairiness (ítsikulé, hair). The clump of long, thin fibers that grow out of the trees' trunks are used to make baskets and brooms, and the fronds are used to thatch roofs. Like most wild plant species named in málikai chants for the work activities of a newborn's father, chique-chique palm fibers have the qualities of length and thinness that resemble the internal umbilical cord of the newborn infant, and the father's uses of such plants are believed to have a direct effect upon the newborn infant's health.

The last spirit-name of the first chant is the species of vine (adápi, Curri.; Anthurium flexuosum) used for lashing together housepoles and other heavy jobs and is heavily charged with mythical and ritual meanings. The spirit-name (litíaka Hérri) apparently refers to other strong vine species in addition to mamuri (adápi), including dzámakwápi vines that grew out of Kuwái's ashes (M5). In myth 4, prior to Kuwái's death and rebirth, Iñápirríkuli had attempted to kill Kuwái by tying him up with dzámakwápi vine. Kuwái had told Iñápirríkuli that he could not be killed with vines, since he himself was made of all species of vines. Kuwái had also told him to use dzámakwápi vines to lash yebaro-bark

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resonators to mouthpieces of macanilla (púpa, Curri.; Socretea eschorrhiza) to make the ancestor trumpets after his death.

Spirit-naming in the second chant begins where the first chant left off with wild plant species that are both useful to the father and potentially dangerous to the newborn infant. Moriche palms of the flooded forest (ítewíppi, Curri.; Mauritia minor) are another member of the category of umáwari spirits because in mythical times they could turn into an anaconda. Like chique-chique palms, moriche palms of the flooded forest have long, hair-like fibers that liken them to hairy forest monsters capable of frightening the father and the newborn infant.

The chant-owner shifts away from wild plant species by naming another object of the father's work activities, the canoe (íita). The spirit-name of canoes (hlíkudáhia kumáterri) translates as "the breast" (hlikúda) of "a species of small duck" (kumáterri). In this case, the spirit-name itself does not carry any indication of the potential harm which the father's use of canoes might cause to the newborn infant. Not the canoe itself but the striking and pulling motion of the father's paddling is seen as dangerous to the newborn's internal umbilical cord. Nor does this spirit-name refer to a category of kumaterri spirits, since there are no other examples of spirit-names in málikai chants in which the duck's spirit is mentioned. The spirit-name for canoes is an isolated mythical-poetic metaphor made up only in this one

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instance.

The same quality of uniqueness holds true for the next spirit-name, wámidzákai ipérrikana, "the one who is like our older brother". There simply is no category of ipérrikana (older brother-like) spirits in the same way as there are classes of spirit-names belonging to Amáru, éenu, and umáwari. Yet this spirit-name meaning "the one who is like our older brother" is extremely important and powerful, for the chant-owner uses this spirit-name to equate the newborn (kérramu) with Kuwái at birth. The usage of Kuwái's spirit-name at birth follows a different logic than spirit-names examined up to this point. The chant-owner calls on Kuwái because at his birth no one knew who was his father and, in this sense, Kuwái at birth did not really have a father (i.e., a socially recognized male parent). Not having a father at birth, Kuwái did not have to go through the childbirth ritual. The spirit-name of Kuwái at birth acts as a model for the separation of the overly close spiritual ties between the father and his newborn child that are symbolically represented in the internal umbilical cord of the child and its vulnerability to the father's activities. The use of Kuwái's spirit-name at birth also makes sense out of the various categories of spirit-names that come before and after its utterance in the course of the three chants: they are all different parts of Kuwái's body at birth.

Naming of the tobacco spirits of the newborn infant's ancestors employs the same logic as the foregoing naming of

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Kuwái at birth. The tobacco spirits of children descended from Baré, Baniwa, Guarequena, and Yeral ancestors are known as "The Cigar of Hérri and the White Man's Children" (nádzamána Hérri hálepiwánai iénipé) because these Arawakan peoples do not have sib names (náikika) like those of the Wakuénai. In the Wakuénai myth of the emergence of sib ancestors, each group of spirits received male and female 'grandparents' who guarded the special tobacco used for curing and other ritual purposes of the living descendants of the sib ancestor spirit. Baniwa, Baré, and other ethnic groups emerged later, after Iñápirríkuli had given away all his sib ancestor and tobacco spirits. Later the Baniwa and other groups received tobacco spirits but not sib ancestor spirits[6]. The tobacco spirits of Baniwa and Guarequena ancestors are called the Cigar of the White Man's Children because these Indian groups, like the Whites, did not receive tobacco spirits until much later than the ancestor spirits of Wakuénai sibs (see Chapter 10). In málikai chants, the name is intended to make the newborn infant become like children of the Whites who do not need to undergo childbirth rituals, for they show no signs of ill health even though their fathers never stop working. The other part of the name, "The Cigar of Hérri", refers to the younger brother of Iñápirríkuli and the first initiation ritual and thus relates Guarequena and Baniwa tobacco spirits to the tradition of Kuwái and initiation rituals.[7]

Spirit-naming in most of the remainder of the second

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chant is centered around large, dangerous animal species. Kuwáida hiwídali is the generic spirit-name for jaguars (dzáwi) and derives from the words kuwáida[8] (unidentified; a type of nut with a large, thick shell like Brazil nuts) and híwida (head). Jaguars are called "hard nut-shell heads" because they were originally humans but turned themselves into animals with thick skulls by putting kuwáida shells on their heads. Jaguars have powerful spirits, and the Wakuénai believe that the newborn child would suffer instant death if the father were to kill a jaguar during the week prior to the childbirth ritual. Dérripénari idúwari is the spirit-name of pumas (kerrápi, Curri.; Puma concolor anthony) and refers to the similarity of their even, yellowish-brown coloring to that of plantanilla leaves (derríp-he) after they have been cut. Táwarinúma iénipé (the starchy-white mouthed one's children) is the spirit-name of spotted jaguars (dzáwi kádanáni, Curri.; Panthera onca mayor). The jaguar's white beard is considered dangerous to the newborn infant since it might frighten the father if he were to see it while working in the forest or manioc garden. Náduhénari éenunai is the spirit-name of tapirs (héema, Curri.; Tapirus terrestris) and refers to shiny spots on the sides of tapirs' bodies that resemble small polished stones (dúhe). The appearance of the tapir's spots might frighten the newborn infant through its father's encounter with the animal.

The final spirit-name of the second chant is the "territory of Káali" (lípwikuwári Káali). This territory, or

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soil, is not believed to be dangerous to the newborn infant in itself but through the father's digging activities. The only new spirit-name in the third chant is líkuruapinéta éenu, a species of large frog (kuwáiri, Curri.; unidentified). Through the generic spirit-name éenu, this frog species is associated with a region in the sky and with poisonous snakes. Beyond these vague connotations, however, the chant-owner could not offer any explanation of the spirit's danger to the newborn nor of its connection to the father's work activities. The name of the frog species in everyday speech (kuwáiri) bears a strong resemblance to the mythical character, Kuwái, and is perhaps related through some obscure mythical episode.

Musical Naming Power in Malikai Chants for the Newborn's Father

Musical naming power in málikai chants for the work activities of a newborn's father is a complex communicative event in which spirit-naming, intonation, rhythm, and tempo all operate together in the myth-ritual nexus that surrounds childbirth. Musical naming power equates the newborn infant with Kuwái at birth and establishes a set of metaphorical interrelationships between the health and well-being of newborn infants and the experiences and activities of their fathers. The umbilical cord as biological connection between mothers and newborn infants is the root metaphor upon which the entire symbolic logic of the spiritual connections between fathers and newborn infants rests. The child at birth is a

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biological appendange of the mother and a spiritual appendage of the father, so the dangers inherent in the father's work activities have direct implications for the health of the newborn infant.

Musical naming power in málikai chants recognizes the condition of overly close relations between fathers and their newborn children and even develops this condition to its logical extreme. The chants attach the various classes of dangerous spirit-names that connect father and child to tobacco spirits of the ancestors as a way of partially neutralizing their potential harm to the newborn infant. However, the contrary effects of the tobacco spirit-names do not really bring order to the overall pattern of spirit-names invoked in the chants. Viewed as a performative process, this pattern of dangerous spirit-names portrays a disorderly movement among different categories of spirits. The chant focuses on different classes of objects but does not set up a one-to-one correspondence between these classes of objects and categories of spirit-names. Useful wild plant species, for example, are not classified as members of a common category of spirit-names. Instead, five species are split up into four separate categories of spirit-names: umáwari (2), Ęeri (1), Hérri (1), and éenu (1). The only category of objects that comes close to falling under a single category of spirit-names are the metal objects of Amáru. However, even in this case, the failure to include fishhooks in the category of Amáru's spirits bisects the class of metal objects into

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two disjunct parts. The process of disorderly classification of objects into categories of spirit-names in málikai chants is a conscious effort to convey logical disorder.

Musical naming power creates logical chaos through spirit-naming and musical chaos through vocal techniques of irregularity of phrase lengths and tonal instability. Through acceleration of tempo, raising of intonation, and increasing of loudness, musical naming power also carries a sense of growth in size and intensity. Chaos and growth in málikai chants directly stand for Kuwái at birth, before his removal from the world. Musical naming power also equates the idea of Kuwái at birth as a form of uncontrolled expansion with the newborn infant (kérramu) in ritual.

Musical Naming Power in Malikai: To Cook the Sacred Food

The disorderly process of expansion which the first set of málikai chants in childbirth rituals expresses in multiple fashion gives way in the second set of chants to a process of controlled transformation that is based on a root metaphor of cooking. In the first set of chants, the naming of tobacco (dzéema, Curri.; Nicotiana tabacum) in search of the tobacco spirits of the newborn infant's ancestors acted as a mere background upon which the various spirit-names of objects, plant and animal species, and mythical characters stood out in relief. In other words, the search for the ancestral tobacco spirits provided a means for elaborating powerful spirit-names but did not actively organize or transform these spirit-names. In contrast, the cooking metaphor that operates

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in the opening refrain section of each of the six málikai chants for sacred food (káridzámai) actively organizes the spirit-names of fish and aquatic animals (umáwari), forest animals (éenunai), and birds (képinai). The texts of these opening refrains shift ritual attention back to the mother-child relationship, since the effect of the sacred food is seen as reaching the newborn infant through its mother's milk (see Figure 5.1).

The lines of the opening refrain are repeated many times with only minor variation throughout the six chants. They appear not only at the beginning of each chant but also in the middle sections during pauses in the spirit-naming of fish, animals, and birds. The verses emphasize four basic actions: 1) licking the hot pepper, 2) falling off of all harmful qualities, 3) killing rawness, and 4) calling the generic spirit of fish, animals, or birds to help cut off the heads of individual spirit-names in that category. The licking of hot pepper by the newborn's mother is a ritual act for ending periods of fasting that originated in the Kuwái myth cycle (M4) when Iñápirríkuli gave hot pepper to his brother, Hérri, to lick at the end of his month-long fast. In another myth, Iñápirríkuli invented the practice of cooking with hot pepper as a way of purifying food into which an evil anaconda-person had thrown poison. In ritual chanting, the effect of the mother's licking of hot peppers is to get rid of (to make fall off) her dirt (máwitwale-nám), her harmfulness or dangerousness (mákwami-kám), and her rawness (máhliuka-nám).

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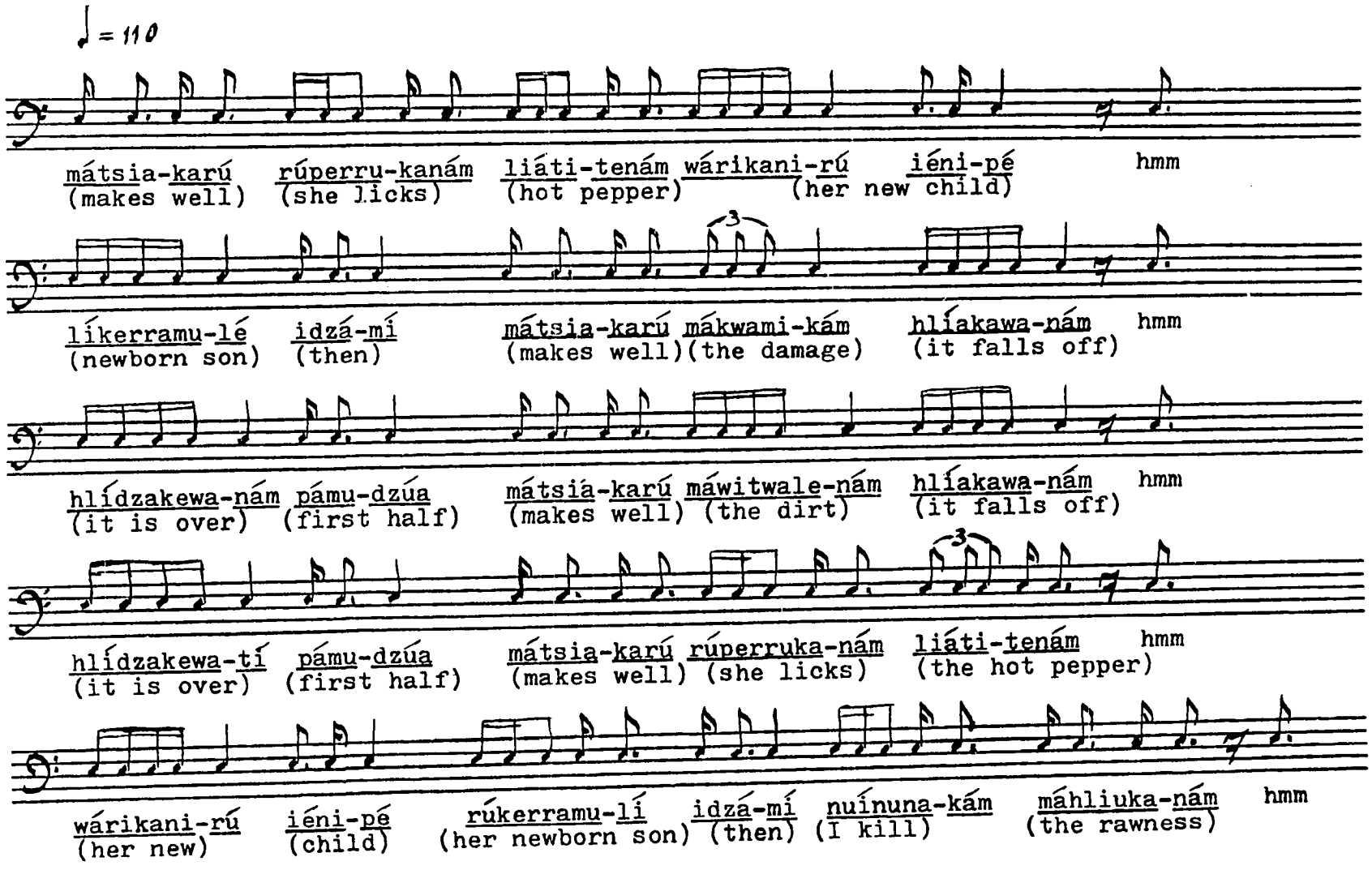


Figure 5.1. Refrain section from malikái chants for káridzámai for newborn infant and parents

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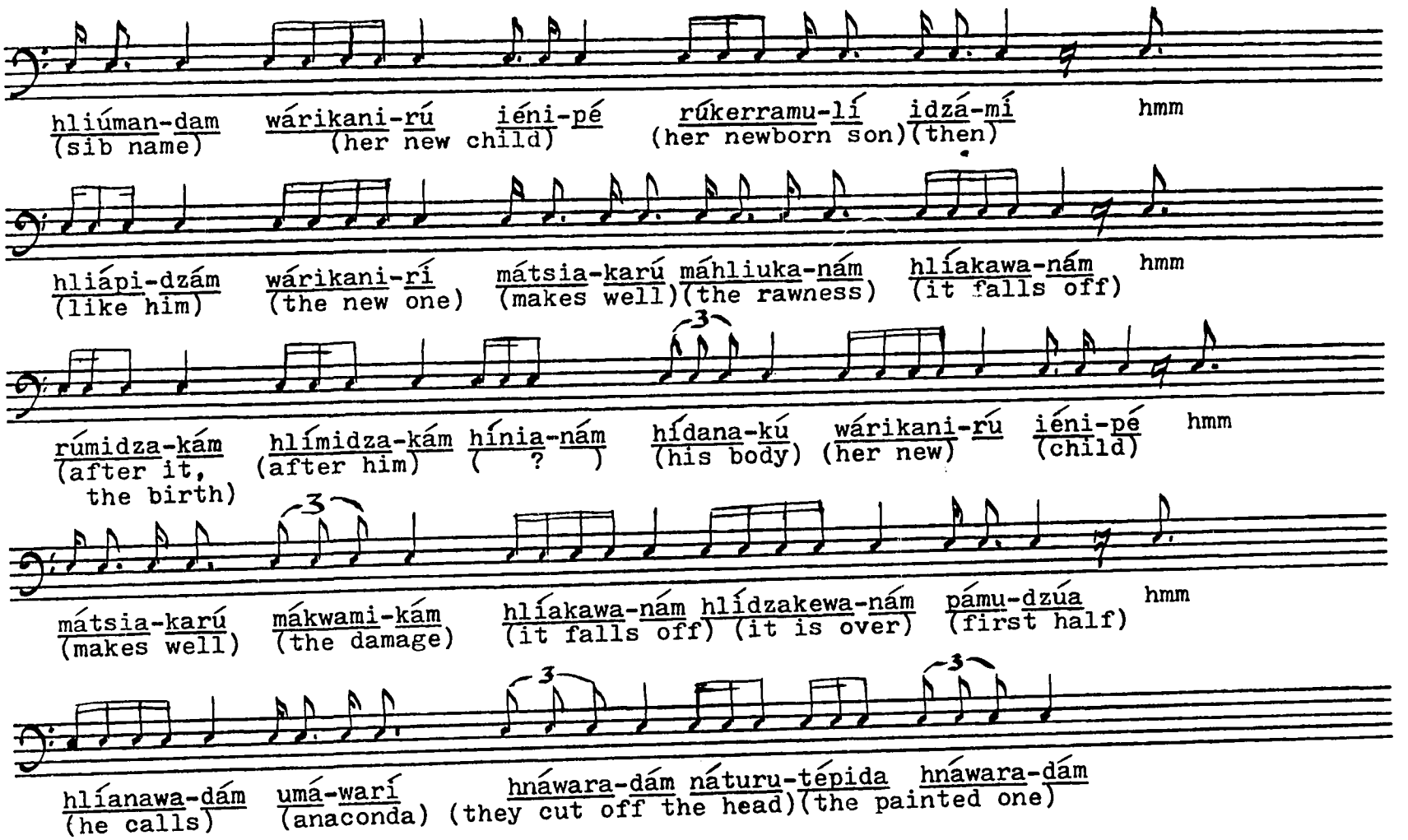


Figure 5.1. Refrain section from malikái chants for káridzámai for newborn infant and parents (cont.)

"I kill the rawness" (nuínuna- kám máhliuka-nám) is a direct statement that the cooking metaphor is the model for organizing the spirit-names in these chants. In a later variant, the chant-owner names the spirit of Kuwái's ritual whips (líwanápu éenu, the 'corner' of the sky where Kuwái kept the whips) to help him beat the rawness out of the fish, animal, and bird species. Finally, just before entering into a recitation of the individual spirit- names, the chant-owner calls on the itáda, or generic spirit-name (e.g., umáwari or éenunai), to cut off the heads (hnáwara-dám) of the various spirit-names which he is about to start 'cooking'. In short, all four main activities in the verses making up the refrain portions of málikai chants for the sacred food of newborn infants and their parents are either direct expressions of the cooking metaphor or parallel symbolic processes such as purification and protection that widen the metaphor's scope of meaning.

The language used in these refrain verses is in many respects different from the language used in everyday speech. The text is composed of words that fall into three basic categories with respect to the degree of alteration from words used in everyday speech: 1) no alteration, 2) partial alteration, and 3) total alteration. The first category includes mátsia-karú ("harm - not"), pámudzuá ("the first part or half"), and wárikani-rú ("her - new"). The second category is by far the largest and consists of words from everyday speech combined with suffixes that are perhaps introduced to

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create a stronger rhyme scheme. Hlíakáwa ("it falls") is given the suffix -nám, nuínuna" ("I kill") is coupled with -kám, liáti ("its or his hot pepper") is attached to -tenám, and so on. These partial alterations are intermediary between unaltered words that are immediately recognizable and words that have been completely altered beyond any recognition in terms of the vocabulary of everyday speech. The latter include such words as idzámi, rúmidza-kám, and hlímidza-kám, which have the same meanings as the everyday words ipúmite, rupúmite, and lipúmite (then or after, after her, and after it, respectively). Hliúman-dám means the same as the word lináikika ("his sib name") in everyday speech. Another example, hnáwara-dám has the same meaning as the phrase hnatáka híwida ("they cut off the head") in everyday speech. Nevertheless, completely altered or unaltered words (the third and first categories) make up only a small fraction of the total text. The second category, that of partially altered words in which unusual suffixes are attached to everyday words, predominates in the verses of the refrain. A similar process of linguistic alteration is discernible in many, but not all, of the spirit-names which I will now discuss.

Musical Naming Power: the Organization of Transformation

The effect of musical `cooking´ in the refrain sections of málikai chants for ending the fast of the parents of newborn infants is to set up a highly structured, classificatory process in which classes of fish, animal, and bird species

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are neatly organized into categories of spirit-names. Figure 5.2 shows the full list of fish, animal, and bird species as they appear in the course of the six chants. Time and space do not permit here a detailed consideration of each individual spirit-name but only a general commentary on basic structural principles that are at work in this chanting.

The first and most important observation on the structure of spirit- names in the chants is that each one contains two basic terms[9]. These two terms correspond to the two souls (or shadows) possessed by each species of fish, animal, or bird. The itáda soul is a generic category to which a particular species belongs: umáwari, éenunai, and képinai. The itáda souls of forest animals (éenunai) and birds (képinai) are believed to live in máliwéko (or máliwakúda itáda in the language of chants), a house in the dark netherworld (íyarudáti) where the souls of recently-deceased persons (lidánam) care for the animal and bird itáda souls like domesticated animals. The itáda soul of fish and aquatic animals (umáwari) is not so neatly classified and is believed to reside in this world (hekwápiríko) (see below, pp. 153-57). The other soul which fish, animal, and bird species possess is called iñákim, the individual spirit-name that gives unique form, coloring, and behavior to a particular species. Iñápirríkuli owns and cares for the iñákim souls of forest animal and bird species in the celestial paradise (likáremi) where the sun shines constantly and food consists of the purest honey. Likaremi is also where

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Spirit-name in chants	Everyday name	Spanish name	Scientific name
Chant 1:			
umáwari kámarinúma ienípe	táari	bocachico blanco	Leporinus sp.
umáwari daruítepérri ienípe	dúpari	bocachico rabo colorado	Leporinus sp.
umáwari duísinúma ienípe	dúme	bocachico pintado	Leporinus sp.
umáwari máriapinúma	tírri	chanqletta	Brachyplatysoma sp.
hlípa ñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	wétsuri	payara	Hydrolicus pectoralis
umáwari yámutsiáduwa ienípe	yamúti	bocón	Brycon whitei
umáwari úwirritána ienípe	hnúkurri	laulau	Brachyplatysoma sp.
umáwari kwáyačáduwa ienípe	uhwí	machete	?
umáwari yámatéwirri ienípe	ínirri	guabine	Hoplias malabaricus
káduičípa dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	čípa	anchoa	?
kerráipenúma dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	kérrapúkurri	anchoa grande	?
umáwari púrutáinuma ienípe	káatama	anchoa mediano	?
umáwari mákaruáduwa ienípe	tsípa	palometa	Mylossoma duriventris
umáwari perrékua ienipe	dakáta	temblador negro, medio amarillo	Electrophorus electricus
umáwari wawiáduwa ienípe	dakáta		
liápam máhnekánari ienípe	yámaru	raya	Potamotrygon hystrix

Figure 5.2. Spirit-names of fish and aquatic reptiles in order of incantation during a performance of malikái for the sacred food of a newborn infant and parents (cont. next page)

*Salt is an important material for preserving fish. The mythical owner of salt is said to be an anaconda that had large teeth like people do today but that took them out and buried them in the ground.

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Spirit-name in chants	Everyday name	Spanish name	Scientific name
Chant 1 (cont.):			
umáwari wítawitáduwa ienípe	dawáki	bagre liso	Brachyplatysoma sp.
hépulekáda oráinainái	háyo	vieja loura	Cichlasoma sp.
umáwari kúlikuliáduwa ienipe	ikúli	cabezón	?
umáwari túmukiáduwa ienípe	tamáki	morocoto	Colossoma macropomus
Chant 2:			
umáwari oráinainái náturúda	érritu	viejita pintada	Cichlasoma sp.
umáwari duírripánari mólituáduwa	dzawírra	viejita propria	Cichlasoma sp.
umáwari tímahéwerri ienípe	pára	algojón	?
umáwari hwarrúi	ukírra	sal*	
umáwari lipáramarétem OR lipáramarétem dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	káaču	cangreja	?
líkerérripírri itádam dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	dzáaka	camarón	?
Chant 3:			
umáwari kudzáinuma ienípe	dzápa	pavón	Cichla ocellaris
umáwari holáduwa	hóla	caribe grande	Serrasalmus rhombeus
umáwari bebéduwa ienípe	kaimána	caimán	Cocodrylus intermedius
umáwari kamáwa kutíye ienípe	katsírri	babilla	Caiman sclerops
umáwari límalídali íñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	katsírri	babilla, cabeza roja	Caiman sclerops

Figure 5.2. Spirit-names of fish and aquatic reptiles in malikái (cont.)

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Spirit-name in chants	Everyday name	Spanish name	Scientific name
Chant 3 (cont.):			
umáwari áapituáduwa ienípe	kulírri	rayado	Brachyplatysoma sp.
Chant 4:			
náwibírrikírri éenunai	apídza	báquira	Tayassu pecari
napúruikáda éenunai ienípe	dzámurítu	chácharo	Pecari tajacu
nérramána éenunai	néeri	venado colorado	Mazama americana
náhipiánuali éenunai ienípe	táaru	osso palmero	Myrmecophaga tridactyla
náduhénari éenunai ienípe	héema	danta	Tapirus terrestris
naṣraínida éenunai	dápa	lapa	Cuniculus paca
nadáparéda éenunai	dápa	lapa	Cuniculus paca
líwadanápale dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	píči	picure del monte	Dasyprocta sp.
litíyen pánare iñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	píči	picure de la sabana	Dasyprocta sp.
Chant 5:			
náturuápa éenunai	kapíti	guachi	Nasua nasua
náturúda éenunai	arídali	armadillo pequeno	Dasypus sp.
líkeráruli iñéni dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	ádzana	armadillo del monte	Pridontes giganteus
hálekáda éenunai	áate	osso hormiguero	Tamandua tridactyla
nétaṣkána éenunai	dzówi	guachi pequeno	Potos flavus
nápuikáita éenunai	káparu	mono caparro	?

Figure 5.2. Spirit-names of fish and forest animal species in malikái chants at childbirth (cont.)

Spirit-name in chants	Everyday name	Spanish name	Scientific name
Chant 5 (cont.):			
hnawíha-kánari éenunai	púwi	mono machin	Aotus trivirgatus
hálekáita éenunai	háaru	mono blanco	Cebus albifrons unicolor
nékakáda éenunai	tsítsi	mono chicoto	Cacajao melanocephalus
nákumhakáita éenunai	wáaki	mono negro chiquito	?
námaréna éenunai	ítči	mono araguato	Alouatta seniculus
Chant 6:			
líkulimápare líkhwatépe iñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	máare	úquirra	?
nápuruikápa képinai	itsírri	úquirra pedrero	?
néturéda képinai pérrumánare ienípe	atíne	grúa	?
nétakápa képinai umáwari** iñániperri ienípe	kwíči	paují amarillo	
natewapa kepinai ienipe	dzate	piapoco	Rhamphastidae sp.
képináika bolánerri	ádaru	guacamaya	Ara spp.
éenunai pepírri nakáuli	paíči	rana	?
képinai dzámutsináre ienipe	kwíči	paují blanco	
lípalitákerri ñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	***	***	
limáitakérri ñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli	***	***	

Figure 5.2. Spirit-names of forest animals and birds from the same performance of malikái (cont.)

**In this spirit-name, the use of umáwari violates the distinction between fish and bird species because in myth the pauji (kwíči) turned itself into a dangerous anaconda.

***These two names come from hípalítakau (to cover with earth) and himáitakau (to burn) and refer to baking and roasting, respectively.

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lidánam spirits eventually reunite with their sib ancestor souls (líwarúna) after a period of separation in íyarudáti immediately following death (see Chapter 7).

In myth, the expansion of the world through Kuwái's music created all the fish, animal, and bird species according to the conceptual principle of "all things in one being". In ritual, the performance of málikai chants that recreate Kuwái's mythical humming and singing demonstrates that the creation of natural species is essentially a process of classification in which the spirit-names of forest animal and bird species are placed in binary opposition to the souls of human beings. Both humans and animals have collective or generic and individual or specific souls, but where human souls exist in their individual forms as the lidánam in íyarudáti, the animal and bird species exist in their generic souls (itáda). Likewise, where human souls exist as collective, sib ancestor souls (líwarúna) in the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli, animal and bird species exist as unique, species-specific souls (iñákim)[10]. The differentiation of humans from animals is a complex classificatory process in which the conceptual principles of Kuwái as "all things in one being" and as "one being in all things" act as basic building blocks. However, the spirit-names of fish and aquatic animals (umáwari) do not form part of this classificatory process and, like human souls, are also in opposition to the forest animal and bird species.

In the performance of málikai chants, the special posi-

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tion of fish and aquatic animal species in Wakuénai cosmological structure is evident in two ways. First, the naming of umáwari as a generic souls always precedes the specific soul, whereas in the spirit-naming of forest animals the specific soul-name (iñákim) always precedes the generic name (éenunai). In most, but not all, of the bird spirit-names, the specific name precedes the general name. Second, the umáwari spirit-names are by far the most numerous category and make up the subjects of three separate chants, whereas the éenunai spirit- names occupy two chants and the képinai only one. The three chants for classifying (`cooking´) umáwari spirit-names are prior to the three chants that classify éenunai and képinai spirit-names. The special position of umáwari spirit-names in Wakuénai cosmology is one of far greater closeness to human souls than the spirit-names of forest animals and birds. The ambiguity or blurring of the human- animal distinction in the case of fish and aquatic animal species is not merely a reflection of the ambiguous position of rivers in the organization of Wakuénai phratries and their constitutent sib groups but is also a phenomenon having mythical origins.

The myth of Ůliámali, an anaconda-person who created a great flood, is an appendage of the Kuwái myth cycle in much the same way that the myth of the vulture complements the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli. Although lacking in any overt connection to the myths about Kuwái and Amáru, the thematic contents of the myth of Ůliámali clearly link it to the Kuwái

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myth cycle insofar as it focuses on conception, pregnancy, and childbirth (see Wright 1981: 571-75 for a full-length transcription of a slightly different variant of this myth). In the myth, Ũliámali was married to Iñápirríkuli and committed adultery with an anaconda-person. Iñápirríkuli caught the two anacondas in the act, and he killed his wife's lover. To punish his unfaithful wife, Iñápirríkuli cut off the penis of her slain lover, turned it into a fish, and tricked his wife into eating the penis/fish. Ũliámali became pregnant and grew very thin because a gigantic anaconda-child was forming in her belly and stealing all her food. After two years, Ũliámali was on the point of death when her sisters devised a plan to get the great snake out of her body by luring it into a high tree filled with ripe fruits. Ũliámali fled from her snake-child and later transformed into a bagre sapo (a species of small catfish, called únturu, that has a remarkably expandable belly with which it can eat whole fish larger than itself, digest the flesh, and vomit the bones to return to its former small size). The anaconda-child of Ũliámali grew furious over his separation from his mother and angrily searched for her in Iñápirríkuli's village. Unable to find his mother, the snake caused a great rain to fall, and the rivers rose in a huge flood that left only the peak of the tall mountain at Tonowi on the Isana River as a refuge for living creatures. Iñápirríkul gathered all his fish, animal, and bird species (iñákim) on the peak of this mountain in a single pile to make it easier for Dzúli to chant and blow

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smoke over them all at once.

The myth of Ũliámali explains the special position of umáwari spirit- names in Wakuénai cosmology. Like the birth of Kuwái, the first human being, the birth of Ũliámali's anaconda-child resulted from sexual intercourse rather than autochthonous emergence from the ground. The difference between the two mythical proto-types of sexual reproduction is that Kuwái's birth came about through genital, incestuous intercourse, whereas the umáwari-child was conceived through gastronomic, adulterous intercourse. Kuwái was separated at birth from Amáru against her will while she was still unconscious, but Ũliámali consciously and willingly did her best to get rid of her anaconda-child. Once separated from his mother, Kuwái's music filled the world with living creatures, whereas the anaconda-child, furious that he had been abandoned by his mother, filled the world with a great flood that in turn shrank the world to a single high point of land. Nevertheless, the conclusion drawn from the myth of Ũliámali curiously parallels the concept of Kuwái as "all things in one being", for the great flood conveniently forced all living creatures into one small place and facilitated Dzúli's chanting and smoke-blowing. The myth of Ũliámali is like a photographic negative of the myth of Kuwái's conception and birth. The same fish, animal, and bird species which Kuwái's music created are also the survivors of the umáwari-child's great flooding of the world. In both cases, Dzúli and Iñápirríkuli brought order to a process of chaotic expansion

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that threatened to destroy all living creatures even as it created and transformed them. Thus, the myths of Kuwái and the umáwari-child demonstrate how the umáwari spirit-names came to live in the same world (hekwápiríko) as the Wakuénai themselves, the former beneath the river's surface and the latter at the river's edge (see Figure 5.3).

Given the distinction between umáwari spirit- names and those of forest animals and birds, the overall classificatory process by which the set of six málikai chants assign the classes of fish/aquatic animals, forest animals, and birds into three discrete categories of spirit-names is remarkable for its orderliness, especially in comparison with the classificatory process that operates in the first set of málikai chants performed in childbirth rituals. Figure 5.4 shows the high degree of correspondence between each category of itáda spirit-name and the total number of fish, animal, and bird species that are named in each of the six chants. Although perhaps not quite as neat and tidy as the menu in a French restaurant, the set of six chants does fairly accurately map out the overall diet of animal foods in Wakuénai culture.

An interesting feature of this classificatory process is that the most frequently eaten species of fish and forest animals are the first spirit-names to be invoked in the chants that deal with these categories. The very first fish species named in the first chant are white, red-tailed, and spotted bocachico (táari, dúpari, and dúme, Curri.; Leporinus sp.), the exact same species that provide such an overa-

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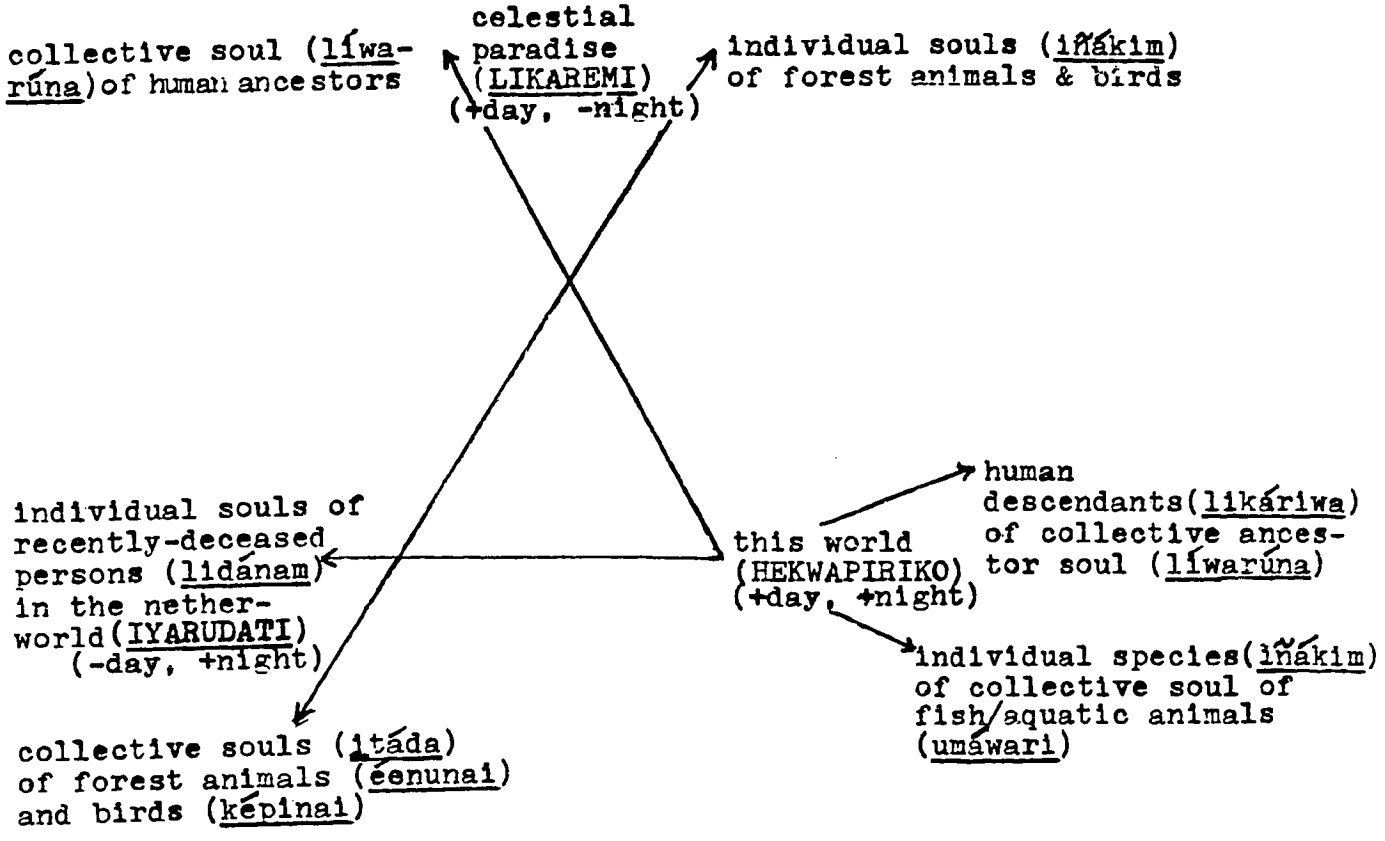


Figure 53. Diagram of Wakuénai cosmology showing polarization of collective and individual souls of humans and forest animal/bird species. Although presented here as a static structure for clarity, there is much overlapping and movement of souls among the three worlds. Also not included are many sub-divisions within each of the three worlds..

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	Chant 1	Chant 2	Chant 3	Chant 4	Chant 5	Chant 6	Total
Category named at beginning of chant	umáwari	umáwari	umáwari	éenunai	éenunai	képinai	
Total number of species named in chant	20	6	7	9	11	9	62
Number of names inside category	15	4	6	7	10	6	48
Number of names outside category	5	1	0	2	1	2	11
Number of names both inside and outside category	0	1	1	0	0	1	3

Figure 5.4. Chart showing that the majority (75% +) of fish, animal, and bird species falls under the category named at the outset of chant

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bundance of fish during the spawning runs at the beginning of the wet seasons and whose everyday names are honored in the kúlirína trumpet-dances of pudáli ceremonies. The fourth fish species named in the chant is the chanqletta (tírri, Curri.; Brachyplatysoma sp.), a species of small catfish that becomes very important in the height of the wet season when fishing becomes underproductive. The chanqletta is one of the only species that continues to bite in the long wet season and is very important in local diets. However, the remaining fish species named in the chants do not necessarily follow this order of importance according to the species' contribution to the diet. The first animal species named in the fourth chant very definitely correspond to the animals' importance in local diets: white-lipped (apídza, Curri.; Tayasu pecari) and white-collared (dzámuríto, Curri.; Pecari tajacu) peccaries. As with the fish species named in earlier chants, the remaining animal spirit-names do not necessarily follow an order of importance by their contribution to the diet.

Naming fish and animal spirits of the most systematically and frequently captured fish and animal species before the spirit-names of fish and animals which men only capture in a fairly random manner is a way of fine-tuning the cosmological system of spirits to the ecological realities of fishing and hunting. Fish and animal species that are most frequently captured are also the most likely to cause harm to newborn infants and their parents simply because they are most likely to be eaten. And they are also the most likely to be cooked,

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so invoking their spirit-names first supports the basic cooking metaphor that operates as a model for the organization of the transformation of Kuwái at birth and the newborn infant throughout all six chants.

Musical Naming Power: the Coordination of Classificatory Processes

In the foregoing analysis, I have emphasized the importance of binary oppositions and the metaphor of cooking as models for the organizing of the transformative power of Kuwái's music. Through the equation of newborn infants with the mythical character of Kuwái at birth, these musically performed oppositions and metaphors are also brought to bear on the experiences of childhood growth. On this level, the second set of málikai chants organizes experience according to the conceptual principle of Kuwái as "all things in one being." The process is one in which the naming of generic spirit-names (itáda) is applied to ("cuts the heads off of") the naming of specific spirits (iñákim). The generic spirit-names act as a given, existential arrangement of three categories which the specific spirit-names fill up with contents. The general categories organize the specific contents into a relatively fixed system of spirit-names. This same classificatory process is implicitly applied to newborn infants in whom collective, sib ancestor souls (líwarúna) are the dominant characteristic of the personal, spiritual identity throughout the growing experiences of childhood. Like all fully human beings, children also have individual souls

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(likáriwa) that resemble their physical bodies during the daytime hours when they are awake. However, children's identities are primarily associated with their sib ancestor souls, generic or collectively shared parts of the human soul which the Wakuénai believe turn into the totemic animal of the sib when they are asleep at night. The transformation of newborn infants (kérramu) who are biological and spiritual appendages of their parents at birth into children (yénpiti) who are conscious, individual members of the local sib group is a process modeled after the organization of Kuwái's transformation in myth and in sacred musical performances as a classificatory operation that establishes the priority of generic categories of spirits (itáda) over individual spirits (iñákim).

In spite of the rather tidy classificatory process which musical naming power embodies in the chants, there are a number of exceptional spirit-names that seemingly or actually break out of the imposition of general order upon specific objects. The generic name oráinainái, for example, seems to violate the categorical order of umáwari spirit-names. This elision, however, does not really disrupt the classificatory process in any significant way, since orainainai is understood as a sub-category of umáwari that covers all species of vieja fish (Cichlidae family, Cichlasoma Spp.). Another example is the spirit-name of stingrays (yámaru, Curri.; Potamotrygon hystrix), líapam máhnekánari iénipé, which literally translates as "the children of nobody knows who's

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placenta". This spirit-name refers to Kuwái's name at birth and the mythical episode (M2) in which Iñápirríkuli and Dzúli show Amáru her afterbirth in the form of a stingray and claim that nothing else had come out of her birth canal. Although this spirit-name is certainly regarded as powerful and the stingray is feared in everyday life for its extremely painful sting, the naming of the stingrays' spirit here merely reinforces the equation between the mythical events of Kuwái's birth and the childbirth ritual, a connection which the first set of chants had already amply established.

An example of a spirit-name that actually does fracture the categorical boundaries of the classificatory process in the chants is the naming of a frog species (paíci, Curri.; unidentified) under the category of bird spirit-names (képinai). The spirit-name of paíci frogs (éenunai pépirri nákauli) also violates the ordering of éenunai names of which it is a member insofar as it places the generic spirit, or itáda, prior to the specific name, or iñákim. In the fourth and fifth chants, all éenunai spirit-names are given specific names prior to the categorical spirit-name, éenunai. Thus, the spirit-name of paíci frogs really does break out of the general classificatory process that operates throughout most of the chants. A partial clarification arises from the name Paícipe, the house of recently- deceased persons (lidánam) of the Kadáwpúrirri sib, the same sib group of which the chant-owner is a member. The éenunai are generic spirits of forest animals believed to reside in íyarudáti where the lidánam

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spirits of recently-deceased persons take care of them. This belief perhaps explains the reversal of order in the paíci frogs' spirit-name (i.e., the placement of éenunai before the specific name). However, the violation of categorical boundaries through naming an éenunai species in the middle of képinai species remains a mystery about which I can only speculate.

The names itáda or iñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli more systematically violate the categorical boundaries that separate fish from animal and animal from bird species. The name dzáwi-ñápirríkuli means "out of the jaguar's bones" and immediately brings to mind the Dzáwinápa (Jaguar-bone) ancestor songs and trumpets of Kuwái in myth (M4-7). In málikai chants, the dzáwi-ñápirríkuli spirit-names transcend the organization of species into discrete categories by appearing in all three major categories (umáwari, éenunai, and képinai). This transcendance is a process of coordination among lower-level classificatory operations and is formally analogous to the principle of continuity which the ancestor songs and trumpets of Kuwái represent in myth. The dzáwi-ñápirríkuli spirit-names do not classify species into categories but impose a higher level of order upon processes of classification. They do not refer to any particular feature of a fish, animal, or bird species in the same way as the majority of spirit-names in the chants (see below, pp. 162-65) but refer to myth episodes that explain the origin of species in terms of specific patterns of events.

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The last two spirit-names in the set of six chants most clearly illustrate how the dzáwi-ñápirríkuli spirit-names act not as a category but as a different structural level of meaning in which not species but classificatory processes themselves are the objects upon which the process of spirit-naming is acting. In these two cases, the objects of spirit-naming are two types of cooking, baking (lípalitákerri ñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli) and roasting (limáitakérri ñákim dzáwi-ñápirríkuli), which the Wakuénai believe are potentially harmful for newborn infants and their parents. The safest method of cooking is boiling in water mixed with hot peppers, and this activity is in turn the metaphorical basis of what the chant-owner is doing to baking and roasting at the end of his chants through invoking two forms of dzáwi-ñápirríkuli spirit-names. The cooking of cooking is the performer's final use of musical naming power prior to blowing tobacco smoke on the pot of káridzámai once more and returning to the house of the newborn infant and its parents to offer them the food.

Word Play in Musical Spirit-Naming

In my earlier analysis of language use in the refrain sections of málikai chants where the performer sets up the basic framework of spirit-naming as a cooking process, I identified a linguistic process of `partial alteration' as the basis for composing most of the chants' text. In this process, whole words taken from the vocabulary of everyday speech are combined with suffixes that have no apparent semantic referents in everyday speech but that help to

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establish a rhyme scheme in the refrain sections of the chants. In this case, the linguistic process of partial alteration primarily acts to contribute a greater sense of sonic unity to the chanting over and above semantic, referential meaning.

On the other hand, spirit- naming in the chants demonstrates a process of partial alteration in which semantic meanings override considerations of sound. The composition of individual spirit-names in the chants are in some instances based on a linguistic process of nominal classification that also operates in everyday speech. The adjectives meaning one, two, three, big, and little have many different forms in Wakuénai language, depending upon what class of nouns they modify (see Figure 5.5). No other adjectives have such a wide range of variants in everyday speech. However, in málikai chants the performer uses adjectival prefixes from everyday speech to make up variant forms for describing different fish, animal, and bird species by adding suffixes that are not used in everyday speech. For example, the everyday word for white (halédali) becomes the basis in chants for three names meaning white. Hálekáda éenunai is a species of small white anteater (áate, Curri.; Myrmecophagus tridactyla), hálekáita éenunai is a species of white monkey (háaru, Curri.; Cebus albifrons unicolor), and hálekápa képinai is a species of white heron (máari, Curri.; Casmerodius albus egrettus). In this example, the prefix hále- is taken from the everyday term for white and combined

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	One	Two	Three	Big	Little	Noun classes modified
1.	páda	dzamáda	madalída	makádali	tsúdali	--some forest animals (peccari and paca) --children (yénpiti) --all turtle species --some fish species (pirana, palometa, anchoa)
2.	ap-héepa	dzamhéepa	madahlípa	makádali	túp-he	--adult men (átsia)
3.	ápama	dzámama	madalíma	makádaru	tsúdaru	--adult women (ínarru)
4.	apáma,	dzamáma	madalíma	makáni	tsúkani	--all flutes that come in male/female pairs
5.	paká	dzamaká	madaliká	mákakái	tsúkai	--large catfish species (laulau,rayado,cajarro) --machete fish species --anaconda (umáwari) and all other species of snakes --all species of vine (adápi)
6.	páita	dzamáita	mandalíta	makáita	tsuíte	--all fish species except those in 1 and 5 above --groups of people (náiki)
7.	apápa	dzamápa	madaliápa	makápali	tsuápali	--wild and cultivated fruits --all bird species --fire (tídze)
8.	apána	dzámana	madalína	makáni	tsúni	--jaguars, tapirs, deer, and squirrels --dogs (tsínu) and cats (pisána) --trees and logs (háiku) --bunches of fruit
9.	ap-héwi	dzahméwi	madahlíwi	makéwi	tsuíwi	--tobacco (dzéema) --sharp objects

Figure 5.5. Partial listing of a system of nominal classifiers based on five elementary adjectives (Curricarro dialect)

with suffixes that are not used with the adjective for white in everyday speech.

Looked at purely as a poetic form, málikai chants are a verbal art which expands upon a process of nominal classification that is restricted in everyday speech to five elementary adjectives. Another way in which the poetic language of spirit-naming in chants expands upon everyday speech forms is by combining nouns from everyday speech with unusual suffixes. The spirit-name of cabezón turtles in chant demonstrates this process by fusing together the everyday word for parakeet (kúlikulí, Curri.; Aratinga pertinax margaritensis) with the suffix -áduwa to form the name umáwari kúlikuliáduwa. This spirit-name is a poetic metaphor that plays upon the similarity between the bright green coloring of parakeets and that of the underside of cabezón turtles. Likewise, the everyday word for a species of small frog (molítu) is aggregated with the suffix -áduwa to make a poetic adjective, mólituáduwa, that exploits the similarity between the small size of both molítu frogs and the viejita (dzáwirra, Curri.; Cichlasoma Sp.) fish [11]. In some cases the alteration is less poetic insofar as it is based on the same word that denotes a species in everyday speech. The species of large piraña fish (Serrasalmus rhombeus) known as hóla in everyday speech thus becomes umáwari holáduwa in the language of chant.

I have chosen to examine language use in málikai chants in some detail in order to substantiate two assertions.

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First, language use in málikai chants demonstrates a ludic, or play, element in which poetic metaphaors build upon and greatly expand the vocabulary of everyday speech. The musical organization of the chants imposes restrictions upon tone, tempo, loudness, and rhythm in language, yet, paradoxically, through word play the language of chants is nevertheless made richer and more polysemous than the vocabulary of everyday speech. Word play in málikai chants calls attention to the danger of reductionist statements to the effect that formalization of language in ritual contexts can only restrict the semantic code of everyday speech (Bloch 1974). On the contrary, formalized speech varieties in ritual may enrich the semantic code of everyday speech varieties in spite of, or even because of, the increased limitations which formalization places upon other dimensions of everyday speech acts. In short, formalization is a means for demonstrating control over speech acts that allows performers to vary one dimension of language (i.e., semantic values in word play) over an extraordinarily wide range of meanings at the same time as they maintain strict control over the other dimensions of the speech act (e.g., tempo, tone, rhythm, and loudness).

Second, the play element of language use in málikai chants is grounded in the vocabulary and syntax of everyday language use. The expanded use of nominal classification in the language of chant is present in rudimentary form in the everyday adjectives meaning one, two, three, big, and little.

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Similarly, the majority of spirit-names in the chants are composed of combinations of adjectival roots and nouns that are common in everyday speech with extraordinary suffixes. In the refrain sections of the chants, even verbs and adverbs are used in this manner. By elaborating in a sacred context upon linguistic principles common in everyday social uses of language, word play in the language of chants mediates between sacred and secular domains of experience. However, the process of carrying over principles from one domain to the other does not operate in only one direction. Not only is the language of chants grounded in nominal classification, but some of the categories which this principle establishes in everyday speech (Figure 5.5) in turn reflect sacred, cosmological principles of order from myth and the language of chant. The sixth category in Figure 5.5, for example, associates fish species with human social groups (<u>náiki</u>, or sibs), a relation that echoes the Wakuénai belief that the spirits of fish are oriented in the same way and inhabit the same region of the cosmos (<u>hekwápiríko</u>, or this world) as themselves. A subtler reflection of sacred principles of order shows up in the fourth category of Figure 5.5, a nominal class composed entirely of musical instruments that have male and female 'sexes'. As I will demonstrate later (Chapter 9), the sexing of musical instruments in ceremonial dance-music of <u>pudáli</u> and <u>kwépani</u> is an important clue to understanding the complex interrelations between these two types of exchange ceremony.

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1. The collapsing of the opposition between "my kinsmen" and "the other people" (affines or potential affines) in childbirth rituals has important implications for understanding Wakuénai concepts of descent. Although the ideology of patrilineal descent is clearly present in the myth of the sib-ancestor spirits' emergence and in other myths from the distant space-time of Iñápirríkuli, this ideology is only put into practice in performances of málikai that apply the Kuwái myth cycle to ritually-defined life crisis situations. In other words, for the Wakuénai, descent is defined through myth and ritual and does not derive from juro-political norms of corporate lineages. In fact, changing residence rules among the Wakuénai of the lower Guainía have led to a situation where the transmission of sib names and language dialects to grandchildren is effected through female lines as well as male lines, a clear indication of the flexibility of descent rules and their foundation upon the myth-ritual nexus of Kuwái and his music rather than the political organization of sib groups (see Hill and Moran, in press).
2. That Wakuénai ritual specialists perform ritual services not only for other Wakuénai but also for Baniwa and Guarequena families of the region is an interesting development which I will take up in a concluding chapter on the role of traditional musical performances

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in creating an emergent, regional Arawakan culture in the Venezuelan Amazon.

3. The release of smoke from the mouth in ritual contexts is also done musically. The smoke is inhaled and then pushed out of the mouth with a sort of humming, moaning tone followed by a loud rush of air passing through the lips. The latter, blowing sound is the basis for the Spanish, Criollo name, soplador (blower), for Wakuénai chant- owners. In my own conversations with Venezuelan Spanish-speakers, I preferred to use the Spanish term sacerdote indigena (indigenous priest) instead of the rather vulgar-sounding `soplador'. This change of the conventional term for a more dignified title is more appropriate to the respect which the Wakuénai (and many non-Wakuénai people of the region) hold for chant-owners. Also, Wakuénai chant-owners are under pressure to discontinue their traditional practices from Evangelical Indians who have been given the title of `pastor' from Protestant missionaries and who are little more than parrot-like imitators of biblical verses and Sunday-school music.

4. The second set of chants begins with the two-toned invocation of Dzúli ("Dzo-re, Dzo-re") in which the first syllable is sung at the same tone as the last tone of the first set of chants and the second syllable is sung a neutral third higher (about C# and E). From this

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point on, the chant is sung completely at the second, higher tone and rises up only slightly to F during the hour-long performance. In other words, tonal organization is almost completely static after the calling of Dzúli that connects the two sets of chants performed in childbirth rituals.

5. On the basis of my earlier discussion of the animal flutes of Kuwái (Chapter 4), the reader might guess that the enormous finger and hand belong to Kuwái. In fact, later in this chapter I will argue that the dangerous spirit-names in this set of chants all refer to parts of Kuwái's body.

6. According to myth, Iñápirríkuli gave each group of fraternal sib-ancestor spirits a pair of male and female Tobacco Owners. All five sibs of the Dzáwinai phratry, for example, share the male and female Tobacco Owners known as Dzáwihárapadékua and Dzáwidéwar, and the four Waríperídakéna sibs share the Tobacco Owners known as Marhádua and Marhédua. These spirit-names are secret knowledge known only to members of the phratry who consider themselves to be spiritual grandchildren of the Tobacco Owners. The Tobacco Owners only have healing and other ritual powers for their own descendants (the living members of the phratry). Since I did not observe and record a childbirth ritual for Wakuénai parents during my fieldwork, I am not able to

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say how the naming of these Tobacco Spirits might differ in málikai chants from the case which I recorded.

7. The Kuwái myth cycle or some variant of it, is widely shared among Arawakan peoples of the Upper Rio Negro region. Since the number of Arawakan groups in the area between the upper Orinoco and the upper Vaupés and along the middle and lower Rio Negro has drastically declined since pre-Columbian times (Wright 1981), the distribution of the Kuwái myth cycle might have been quite extensive in the prehistoric past. Ritual practices based on the Kuwái myth cycle might have varied among different peoples and yet overlapped enough so that all neighboring Arawakan groups shared a basic cultural identity. Matos Arvelo (1912) observed that the Guarequena, Baniwa, and Wakuénai of the lower Guainía in Venezuela shared a common tradition of male initiation rituals devoted to 'Máuari' (Kuwái) but that only the Wakuénai held both male and female initiation rituals. This assertion is difficult to prove (or disprove) today, for the Wakuénai are the only Arawakan group that continues to practice initiation rituals with any regularity or spontaneity. Gonzalez (1980) describes a Guarequena male initiation ritual that he observed in 1973 and that was held as a demonstration for the anthropologist. Chant-owners and shamans among the Guarequena and Baniwa are dying of old age, and

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with them goes the basis of life crisis and curing rituals (see Chapter 10). This is the practical reason for the frequent participation of Guarequena and Baniwa families in Wakuénai rituals: only the Wakuénai have practicing chant-owners and shamans.

8. The name kuwáida looks suspiciously like a variant of the name of the mythical character, Kuwái. Kuwáida fruits play an important symbolic role in the myth of Ůliámali where they act as a substitute womb and allow her to get rid of an unwanted anaconda- child that has grown to huge proportions inside her body (see below, pp. 153-57).

9. This assertion is admittedly an oversimplification for purposes of analysis and clear exposition. Many spirit-names, for example, contain a third term, iénipé (children), but this term only means that the spirit-name refers to the living descendants in this world as well as the souls from other regions of the cosmos.

10. In his discussion of beliefs about animal and human souls among the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River in Brazil, Wright has come to the same conclusion about the reversed `polarization´ of animal and bird vs. human and fish spirits.

> "The relation between the "people" aspect of animals, fish, and birds is described as one of "shadows" (idánam). As for instance, a hand

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> casts its equivalent figure in a black shadow on a wall, there are two forms, body and black shadow, separated by a barrier of some space. Both are active; what one does, the other follows. However, for the fish-people and animal people, their bodies are their shadows which humans see. The human body/ shadow equation is reversed" (1981: 404).

I point out as clarification that fish should not be included on the same side of the equation as forest animals and birds, since fish spirits are oriented in the same way as human spirits. Also, the shadows of animals and birds are called iñákim, and their "people" aspects are called itáda. Idánam is a general term for shadows and specifically refers to the shadows, or souls, of recently- deceased people when used in sacred contexts.

11. Both molítu frogs and viejita (dzáwirra) fish are important symbols in Wakuénai ceremonial music (Chapter 9). The former is the name of one of Kuwái's flutes in kwépani ceremonies, and the latter is the name of a popular duet played on yapurútu (máwi) flutes in pudáli ceremonies.

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Chapter 6:

"Sacred Musical Performances (málikai) in Initiation Rituals"

Introduction

The performances of málikai songs and chants in initiation rituals explicitly enact the series of myth events (M4) in which Kuwái taught Dzúli how to sing and chant so that Hérri could break his fast. There is no need to search for parallels between myth and ritual, since both are primarily about the transformation of Kuwái as "all things in one being" into the opposite conceptual principle of "one being in all things". A key symbol of Kuwái's transformation in initiation rituals is the kadápu whip used to tap out the rhythm of the long series of málikai songs and chants. In addition to their metronomic function in the organization of musical time throughout the singing and chanting, the kadápu whips act to `cook' the sacred food. The performers strike the whips on an overturned basket covering the pot of sacred food (káridzámai), and they repeatedly ask the spirit-name of the whips (líwanápu éenu) to "beat the rawness out of the food". The kadápu whips are highly condensed symbols of the mythical death of Kuwái in fire, the `cooking' of the sacred food in ritual, and the temporal organization of musical naming power in málikai songs and chants. The climax of initiation rituals comes when the owner of songs and chants

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(málikai limínali) lifts a small amount of káridzámai on the end of the kadápu whips, places it in the initiant's mouth, and administers two hard lashes to the initiant's back with the whips. The whipping 'cooks' the initiant and applies the transformation of Kuwái which key myth events encode and which musical performances and other ritual activities dramatically portray.

Like the málikai chants for the sacred food of newborn infants and their parents, the chants performed in initiation rituals also make cooking the central metaphor for the transformation which the ritual participants experience. In both rituals, musical cooking of káridzámai is a process of classification that organizes the transformation of experience in transitional periods of the life cycle according to the mythical model of Kuwái. However, performances of málikai chants in initiation rituals turn inside-out the classificatory process that operates in performances of málikai chants in childbirth rituals. In the transformation of children (yénpiti) into recent- initiates (wálit'áki, newly fasted) the individual soul (likáriwa) becomes dominant over the collective ancestor soul (líwarúna) in the organization of experience. In initiation rituals, specificity, uniqueness, and individuality gain the upper hand over generality, sameness, and collectivity.

Both male and female initiation rituals organize the transformation of children into recent-initiates according to the conceptual principle of Kuwái as "one being in all

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things". The chief difference between male and female initiation rituals among the Wakuénai lies in the cultural materials out of which the transformation of experience is constructed and revealed to the initiants. For males, learning to construct and perform the flutes and trumpets of Kuwái is an important means of accomplishing their transformation into recent-initiates, whereas for females, who are excluded from any contact with the musical instruments of Kuwái, málikai songs and chants and the ritual advice of the elders carry out the transformation without the added effects of the Kuwái instruments. The indigenous terms used to refer to male and female initiation rituals clearly indicate this contrast. Male initiation rituals are called wákapétaka yénpiti, or "we show our children", referring to the revelation of Kuwái in the visible, tangible form of sacred musical instruments to male initiants. Female initiation rituals are called wakáitaka yénpiti, or "we speak to our children", referring to the ritual advice which the chant-owner and other elders (both men and women) give to female initiants.

An important sociological difference between male and female initiation rituals is that males are (or were) initiated in groups representing more than one phratry, whereas females are individually initiated shortly after the onset of their first menstrual period. In their traditional form, male initiation rituals brought together several chant-owners who performed slightly different versions of málikai. Each specialist tailored his chanting to address the sib ancestor

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spirits of the initiant for whom he performed. Likewise, the ritual advising of young men was carried out in plural style with several elders giving advice at the same time. The musical instruments of Kuwái counterbalanced this plurality of chanters and advisors, since one set of flutes and trumpets sufficed for all the different initiants. Female initiations, however, focus ritual attention exclusively on an individual girl and her transformation into a recent-initiate after puberty.

The Dzáwinai and Waríperídakéna families of Gavilán on the lower Guainía continue to perform female initiation rituals in relatively unchanged style[1]. Upon reaching puberty, young women fast on manioc and wild fruit drinks for approximately one week before the ritual chanting, advising, and whipping. Males used to fast for about a month while undergoing initiation, but nowadays they do not fast for more than one or two days. Male initiation rituals, like kwépani and pudáli ceremonies, have declined due to social changes that have deeply affected relations among widely dispersed local groups[2]. Female initiation rituals have largely survived these changes, since they do not depend on the participation of specialists, families, and initiants from different local groups and phratries. The following description and analysis of musical performances and other ritual activities is based on a female initiation ritual held in Gavilán in 1981[3].

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Description of Ritual Activities

A girl's first menstrual period is the first sign that she is ready for initiation, but the observance of ritual seclusion and fasting does not begin until there are wild fruits ripening in abundance in the vicinity of her village. Then she begins to fast on manioc drinks made from water, wild fruit juices, and manioc flour. The wild fruits are collected by her father and processed into drinks by her mother. Her fast marks the end of a process of childhood growth that begins with the káridzámai (via mother's milk) in early infancy and gradually opens up to include manioc, fruits, vegetables, small fish, and finally, by age four or so, meat of game animals, birds, and 'strong' fish species (e.g., bocachico and large catfish species). Seclusion of the pubescent girl during her fast on manioc and wild fruit drinks is a highly visible sign of her special status in the village. The girl stays behind a partition made of chique-chique palm thatch (máramápe) that sets aside one corner of her family's house[4].

The performance of málikai songs and chants on the last day of the girl's ritual fast and seclusion begins at noon and lasts until sunset. The girl's mother prepares a pot of hot-peppered meat and gives it to the málikai limínali in the late morning. The chant-owner covers the food with leaves of white yagrumo (dúkurípe) and then places a large, shallow basket upside-down over the pot of food. The chant-owner and his accompanist[5] cut two sticks of kadápu wood and sit down

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on a bench in front of the sacred food. The chant-owner begins to sing, and both men tap their whips in a prestissimo rhythm upon the overturned basked that covers the pot of sacred food. After less than four minutes, the song transforms into a flat, monotone chant, and shortly thereafter the tempo and rhythm settle into a steady, binary pulse of 100 beats/minute (andante). The chanting that emerges out of the initial song of initiation rituals has a familiar sound. Aside from a few technical details, the málikai chants in initiation rituals have almost exactly the same musical organization as the chants performed for the sacred food of newborn infants and their parents in childbirth rituals. At the end of each chant, the chant-owner lifts up one side of the basket covering the sacred food and blows tobacco smoke onto the food through a small hole in the yagrumo-leaf covering.

The chants (22 in all) continue in this way for several hours. In current practice, the girl being initiated does not come out of seclusion until the chanting and singing is almost over. In traditional rituals, however, the girl's first emergence from seclusion came during breaks between the chants when her kin performed dance-songs called kápetiápani. Kapéti is a different type of whip that is not considered suitable for whipping the sacred food or initiants. The kapéti whips are used only for marking time in dance-songs. Men carry the long sticks of dzámakwápi or other wood in a vertical position and mark time by ramming the thicker,

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handle portion against the ground as they step down with their right foot. The musical function of kapéti whips thus parallels that of kadápu whips in málikai songs and chants, but kapéti are not regarded as highly powerful symbols of transformation in the same way as kadápu. The music of kápetiápani dances does not include spirit-naming like the málikai chants but refers rather to myth events and parallel ritual activities such as the "house door" (pána-numá, or mouth of the house) through which the girl's mother leads her out of seclusion to dance with her kinsmen, and the thirst and drunkenness of Kuwái (and his musical instruments). Kápetiápani dance-songs form part of a different genre of musical performance, called líaka, that also includes the dance-music of animal flutes played in male initiation rituals and kwépani ceremonies[6].

The final málikai song returns to the same melody and rhythm that had served as an overture to the series of chants and which now signal the girl's mother to bring her daughter out of seclusion for the last time to receive advice, the hot-peppered food, and the ritual whipping. The initiant's body and face are painted red with kérawídzu, and she stands on a small mat of tirita (pwáapwa) in front of the chant-owner. Before starting his advice to the girl, the chant-owner prays over the sacred food and blows smoke into it for the last time. The prayer is uttered without any singing and is believed to make the pepper, meat, and other ingredients of the sacred food safe for the girl to eat without ag-

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gravating the pain caused by her menstrual period. The two kadápu whips that had been separately used to beat out the rhythms of málikai songs and chants are now tied together to form a double-stranded whip. The chant-owner holds the whip in his right hand and gestures with it toward the girl, in this case his granddaughter (daughter's daughter). His voice grows ever tenser and angrier as the advice proceeds, and other senior kin of the girl often interject angry exhortations ("Listen to what your grandfather is saying!").

The following list of exhortations is an approximate translation of the advice which Hernando Camico, headman of Gavilán and owner of málikai chants and songs, gave to his granddaughter at her initiation ritual in July, 1981.

> "I am going to explain for you why I must give you this whipping. I do it so that you don't enter into evil relations with others, so that you work well for your parents, and so that you listen to your father. If you think that your hunger is painful, you don't know real hunger like we (elders) did when we fasted for an entire month."
>
> "Don't look at the work of other people with envy. If you like the work of another person, do the same. Never rob from others. Always give food to visitors --- yucuta, meat, everything. If White people or bad people come and don't share with us, don't give them anything. This whipping that I'm going to give you doesn't hurt so much. Before, our grandfathers hit us with whips

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made of solid wood and four sticks. That really hurt"[7].

"Look at me, your grandfather. I have never killed another person. There are people who kill others with poison, but not me. We are people who never fight with our parents. There are little girls who fight with their mothers, but from now on, you cannot get angry at your mother. Look at your mother who brought you up. You cannot fight with her. Now you must work for her in exchange for all the work she did for you when you were still a child."

"Speak the truth, and don't tell lies."

"When my cousins arrive, I always give them yucuta to drink if I don't have any smoked meat to offer them. My grandfathers taught me to share food with others in this way, and that is what I've always done. Whichever White men arrive, I give them food. If they don't want to eat, I don't give them food. Food is for sharing not only with your kin but also with visitors and strangers. Food is for everyone."

"I'm giving this advice to you because I am a good man. I never fought with your father or with the other men here. I do not argue with them. When I'm drinking liquor, I speak calmly with them."

The advice represents a set of moral rules that transcend the rules and axioms of everyday social life, many of which lead to potential or actual conflicts of interest. The ritual advice given to initiants represents the comple-

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tion of the individual as a moral being in society, a process that parallels Kuwái's mythical completion of the unfinished creation of Iñápirríkuli, a distant mythical space-time in which semi-human beings delighted in killing and deceiving one another. The ritual advice asserts that the initiant is now part of the order established by Kuwái in myth when he taught Dzúli the málikai songs and chants and then surrendered himself to death by fire. With the burning pain of hot pepper in her mouth, hunger in her stomach, and two hard lashes on her back, the initiant relives Kuwái's firy death. Like Kuwái in myth, she willingly surrenders herself to the burning pains of hunger, hot pepper, and whipping. Even as two loud cracks of the kadápu whip slamming into her back ring out in the complete silence of the evening, her face shows no pain, and she does not utter the faintest sound.

Musical Symbolism in Málikai

Songs and Chants of Initiation

The degree to which non-specialist participants and observers understand the referential meanings of language used in málikai songs and chants is not clear. In general, they know the meaning of categorical terms (e.g., éenunai or umáwari) and that the chant-owner is naming all the fish, animal, and bird species. But whether or not they understand how spirit-naming operates, the organization of language into musical tones and rhythms provides an accessible framework within which the application of conceptual principles from the Kuwái myth cycle to the transformative experiences of

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ritual becomes intelligible to anyone listening to the chants. I begin with an analysis of musical symbolism in málikai songs and chants and how this organization contributes to the effectiveness of ritual activities in the transformation of children into recent-initiates.

The first and last performances of málikai for the sacred food of initiants are musically constructed out of two principal tones in a high baritone/low tenor range and three slightly lower passing tones. They are songs instead of monotone chants, and the tonal movements, or melodies, are accompanied by a very rapid tapping rhythm and an equally swift flow of speech. Like the first set of chants performed in childbirth rituals, the opening and closing songs in initiation rituals convey a sense of motion, growth, and expansion. However, the use of five distinct tones in the opening and closing songs of initiation rituals represent a different kind of transformation than the raising of pitch by microtonal intervals that characterizes the first set of chants in childbirth rituals. The use of distinct tones in initiation songs is a musical model for spatial movements among separate locations. The continuous and rapid flow of speech and tapping of rhythm compress time into extremely short intervals. Time compression helps to accentuate the sense of spatial mobility conveyed through movements among distinct tones, since the performer does not remain on any one pitch for longer than a few seconds[8].

In total contrast, the set of twenty-one chants which

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the chant-owner performs after the opening song and before the closing song are each based on a single pitch that slowly rises by microtonal intervals. The total rise is usually less than one chromatic half-step[9]. These chants are in many respects identical in terms of musical organization to the second set of chants performed in childbirth rituals. Nevertheless, there are a number of important musical differences between the two sets of chants. One main difference is that the chants for initiation rituals are longer and over three times as numerous (21 as opposed to 6). Also, they are not as tonally unified as the childbirth chants, all six of which stay within a single chromatic half-step. By contrast, the chants for initiation are not all sung at the same pitch: the highest are almost a major third above the lowest. This difference is another expression of movement among disconinuous spatial locations through singing on different pitches. Time compression is also more evident in the chants for initiation than those for childbirth rituals. Instead of a static, unchanging tempo,the chants for initiation begin at around 98 beats/minute and accelerate up to as high as 112 beats/minute. Whereas in childbirth rituals, the spirit-name of kadápu whips (<u>líwanápu éenu</u>) is named in the chants only once, in the chants for initiation the whips are frequently named throughout the chants and are used to mark time by splitting each word of the text into two parts. A final musical difference is that in chants for initiation, the chant-owner has an accompanist who sings the last word of

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each phrase (usually five words or ten beats in each phrase). This practice allows the main performer to catch his breath while his accompanist sings and to begin the next phrase without having to stop for one beat to breathe. The effects are to shorten the average phrase length of childbirth chants by a single two-beat unit of time and to give greater volume to the last word of each phrase. Some chants go on in this way for almost 20 minutes without missing a single beat.

In spite of the musical differences between the málikai chants performed in initiation rituals and those performed for the sacred food of newborn infants and their parents in childbirth rituals, the striking similarity of the tonal and rhythmical organization in the two sets of chants is so overwhelming that no one can fail to recognize that the chants are closely interrelated. An analysis of chants performed in initiation rituals has to take into account their similarity to chants performed in childbirth rituals in order to explore the meanings of the differences between the two sets of chants. In childbirth rituals, the strict binary rhythm, unity of tone and loudness, and steady tempo of málikai chants represent the imposition of a relatively fixed conceptual order of Kuwái as "all things in one being" upon an uncontrolled, disorderly process of expansion. The growth processes of Kuwái and the newborn infant are put into order in the second set of chants; their `everything-ness´ is organized into a single entity that has clearly-defined boundaries. In initiation rituals, the conceptual order of

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Kuwái as "all things in one being" is itself the object of transformation and is put inside of, or bracketted by, opening and closing songs that express rapid temporal movement through a number of distinct spatial (tonal) locations. The strict binary rhythm and even loudness of the chants are sandwiched between the two songs and are thus transformed in two ways: 1)they are sung on different pitches and 2) they each accelerate in tempo by 10 or more beats/minute.

To translate these musical terms into the terminology I have used in my analysis of the Kuwái myth cycle, the constancy of tone, loudness, rhythm, and tempo of the second set of chants performed in childbirth rituals can be said to communicate the conceptual principle of sameness, or "all things in one being". In initiation rituals, placement of this same musical style of chanting into a musical 'envelope' of closing and opening songs transforms it into a principle of uniqueness, or "one being in all things". The diagrams in Figures 6.1 and 6.2 are an attempt to bridge the gap between musical and verbal analysis by giving a visual representation of the differences between málikai chants performed in childbirth rituals (Figure 6.1) and the songs and chants of initiation rituals (Figure 6.2).

Mythical Characters and Place-Naming in the Opening Song-Chant

The texts of the opening and closing songs in initiation rituals focus on the three mythical characters of Dzúli (the mythical owner of málikai), Hérri (the first initiant), and

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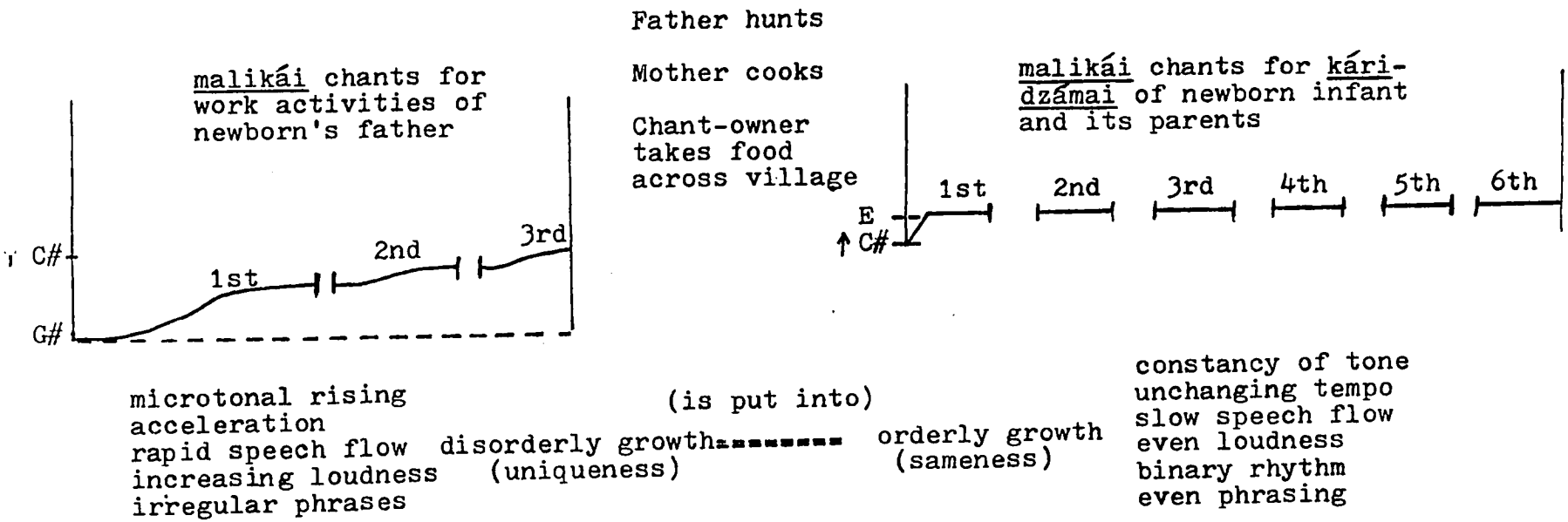


Figure 6.1. The two sets of chants (malikái) performed in childbirth rituals; disorderly growth (uniqueness) is put into an order of sameness.

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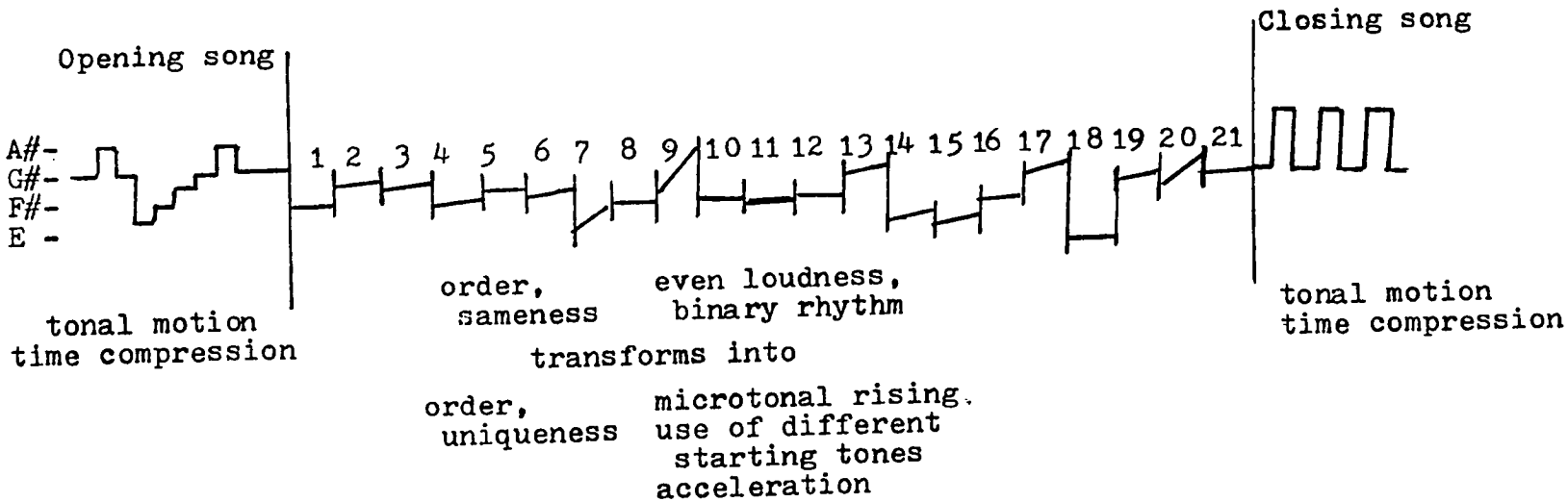


Figure 6.2. Songs and chants (malikái) performed in initiation rituals; an order of sameness is put inside songs that express transformation and change through tonal motion and time compression. Order of sameness transforms into an order of uniqueness.

Amáru (the mother of Kuwái). The repeated naming of Dzúli and Hérri in the songs connects the musical performaces and other ritual activities with the myth of Dzúli's memorization of the chants and songs (M4) that would enable Hérri to end his fast and Kuwái to allow himself to be killed in fire and transformed. The naming of Amáru refers to that part of the myth cycle in which Amáru stole the flutes of Kuwái and travelled with them over great distances in order to avoid losing them back to Iñápirríkuli (M6). In the mythical chase, the world opened up for a second time as Amáru played the flutes of Kuwái in various places. Depicting this second transformation of the world and applying it to the transformation of children into recent-initiates are primary concerns of the opening and closing songs of initiation rituals.

The physical embodiment of Kuwái's transformation is the kadápu whip, the instrument which later allows the chant-owner to 'cook' (classify) spirit-names of fish, animal, and bird species, the pot of sacred food, and the initiant herself. Significantly, the spirit-name of kadápu whips is named several times in the opening and closing songs, whereas the spirit-names of fish, animal, and bird species do not appear in the song texts. This omission illustrates the songs' purpose as transformative agents that act upon principles of order rather than the objects of an ordering process. The songs are not concerned with classifying the diverse natural species that collectively make up the mythical being of Kuwái but with transforming the classificatory process by which

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natural species are ordered.

The opening song modulates into a monotone chant, but still there is no naming of the spirits of fish, animal, and bird species. Instead, the text focuses on spatial movements from celestial regions of the cosmos down to the village of Hípana, a village on the Aiarí River that corresponds in myth to the village of Iñápirríkuli before the two expansions of the world in the Kuwái myth cycle. Two important celestial regions are named as points of departure in the chant: hlíwa-káremi dzá-wí ñápirriku-lí and líwana-pú ée-nú. The former refers to the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli, or likáremi, where the souls of recently-deceased persons (lidánam) eventually rejoin their sib ancestor souls (líwarúna), and Iñápirríkuli is believed to 'own' and care for the specific souls (iñákim) of forest animal and bird species. Líwanápu éenu, of course, is the spirit-name of kadápu whips, but its literal meaning is "corner of the sky", a meaning which the chant-owner understands as the corner of Kuwái's house in the sky where he kept the kadápu whips for the first initiation ritual. The different regions of the sky (éenu) are symbolically connected to one another and to the surface world through naming the celestial umbilical cord, hiépule-kwám ée-nú. The next place name in the chant is Hípana-kwám dzáka-ré (Hípana-place village), the site where Kuwái came down to earth to perform málikai songs and chants for Hérri. The chant thus imitates the vertical movement downwards in myth from the celestial homes of Iñápirríkuli and

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Kuwái to Hípana, the same place where the sib ancestor sirits had originated through an opposite process of emergence upwards from underground in the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli.

Place-Naming in Malikai Chants for Female Initiation

In the first chant after the opening song-chant described above, the beginning of horizontal movements across the surface of the world coincides with the first spirit-naming of fish, animal, and bird species. Each of the twenty-one chants names at least one place that is not named anywhere else, and some chants name several different places. In some cases the chant-owner only names a place in passing, but there are a number of important locations where the performer stops to name the spirits of fish, bird, and animal species. Some longer chants change locations several times and name the spirits of fish, animal, and bird species at each of the locations. The range of place names approximates the total number of places in the collective experience, both mythical and actual, of the local group. Not every place known about but only those based on myth or which one or more members of the local group have actually experienced are named in the chants.

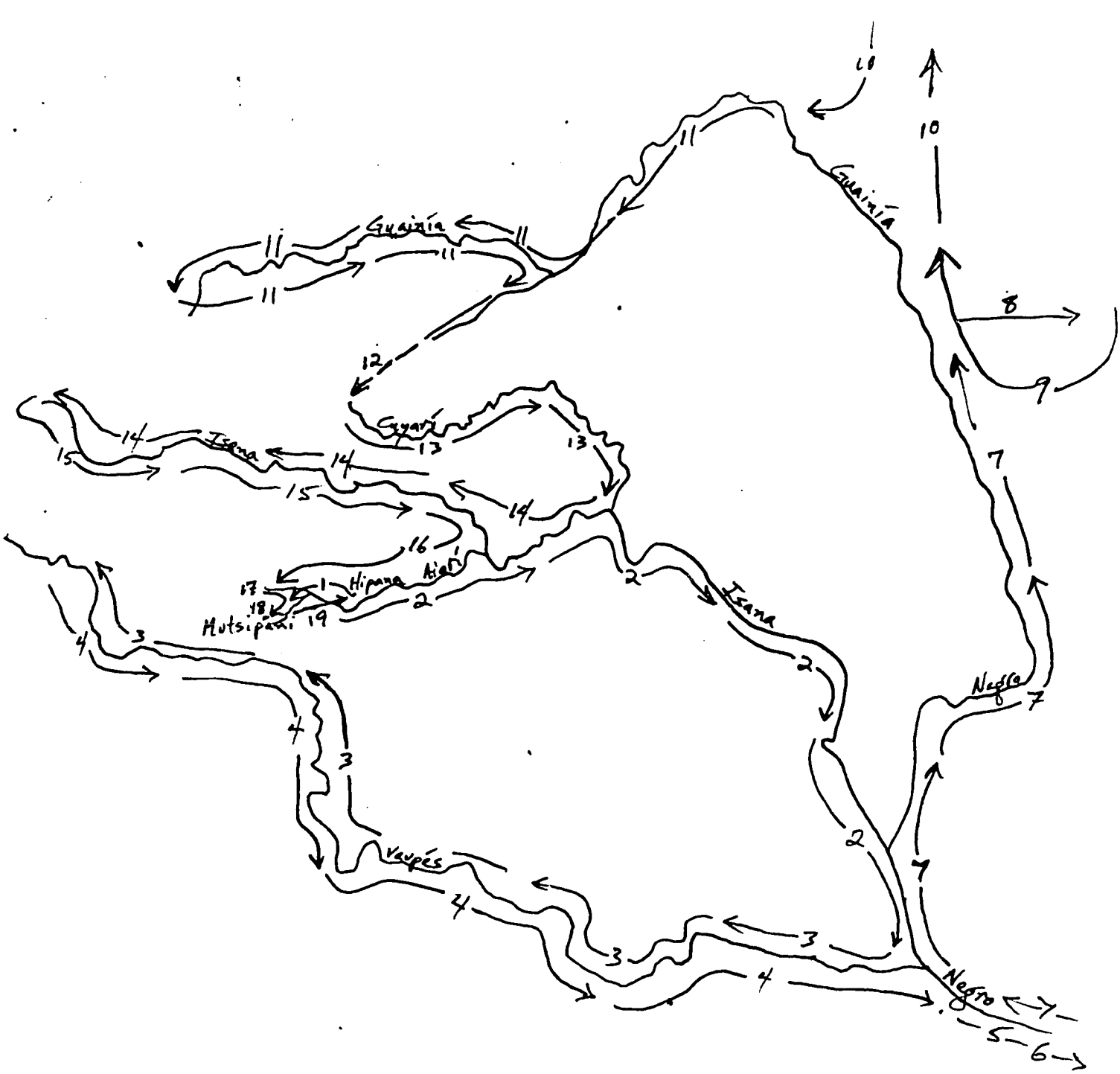
The mythical basis of place-naming in chants is the story of Amáru's stealing and playing of the sacred flutes of Kuwái in various locations. Thus, place-naming in most of the chants parallels Amáru's mythical travels down the Aiarí from Mútsipáni, down the Isana, up the Vaupés and Cayarí, and so

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forth (see Figure 6.3 and Map 6.1). At a certain point, the place-naming in chants starts to break away from the mythical travels of Amáru and begins to fill in all the locations which members of the local groups living in Gavilán have come to experience in the ten years since they immigrated to Venezuela from the Isana River. The place names include a number of villages and towns along the Temi and Atabapo rivers, major ports along the Orinoco River as far away as Ciudad Bolivar, and several locations along the Guaviare and Inirida rivers (see Map 6.2). From there, place-naming in chants returns to traditional Wakuénai territory, ascending the Guainía River to a portage that reaches the headwaters of the Cuyarí, descending the Cuyarí to the Isana, and ascending the Isana to its headwaters. After returning back down the Isana to the mouth of the Aiarí, the place naming goes up the Aiarí to its headwaters. Then it returns down the Aiarí to the mouth of Caño Waraná and ascends to Mútsipáni. The last place to be named is Hípana.

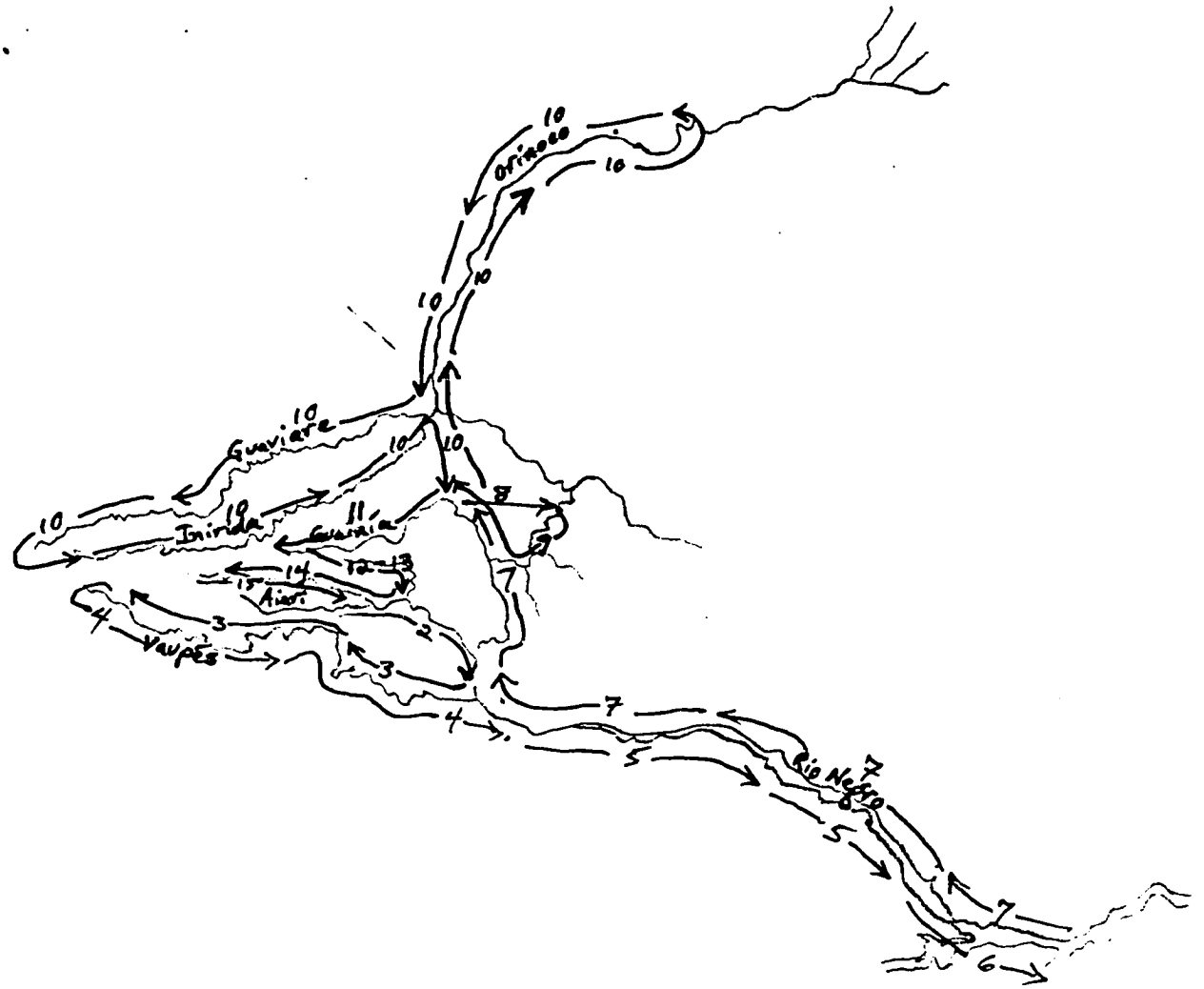
Place-naming becomes especially prominent in the last two chants, where the number of fish, animal, and bird spirit-names tapers off to nearly zero and the number of different places names soars to fifteen per chant. Many of these final place names are considered highly sacred sites: Raudal Aranha, where Iñápirríkuli left petroglyph diagrams of the Dzáwinápa trumpets for male initiation rituals; wálirru-kwá dzáka-ré, where bitter manioc originated; Raudal Yuruparí, or Tsépani-kwá Dzáka-ré, where Kuwái danced and played the heron

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MAP 6.1. Spatial movements of Amáru as told in málikai chants for female initiation rituals

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Map 6.2. Long distance travel in malikai chants for female initiation rituals

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1) from Hípana to Mútsipáni (Amáru's home at headwaters of Caño Waraná)
2) down Caño Waraná, down the Aiarí, and down the Isana to the Vaupés
3) up the Vaupés to headwaters
4) down the Vaupés to São Gabriel (Kúrukwi-kwá)
5) down the Río Negro to Manaus (Báara-kwá)
6) down the Amazon to Tsówai-kwá
7) up the Río Negro past Cucuí to Paso del Diablo on the lower Guainía
8) over to Paso del Diablo on the Casiquiare
9) down the Casiquiare and up the Guainía to Maroa (Venezuelan town near Gavilan)
10) down the Temi, Atabapo, and Orinoco rivers (see Map 2)
11) up Orinoco to Guaviare, up Guaviare to headwaters
12) portage to headwaters of Inirida, down Inirida to Atabapo
13) up Atabapo and Temi to Maroa on lower Guainía
14) up Guainía to headwaters
15) up Caño Naquen, portage to headwaters of Cuyarí
16) down Cuyarí to Isana
17) up Isana to headwaters
18) back down Isana to mouth of Aiarí
19) up Aiarí to headwaters
20) back down Aiarí to mouth of Caño Waraná
21) up Cano Waraná to Mútsipáni
22) down Caño Waraná and up Aiarí to Hípana

Figure 6.3. Outline of horizontal movements in malikái chants for female initiation; movements 5, 6, &10-13 are too large to appear on Map 1 and can be seen on Map 6.2.

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(máario) flutes after eating the three nephews of Iñápirríkuli; and Mútsipáni and Hípana, the center of the world. The return from Mútsipáni to Hípana brings the chants back to their starting point in the opening song-chant and parallels Iñápirríkuli's recuperation of the sacred flutes from Amáru near the end of the Kuwái myth cycle (M7).

Mythical Characters and the Return to Vertical Movement in the Closing Song

Place-naming that describes horizontal movements in this world (hekwápiríko) ends in the last chant at Hípana and is absent from the text of the closing song. The mythical characters of Dzúli and Hérri are the main subjects of the song. Amáru is no longer directly named as she was in the opening song-chant, since her journey through this world is now complete. However, the song text does name Amáru's celestial home on the eastern horizon (éenutánhi), a place where the rivers run in a full circle. The naming of Amáru's celestial home (hlípu-kwáta ée-nú) shows that the closing song has returned to the theme of vertical movements between celestial regions of the cosmos and the surface world. The closing song also names Kuwái's celestial home (liwana-pu ée-nú), the mythical place where Kuwái lived after separation from his mother, after his death in fire, and again after his eventual recuperation by Iñápirríkuli.

The return to the theme of vertical movement in the last song brackets the horizontal movements that are depicted in the long series of chants between a pair of downward and

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upward movements. The horizontal movements of place-naming in the chants are put into an enveloping pair of vertical movements in much the same way as the musical tones of the chants are put inside of opening and closing songs that make use of two or more distinct tones (see Figure 6.2). The sandwiching of horizontal movements between vertical ones in both place-naming and musical organization transforms the process of ordering which the chants put into operation. The singing of chants on different pitches transforms the classification of objects according to their sameness into an organizing process that emphasizes uniqueness. Likewise, place-naming and the horizontal movements that it portrays in the chants transform a process of ordering all objects (things and places) into one being on the basis of their sameness into a classificatory operation in which one being (Kuwái) makes all things and places unique. Each place where Amáru took Kuwái in myth has its own distinct name in the chants, and some locations are further differentiated by naming specific patterns of fish, animal, and bird species.

Spirit-Naming in Malikai Chants for Initiation

The transformation of Kuwái as "all things in one being" into "one being in all things" takes on full form in the spirit-naming of fish, animal, and bird species in málikai chants for initiation. The general pattern of spirit-naming is one in which each chant includes names from at least two of the major categories (itáda) of spirits. The deliberate mixing together of categories in each chant demonstrates that

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the specific (iñákim) spirits from the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli are now being used to `cook', or classify, the general categories of fish and aquatic animals (umáwari), forest animals (éenunai), and birds (képinai). One of the best examples of how the chants lay emphasis on the specific, or iñákim, part of spirit-names through crossing categorical (itáda) boundaries is the use of the name náwibírrikírri ("collared") in the fifth chant. In this case, the chant-owner is in the process of naming several forest animal, or éenunai, species and arrives at náwibirri-kírri éenu-nai ("collared forest animal", collared peccary) and goes without any intervening verses to náwibirri-kírri orái-nainái umá-warí iéni-pé ("the collared vieja fish children"). From there he changes to a new place and names two fish species (lau-lau and chanqletta), moves to another place and names a bird species, moves again and names four fish species, one animal species, and ends the chant after naming one more fish species. The process of spirit-naming is one in which specific (iñákim) spirit-names classify different locations according to their uniqueness. The great number of iñákim spirit-names gives the performer an almost unlimited ability to classify each place in the world according to a unique pattern of fish, animal, and bird species.

A few places, such as Kuwáiñai-kwá dzáka-ré, the village of bee-spirits (kuwáiñai) who play an important role in málikai songs for curing illness (see Chapter 7), receive a full complement of fish, animal, and bird names. In chant 16,

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when the chant-owner reaches the bee-spirits' village near the headwaters of the upper Guainía river, the spirits of eleven fish species, nineteen animal species, and four bird species are named before moving to another place on the Cuyarí River. Thus, spirit-naming in the chants acts in combination with place-naming to classify all things and places according to their uniqueness and relative value. Some places receive a full complement of natural species from all three main categories, some are given only a few species from one or two categories, and others are named only in passing without being given any spirit-names of natural species.

Analysis of Place- and Spirit-Naming in Malikai

The process of classification according to a conceptual principle of uniqueness unfolds within a musical and verbal context of transformation which the opening and closing songs communicate as vertical movements downward and upward. The application of this model to the transformation of children into recent-initiates is heavily laden with sociological implications, since recent-initiates enter that stage of the life cycle in which they become capable of sexual reproduction, and this capacity in turn requires the young people to travel. Young men must travel to their future wives' villages and prove their self-worth through brideservice for their fathers-in-law. Young women must leave their kinsmen's villages upon their husbands' successful completion of the brideservice and travel to their husbands' villages or whereever else their husbands might go (see Chapter 8).

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The mythical origins of brideservice and the spatial movements of individuals that it entails are discernible from the very beginning of cosmic history in the myth of Iñápirríkuli's creation. The myth portrays a relationship of ongoing, violent hostility in which the father's sister's husband repeatedly tries to kill Iñápirríkuli (WBS) in the manioc gardens, while fishing, and elsewhere. The myth of Iñápirríkuli's creation implicitly contains a sociological understanding of Wakuénai society that recognizes the potential conflicts of interest centered around the institution of exogamous marriage. The myth speculates upon the results of everyday social norms in the absence of any higher, restraining power that can override potential and actual conflicts.

Musical place- and spirit-naming in <u>málikai</u> songs and chants for initiation portray the same critical stage of the life cycle, the period from puberty to parenthood, as a transformation of the conceptual principle of Kuwái as "all things in one being" into its opposite. The songs and chants of initiation rituals bracket horizontal movements, or travel, within vertical movements that represent an infusion of the sacred power of Kuwái's music into this world in the person of the initiant as a unique individual. The uniqueness of each place and object in the world is equated with the uniqueness of each individual human being in the world. Individuality is thus sanctified as the logical outcome of a controlled and orderly transformation of children into

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recent-initiates. Initiation makes individuality and uniqueness into qualities that enhance the social order and the natural world rather than defects that lead to breakdown of social order and loss of control over the natural world and that must therefore be banished.

Post-Initiation Practices

Post-initiation practices for female initiates differ from those for male initiates. In the past, young men were expected to abstain from eating meat of game animals, birds, and `strong' fish species for the 6-month period immediately following their initiation ritual. Their period of semi-fasting ended in a brief performance of málikai chants for the stronger meat foods. However,neither the fasting nor the ritual chanting are still practiced today among the Wakuénai of the lower Guainía. As mentioned earlier, male initiation rituals have diminshed in size and frequency relative to female initiation rituals. For young men, constructing and playing the animal flutes of Kuwái with adult men in kwépani ceremonies and initiation rituals for their younger brothers marked the completion of their transformation into initiates. The animal flutes of Kuwái represent different parts of Kuwái's body, and to dance in a group of men while playing the instruments is a dramatization of the conceptual principle of "one being in all things".

For female initiates, the completion of their transformation centers around performances of málikai prayers for each different species of plant or animal food before they

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eat some of it. These prayers carry the conceptual principle of uniqueness to its logical extreme by focusing exclusively upon one particular species/spirit (iñákim) at a time. The process of naming each food species as it enters the village can go on for several years, since many fish, animal, and bird species are seldom actually captured. What tends to happen is that perennial crops like manioc and the most commonly eaten fish and animal species are all addressed in a relatively short period of time, leaving the more exotic and rarer species to be filled in over the years prior to a young woman's departure to live in her husband's village. During the time I was in the field, the chant-owner performed málikai prayers for all the major crops that were available, peccaries, large catfish, and some fruits brought to the village by a kinsman returning from a long trip up the Guaviare River to the north.

Childbirth Rituals from the Parents' Perspective

The classification of places, objects, and people according to their uniqueness is diametrically opposed to the classificatory process by which children's identities are disentangled from those of their parents shortly after birth and attached to the sib ancestor soul of their father's kinsmen. Nevertheless, the chilbirth ritual does not transform the parents of newborn infants in the same way as it does the infants themselves. For the newborn infant (kérramu), the performances of málikai chants bring about a profound and irreversible transformation from disorderly ex-

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pansion to controlled growth organized by the principle of sameness. The parents' first participation in childbirth rituals marks the beginning of full adulthood. Unlike the kérramu, the parents do not actively undergo transformation so much as passively experience an irreversible transformation of their children from biological and spiritual appendages of themselves into individual descendants (likáriwa) of the father's kinsmen's sib ancestor soul. After the ritual, the parents lead normal adult lives so long as they remain healthy, provide for the children's needs, and maintain everyday social relations with the other adults of the village. After each new childbirth, the parents participate in the transformation of their newborn child into another descendant of the sib ancestor soul. The repetition over time of the parents' participation in childbirth rituals is what sets it off as a different type of experience than the one-time only transformation which each newborn infant goes through shortly after birth.

The repetition of childbirth rituals for parents is a process in which they become more and more a part of the chain linking the sib ancestor soul to living descendants. The greater the number of occasions on which the parents participate in the transformation of disorderly expansion into controlled childhood growth, the greater is their contribution to the continuity of the sib. At each childbirth ritual, the parents' participation allows the ritual specialist, or owner of málikai, to take the child's spiritual

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growth away from direct control by its parents and into the hands of the sib group as a whole. Through repetitions of this process over time, fathers actually become sib ancestors who grow closer to the sib ancestor soul. For mothers, the repeated childbirth rituals make them more and more like sib ancestors by showing that the children they bear are descendants of the local sib ancestors. Each new childbirth ritual reinforces this gradual changing of women's identities through the associated myth of Iñápirríkuli's incestuous sexual relations with Amáru. Women who are seen as strangers and outsiders when they first move into their husbands' villages thus gradually become insiders of the local sib through repeatedly bearing children and participating in childbirth rituals.

Both men and women become identified with the continuity of the local sib group through their alternating statuses as kinénerri/ kinédua and hnúnirri/hnúdua (my father/my mother). As parents advance in age and their children are initiated and begin to have children of their own, they grow closer to the sib ancestor soul even as they retain their individual human souls (likáriwa) as conscious, initiated sib members. They are the spiritual and social leaders of the local sib group, and among them are the powerful shamans (malírri), the chant-owners (málikai limínali), the master musicians (mádzeru), the house-owners (pantímnali and pantímnaru, male and female ceremonial hosts), the ceremony-owners (kwépanímnali, púdalímnali, and púdalímnaru; owner of kwépani

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and male and female owners of pudáli, respectively), and other elders who advise, guide, and control the growth and transformation of children and initiates. Over the years, senior ritual specialists take on more and more resemblances to the mythical characters who originated musical and other ritual practices: the shaman becomes like Dzulíhwerri, the chant-owner becomes like Dzúli, and the master musician becomes more like Káaliéni (Káali's child). Collectively, the elders represent the continuity of the local sib group and its particular cultural and linguistic traditions.

In myth, continuity as a principle of integration is represented by the ancestor songs and trumpets (Dzáwinápa) of Kuwái. This same principle of continuity is present in the language of chants as the category of spirit-names called dzáwi-ñápirríkuli. In the social order of the local sib group, the ongoing process of bearing children and participating in childbirth rituals represents the principle of continuity. Seen as a long-term performative process that lasts for the entire span of adult women's reproductive years, the childbirth ritual is structurally equivalent to Kuwái's third transformation as the ancestor songs and trumpets. In this sense, the ritual is no longer a matter of being transformed but of gradually reaching a state of active control over transformation itself.

Performances of Malikai as a Meta-Symbolic Code

Taken as a whole, the málikai chants and songs performed in childbirth rituals provide a meta-symbolic code within

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which the application of sacred conceptual principles of Kuwái to the life cycle becomes intelligible. The phenomenon of musical naming power makes use of illocutionary force that is based on the concept of cooking as a transformative process. At the same time, the cooking transformations of musical naming power are classificatory operations that organize the experienced world of objects, places, and people according to conceptual principles implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle. Musical naming power allows the performer to construct the conceptual principles of Kuwái and apply these principles to the social experience of life cycle transitions through an increase in formalization and control over tonal and temporal dimensions of language use coupled with an increase in the range of variance of semantic meanings of words. Musical naming power also allows the performer to make meta-symbolic commentaries on the meaning of the conceptual principles which he uses to organize the experienced world of objects, places, and people. For example, the chant-owner can name a special class of spirits, the dzáwi-ñápirríkuli, to stand for the classificatory operation of cooking with which he is organizing spirit-names throughout the chants. In doing so, he applies the illocutionary force of `cooking' as a classificatory operation to the same process of cooking. This procedure appears in málikai chants for both childbirth and initiation rituals, and it illustrates how musical performances can make not only logical propositions (e.g., "A cooks B", or "A classifies B") but also logical propositions

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about the same logical proposition (e.g., "C cooks "A cooks B"").

Another way in which musical naming power acts as a meta-symbolic code for the organization of the experience world at transitional moments in the life cycle is through making one set of performances stand for another set of performances. The chants for initiation, for example, refer not only to the context of initiation in which they are performed but also to the second set of chants performed in childbirth rituals. In this case, a very distinctive process of formalization, a strict binary rhythm applied to each word of the text, connects two widely separated points in the life cycle (and myth cycle). At both childbirth and initiation, the chant-owner uses the cooking metaphor of musical naming power to effect a transformation of the ritual participants. However, other features of the musical organization in the two sets of chants also show how the classificatory processes of cooking that are common to both are diametrically opposed. In short, the musical organization of málikai chants provides a conceptual framework within which childbirth and initiation can be understood as parts of the same classificatory process only applied in opposite directions.

In terms of Wakuénai eschatology, the musical application of conceptual principles of Kuwái at different points in the life cycle results in different emphasis on either the individual or collective soul or both. After childbirth, the kérramu is given both collective and individual souls, but

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emphasis is placed on the child's collective soul. After initiation, the emphasis is reversed and placed on the individual soul of the initiate. Full adulthood is attained through a gradual equalization of emphases upon both the collective (líwarúna) and individual (likáriwa) souls. Figure 6.4 is a schematic diagram of the evolution of souls in the Wakuénai life cycle and how this process of change parallels both the Kuwái myth cycle and performances of málikai songs, chants, and prayers at transitional points in the life cycle.

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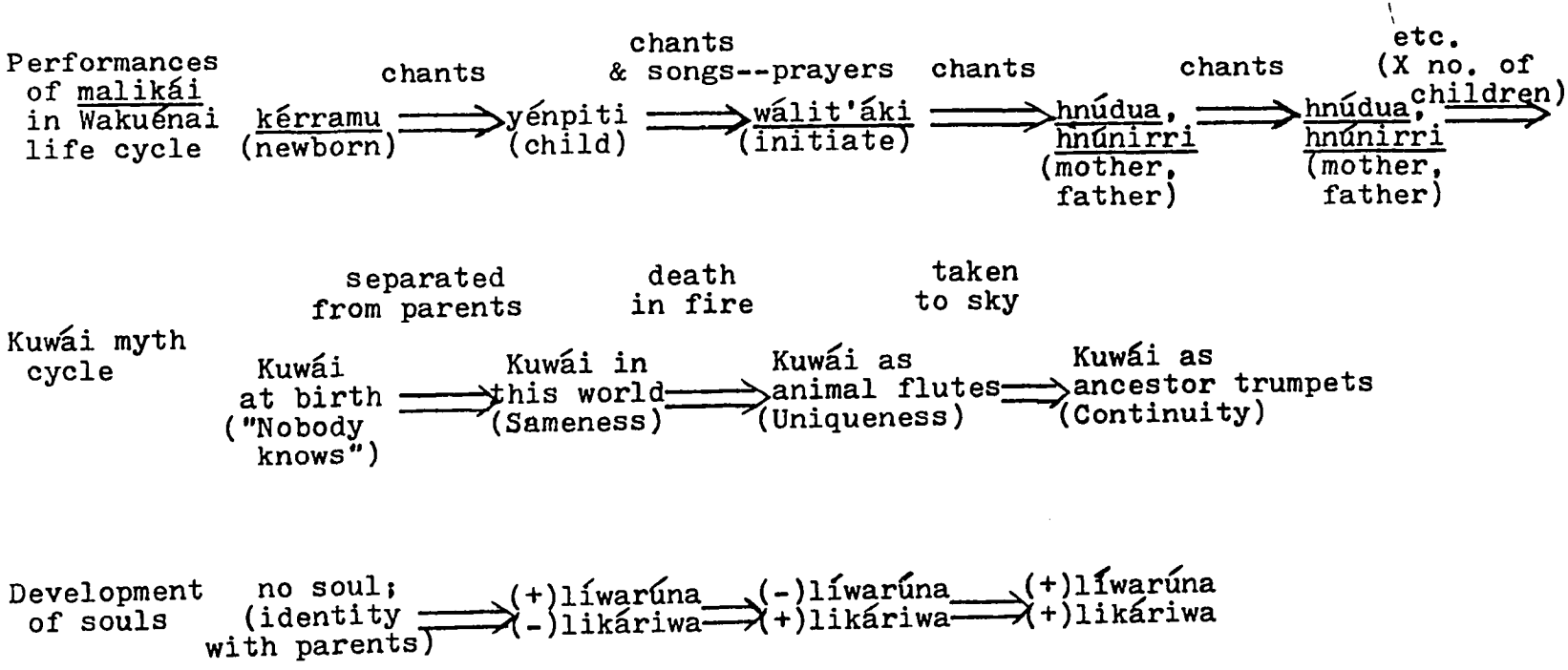


Figure 6.4. Diagram of the interpretive framework constructed through performances of malikái at childbirth and initiation showing application of Kuwái concept and its transformations to the life cycle and beliefs in development of souls

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1. See Matos Arvelo (1912: 172-ff) for an excellent description of a traditional female initiation ritual among the Curripaco-speakers of the lower Guainía.

2. In my own estimation, missionary intervention and conscious destruction of traditional Wakuénai social customs and religious practices is the most compelling reason for the decline in intergroup rituals and ceremonies. The importance of sacred musical instruments of Kuwái in both male initiation rituals and kwépani ceremonies made easy targets for missionary intervention, and Wakuénai elders speak of massive conversions to Christianity in the 1950's in which the missionaries assembled large gatherings of people and held mass burials of the instruments of Kuwái. Other economic and political factors have certainly compounded the problems for Wakuénai groups that wish to maintain their rituals and ceremonies, but none of these represent the same kind of organized and systematic destruction of the traditional culture as the Evangelical missionaries (see Wright 1981 and Goldman 1979: 300).

3. Another female initiation ritual was held in the same village in 1980 and observed by two of my colleagues from IVIC, Rebecca Holmes and Katherine Clark. I am very grateful to them for sharing their notes, photographs, and films of the ritual activities.

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4. Although girls are taught how to make and decorate pottery during their seclusion at puberty, the main rationale of the seclusion and fasting is to reduce the pain of their menstruation and to protect them from harm caused by eating strong foods. Since young girls have already learned how to carry out most of the everyday activities of adult women prior to their initiation, their fasting and seclusion does not emphasize the learning of new skills to the same degree as male initiations. Boys prior to initiation are free to roam with their playmates, and for them initiation is a period of serious learning. They learn how to weave, make weapons and tools, and play the sacred flutes of Kuwái. Thus, seclusion and fasting in male initiations were times set aside for the boys' practical education much more so than in female initiations, where attaching a moral lesson to the physical pain of menstruation outweighs the importance of teaching practical skills.

5. In this case, the chant-owner, Hernando Camico, was accompanied by his older brother, Hervilio, who is a shaman but not a chant-owner.

6. The animal flutes of Kuwái used to be played on the night following málikai chants and songs for female initiation (Matos Arvelo 1912: 176) but nowadays are played only in kwépani and male initiation rituals. In

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this description and analysis of musical performances in female initiation rituals, I will focus only on málikai chants and songs, since these performances form the core of female initiation rituals as they are practiced today by the Dzáwinai and Waríperídakéna families of Gavilán. See Chapter 9, "Ceremonial Musical Performances", for further discussion and analysis of the líaka genre of music.

7. Matos Arvelo, who claims to have received the ritual lashes in order to participate in and observe a Curripaco initiation ritual, describes the traditional form of kadápu whips as sticks with a piraña fish tooth tied on its end (1912: 86). The sharp tooth cut the initiant's back, causing great pain and bleeding.

8. This musical metaphor of rapid temporal movement through a number of different spatial locations foreshadows the mythical movements of Amáru (M6) over large distances with the flutes of Kuwái. She could never stay in any one place for long because Iñápirríkuli was always close behind and hoping to take Kuwái away from her.

9. As a rule, the chants do not rise in pitch by more than a half-step (see Figure 6.2). Six of the chants begin and end on the exact same pitch, showing no rise at all. The majority of chants (12) rise a chromatic half-step or less from beginning to end. Three chants rise

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more than one half-step (two rise 3 half-steps and one rises slightly more than a full half-step). These three chants are another indication of the transformation of order that has taken place.

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Chapter 7:

"Málikai and Málirríkairi Songs for Curing"

Introduction

This chapter will focus on two genres of musical performance which the Wakuénai use for curing, the ritual specialists who practice curing by traditional methods, and the mythical foundations of disease and its treatment. Unlike the performances of sacred songs and chants in childbirth and initiation rituals, the málikai and málirríkairi songs performed in curing rituals are not directly concerned with the application of conceptual principles from the Kuwái myth cycle to ritual experiences of individuals and groups at transitional points in the life cycle. Performances of music in curing rituals are based on the idea of a partial breakdown in the system of controlled growth and development according to conceptual principles embodied in the mythical character of Kuwái. Disease causes a temporary, partial separation of the two parts of the human soul, the collective (líwarúna) and the individual (likáriwa), and an interruption of the normal processes through which the two parts of the soul are organized and transformed during the life cycle. Sickness ultimately leads to death, a state of complete separation between the two parts of the soul that is nevertheless temporary insofar as the individual souls of recently- deceased persons (lidánam) are believed to

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eventually transmigrate to their collective souls (líwarúna) in the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli. Once there, the souls of the dead never leave and are never reincarnated in any humanly form, although they contribute to the sib ancestor soul that is infused into newborn infants in childbirth rituals and that envelopes the transformation of children into recent-initiates.

Performances of málikai and málirríkairi songs in curing rituals attempt to symbolically re-create the circumstances that brought about a breakdown in the orderly processes of growth and transformation. In doing so, they direct the patient back toward a rejoining of the two parts of the soul so that physiological treatments such as dietary control, herbal remedies, and even modern pharmaceutics can begin to restore the patient's health. Musical performances in curing rituals do not aim at imposing order upon the sick individual and his situation so much as revealing the disorderly processes of decay and breakdown that have led to the sick individual's condition. In myth, the breakdown of orderly life processes resulted from violations of fundamental conceptual boundaries. In everyday social life, the conceptual boundaries of myth translate into culturally-defined social and spatial boundaries that always represent a danger to individuals who cross them, although countermeasures to avert danger are usually available. The ultimate mythical boundary, and one that cannot be crossed by non-specialist individuals without dire consequences, is the great cosmic divide between

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the miniature, distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli and the more recent, life-sized mythical world created by Kuwái. Musical performances in curing rituals and the myths that explain them point to loopholes through which unprincipled conflict and disorder can penetrate and contaminate the system of growth and transformation according to orderly principles.

In this chapter, I will show how the two main genres of curing songs, málikai and málirríkairi, are distinctly different ways of portraying the breakdown of orderly processes of growth and transformation and yet act together as interrelated parts of a single myth-ritual nexus. Each of the two genres of curing music has its own corresponding class of ritual specialist, the owners of málikai and the shamans (malírri). Although the two kinds of specialist often perform curing music in isolation from one another, they join together and work as a team in situations of very serious illness. My analysis of musical performances as a pivotal component in the myth-ritual nexus that centers around sickness and disorderly processes of decay will focus upon a curing ritual in which two different specialists, an owner of málikai and a shaman, worked together as a team.

Theoretical Considerations

As I pointed out in the opening chapter of this dissertation, processual structuralism is not limited in scope to only those processes of structuration that organize the flow of individual and collective experience into clearly

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defined categories, or transformations of such orders, but also takes into account processes of structuration that contradict the conceptual organization of the world into categories of objects, places, and people. This second type of process is a sort of 'destructuration' insofar as it systematically violates categorical boundaries that are constructed with great precision and elaboration in other ritual contexts.

> "Yet life involves process, change; it transcends and defies such categories even as it is apprehended through them. Categories and groupings must contradict one another in some ways if they are to contain a myriad world" (Beidelman 1981: 154).

The capacity of processual structuralism to deal with such processes of destructuration as parts of the same performance system as other processes of structuration which they contradict is one of the advantages of processual structuralism as a method of cultural analysis in anthropology. For it allows the complexities and ambiguities of social behavior to be seen as social phenomena arising from the contestation of conflicting processes of structuration that all operate as part of a single performance system rather than as a divergence between ideal and real behaviors.

In observing and analyzing the musical performances which Wakuénai ritual specialists use in curing rituals, the distinction between ideal and real behaviors is of little or

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no use and is perhaps even counterproductive, since it sets up an opposition between 'real' or objective evaluative criteria of the observer and the imaginative beliefs of the performers, participants, and audience. The distinction between ideal and real behavior does not hold for Wakuénai curing rituals, since the two levels are inextricably intertwined. On the one hand, the ritual healers view their activities as a form of work in the very practical sense that they want to improve their patients' health in order to receive a payment that is offered to Dzulíhwerri, the mythical owner of dzáato snuff. On the other hand, curing rituals bring into play a complex series of communications with spirits and metaphorical journeys to other regions of the cosmos through which ritual healers relive the processes of breakdown that led to their patients' diseases and link these processes of decay to their patients' natural and social environments.

In "The Effectiveness of Symbols," Levi-Strauss made the same point about the irrelevance of an analytical distinction between ideal and real behaviors for understanding shamanism and sorcery. "That the mythology of the shaman does not correspond to an objective reality does not matter" (1963a: 197). What does matter is the performer's belief in the efficacy of his curing techniques, the patient's belief in the performer's powers, and the beliefs and expectations of the group of people who observe and/or know that the curing ritual is taking place in their community. Levi-Strauss

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placed greatest emphasis on the role of the collective consensus of social groups acting as "a sort of gravitational field within which the relationship between sorceror and bewitched is located and defined" (1963a: 168). The least important of the three parties to the curing ritual is the patient or victim whose role is essentially passive and dependent upon the ritual curer's ability to convey his own sense of belief and confidence in the effectiveness of the techniques he is employing to a larger social group of participants and observers.

The ritual healer objectifies the patient's disorganizing experiences of pain and suffering to the total group of participants and observers by placing these experiences into a set of mythical beliefs and structures which the entire group shares. "Quesalid did not become a great shaman because he cured his patients; he cured his patients because he had become a great shaman" (Levi-Strauss 1963a: 180). In other words, ritual curers induce cures in their patients by virtue of their ability to convince themselves and the social group of which the patient is a member of the effectiveness of their symbolic re-enactment and re-experiencing of the process that led to sickness and breakdown. This point is especially important in the Wakuénai curing ritual that forms the main topic of analysis in this chapter, because the patient in this case was a one-year-old girl who could hardly be expected to play any active role in her own cure. In fact, the entire series of events centered

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around the relationship between the ritual healers and the family of the dying child.

The analysis of musical performances in curing rituals raises the problem of limitations of the anthropological investigation of culture, since here more than in any other ritual context, the analysis of musical performance touches on psychological processes and the conceptual components of personality in Wakuénai society. I will follow the advice of Gluckman et al. (1964) by recognizing from the outset the limits of my anthropological naivete and pronounce myself professionally competent to focus only on the problem of how musical performances, other ritual activities, and collectively shared mythical beliefs act to objectify the experiences of pain and sickness. This process of objectification centers around Wakuénai concepts of the collective and individual souls, the former an unconscious self manifested as a totemic animal during sleeping and dreaming states and the latter a conscious, waking-state self residing in the human body. I make no claims as to the universality of these concepts or their relationship to analytical concepts of personality that have been developed in Freudian, Jungian, or other branches of modern psychology. These developments are beyond my professional competence, and I leave the task of interpreting why people have such beliefs about the self to the psychologists[1]. The major psychological assumption of processual structuralism is the very general one that highly-structured social interaction can and does have organizing

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and transforming effects on the experiences of individuals and groups. Recent developments in psychology that emphasize the power of situations to give structure and meaning to behavior tend to back up this basic assumption (see Howard 1982: 37-53)[2].

Ritual Healers: Owners of Málikai and Shamans (Malírri)

The ritual healers whose music forms the topic of inquiry in this chapter are the senior men living in the predominantly Dzáwinai village of Gavilán on the lower Guainía. Hernando Camico is the village headman and owner of málikai, while his older brother, Hervilio, is a shaman (malírri). Both men are grandfathers whose grandchildren range in age from early childhood to beyond initiation and nearing marriage. They have practiced curing for many years, perhaps as long as three decades, and whatever doubts or skepticism they might have had towards themselves and the effectiveness of their techniques in the early years of their careers have all but vanished by now. Through years of practice, they have come more and more to resemble the mythical characters of Dzúli and Dzulíhwerri, and the villagers hold almost the same feelings of awe and respect for the two men as they would toward powerful mythical characters. When Hernando or his brother announce that they have had a bad dream or experienced something that might turn out to be an evil omen, the other villagers grow apprehensive and retire early to their houses at the day's end. The two men are also well-known as ritual healers in towns and villages along the

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Guainía and Upper Rio Negro and throughout the entire region bounded by the Upper Orinoco and Guainía rivers in Venezuela.

Their fame as ritual healers brings them extra prestige and financial income through the payments received for successful cures. In cases of mild illness, the specialist is usually rewarded with only a small payment (dawáinaku or lidáwai pukúri) of food or some useful implements such as fishhooks and ammunition. When a seriously ill patient arrives for treatment, however, his relatives must bring objects of high value, such as sewing machines, shotguns, and spearguns, and they are expected to offer this high payment at the outset of the curing ritual as a token of their generosity and sincerity. If a family is reluctant to make a generous offer on behalf of their ailing kinsman, the mythical owner of dzáato snuff, Dzulíhwerri, is believed to resent this stinginess and to withhold his healing powers from the shaman and owner of málikai who wish to apply them to the sick individual. The generosity with material objects which the ritual healers expect of the kinsmen of seriously ill patients is only one element of a general openness and willingness to share intimate knowledge and emotions without which the ritual curing process cannot progress.

The payments and prestige that accrue to ritual healers do not mean that they are in any way removed from the ongoing cycle of everyday subsistence activities and decision-making processes. To the contrary, both Hernando and his brother are active manioc gardeners, fishermen, and, on occasion,

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hunters. And both men take an active role in communal work parties for cleaning up the village and house-building or repairing. They acquire a few material valuables that others cannot afford, but they freely lend them to the other household headmen of the village. Except in cases of serious illness where the two men spend up to four or five consecutive days in nearly complete devotion to their curing practices, curing rituals are generally brief performances that last only a couple of hours and do not take away much time from everyday subsistence and social activities. In short, curing rituals are for the most part worked into the schedule of everyday activities and do not require any major disruption of that schedule.

Only in cases of very serious illness do to the two specialists, málikai limínali and malírri, simultaneously perform music and the other ritual techniques designed to bring the two parts of the patient's soul back together again and to cast out the spirit of sickness that has caused separation. Most patients are not so gravely ill, however, and either the owner of málikai or the shaman individually works to cure the patient. Figure 7.1 lists seven curing rituals which I observed in Gavilán in the months of July through November of 1981. Each ritual is broken down according to the type of illness being treated, the treatment (whether málikai or málirríkairi), approximate age of patient, sex of patient, village where the patient's family lives, ethnic group(s) of the patient's family, and the

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Problem	Treatment	Age / Sex	Village	Ethnic Group(s)	Results
Severe diarrhea & weight loss	malikái & málirríkairi	1yr/ F	Quitare (R. Orinoco)	Baniwa-Guarequena	Death attributed to evil omens*
Toothache, rear molars	málirríkairi	14yr/ F & 17yr/ F	Isletta (R. Guainia)	Baniwa& non-indigenous	Pains reduced
Cough, fever (cold or flu)	málirríkairi	1yr/ M	S. Felipe (R. Guainia)	Wakuénai (Dzáwinai)	Cough and fever gone in 3 days
Nightmares & tantrums	malikái	4yr/ M	Crespo (R. Guainia)	Wakuénai (Ádzanéni)	Child still withdrawn; nightmares & tantrums alleviated
Earache	malikái	7yr/ F	Gavilán (R. Guainia)	Wakuénai (Dzáwinai)	Not effective; pain attributed to toothache
Stomach pains (not severe)	málirríkairi	1yr/ F	Gavilán (R. Guainia)	Wakuénai (Dzawinai)	Pains alleviated; no recurrence
Abdominal cramps (menstruation)	malikái	45yr/ F	Gavilán (R. Guainia)	Wakuénai (Waríperí-dakéna)	Pains relieved; resumed normal diet within 2 days

Figure 7.1. List of seven curing rituals performed by Hernando Camico and his brother, Hervilio, in Gavilán. Symptoms and treatment are at far left, background data on patient in middle columns, and stated or observed results are at far right.

*See analysis of this curing ritual and myths, pp. - .

stated results of the treatment[3]. Although the number of cases is too small to detect any definite patterns, performances of málirríkairi appear to aim mostly at curing diseases of the mouth, respiratory tract, and digestive system, whereas performances of málikai are directed toward alleviating disorders of the reproductive organs, ear infections, nightmares, and any disease that has become life-threatening. The performance of málikai as treatment for menstrual pains or other problems of the reproductive organs is not at all surprising in view of the central importance of málikai (albeit different sub-genres) in childbirth and initiation rituals. That málikai is also performed to cure psychological disorders such as nightmares is an interesting phenomenon. Among other things, the following analysis of witchcraft beliefs, myths, and musical performances will attempt to reveal the logic of the association between málikai and dreaming.

The present study of málikai and málirríkairi performances in curing rituals is not an exhaustive study of the many sub-genres and specific manifestations which these two genres encompass. The above description of ritual healers and their work is sufficiently detailed to give a general picture of the division of labor between the two kinds of ritual specialist and the range of diseases and disorders which they seek to cure. More precisely, the song texts which they employ can vary almost infinitely in their details according to the different diseases to be treated and differences in the

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patients' situations, but the major musical contrast is that between málikai and málirríkairi. This musical contrast, together with the contrast between mythical beliefs which the two genres of singing bring into play, are more important to understanding beliefs in the efficacy of traditional Wakuénai curing methods than minor details and variations within each of the two performance genres[4].

Secondary Burial and the Soul's Journey After Death

Málikai is performed on the occasion of any disease that has become life-threatening because death brings about a total separation of the two parts of the soul, a situation which is eventually restored to order when the soul of a recently-deceased person (lidánam) re-unites with the collective ancestor soul (líwarúna) of the sib. The reunification of the soul after death is by no means an inevitable fate, however, but depends upon ritual activities and performances of málikai when the deceased's bones are exhumed a year or more after death[5]. I did not record this genre of málikai and never witnessed the custom of secondary burial but learned about the music and customs through a myth of the origin of death[6]. After digging up the deceased's bones, an owner of málikai performs chants and blows smoke on them to send the lidánam soul on its final journey up to likáremi, the celestial paradise[7].

There are very few openly stated beliefs about life after death in either íyarudáti or likáremi. Ritual specialists who must travel to the houses of different sibs in

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íyarudáti say that the lidánam souls go out to work like people living in this world (hekwápiríko) but that when they return to their houses,they always eat rotten meat (i.e., the éenunai and képinai, or itáda souls of forest animals and birds which the lidánam souls care for and feed). The lidánam souls are also said to drink great quantities of fermented manioc beverages (padzaóru, or manioc beer, and yúpuni, or strong liquor made from burnt manioc bread) and to frequently dance to the music of yapurútu (máwi) flutes of the mádzerunái (dance- music of pudáli) genre[8]. The lidánam souls suffer great pain in íyarudáti because they are separated from their collective ancestor souls. Beliefs about the afterlife in paradise (likáremi) after the soul's transmigration and reunification are even sketchier and point to only two basic features: the eternal sunlight and the pure food (honey) eaten in great quantities[9].

Beliefs in Sorcery and Poison-Owners (Mahnéti limínali)

Beliefs in sorcerers, or evil people who consciously damage other people's bodies through putting poison (mahnéti) into their food, abound among the Wakuénai. Everyone has stories about poison- owners (mahnéti limínali) and their victims, but no one is prepared to comment upon how the poison is made. Two men, one in Gavilán and one in an Ádzanéni village downstream, claim to be victims who have survived poisoning, but their claims are generally discredited by other people in their villages. The abundance of claims and counterclaims of alleged poisonings have no doubt

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been exaggerated with the declining numbers of ritual specialists who traditionally maintained a strict control over the processes of determining whose claims were to be believed and whose were to be ignored.

Protestant missionaries of the New Tribes Mission have greatly contributed to the current imbalance of sorcery beliefs through their zealous campaign to undermine traditional beliefs in the efficacy of ritual healers and to establish a new faith in modern pharmaceutics. One of the most sinister of all missionary attacks on traditional beliefs was the practice of conversion to Christianity through personal confession of guilt. The missionaries required each new convert to publicly announce that he or she had harmed or killed others by poisoning their food. In this way, the missionaries succeeded in largely destroying traditional beliefs in the ability of ritual specialists to identify and revenge poison-owners and to cure their victims, but the plan backfired inasmuch as beliefs in sorcery rebounded out of control. The door was left open for a return to beliefs in the powers of ritual healers, and among the Wakuénai of the lower Guainía today, even the most staunchly Evangelical individuals and families are turning back to traditional curers living in nearby `Catholic' or traditional villages (see Chapter 10).

Be that as it may, beliefs in sorcery and witchcraft among the Wakuénai have probably always played a major role in the interpretation of illness, especially when the in-

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dividual's health is seriously damaged. Poisoning with mahnéti (called camajái in the regional Spanish) is said to bring on a process of bodily decay in victims that centers around the rotting of the liver, stomach, intestines, lungs, or any combination of these organs[10]. The victim gradually becomes thinner and weaker as his insides continue to rot, usually lasting for several weeks or months before finally succumbing. Only in rare instances is poisoning with mahnéti believed to cause illnesses that rapidly culminate in death, and then only when the poison's effects are augmented by witchcraft.

The mythical origins of mahnéti poison are twofold. On the one hand, Kuwái's hair is said to have consisted of mahnéti before Iñápirríkuli pushed him into the great bonfire. Periods of transition in the life-cycle are dangerous times when individuals and groups undergo fasts to protect them against the harmful effects of eating strong foods or of any food which the owner of málikai has not properly treated in songs, chants, and prayers. The association of mahnéti poison with the mythical character of Kuwái just prior to his death and with initiants about to end their ritual fast by eating káridzámai is part of a general belief in the danger of transitional periods in the life cycle. On the other hand, mahnéti poison had already originated in the earliest moments of Wakuénai cosmic history, for Iñápirríkuli is said to have made mahnéti poison out of hairs taken from a lapa (dápa, Curri.; Cuniculus paca). This animal was actually

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a transformed body of one of Kunáhwerri's wives. After Iñápirríkuli had killed her, he left a pot of the meat, including the mahnéti hairs, boiling over a fire in Kunáhwerri's house. When Kunáhwerri returned home, he ate the meat, and the mahnéti hairs stuck in his throat.

The mythical origins of mahnéti poison are thus twofold, and in both myths the poison takes the form of hair. The association between Kuwái's hair and mahnéti poison is only mentioned in passing and does not enter directly into any of the myth events. However, in the myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli, poisoning with animal-hair mahnéti makes up an entire episode of myth events. Poisoning with mahnéti is also cited as the mythical cause of the first death in another myth about the unceasing hostilities and revenge-killings between Iñápirríkuli and Kunáhwerri. Thus, poisoning with mahnéti is most firmly rooted in the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli and only secondarily related to the Kuwái myth cycle.

Master Shamans (Dzáwinaitairi) and Witchcraft Beliefs

Most shamans (malírri) can only cure victims of sorcery by extracting the physical cause of sickness and recapturing the patient's lost soul (likáriwa). They can determine that the patient suffered from poisoning with mahnéti and try to suck the poisonous object out of his body, but they can neither identify the specific person who actually carried out the poisoning nor take revenge against the poison-owner through witchcraft. Unlike the sorcery of poison-owners who

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are believed to attack the conscious, body-like soul (likáriwa) through the victims' food, witchcraft is a purely supernatural assault on the unconscious, animal-like soul (líwarúna) of sleeping or dreaming victims. Witchcraft causes grave damage to the líwarúna through invisible spiritual powers that operate without any intervening physical medium. The effects of witchcraft are immediately felt as severe heart pains and/or headaches, and the great majority of victims are believed to die within a few hours. Lightning is another manifestation of witchcraft, and the sudden death of a person hit by lightning epitomizes the high speed at which witchcraft is believed to destroy its victims. However, not all victims of witchcraft are instantly killed, and they often exhibit milder symptoms that respond to certain treatments.

The power to bewitch is not accessible to non-specialists in Wakuénai society, and not even shamans or owners of málikai are thought to have such powers. There is a special class of master shamans, called dzáwináitairi (lit., "snuff jaguars"), who are the only individuals thought to be capable of bewitching. Ironically, the master shamans are also considered to have the strongest curing powers. The dzáwináitairi have powers of clairvoyance with which they can instantly tell what people around them are thinking[11]. In curing rituals, the dzáwináitairi do not have to spend hours of time searching for the victim's lost soul (likáriwa) or dragging confessions out of the victim's relatives because

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they can immediately perceive all these things and know within minutes whether or not they can effect a cure. Likewise, the dzáwináitairi can sense the presence of a poison-owner when visitors arrive at his village, and they are believed to confront poison-owners in public with this knowledge to make them admit their evil intentions. If the suspected poison-owner denies having brought any poison into the community, the dzáwináitairi is said to grasp a handful of poison out of thin air and display it to everyone present, thus offering a visible proof of the intruder's guilt.

Nowadays, only a very few master shamans remain among the Wakuénai, and the institution of dzáwináitairi may well cease to exist within a few years. Hernando Camico, the headman of Gavilán and an owner of málikai, took great care in explaining to me that the last dzáwináitairi had already died of old age. However, he admitted that there are still a few very old master shamans when I reminded him of stories I had heard in another village about an old man named Arídali (lit., small armadillo). The remarkable curing powers of old Arídali were last at work on the lower Guainía in 1979 when he saved the life of a young Ádzanéni woman who came close to dying in childbirth. A rumor spread in 1981 that old Arídali had finally died in his village on the upper Guainía, but later messengers denied this news and claimed that he still lived. Curiously, many of the powers attributed to Arídali and to master shamans in general matched Hernando's statements about his own abilities to detect the presence of

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sorcerers and cure their victims through divination[12]. If these beneficial powers were the only ones credited to dzáwináitairi, the reluctance of Hernando to directly identify himself as a master shaman would be difficult to understand. However, in addition to the abilities to cure and protect against sorcery, the dzáwináitairi also wield the ambiguous and dangerous weapon of witchcraft.

Shamans (malírri) are unambiguously beneficial to their social groups because they cure the sick. When their curing techniques fail and the sorcerer's victim dies, the kinsmen of the deceased do not blame the shaman for his failed effort (although they do have the right to withhold their payment to him). Instead, they seek revenge against the sorcerer, or poison-owner, by holding a special ritual with a master shaman (dzáwináitairi). I never witnessed such a ritual and so cannot say how the music of the dzáwináitairi differs from the málirríkairi curing songs of ordinary shamans. The purpose of the ritual is to identify the collective soul (líwarúna) of the sorcerer through singing, taking dzáato (an exciting, hallucinogenic snuff), reading shadows in the sky, and setting up a channel of communication between the victim's kinsmen and Dzulíhwerri, the mythical owner of shamans' snuff. Once the master shaman has ascertained the collective soul of the sorcerer, he searches in his dreams for clues of the individual soul (likáriwa) of the sorcerer. Such clues include clothing, personal possessions, distinctive bodily traits, or behavior patterns that help the

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dzáwináitairi to zero in on the sorceror's individual identity. Having reached a conclusion as to the sorceror's collective and individual souls through ritual activities and dreams, the dzáwináitairi travels in his dreams at night to the village of the sorcerer, enters into his house, and opens up the hammock where the sorcerer's líwarúna soul lies sleeping in the form of a small animal of the totemic species that represents the local sib group. The dzáwináitairi then throws the sorcerer's unconscious soul on the ground and quickly destroys it with a sharp knife or machete. The next morning, the sorcerer wakes up with severe pains in the head or heart and dies within a few hours. Non-indigenous people who have no sib ancestor souls in the form of totemic animals are nevertheless susceptible to the witchcraft of the dzáwináitairi, since their souls are believed to take the form of books or papers when they are asleep. In their sleep, missionaries' souls appear as the Bible, merchants' souls as financial records, anthropologists' souls as field notes, and so on. The dzáwináitairi who identifies such non-indigenous persons as sorcerers or murderers can enter their houses at night and rip to shreds the book representing their unconscious souls.

So far, the witchcraft of the dzáwináitairi operates solely as a process of revenge-killing against evil sorcerors whose identities are carefully determined before the exercise of lethal power. However, witchcraft is not always such a discriminating power and can inadvertently take innocent

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lives. The Wakuénai believe that the unconscious souls (líwarúna) of people who experience nightmares leave their houses at night and walk around on the village plaza until the bad dreams subside. Such wandering souls are extremely vulnerable and can be accidentally stricken by the witchcraft of a dzáwináitairi who is searching the area for a sorcerer. The most randomly destructive manifestation of the dzáwináitairi's witchcraft is believed to be a heavy thunderstorm that comes directly into the village at night and kills a whole family while they sleep. As in most cases of witchcraft, there are countermeasures which ritual specialists and other elders can apply to ward off a master shaman who attacks an entire village in the form of lightning.

Counter-Witchcraft Techniques:
Kuwáikanérri and the Bee-Spirits[13]

The principal means for counteracting harmful effects due to the witchcraft of a dzáwináitairi, or master shaman, is the performance of málikai songs in which the mythical journey of Iñápirríkuli and his younger brother, Kuwáikanérri, is re-experienced and applied to an actual victim. In later sections I will discuss these málikai songs as they are actually practiced in curing rituals. Here I am only interested in the text of the song as a sort of quasi-myth that throws light on Wakuénai concepts about how witchcraft victims can be cured and that introduces the mythical characters of bee-spirits, or Kuwáiñai ("Kuwái-owners").

Kuwáikanérri was the first victim of witchcraft, yet Iñ-

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ápirríkuli managed to save his life by making honey out of diverse fruit trees and taking him to the mythical homes of the bee-spirits. The story begins in the vicinity of São Gabriel (Kúrukwi-kwá) with Kuwáikanérri in a seriously ill condition. Iñápirríkuli picked flowers from a number of sweet fruit trees, blew tobacco smoke over them, and made honey out of each one. After Kuwáikanérri had finished drinking all the honey, Iñápirríkuli made a canoe out of beeswax and told his sick brother to lie down inside, since the beeswax would cool his fever. Iñápirríkuli paddled up the Rio Negro to a place near the mouth of the Rio Cayarí where there was a grove of temari (karrápa, Curri.; unidentified), and he made honey from the tree's flowers. They continued up the Rio Negro, stopping for honey made from flowers of guama (hawádzaza, Curri.; Inga edulis) and other tree species. Then they turned up the Rio Isana and made honey from the white flowers of a large tree species known as dzawáka. Finally, they reached a village on the lower Isana called Mapawíka, the home of the bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai).

At Mapawíka, Iñápirríkuli gave his brother honey (máapa) made from a variety of cultivated fruit trees, just as he had done before leaving São Gabriel. Kuwáikanérri felt somewhat better after this treatment and asked if he could sit up and help paddle upstream. Iñápirríkuli made a paddle for him out of beeswax, and this further improved his health as the two brothers paddled up the Isana. They stopped to make honey from flowers of two other species of fruit trees. Their next

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movement broke away from the pattern of continuous, upstream travel. The two brothers went through the "center of this world" (Hípana) or "around this world" and ended up back at the grove of dzawáka trees on the lower Isana. From there they jumped over to Mápakwá Makákwi at the headwaters of the Rio Guainía, the home of the 'headman' of the bee-spirits, Kuwáiñai Dzámadáperri ("The Two Brothers-Kuwáiñai"). The bee-spirits' headman gave honey made from a wide variety of flowering trees to Kuwáikanérri, who by now was well enough to walk on his feet. The bee-spirits' headman also diagnosed Kuwáikanérri's illness as the result of the witchcraft of a dzáwináitairi.

From there, Iñápirríkuli and his brother walked over to the headwaters of the Rio Cayarí, and Iñápirríkuli left his brother there under the care of an old woman, or step-mother. She kept Kuwáikanérri safely hidden beneath piles of manioc leaves when she was at work in her garden or under a woven mat when she was at home. Since then, the owners of málikai have had to search for Kuwáikanérri, the owner of sickness, whenever they wanted to cure victims of witchcraft.

Analysis of Kuwáikanérri's Journey

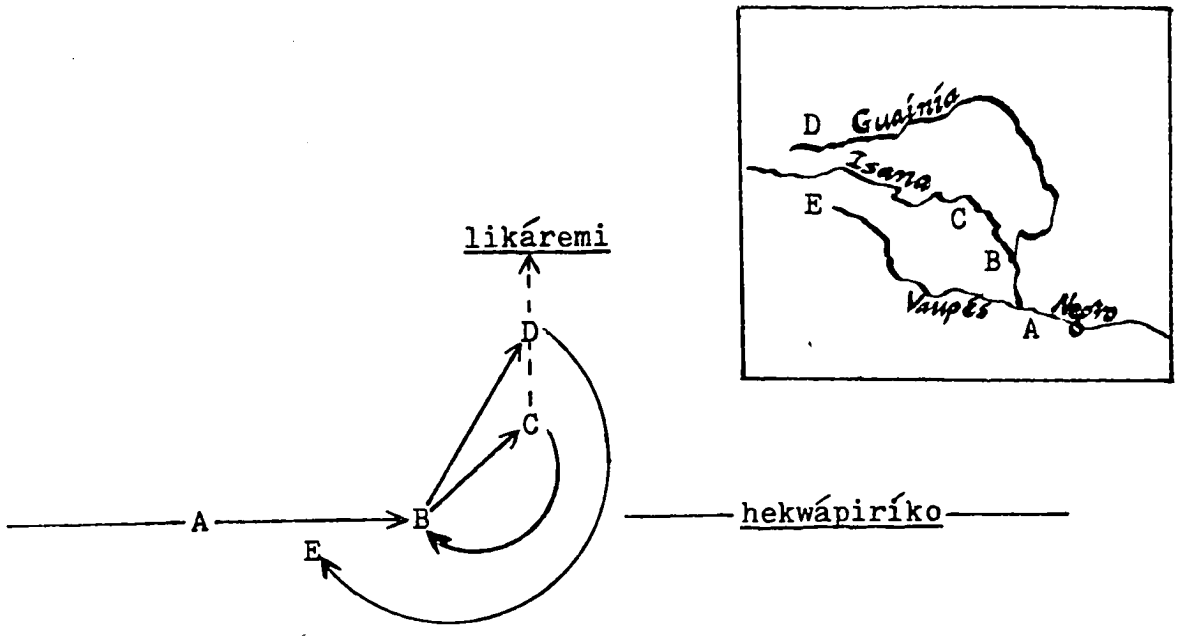
As the original victim of witchcraft in mythical times, Kuwáikanérri and his journey to the home(s) of the Kuwáiñai represent the fate of the unconscious soul (líwarúna). The two homes of the Kuwáiñai, Mapawíka on the Isana and Mápakwá Makákwi on the Guainía, are mythical gateways through which the unconscious líwarúna soul passes on its one-way journey

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after death up to the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli. The story of Kuwáikanérri parallels the líwarúna soul's journey after death but at the same time brackets the vertical movements up to the Kuwáiñai's celestial villages inside of two horizontal journeys in this world. Prior to reaching the bee-spirits' home on the Isana at Mapawíka, Kuwáikanérri lies down in the canoe made of beeswax, and his illness shows no sign of improvement. After leaving Mapawíka, Kuwáikanérri helps his older brother to paddle upstream, and they cross a threshhold at "the center of this world" that sends them back to the place called Dzáwakaná at the mouth of the Isana where they had gathered flowers to make honey immediately before going to the bee-spirits' village at Mapawíka. Only after this reversal in time and space do the two brothers travel to Mápakwá Makákwi, the highest point in the líwarúna soul's journey after death before reaching the celestial paradise (likáremi) of Iñápirríkuli, a place from which there is no return. The mythical return of the two brothers back to the point in this world where they went immediately before going to Mapawíka is a highly significant event, since it establishes a direction from the celestial home of the bee-spirits back to this world prior to the great leap up to Mápakwá Makákwi (see Figure 7.2).

The story of Kuwáikanérri thus replicates the journey of líwarúna souls after death to the last point before a return of the soul to this world becomes impossible. The return in time and space prior to leaving for the bee-spirits' home ap-

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A = São Gabriel (Negro and Vaupés Rivers)
B = Dzáwakaná (Isana River near Negro)
C = Mápawíka (lower Isana River)
D = Mápakwá Makákwi (headwaters of Guainía River)
E = headwater of Vaupés River

Figure 7.2. The journey of Kuwáikanérri in malikái songs for curing witchcraft-related diseases; two returns to this world are shown as curved lines from C to B and from D to E. Map at upper right shows approximate locations of the five places (A-E). Solid lines represent movements in story of Kuwáikanérri, dotted lines are the journey of the soul after death.

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plies a concept of reversibility, the capacity to turn around both temporal and spatial movements, to the fate of detached líwarúna souls. Placing the unidirectional journey in the context of a reversible mythical space-time effects a partial cure of the witchcraft victim (Kuwáikanérri) and brings the líwarúna soul back to the conscious, body-like soul (likáriwa). The reunification of the two parts of the soul is apparent in the last part of the story when Kuwáikanérri is able to leave Mápakwá Makákwi walking on his feet.

In terms of body posture, the story of Kuwáikanérri describes a change from travelling while lying down to walking upright. The former is a metaphor for the unconscious soul's journey after death, whereas the latter stands for its re-incorporation into a conscious active human body in this world. The mediating category in the transformation from detached líwarúna soul to one residing in a human body, or conscious soul (likáriwa), is the posture of travelling while sitting up (or down). However, the transformation is only a partial cure insofar as Kuwáikanérri ends up in a different place than he started and must remain hidden from view. In the end, victims of witchcraft are never really the same people that they were prior to being bewitched, since they remain more vulnerable to witchcraft than other people, even though the líwarúna soul has been restored to its proper place in a conscious, human body.

The Kuwáiñai, or bee-spirits, and the honey which they produce along with Iñápirríkuli, are dominant symbols of the

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transformation of Kuwáikanérri through a reversal in the process of decay in which the líwarúna soul splits away from the body. The two homes of the Kuwáiñai occupy a marginal position in the tripartite structure of the cosmos. Mapawíka and Mapakwa Makakwi are along the Isana and Guainía rivers, two areas which the Wakuénai inhabit in this world, but at the same time they are in another world that can only be reached by crossing a conceptual threshhold, by going "through the center of this world" or "around this world", a reversal in space and time. The double affiliation of the Kuwáiñai with this world (hekwápiríko) and the other world (likáremi) is one reason that they are such powerful symbols for carrying out a transformation through reversal of movements in time and space.

Honey (máapa) is the food of ancestor souls (líwarúna) in the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli. The ancestor souls are believed to eat great quantities of honey in their eternal home. In the story of Kuwáikanérri, honey is the food-substance that reverses the process of decay through which the unconscious soul leaves the body. Beeswax in the form of a canoe and a paddle, symbols of motion and activity, augment the cooling and curing effects of honey. In actual curing practices, honey is important not only as a symbol of a reversible space-time in curing songs but also as the first food given to a witchcraft victim after manioc and water that has been treated with songs and tobacco smoke. The headman of the bee-spirits is called Kuwáiñai Dzámadáperri ("The Two

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Brothers - Kuwáiñai") because he is the owner of two species of small bee, mapíwa and kwemápani, that produce the best honey for treatment of a witchcraft victim. These bee species make their hives in hollow trees, and each hive contains only a tiny amount of honey. Still, honey in very small quantities is sufficient for curing. In fact, large amounts of honey would certainly be considered counter-productive, since then the honey would resemble the food of ancestor souls of deceased persons in likáremi (see below, p. 237). Two other species of small bee that produce honey for curing, kerrádi and kéturri, are considered less powerful than mapíwa and kwemápani.

In addition to the four species of small bee that make small amounts of honey for curing, the large bee species called éenui builds large hives on the exterior of tall trees that are useful for fighting and preventing witchcraft and produces honey useful for preventing and curing measles and other epidemics (collectively known as rupápera sAmáru, "the paper of Amáru"). When several people have bad dreams in a short space of time, the men go to cut a tree upon which a hive of éenui bees is situated and drive out the angry inhabitants with heavy smoke. The honey is eaten as a preventative against measles or any other highly contagious disease which has been reported in the region or as treatment for individuals who have already been infected with such diseases. The hive is burned like incense to spread smoke over the village plaza and inside each household. This smoke is believed

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to form a protective veil against the attacks of dzáwináitairi (master shamans or witches) and the spread of contagious diseases. The smoke is also said to make thunder and lightning pass by the village without causing any harm to its members.

The relationship of bee-spirits to beeswax and honey is one of producer to produced, and the locus of this natural production process is in sweet-smelling flowers. The story of Kuwáikanérri portrays a world that is defined through the physical location of flowers in space. The great majority of flowering tree species mentioned in the story are cultivated fruit tree species standing in groves along the banks of major rivers. This situation is also an accurate portrayal of Wakuénai villages that are always built alongside of a major river or tributary and that always have cultivated trees planted on the plaza, between houses, and around the perimeter of the village. In fact, village names are not uncommonly based on the abundance of a particular fruit tree species: Sejal, Manacal, Cucurital, Guayabal, Merey, El Mango, Punta Jaboa, and so on. The cultivation of fruit trees in villages is a cultural process of food production by people and at the same time, through flowering and pollination, part of the natural process of honey production by bees. Thus, the planting of fruit trees in and around villages is not merely an extension of gardening and other food production processes based on the ripening and harvesting of fruits but is also a technique of counter-witchcraft in which

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flowering, pollination, and honey production act to symbolically equate villages of people in this world with the celestial homes of bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai).

Summary and Analysis of the Kuwáiñai Myth

The story of Kuwáikanérri is not a myth in the sense of other narratives discussed in this dissertation but the basis of a symbolic healing process that begins by replicating the separation of the unconscious líwarúna soul from its conscious, human body and proceeds to reverse the damaging process of separation. The story tells how the powers of the bee-spirits and honey can only be safely applied to afflicted individuals through crossing a conceptual threshhold somewhere between this world and the mythical home of the be-spirits' leader on the upper Guainía. To cross this conceptual boudndary is to step out of the world of irreversible processes of growth and transformation that parallel the Kuwái myth cycle and to enter into a mythical space-time in which all life processes are reversible. The myth of the bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai) depicts a violation of the conceptual boundary between this world and the celestial realm of bee-spirits as well as the lethal consequences of such an infraction.

The myth begins with a group of men out in the forest chopping down trees that contain beehives and extracting small amounts of honey from each tree. One of the men had brought along a large clay pot and, in hopes of filling it to the brim, he split off from the group of honey-gatherers to

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search for a hive with more plentiful honey. Alone in the forest, the man heard talking voices and saw a group of little old men who were only as tall as young adolescent boys at the age of initiation. The old men were picking flowers of yebaro and dropping them to the ground where their wives collected them into pots. The lone visitor asked the old men to take him to the home of the bees, and they took him to Mápakwá Makákwi to meet the headman of the bees (Kuwáiñai dzámadáperri). When the old men explained that they were all bee-people, the visitor grew very frightened. The bee-people calmed him down by granting his wish to fill up his pot with honey. They stuffed the pot full of yebaro flowers and told him to bathe in the very early morning so that the flowers would turn into honey. They invited him to return to their home whenever he wanted another pot of honey but also warned him never to tell other people what he had seen and heard in their home. The man returned to his village and heeded the bee-people's advice. After he bathed in the very early morning before any other people had arisen, the flowers turned into honey. The man ate honey all day long but without sharing any of it with his kinsmen or other people in the village, who could not figure out how he had gotten so much honey. The man finished his first pot of honey and went back to refill it at the bee-people's home. The bee-people granted his wish and repeated their warning not to tell other people what he knew about them and about honey production out of flowers. This time, however, the man's kinsmen could not

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restrain their curiosity about the source of the man's honey, and they got him very drunk before pestering him with questions on the matter. For a time, the man dodged their questions, saying that he had only had the good fortune of finding rare, large hives. Finally, under persistent questioning, the drunken man gave up and told the other people about his encounters with the bee-people, the pot full of flowers, and his secret baths that turned the flowers into honey. The group went back to drinking until the man exited to urinate. There he was bitten by a poisonous snake and instantly died. Ever since then, people have encountered a little bit of honey in beehives. On the rare occasions that a man finds a large amount of honey in a beehive, it is considered to be a very bad omen (hínimai), and the man who cuts down the tree will become sick and die within two years of the incident.

The Kuwáiñai myth offers many insights into how men can cross conceptual boundaries between different regions of the cosmos in the course of everyday activities and the symbolic meanings of the bee-spirits' production of honey from flowers. The first step toward crossing a conceptual boundary is the separation of a man desiring especially large amounts of honey from the group of men with whom he had been gathering small amounts of honey in the forest. An unusually strong desire for honey leads to the alienation of the individual from the collective order. In terms of Wakuénai eschatology, the conscious, body-shaped soul (likáriwa) of

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the individual splits off from the unconscious, collective soul (líwarúna). The individual leaves his own group of kinsmen and affinal relatives and encounters a group of old men whose bodies are no taller than those of pubescent boys, thus entering into relations with beings from a different mythical space-time in which the processes of growth and transformation of this world are reversed and bodily aging regresses to the point of late childhood. The individual has crossed a conceptual boundary without consciously knowing that he has done so, for he asks the old men to take him to the home of the bees and does not realize that they are bee-people. His excessive desire for honey was originally the cause of his separation from the group of men collecting honey and now causes him to overlook the reality of his current situation.

The old men take their visitor to the village of their headman on the upper Guainía and reveal that they are bee-people. This knowledge terrifies the visitor, who now is consciously aware that he has crossed a conceptual boundary. The bee-people calm him by promising to fill his pot with flowers that will turn into honey when he returns to his village. Honey, or rather its production, is a transformation that allows people to cross into the other world and to safely return to human society. Honey production calms fears and cures the sick. The visitor can cross back into his own world with the pot-full of flowers to make honey, but he is ordered not to communicate his experiences and knowledge to other pe-

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ople in his own world. His knowledge of honey production is not dangerous per se, but the communication of his knowledge to other people is a violation of the conceptual boundary between the Kuwáiñai and human society. In general, communication of knowledge gained through experiences in other regions of the cosmos or from other cultural-linguistic regions of this world is believed to place the returning individual in great danger. Therefore, the Wakuénai do not ask many questions of people returning from a long journey to places like Manaus or Puerto Ayacucho. Only the most general questions such as whether or not the person liked his visit to the distant region are considered proper in such situations. The returning individual should above all avoid describing people, animals, and natural objects of the landscape where he has visited to his kin or other people in the village[14].

Returning to the myth, the visitor takes his pot-full of flowers back to the world of his kinsmen and follows the bee-people's advice and warnings. He does not allow other people to see the pot of flowers and secretly bathes in the river at night, an act that converts the flowers into honey. The myth thus shows that honey production is symbolically equivalent to bathing or cleansing. The curing powers of the Kuwáiñai are built upon a metaphor of purification through the conversion of flowers (nectar) into honey.

The excessive desire for honey now becomes a greedy consumption of great quantities of honey. On his first trip back

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from the Kuwáiñai, the man's greedy refusal to share honey with other people actually brings him no harm, since he is able to contain the secret knowledge of honey production. His stinginess becomes dangerous to his own safety when he returns home with a second pot of honey from the Kuwáiñai, for it drives the other people to badger him with questions after getting him drunk. The divulgation of his knowledge rapidly leads to his death, a process in which the líwarúna soul splits off from the body-like likáriwa soul. In essence, his death is the opposite process of the splitting off of his conscious, body-like soul in the beginning of the myth. In the beginning, his desire for honey in large amounts led him away from his kinsmen, whereas in the end, his refusal to share honey led his kinsmen to pressure him to reveal his knowledge to the entire group. Whereas the individual initiated the entire sequence of myth events out of an excessive desire for honey, the group takes control over the individual's greed in the end. Rapid death of the individual results from a poisonous snakebite while urinating. In curing practices, too, poisonous snakebites are strongly associated with urination. The victims of poisonous snakebites, if they survive, are ordered to stay inside of their houses for several weeks after being bitten so that they do not walk on ground where other people have urinated. To do so would cause the pain and swelling of the snakebite to return and possibly kill the victim.

Finally, in a conclusion drawn from the Kuwáiñai myth,

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the man's death is cited as the precedent for a specfic type of evil omen that can afflict people who gather honey. If a man chops down a tree containing large amounts of honey, he will sicken and die within two years. This belief is only one example of the phenomenon of evil omens (hínimai) that can theoretically take an unlimited number of natural and social forms. What is particularly interesting about the evil omen derived from the Kuwáiñai myth is its bearing on the issue of crossing conceptual boundaries. In this case, the form of evil omen is identical to the form of food which the Wakuénai believe is eaten by the collective líwarúna souls of deceased persons in the celestial paradise: large quantities of honey. Thus, to find a large quantity of honey in this world (hekwápiríko) is an uncontrolled, unsolicited intrusion of a powerful symbol of the other world (likáremi) into the lives of men living in this world. The improper crossing of this fundamental conceptual boundary predestines death.

Summary and Analysis of the Myth of Evil Omens (hínimai)

Evil omens consist of a combination of a natural event or process with a social process of communication about the meaning of the natural phenomenon. The case of large amounts of honey is unique in this respect, since to find a large quantity of honey is always interpreted as an evil omen even if not connected with any speech act in human society because it is already firmly linked to mythical speech acts in the Kuwáiñai myth and with mythical beliefs about the afterlife in likáremi. To encounter the overproduction of honey is in-

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herently bad luck. Other natural events and processes are not so automatically seen as evil omens but are given this interpretation through speech acts according to the situation. The myth of the origin of evil omens is an important text for understanding the role that they play in curing rituals performed by shamans (malírri) and how they are related to witchcraft beliefs. In fact, the myth explains the origins of both witchcraft and evil omens as parts of a single process[15].

The myth begins with Iñápirríkuli courting one of Kunáhwerri's daughters in the latter's village. The girl's brothers wanted to kill Iñápirríkuli because they knew that he was already married to another woman and only wanted to dishonor their sister. They sent the girl off into the forest with Iñápirríkuli under orders to seduce him at night so that they could come and kill him in his sleep. Iñápirríkuli and the girl stopped to spend the night in the forest, but they had only one hammock in which to sleep. Iñápirríkuli built a fire to keep warm and cut a large plantanilla leaf to serve as a make-shift bed. The girl invited him to sleep in the hammock and spread her legs in a seductive posture. Iñápirríkuli refused to get in the hammock with her and claimed to be too tired to screw her then. He closed his eyes and pretended to snore, tricking the girl into thinking he was asleep. When she fell asleep, Iñápirríkuli got up and blew tobacco smoke over her to make her sleep very heavily like a drunkard. He heard the two brothers coming in the treetops in

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the form of nocturnal monkeys (kúto) and prepared two poisoned darts in his blow-gun. The monkeys heard the snoring sound of a person in deep sleep and threw poison down over the hammock. Iñápirríkuli jumped out of the way and shot the two monkeys with poisoned darts. Then he went over to blow smoke on the sleeping girl so that she could wake up again and quickly went to his `bed' to feign that he was asleep. The girl woke up and saw him sleeping. Just as she got out of her hammock, she heard a loud sound ("Thump") and then another similar sound. She tried desperately to awaken Iñápirríkuli and finally succeeded by kicking him. He pretended to be waking from a deep sleep, and the frightened girl showed him where the two sounds had come from and asked him if this were not a sign that he had killed her two brothers. Iñápirríkuli claimed ignorance of any knowledge on the matter and suggested that she had most likely heard a couple of dead tree branches falling. The girl went back to sleep, and again Iñápirríkuli blew smoke on her to induce heavy sleep. When he woke up in the morning, he told her that he had had a dream that something very bad had happened to her family, that perhaps they had fallen ill. Actually, he had gone into the forest while the girl was asleep and cut off the heads of the two dead monkeys. The girl became still more afraid when she heard about Iñápirríkuli's `dream', and he easily convinced her that they should return to her father's village to see what had happened to her family instead of continuing on toward Iñápirríkuli's village. The girl walked several paces

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in front of him, and he took a small stick and picked his teeth while she had her back turned. He threw the stick on the trail in front of her, producing a foul odor. "This is an evil omen (hínimai) for you, and it means that someone in your family is sick," Iñápirríkuli explained. After they had walked a little further ahead, the girl began to run, and Iñápirríkuli secretly put his blowgun across the trail in front of her. She tripped over the weapon. "This is another hínimai, and it means that someone in your family has probably died," he explained. The girl ran faster than ever toward her family's village. Iñápirríkuli found a vine and took off some of the knots. He threw these in front of the girl, and they turned into little white-throated birds (hádze). "This is another hínimai, and it means your whole family is in great danger." The girl was running ahead, drawing near to her father's village, but Iñápirríkuli did not want to arrive there with her. He came to a log covered with worm shit and grabbed a handful to make a round ball. He pushed the ball of worm shit against his hip and called the girl over to show her how 'swollen' his leg had become. He cried out in mock pain and told the girl to go on without him, since he could no longer continue to walk. As soon as she had left, Iñápirríkuli threw away the ball of worm shit and quickly returned to his own village. The girl reached her father's village, and he (Kunáhwerri) told her that two of her brothers had died during the night but that he did not know why. They had had sharp pains in their stomachs as

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though shot by arrows.

In analyzing the myth of the origin of evil omens, the most important consideration is its dual structure: leaving the village for the forest and returning from the forest into the village. The first half of the myth revolves around an elaborate plot of seduction and betrayal against Iñápirríkuli. Kunáhwerri's sons and daughters consciously conspire to kill the trickster-hero, but their plans are actually carried out at night on an unconscious level in which the girl's two brothers take the form of monkeys and the girl herself is in a profound state of sleep. The attack on Iñápirríkuli is a kind of combined sorcery and witchcraft insofar as they try to kill him with poison while he is asleep. Iñápirríkuli's act of killing the two monkey-brothers and cutting off their heads is the original act of revenge-killing of sorcerers by a master shaman. So far, all the action takes place on an unconscious level, and like witchcraft, the killings operate in dreams at night.

The first manifestation of evil omens arrives at the moment when consciousness is returned to the girl whose brothers have been slain during the night. Just as she is stepping out of her hammock, she hears two loud sounds like bodies falling from the trees ("Thump"). The change of direction from conscious thought penetrating unconscious dreams to its opposite is expressed in the myth as a reversal in the direction of spatial movements. In the first half of the myth, Iñápirríkuli and the girl head out of Kunáhwerri's

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village on a path that leads into the forest and toward Iñápirríkuli's village. Likewise, the girl's brothers follow them out into the middle of the forest at night in their dreams. However, in the morning, after killing the girl's brothers with his blowgun and cutting off their heads, Iñápirríkuli and the girl turn around and go back to her father's village to find out what, if anything, had happened to her brothers during the night. This time the girl's unconscious fears are further reinforced by Iñápirríkuli, who pretends to have had a bad dream that an illness had befallen her kinsmen during the night. For Iñápirríkuli, the entire sequence of events has taken place on a conscious level, and there has been no violation of the boundary between conscious experience and unconscious dreams.

Iñápirríkuli uses his superior knowledge to ruthlessly terrify the girl as they proceed back to her father's village. (This part of the story is most satisfying and humorous to the narrator and his audience.) He creates a variety of natural events that require an explanation: a foul odor, a stick that trips the girl, and pieces of vine that turn into birds. The explanations go from bad to worse: an evil omen that means someone in her family is sick, one that means someone in her family has died, and one that portends great danger for her entire family. By this time, the girl's unconscious fear has completely permeated through her conscious experience. She has heard, smelled, touched, and seen signs of her unconscious fear, and each time Iñápirríkuli confirms

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her fear by stating the evil meanings of the odd things she has perceived. However, Iñápirríkuli does not want to be present when the girl's father tells her about her brothers' deaths from sharp stomach pains in the night, so he invents a sign of his inability to continue his journey with the girl. This action is the crowning glory of Iñápirríkuli's revenge on the sorcerer/witch who had tried in vain to kill him, for he has so successfully filled the girl's senses with her fears that they now carry her straight into the arms of her punishment: fully conscious knowledge that her unconscious fear is actually true.

Evil omens, or hínimai, are experiences that encompass both the perception of unconscious sentiments and the performance of speech acts in which these unconscious sentiments are expressed. The perception of unconscious sentiments operates through the medium of natural objects, events, and processes and can take any form in the realm of nature-as-perceived. The expression of unconscious sentiments in speech acts begins with the individual who actually holds these sentiments and is taken over by other people (Iñápirríkuli and the girl's father, Kunáhwerri).

The myth of evil omens reverbrates with the theme of conflict between kin and affines that plays such a prominent role in the myth cycle of Iñápirríkuli. At the same time, the myth is concerned with resolving conflicts between the two parts of the soul, the individual (likáriwa) and the collective (líwarúna), a theme that is clearly and forcefully ex-

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pressed in childbirth and initiation rituals and the Kuwái myth cycle in which the two parts of the soul are shaped and transformed. The myth of evil omens occupies a sort of gray area between the experience of human beings in this world (hekwápiríko), a place of both day and night, and the two worlds of the afterlife in which either night (in íyarudáti) or day (in likáremi) prevails. The polarization of the two worlds of the deceased is based on conceptual principles of the Kuwái myth cycle and applied to human experience in childbirth and initiation rituals. The myth of evil omens portrays a process of breakdown in the organization of the cosmos into three worlds and the polarity of the two worlds of the afterlife. The experience of evil omens is a process of perception and communication in which conceptual boundaries between different regions of the cosmos are broken down and the conceptual principles of cosmic order are violated. The perceived world of conscious experience penetrates the unseen world of unconscious dreams and vice-versa until the processual destructuration of cosmic order is finally halted by conscious knowledge of the unconscious actions that have caused the breakdown of orderly growth and transformation.

The myth of the origin of evil omens is in many respects a model for the musical performances and other ritual activities of shamans (malírri) and owners of málikai in curing rituals. Like the first half of the myth of evil omens, performances of málikai in curing rituals are a con-

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scious plan of action that penetrates into the realm of unconscious dreams. The owner of málikai uses the story of Kuwáikanérri as a way of isolating the activities of the unconscious líwarúna soul and objectifying its detachment from the conscious likáriwa soul. Like the second half of the myth of evil omens, performances of málirríkairi in curing rituals act in combination with a number of visual, tactile, and olfactory stimuli to demonstrate that the victim's unconscious process of decay has permeated and -- the word is not too strong -- saturated the consciously perceived world. The shaman works by convincing the victim and his kinsmen, as well as the larger social group of villagers in the community, that his senses have become overloaded with the invisible sickness of the victim. The victim's kinsmen confess their experiences of evil omens to the shaman after he has reached this state of complete saturation of the senses, and in doing so, they make public a knowledge of how the victim's sickness is part of a general destructuration of the natural, social, and supernatural orders of the cosmos.

Description of Curing Ritual

The contrast between málikai and málirríkairi performances was vividly illustrated in a prolonged curing ritual held for a seriously ill infant girl whose parents had brought her all the way from Quitare, a predominantly Guarequena village on the upper Orinoco. Everyone knew from the beginning that the child was too sick to live much longer, but the parents, a Baniwa man married to a Guarequena woman

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whose kinsmen lived in nearby Sebucán, offered a highly valued payment to Hernando and his brother. Other ritual healers and doctors had treated the severe diarrhea that was killing the one-year-old girl, but all their efforts had failed. The girl's family turned to Hernando and his brother in desperation, and the two men compassionately responded with an all-out effort to cure the dying child.

Soon after their arrival in the village, the parents, brother, and grandmother of the girl were shown into a vacant house where they could hang up hammocks and rest before the commencement of ritual curing activities. Hernando told all five to refrain from eating anything until he had sung málikai and blown tobacco smoke over a mixture of manioc flour and water (pacáka) for them to drink. A little while later, Hervilio brought out his bag-full of shamanistic curing devices, set up two small benches behind the visitors' house, and lit a smoldering wood fire off to one side. He lit a strong, filterless cigarette on an ember and stood up to stare at the clear, mid-afternoon sky, his face painted with large red dots of kérawídzu on each cheek and a red line down the center of his forehead. He sat down on a low bench and blew smoke over each ritual object that he took out of his bag before laying them out on a small square cloth. He poured dzáato snuff into the palm of his left hand, scooped it into a V-shaped bone tube, and self-snorted several blasts of the purplish powder into each nostril. With the sacred rattle (kútirúda) of the shaman in his right hand, he picked up the

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round red stone known as éenu íshu ("sky hook", or lightning) in his left palm and clasped a long white tube of paper between the fingers of his left hand. He began to shake the rattle in large, slow circles and to sing a low, gently-descending melody, often echoing the final word of each phrase in a soft, ventriloquist voice. While singing, his eyes constantly scanned the eastern horizon. At the end of his song, he pushed out into the air with both arms and exhaled loud breaths as though clearing away invisible layers of fog that hindered his view of the sky. Standing up, he held his rattle high up over his head and peered at the sky through its colorful feathers. Then he returned to light another cigarette and waved it in circles over his head.

The shaman worked this way for a while longer before bringing out the payment (dawáinako), in this case a hand-powered sewing machine in almost new condition. Then he called for the visitors to come outside with the sick child and sit down on his left side near the sewing maching. He lit a cigarette and waved it in circles overhead, inhaled a puff of smoke, and held in his breath while walking over to blow smoke on the heads of the patient and all her kin. He waved his rattle over the patient's body, using the feathers like a fan to cool down her fever. After several more rounds of smoking, snorting dzáato snuff, and singing, the shaman was ready to begin sucking the patient's body. He sucked quite hard on the little girl's stomach, then stood up to 'read' the sky through the feathers of his maraca and made a

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scooping motion with his hand as if eating some invisible substance he had caught in the air. Then he walked over to the bushes at the edge of the clearing, bent over, and vomited into his hands. Several repeated attempts to suck out the object causing the girl's sickness failed to produce anything solid.

The shaman turned his full attention back to the sky. While he had been busy sucking and vomitting, a dark thundercould had come into view on the eastern horizon. Now the cloud was rapidly approaching in our direction, and a strong wind began to cool down the blazing heat of afternoon sun. The shaman worked to capture the cooling winds with his cigarettes, stones, and maraca. When the wind stopped, the air became sultry and still, and he sang at the sky. The storm cloud blocked out all sunlight and dropped heavy rains over the gardens across the river channel only two hundred meters away. The shaman finished his song and rose to talk to the storm cloud, mumbling questions through the feathers of his maraca until a loud crash of thunder obliterated the sound of his voice. For several minutes, he spoke like this to the storm cloud that hung over the manioc gardens but that did not cross over to the island-village. The child screamed and cried, and her kinsmen and a growing number of local spectators sat spell-bound by the shaman's magical conversation with thunder.

When at last the heavy rains swept across the channel and into the village, everyone except the shaman moved into

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the wall-less, covered kitchen behind the visitor's house. The soggy shaman's singing was joined by a veritable roar of falling rain striking the crisp, dry palm-thatch overhead. The sick child and her family listened to the shaman from the kitchen and went back outside to resume their previous positions as soon as the cloudburst had ended.

Meanwhile, Hernando was getting started with a long series of málikai songs in a front room of the visitors' house. He sat in one of their hammocks and placed a small pot of pacáka at his feet. With a cigarette burning in his upraised hands, he fixed his eyes on a blank wall across the room and sang a four-note, arch-shaped melody over and over without interruption for about 15 minutes. At the end of his song, he lit another cigarette and promptly raised the pot of pacáka to his mouth. Accompanied by high-pitched, descending "Uu-mm-ff" sounds, he released thick veils of tobacco smoke into the pot and resumed his four-note melody at exactly the same point where he had left off. The málikai songs and occasional smoke blowing went on for almost an hour. The sounds of the shaman's rattling, singing, and vomitting faintly penetrated the front room where we sat alone. Finally, the shaman finished his day's work on the patient and her family, and they came into the room where Hernando was singing málikai while the shaman started to work on another patient, a much less seriously ill baby girl from Gavilán. Hernando finished his málikai song and started to pray directly into the pot of pacáka. At the end of his prayer, he lit another

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cigarette and blew clouds of smoke on the heads of the patient and all her family before instructing them all to drink the pacáka and reminding them not to eat any other food substance.

Both specialists continued to work individually for two more days. The shaman began his work in the mid-morning of the second day without anyone else present for two hours or so. Shortly before noon, he went inside to fetch the sewing machine and sang once more before staring up at the bright sun through the feathers of his maraca. Then he brought out the mother and her sick child. The time was exactly 12:00 noon. After an hour of málirríkairi songs, snuffing dzáato, and blowing smoke, he embarked on a prolonged session of sucking and vomitting, but still he could not manage to come up with any solid object. By now, he had snuffed dzáato well over twenty times in each nostril and was entering into a stage of ecstatic trance in which his voice no longer seemed to come from his own body but from somewhere else.

He glared at the infant girl's body and interrupted his singing with a series of questions directed at her frail, tiny body. "Who or what has made this evil omen?" (Kwákada wátsa hínimánali?). The mother of the sick girl, who was holding her on her lap, did not know what to make of the shaman's strange behavior and words. She grew visibly upset as the singing continued to be interspersed with aggressive interrogation of her dying child. Hernando, the shaman's brother, sat down beside the frightened woman and explained

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to her in Spanish that Dzulíhwerri, the mythical owner of dzáato snuff, was speaking through his brother and demanding that she confess any evil omens that she or her family had experienced in recent weeks. The mother resisted at first but then remembered how she and her husband had heard a chicken 'sing' in exactly the same voice as the crying of their daughter during the first week of her illness. The father had immediately killed the chicken, since they had seen it as an evil omen portending their child's death.

The mother's confession did not make a strong impression on the shaman, who kept singing that the evil omen must be confessed. Dzulíhwerri was angry that he had not been told the whole truth, and he demanded a raise in payment as a show of greater cooperation by the family of the sick child. The mother pulled out two 20 bolivar notes and handed them to the possessed shaman, who placed them on top of the sewing machine. The singing and interrogation intensified until at last both parents confessed a far more serious evil omen. The father admitted that he had wished his daughter's death out loud in a quarrel with his wife. The child's constant crying had annoyed him day and night until he had angrily told his wife that he would rather see his daughter die than continue to hear her crying. Hernando relayed this message to his brother, who sang on without pausing.

The parents' confession of hínimai opened the way for another round of sucking and vomitting. This time the shaman succeeded in some solid results: a hair-like stomach sickness

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(iwálikunám) that was interpreted to be either a sorcerer's poison (mahnéti) or the rawness (mahliúkanám) of a fish spirit (umáwari). The shaman appeared to suffer great pains when this hair-like object came out of his mouth, and he cleaned it and examined it for a minute before showing it to the patient's family. The shaman sang several closing songs after everyone else had left and blew tobacco smoke over each of his sacred objects before putting them away. The time was nearing 4:00 pm, and he had worked without a break for almost six whole hours.

In the evenings and early morning hours, Hernando sang málikai and blew tobacco smoke over pacáka for the visitors to drink. The third day was very rainy, and the two curers worked at different times inside the visiting family's house to revive the dying child. Her condition had not changed either for better or worse since the start of the curing ritual three days earlier. At the end of the third day, Hernando stated that he and his brother had done everything in their powers to cure the infant girl and that they would not work any more until they could see some change in her condition. He predicted that an improvement in her condition on the following (fourth) day would mean she would eventually recover but that a new onset of diarrhea and fever would mean certain and speedy death. Throughout the night and the following morning, the child's health remained steady. Shortly after noon, in the hottest hours of the day, her condition suddenly took a turn for the worse, and she very nearly died.

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Hernando stood by his prediction of the previous day and sadly gave up hope of saving the child's life. He sent her father upstream to Sebucán to summons the mother's Guarequena kinsmen to Gavilán to mourn the child's death. Hernando's brother, however, surprised everyone by holding an emergency curing session in back of the visitors' house. The child lay in her mother's arms, her crying reduced to the pathetically weak voice of an infant who was closer to death than life. Everyone brought out their most valuable possessions and heaped them into a pile on top of the sewing machine. Shotguns, cloths, money, and other modern articles of value piled up to please Dzulíhwerri and allow the shaman to bring back the girl's lost soul. The emergency session soon ended, and Hernando explained to me that the heap of valuables would be returned to their owners, regardless of the outcome of the curing ritual, since they were only on loan to the shaman as an emergency measure. Oddly enough, the infant girl began to show some improvement after the unplanned curing ritual and, for the time being, everyone was happy that Hernando's gloomy prediction had not come to pass.

The girl's father returned with a number of Guarequena men and women just before dawn. They had all been far up Caño San Miguel at their single-family gardening and fishing sites. They were relieved to find the infant girl still alive but seemed resigned to accept that she could not survive another recurrence of the fever. They began to formulate an alternate explanation for the child's illness and the inabil-

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ity of Hernando and his brother to do more than postpone her death by a few days. The failure of the brujos, they reasoned, clearly meant that the sorcerer had been a non-indigenous person, a velero (candle-manipulator) who had conspired to kill the child out of hatred toward its parents. That night, they lit five candles, one for each of the five visitors, and set a coin opposite each one about two inches away. They left the five candles burning all night. One man dreamed that he saw the child's mother surrounded by burning candles inside a church, and his dream reinforced a reading of the candlewax in which it was claimed that the candle representing the sick child had left a fairly round pattern meaning that she would inevitably die. The candles representing the four kinsmen of the sick girl had all left patterns that showed little arms of wax extending toward the nearby coins. The Guarequena kinsmen of the girl's mother all agreed that a velero had cast an evil spell upon the infant girl and that there was no longer any hope of saving her life. They took her to Sebucán, and she died there early the next morning, nearly a week after the curing ritual had begun in Gavilán.

Processual Structuralist Analysis of the Curing Ritual

The performances of málikai and málirríkairi in the curing ritual which I have just described are two distinctly different, yet interrelated, ways of re-creating the processes of destructuration that cause sickness and death. The most important mythical text for understanding the dif-

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ferences and similarities between these two performance genres is the myth of the origin of evil omens. The myth serves as a model for performances of málikai in which the story of Kuwáikanérri acts as a conscious strategy for isolating and objectifying the líwarúna, or unconscious, soul's separation from the conscious likáriwa soul. The málikai prayers that immediately follow the performance of songs based on the story of Kuwáikanérri correspond in myth to the episode where Iñápirríkuli puts Kunáhwerri's daughter to sleep with tobacco smoke for the second time and goes to cut off the heads of the two monkey-brothers who he had previously slain with his blowgun. In the prayer, the owner of málikai "cuts in half" (n'tedáhe or n'dáhe líakúna) all the major categories of spirits in their generic, or itáda manifestations: éenunai (forest animals), képinai (birds), and umáwari (fish). He accomplishes this destruction by invoking the power of tobacco (dzéema) and also tries to cut in half the spirit of all contagious diseases carried by non-indigenous outsiders, rupápera púware sAmáru ("the paper of Amáru"). After attacking all these generic spirits of sickness, the owner of málikai goes after the specific spirits of sickness which he believes to be responsible for his patient's condition: iwálikunám (stomach sickness) and tóli máturinám (diarrhea). The metaphorical cutting in half of the spiritual agents of sickness and bodily rotting in málikai prayers corresponds to the myth episode in which Iñápirríkuli cuts off the heads of the two slain monkey-brothers.

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The cutting in half of dangerous spirits is a key event in both the myth of evil omens and in curing rituals. In myth, the action of cutting off the monkey-brothers' heads marks a turning point in terms of the activities of Iñápirríkuli, the myth's hero. Prior to cutting off their heads, Iñápirríkuli played a defensive role in anticipating and counteracting the attack of Kunáhwerri's two sons. He was an object of their plans and actions. This relationship reverses its direction in the episode where Iñápirríkuli cuts off the two brothers' heads, and from then on, Iñápirríkuli's thoughts and actions take full control over the course of myth events. In the same manner, the performance of málikai prayers to cut in half disease-causing spirits with tobacco smoke places the owner of málikai in an active role for the first time, since his role throughout the songs based on the story of Kuwáikanérri is defensive and passive. Performances of málikai songs for curing isolate the detachment of the unconscious líwarúna soul and objectify its plight by placing in the context of the reversible, mythical space-time of the bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai). The songs are a process of re-creating the fate of the unconscious soul that has experienced a witchcraft attack and of constructing a conceptual framework in which the defense and recovery of the separated líwarúna soul becomes intelligible. Once the performer has fully established this framework through a series of songs in which he travels to the two celestial homes of the Kuwáiñai, he takes on a fully active role in málikai

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prayers that attack, or "cut in half" with tobacco smoke, the sources of sickness and death.

Destructuration of the cosmos is readily apparent in the kinds of spirit-names which the performer assaults in his málikai prayers for curing. Unlike the málikai-owner's performances of songs and chants in childbirth and initiation rituals, his prayers for curing the sick are not concerned with balancing categories of animal bird, and fish spirits (itáda) with the names of particular species' spirits (iñákim) that belong to the different categories. Instead, only categorical spirits of forest animals, birds, and fish are named as objects of "cutting in half" in málikai prayers for curing. The categorical spirits of forest animals (éenunai) and birds (képinai) are believed to exist apart from the spirits of individual animal and bird species in íyarudáti, the dark netherworld of recently-deceased (lidánam) persons. Separated from the spirits of individual species by a cosmic boundary between íyarudáti and likáremi, the categorical spirits of forest animals and birds are an embodiment of physiological decay and rotting, the destructuration of life and the world of the living (hekwápiríko) where people, animals, and plants have two souls. The owner of málikai seeks to destroy these detached, categorical spirits of forest animals and birds because they are symbols of cosmic destructuration. However, he can only take this offensive action after having defensively set up a mythical context of reversible space-time.

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The myth of evil omens also serves as a model for the shaman's performances of málirríkairi and other ritual activities. The second half of the myth demonstrates a process of unconscious, dream activities that gradually permeates the realm of conscious experience through a combination of perceptions of natural events and performances of speech acts. Iñápirríkuli creates a series of events, beginning with the sounds of two falling bodies, that cause Kunáhwerri's daughter to hear, smell, touch, and see signs of the unconscious dream actions of her two brothers' deaths. In curing rituals, the shaman is essentially re-creating this process of the unconscious líwarúna soul's permeation of conscious experience through an overloading of his own senses. Dzáato snuff is a powerful stimulant made from tree-bark of virola calophylla, and the snuff also has hallucinogenic properties when taken in sufficient quantities. Its main effect, and its most important function as an instrument of ritual curing, is the excitation of sense perceptions as a means for crossing conceptual boundaries. The shaman's heavy usage of dzáato snuff in curing rituals is instrumental in a process of overloading the senses which he uses to see, hear, smell, and feel the presence of shadows, or spirits, that are not perceived in everyday social life.

When the shaman is singing or talking to a storm cloud, the ritual participants and observers are very likely to wonder whether this storm just happened to come at an opportune moment or if the shaman actually brought it to the

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village. Such skepticism and doubts do not reduce the effectiveness of the shaman's activities, for, as Levi-Strauss has pointed out, the two explanations can be logically incompatible and yet equally plausible.

> "The important point is that these two possibilities were not mutually exclusive; no more than are, for us, the alternate interpretations of war as the dying gasp of national independence or as the result of the schemes of munitions manufacturers" (Levi-Strauss 1963a: 171).

Whatever doubts other people have about the shaman's ability to cause natural events such as thunderstorms at key moments in the curing ritual, the shaman himself is not passively reacting to such natural events but is actively incorporating them into the process of overloading his own senses. The shaman stands up and walks toward the storm cloud to get a better look at it, and his unintelligible mumbling prior to each peal of thunder is enough to convince the ritual participants and observers that he is indeed seeing and otherwise perceiving spirits within the cloud. Although the shaman's conversation with a storm cloud is very effective in raising the level of emotional intensity of the ritual curing process, such unfathomable speech acts alone do not give a sense of the shaman's reliving of the patient's sickness as a process of destructuration. Málirríkairi songs provide the language through which the shaman effectively conveys his

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reliving of the patient's sickness to the patient's kinsmen who participate in the curing ritual and to the larger social group of villagers who observe it.

Many verses of the shaman's songs are simply a verbal description of the activities that he carries out in the periods of time that elapse between songs. The texts of opening songs, for example, dwell on the action of looking at the sky (wápidza wapédzua). "We smoke" (watítwáka) and "we are going to suck" (wákakawa watsútsu) are other verbal replications in song of the shaman's curing activities.

Other verbal actions in the texts of málirríkairi songs define the situation of the ritual participants. "She does not want her child to die" (kápapída rúmaka ruénipe ñákawa), "I do not want us to die" (kárru kanúma wáiñakawa), and "I do not like the way we are living in this world" (kárru twanúmaka kwámika wémaka hekwápiríko) are examples of statements in song that define the situation of the shaman, patient, and patient's family in this world. The ultimate example of these situation-defining statements (or questions) in málirríkairi songs comes toward the end of the second day of the curing ritual when the shaman begins to ask "Who/what has made this evil omen?" (kwákada wátsa hínimánali?). Here the situation-defining verses of songs play a decisive role in the ritual curing process by requiring the patient's kinsmen to confess their experiences of evil omens.

The confession of evil omens in this case was considered absolutely essential to a continuation of the curing ritual,

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and both ritual specialists said that they would have immediately ceased their curing activities if the sick girl's kinsmen had not confessed. Both the natural event and the speech act to which the parents confessed centered around the sound of their sick child's crying. The true meaning of the chicken's `song' became clear only in light of the second part of the confession: the father had killed the chicken because its `song' triggered unconscious feelings of hostility toward his infant daughter. These feelings later permeated not only his conscious perceptions but also his conscious thoughts as expressed in language during a quarrel with his wife. At the moment of the parents' confession, the shaman continued to sing about evil omens so that in effect the confession was fit into the symbolic space-time of the songs rather than vice-versa. The songs thus define a situation in which the parents' private experiences of evil omens must be made public knowledge in order for the shaman to relive the patient's sickness as a breakdown of orderly growth and transformation that has natural and social dimensions beyond the locus of disease in the patient's body.

The song texts of málirríkairi replicate shamanistic curing activities and play an important role in defining and redefining situations in the course of the ritual curing process. The song texts also serve as a partial explanation of the shaman's manipulation of human and supernatural spirits that are located in this world (hekwápiríko) and in íyarudáti, the world of recently-deceased (lidánam) persons.

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Perhaps the most common verbal action of this type in the song texts is hútu ("send", command form), and it is applied to Dzúli-káuli (Dzulíhwerri's heart), dzéema (tobacco), tudáiri (the power of dzáato snuff), and mánalínu kérramu (the lost soul of the infant girl). The command "to send" is repeatedly used in málirríkairi song texts and expresses the shaman's application of supernatural powers in the restoration of the patient's lost soul to its proper place in a living human body in this world.

The other half of this process is the shaman's attempt to "bring back" (nudiétakawa, "I bring back") the lost soul of his patient from íyarudáti, referred to in songs as "the place where the sun falls" (liúdza hlíakawa hérri)[16]. In particular, the songs frequently mention the names of the houses of two Wakuénai sibs in íyarudáti, paicípana and heemápana. Paíci is the name of a frog species that is also given unusual attention in the spirit-naming of málikai chants for ending the fasts of the parents of newborn infants. Paicípana, the house of paíci frogs, is the name of the house in íyarudáti of the Kadáwpúrirri (the second-ranked sib of the Dzáwinai phratry). Heemápana, the house of tapirs (héema), is the house of the top-ranked Waríperídakéna sib in íyarudáti[17]. The Kadáwpúrirri and Waríperídakéna sibs, of course, are the two main Wakuénai groups represented in the village of Gavilán, the location of the curing ritual. That the shaman names places where the members of his own and his wife's sib groups are believed to travel after death is a

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phenomenon that strongly supports Levi-Strauss's contention (1963a: 168) that the shared belief system of the social group is of primary importance for understanding the effectiveness of shamanistic curing. "I bring back from Heemápana" (nudiétakawa liúdza heemápanadáli káuli) and "We bring back from where the sun falls" (wadiétakawa liúdza hlíakawa Hérri) are verses that express the shaman's intent to reverse the process of decay and sickness that has afflicted the patient's soul. Other verses name the door of íyarudáti (táuri numá) which the shaman must open up to let the patient's soul return to the world of living people.

There remains one last type of spiritual power with which the shaman must come to terms in his málirríkairi songs: the spirit of sickness itself. Like people, animals, birds, fish, plants, and the rest of the elements making up the world of living beings which Kuwái's music created, sickness has two sides, a generic or categorical side and a specific, individual side. The generic side of the spirit of sickness is called wáramápwa in shaman's songs. Wáramápwa is a single spirit-name that encompasses all the categories of spirits in separation from any specific names. Wáramápwa is éenunai, képinai, umáwari, and the newer category of rupápera púware sAmáru ("the paper of Amáru", or exogenous diseases) all in one being, a breakdown of the conceptual principles of Kuwái in which the generic and categorical has split apart from the specific and individual. Wáramápwa is a processual breakdown of Kuwái in which the "everthing - ness" has split

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off from the "being - ness". This process is formally homologous to the process of destructuration in which sickness and death bring about a detachment of the unconscious líwarúna soul from the patient's conscious likáriwa soul. Both shamans and owners of málikai are concerned with wáramápwa as a general category of sickness. The shaman tries to suck it into his stomach with the help of his sacred rattle (kútirúda) and to neutralize its harmful effects by combining it with a specific, physical manifestation of sickness (e.g., iwálikunám) that comes from sucking the patient's body. The owner of málikai names the concept of wáramápwa in the vocabulary of málikai chants and songs, the itáda spirits of forest animals, birds, and fish. The owner of málikai "cuts in half" the combination of itáda spirits with tobacco smoke and also tries to destroy the spirit of the specific sickness (e.g., tóli máturinám) that is causing harm to the patient.

Body Postures and Movements of Ritual Healers

A consideration of body postures and movements (or lack thereof) which the owner of málikai and the shaman display in the course of curing rituals is useful for understanding the musical differences and similarities between málikai and málirríkairi songs. The owner of málikai sits in a hammock while performing curing songs and does not stand up until the end of the prayer with which he concludes his performance. Since hammocks are places where people usually sleep or rest, the posture of the málikai-owner is one of sitting up. The

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shaman, too, performs nearly all his songs in a sitting position, but he sings while sitting down on a low bench after standing up for various reasons. Thus, both genres of curing music are performed in a sitting posture, but the málikai-owner sits up, whereas the shaman sits down.

Beyond this similarity of posture, the body movements of the two types of ritual healers completely differ from each other. The owner of málikai sits rigidly still except for the unconscious, somatic movements of respiration and occasional eye-blinking. His mouth and speech organs are the only body parts subject to voluntary movement while singing. And in the brief intervals between songs for blowing tobacco smoke over pacáka, the owner of málikai restricts his movements to the minimal hand and body motions necessary for bending over to pick up the pot of pacáka, raising the lid, and setting it back on the floor. Furthermore, the málikai-owner sings inside a room where no one else is present until the closing prayer. In short, performances of málikai songs in curing rituals are a process of restricting all conscious body movements to a minimum and of temporarily depriving sense perceptions except for hearing and the smell (taste) of tobacco smoke.

Meanwhile, the shaman working outside is the embodiment of human activity and sense perception carried to an extreme. Even in his most inactive moments when he sits down on a low bench to sing, the shaman shakes his rattle in large, slow circles and moves his head and eyes from side to side as he

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scans the sky for `shadows'. The hyperactivity of the shaman is reflected in the great number of spiritual forces which he manipulates both in málirríkairi songs and in physical actions accompanied by a variety of sacred objects: the rattle (kútirúda), cigarettes, stones (both polished, red ones and jagged, quartz-like crystals), the dzáato snuff, the V-shaped bone tube for snorting, a white tube made of paper, the payment, and the patient's body. Nevertheless, the shaman does not act in a random manner with these objects but uses them in highly-structured and redundant sequences of action[18].

Each activity of the shaman has a clear purpose in terms of the objectives of the curing ritual. Waving a cigarette in the air is done to capture the lost soul of the patient. The shaman tries to bring the lost soul into his arms with the cigarette so that he can inhale it into his lungs, carry it over to the patient, and blow it back into his head. He performs this same action hundreds of times and on occasion blows smoke not only on the patient's head but on the heads of every person sitting in the vicinity. The shaman's own view of the effect of blowing smoke on people's heads in curing rituals is that he is putting power back into their bodies and that this power is like the compression inside an engine. The cigarette is a means of capturing the body's power after it has escaped into the sky and putting it back into the head. By blowing smoke over the heads of everyone else present from time to time, the shaman symbolically incorporates the collective body-power of all these people into

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the process of restoring the individual, conscious likáriwa soul of the patient.

Capturing and restoring lost souls with tobacco smoke are the only physical activities that bring the shaman into close contact with the entire group of ritual participants and observers. Most of the time, the shaman is either in direct contact with the patient's body or standing alone in the open space in front of the patient. The shaman searches the sky for the spirit of sickness (wáramápwa) while singing and immediately afterwards sucks the patient's body to remove the physical object that causes sickness. Then he stands up and tries to scoop the external spirit of sickness into his mouth and stomach with the feathers of his rattle. The purpose of his actions is to link together the external and internal (or generic and specific) causes of sickness inside his own body so that both disease-causing agents can be vividly expelled into the bushes through vomitting. The shaman finally manages to achieve this internal synthesis of disease-causing agents only after the confession of evil omens by the patient's family. This moment in the curing ritual marks the shaman's triumph over the evil forces of sorcery and/or witchcraft and is analogous to the final episode of the myth of evil omens where Iñápirríkuli terrifies Kunáhwerri's daughter into running by herself into her father's village, only to learn that her fears were really true. Like Iñápirríkuli's revenge in the myth, the shaman's victory over sickness works by first getting the ritual

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participants to take an active role in the curing process so that the sickness itself has dynamic social and natural properties.

Comparative Analysis of Málikai and Málirríkairi Songs

Málikai songs for curing reconstruct the fate of the patient's unconscious líwarúna soul and place this partial separation into the reversible space-time of the mythical producers of honey, or Kuwáiñai. Aside from a few very brief interruptions to blow tobacco smoke on pacáka, the songs are continuous and unchanging. The four tones of the first phrases are repeated over and over without variation of loudness, pitch, rhythm, or tempo. The repetition of this descending phrase over one hundred times has a sort of hypnotic effect on the performer, who at times looks as though he is on the verge of falling asleep. While the song texts are based on images of a prolonged journey through space and time, the music conveys a sense of frozen space-time in which the same, simple movement unceasingly repeats itself, like a heartbeat or breath of air.

The purpose of málikai songs for curing is to relive a mythical journey that goes backwards in time and space so that the patient can re-enter the life cycle of orderly growth and transformation based on conceptual principles implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle. Following the mythical journey backwards in time and space through songs, málikai prayers aim at "cutting in half" the manifestation of Kuwái as a purely generic being that has been split off from all

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specific things. In these prayers, both the verbal action of "killing" spirits with tobacco smoke and the musical or poetic organization of sounds strongly resemble the set of three chants that are performed for the tools, weapons, and work activities of the fathers of newborn infants[19]. The málikai prayers for curing are an intoned, rapid flow of speech that sound similar to the first set of chants performed in childbirth rituals, but they do not contain any raising of pitch or acceleration of tempo that would convey a sense of growth. The musical similarities between málikai for curing and for childbirth suggest that the purpose of the mythical journey of Kuwáikanérri backwards in time and space is to symbolically bring the curer and patient into a relationship that is like that of the chant-owner to newborn infant (kérramu) at the very beginning of the life cycle. Of course, the processes of arriving at these similar points of (re-)entry into the life cycle are very different, since in childbirth rituals the owner of málikai separates a newborn infant's identity from that of its father, whereas in curing rituals the process is one of destroying the separate existence of the collective, unconscious soul (líwarúna).

As pointed out earlier, the main purpose of the shaman's málirríkairi songs is to provide a language for conveying the shaman's reliving of his patient's illness as a process of destructuration that permeates conscious perception and thought, both inside the patient's body and in external natural and social dimensions. Perhaps the most striking con-

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trast between the shaman's songs and the málikai songs of his partner is their discontinuity. Although the shaman's songs sometimes come right after one another, a period of several minutes usually elapses between the ending of one song and the beginning of the next one. These are periods when the shaman is actively using his sacred objects as a way of manipulating supernatural powers, spirits, and souls in the external world and of bringing these invisible powers to bear on the patient's body and the disease-causing agent inside it. The shaman's songs are for him the most relaxing moments of what is otherwise a test of his endurance in the face of increasingly painful overloading of the senses. The songs are the only form of intelligible, verbal communication of the shaman after he has entered into the trance-like state of sensual overload induced by massive doses of dzáato snuff.

The contrast between the continuity of málikai songs and the discontinuity of málirríkairi songs in curing rituals reflects a basic underlying contrast between the mythical functions of the two genres of music. Málikai songs are concerned with the journey of the unconscious líwarúna soul at death. Like the creative power of Kuwái's music in myth, performances of málikai act as a power that dominates the spatial and temporal structuring (or de-structuring) of all ritual actors and activities. On the other hand, the málirríkairi songs of the shaman are part of a wider context of ritual actors and activities. The songs both structure and are structured by these other actors and activities and, unlike

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málikai, are not the central creative power around which the ritual curing process gravitates. The songs are concerned with the journey of the conscious likáriwa soul after death and its transformation into a lidánam soul in íyarudáti. The shaman's songs are only one part of his effort to bring back the patient's conscious likáriwa soul from íyarudáti and to expel the internal and external spirits of sickness that afflict the patient.

The tonal and rhythmical organization of the shaman's málirríkairi songs are far more varied and complex than the frozen melodic structure of the málikai songs for curing. Whereas málikai songs repeat the same four-note melody over and over again to create a hypnotic feeling of falling asleep, málirríkairi songs systematically explcit all logical possibilities for musical contrasts out of a small number of principal tones (3 or 4, depending on the song). A contrast between loud and soft is very noticeable in the shaman's technique of echoing the last words of each phrase in a soft, ventriloquist voice[20]. While the majority of songs are based on descending melodies, a few make very pronounced use of ascending as well as descending melodies, thereby creating a contrast between ascending and descending tonal motion. A contrast between high and low levels of pitch is clearly present in the technique of singing the same melodies on different pitches at different points in the curing ritual, with a general tendency for pitches to rise over time. The first melody is sung on relatively low pitches, the next one on

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slightly higher pitches, and so forth until the same melody is sung on pitches that are five chromatic intervals higher than the first song. Finally, the songs display a contrast between a faster and a slower tempo. Most of the time, the shaman shakes his sacred rattle (kútirúda) at a moderate tempo and in large, clockwise circles made with his right hand. At odd moments during his songs, however, he doubles the tempo of his rattling to an extremely fast pace by making smaller circles with his right hand. This acceleration also increases the sound output of his rattling and further reinforces the vocal contrast between loud and soft dynamics.

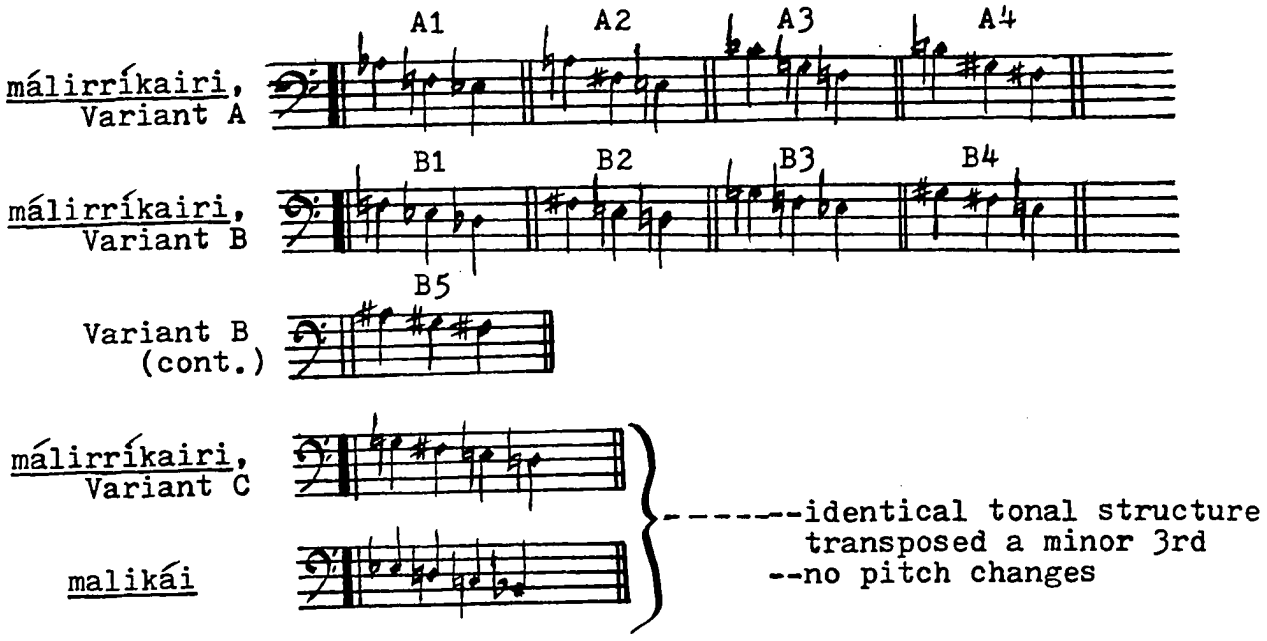
The amount of musical variation available to the shaman through exploitation of different musical contrasts is almost limitless, and a complete musical transcription and analysis of these variations is beyond the scope of the present study. The importance of musical variation and contrast in málirríkairi songs is how it works in the opposite direction from the strictly controlled, unchanging tonal and rhythmical organization in málikai songs. The former is a process of awakening the senses and making perception more sensitive to contrasts, whereas the latter is a process of numbing the senses into a frozen state of insensitivity that shuts out or minimizes the perception of contrasts.

In spite of the opposite effects of málirríkairi and málikai songs, there is an underlying similarity of tonal organization that allows the two genres of curing music to be understood as two opposite ways of reliving the same process

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of destructuration. Looking beyond the smokescreen of musical variation and contrast, the shaman's songs are all based on three simple tonal structures that can be grouped into three classes. Using as a sample the 19 málirríkairi songs performed on the second day of the curing ritual which I have described and analyzed in this chapter, the most frequent tonal structure consists of three tones dividing the interval of a fourth into two unequal, smaller intervals (a whole step and a minor third). This tonal structure, or variant A, is the basis of 9 shaman's songs out of a total sample of 19 from that day[21]. Variant A is reproduced on 4 different pitches that are a chromatic half-step apart. A second tonal structure, or variant B, consists of three tones in which a minor third is divided into two whole-tone intervals. Tonal structure B is the basis for 7 songs out of the total sample of 19, and it is reproduced at five different pitch levels that are each a chromatic half-step apart. Variant B shows the greatest contrast between high and low pitches and is also the tonal structure used for creating ascending as well as descending melodies. The third and least frequent tonal structure, or variant C, consists of four tones that divide the interval of a fourth into three smaller intervals, two whole-tone steps and a single chromatic half-step. Variant C is the basis of three short songs all of which are reproduced on exactly the same pitch level. Figure 7.3 illustrates the three tonal structure-variants that form the basis of málirríkairi songs from the second day of the curing ritual

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Sequence of shaman's málirríkairi songs on second day of curing ritual according to tonal structure (indicated by capital letters) and pitch-level (indicated by numerals):

B1, B3-B4, A1, B3, B5, A1-A2, C,
A1, B4, A2, A2, A1, B5, C,
B5, A3-A4, A1, A2, C

Figure 7.3. Transcriptions of tonal structures and pitch changes in málirríkairi and malikái songs for curing; rhythmical and melodic structures not shown.

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and the range of pitch levels which each of the three variants spans.

Figure 7.3 also shows the 4-tone structure of málikai songs for curing. An interesting fact that emerges from a comparison of variant C of the málirríkairi songs with the tonal organization of málikai songs is the identical structure of the tonal organization in the two types of song. Both consist of four tones in which the interval of a fourth is divided into three smaller intervals, two whole-tone steps and a single chromatic half-step at the top. Variant C of málirríkairi songs also resembles málikai songs insofar as it is always sung at the same level of pitch, whereas variants A and B both rise in pitch in the course of the curing ritual. The identity of tonal organization in variant C of shaman's songs and in málikai songs is a way of expressing through musical symbolism the message that both genres of curing music are interrelated parts of a single myth-rituals nexus that deals with sickness and death as a process of destructuration. Thus, musical symbolism reinforces the interconnectedness of the two genres which song texts establish through a common concern with getting rid of or destroying wáramápwa, the separation from generic being from individual form and substance. Málikai and málirríkairi represent two parts of the primal self, or Kuwái, as opposite, complementary phases in the destructuration of orderly growth and transformation of individual members of Wakuénai society. Like the witchcraft which they are designed to counteract,

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málikai songs for curing work from a distance and without any intervening physical medium. Like sorcery, málirríkairi songs cannot effect any changes in other people without the addition of physical actions and close interpersonal contact between curer and patient.

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1. However, I am not uninterested in psychoanalytical concepts and would welcome the opportunity to collaborate with a specialist in either psychology or culture and personality studies in a future re-study of the same ritual performances of music that are the subjects of my cultural analysis in this chapter.

2. In fact, Howard's discussion of culture "as a construct based upon the organization of experience around situations" (1982: 49) when viewed through the interactionist lens in many respects parallels my own view of culture as a set of processes of structuration that operate together to organize experience into categories and transform these orders of experience according to situational factors.

3. Again I feel obligated to clearly state the limits of my anthropological naivety, this time with respect to medical and biological sciences. My criteria for judging the results of treatments were the patients' own statements and activities (e.g., return to normal diet and work activities vs. continuation of fast and prolongation of inactivity). In no cases are these "emic" evaluations of recovery (or failure to recover) compared with "etic" evaluations based on medical or scientific measurements. In any case, I do not believe that a comparison of West European medical standards with Wakuénai beliefs and practices is a valid

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methodology for studying shamanistic and other indigenous curing practices unless such comparison is based on a careful analysis of how the Wakuénai themselves interpret and act on disease as a mythical, musical, and ritual process that cannot be reduced to mere biological phenomena.

4. I am omitting consideration of a sub-genre of shaman's songs called íyarudáti, a method for travelling to the house of forest animal (éenunai) and bird (képinai) spirits in the region of recently-deceased (lidánam) persons. I did not record this music or ever observe a performance of it and so cannot say how it differs from málirríkairi songs for curing.

5. The bones of deceased persons are seen as a permanent entity which is passed on to the younger generations in the form of the sib ancestor soul (líwarúna). The soft, fleshy parts of the body all rot while the lidánam soul is in íyarudáti. The contrast between bones as a symbol of permanence and soft body parts as a material that changes or disintegrates is very clearly present in the myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli, whose name means "out of bones". In some versions, a body was sewn onto the bones of Iñápirríkuli's dead father, while in others the trickster-hero emerged from the bones of his dead father.

6. The myth of the origin of death is situated in the dis-

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tant mythical past of Iñápirríkuli and describes another set of episodes in the ongoing conflict between Iñápirríkuli's kinsmen and their affines, the children of Kunáhwerri. The former are invited to attend a pudáli ceremony, and, expecting to have poison (mahnéti) put in their food and drinks, they bring a remedy along that saves everyone except for a younger brother of Iñápirríkuli. They take the dying kinsman home, and Iñápirríkuli blows tobacco smoke over his body. He instructs everyone to stay out of the special house where his brother is coming back to life, but the brother's wife sneaks into the room, and the poison-victim immediately turns into a heap of bones with no flesh on them. Iñápirríkuli tries to revive him again but with no success. This myth is the origin of the custom of secondary burial in which a person is not mourned immediately after his death but only later when his bones are dug up and the chant-owner performs málikai, an act that signifies that the deceased person will never return to life in this world.

7. Matos Arvelo (1912: 95-97) has written an excellent description of Wakuénai beliefs in the soul's journey after death and has shown how the manner of death is believed to affect this spiritual journey. The soul always re-unites with the sacred animal soul of its ancestors, but a violent death preceded by large losses

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of blood is considered to prolong the period of painful separation from the ancestor soul. Poisoning with mahnéti is a more merciful way of killing enemies since it leaves their bodies intact and reduces the period of painful separation after death. Matos Arvelo attributes the low rates of violence and murder among the Wakuénai and other Arawakan groups near Maroa to this belief system. According to the author, only 3 murders took place in his 15 years as Prefect of Maroa (1912: 97).

8. The Ge-speaking Suya Indians of Central Brazil have a similar belief in the importance of ceremonial activities in the afterlife. "Corpses are buried fully decorated because the principal activity of the spirits (mẽgaron) in the village of the dead is the performances of ceremonies" (Seeger 1981: 172).

9. Investigating beliefs in the afterlife in the field required a high degree of critical evaluation to filter out Christian beliefs that have entered into the traditional belief system through missionary influences. Some informants, for example, equated iyarudáti with the Christian concept of purgatory and claimed that the length of a deceased person's stay in iyarudáti depended on the person's crimes and sins in this world. However, as I pointed out earlier (see fn. 7), the earliest ethnographic account does not uphold such views but indicates instead the importance of manner of

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death in determining the length of a deceased person's separation from the ancestor soul (Matos Arvelo 1912). Both myth texts and descriptions of traditional Wakuénai beliefs and customs made by senior men and women of the two villages where I worked confirm Matos Arvelo's commentary rather than the more common equation of íyarudáti with purgatory.

10. Bacterial and viral diseases affecting these visceral organs such as hepatitis, tuberculosis, pneumonia, and parasitosis are invariably attributed to poisoning with mahnéti. One man in a nearby village fell ill after a fight with his affines and grew very thin and weak. His condition was popularly seen as the result of poisoning with mahnéti. Even after the local doctor in San Carlos de Rio Negro had the man flown to a hospital to be treated for tuberculosis (that tested positively on the skin), the man did not fully recover upon returning to his village, and people generally scoffed at the idea that modern medical doctors could actually cure sorcery victims.

11. The power of the dzáwináitairi, or master shaman, is in this respect identical to the power attributed to the kumú in Desana society. "On a much higher level than the payé, the kumú is a luminous personage who has an interior light, a brilliant flame that shines and unveils the intimate thoughts of all people who speak to

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him" (Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971: 137).

12. Hernando learned divination from a Hohódeni father-in-law on the Aiarí River in Brazil who had in turn learned it from the Desana of the Vaupés River. Tukanoan groups of the Northwest Amazon region probably all practice divination, but the Desana are considered the most powerful masters of this art. Since divination is not a traditional Wakuénai ritual practice and has no accompanying musical performances or myths, I will not beleaguer the present analysis of Wakuénai curing practices with Hernando's stories of successful divinations. The only important point to mention here is that Hernando uses a drug from a divining plant, called pánupárupátakáita, whenever he performs málikai songs for curing and claims that the drug increases his ability to locate both the external (geographical) and internal (physiological) causes of his patients' diseases.

13. The name of Kuwáikanérri is obviously based on the name of Kuwái, but unfortunately I could not determine the meaning of the suffix -kanérri through direct questioning. An answer to this question could perhaps be indirectly arrived at through a linguistic analysis of all words based on the name Kuwái and its variant, kwé-, a prefix used in such words as kwépani (dance of Kuwái).

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14. This belief in the power of speech acts as causal agents that can have tangible results is perhaps related to the belief in the power of Kuwái's music as a transformative agent. However, the latter uses words in singing and chanting to "cook" or "kill" in a highly controlled manner, whereas the belief in harmful effects of certain speech acts is an uncontrolled process of divulgation.

15. The summary of the myth of the origin of evil omens given here is reduced to its barest outline because I am mainly interested in how the myth serves as a model for the curing practices of ritual specialists. Like other myths about Iñápirríkuli's fights against Kunáhwerri, this one is highly embroidered by the narrator with details of how Iñápirríkuli cleverly defeats his enemies (see Chapter 2).

16. The use of this name to describe íyarudáti has interesting implications. I noted that the shaman only starts to work directly with his patients after 12:00 noon and that he and his patient always sit facing east. After 12:00 noon, the sun casts shadows in an easterly direction.

17. Wright (personal communication) observed a collective ceremony, called Heemápana, among the Hohódeni of the Aiarí River in Brazil. In the ceremony, all adult men drank a brew made of banisteriopsis caapi. As far as I

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can tell, this ceremony is another example of the influence of Tukanoan cultures on Wakuénai groups of the Aiarí, since the use of hallucinogens among the Wakuénai was traditionally restricted to shamans (malírri) and master shamans (dzáwináitairi) and no one else. Collective use of hallucinogens among the Cubeo, Desana, and other Tukanoan groups of the Northwest Amazon region is a well-documented ceremonial custom (see Goldman 1963; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971; S. Hugh-Jones 1979).

18. The myth of the origin of dzáato snuff emphasizes the importance of the shaman's self-control while under the influence of the stimulating drug. Four animal-people and a brother of Iñápirríkuli took dzáato snuff after the latter sucked it out of the stomach of the daughter of Dzulíhwerri. The four animal-people went crazy from the snuff, but Iñápirríkuli's brother, ẽeri, fell asleep and woke up in full control of himself and became the first shaman.

19. The málikai prayers for curing are also connected with the first set of málikai chants in childbirth ritual through the common practice of blowing tobacco smoke over the heads of ritual participants. The two subgenres of málikai thus differ from performances of málikai songs and chants in which the specialist blows smoke over hot-peppered, boiled meat (káridzámai) in

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both childbirth and initiation rituals.

20. Wright (personal communication) has recorded Hohódeni shamans who perform málirríkairi songs in groups. The lead singer's voice is constantly being echoed by response singers creating a somewhat disorienting, contrapuntal effect since the 'echo' of the second singer is usually not much softer than the principal melody. The Dzáwinai shaman with whom I worked did not ever practice together with other shamans but only with a málikai-owner, and they were separated by at least 10 m distance so that their singing did not overlap except as a faint echo in the background.

21. This set of recordings is my most reliable sample of málirríkairi songs because on the second day I recorded the shaman without any interruption for several hours. On the first day, I left him to record the málikai songs and prayers for curing and did not get a fully representative sample.

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Chapter 8:

"Raw, Cooked, and Rotten: Wakuénai Ancestor Cults"

Introduction

This chapter will bring together the results of preceding analyses of sacred musical performances in childbirth, initiation, and curing rituals in order to examine how they interact to form a sub-system of the overall musical performance system of the Wakuénai. The analysis takes as its starting point the Levi-Straussian idea that empirical categories such as the raw and the cooked or the fresh and the decayed can serve "as a means for elaborating and combining abstract ideas in the form of propositions" (1969: 1). By changing the emphasis on empirical categories to a concern with empirical processes, Levi-Strauss's basic idea in The Raw and the Cooked can be rephrased as follows: empirical processes such as cooking or rotting can serve as a means for elaborating and applying abstract principles in the form of processes of classification, transformation, reversal, and inversion. In making this modification, the structuralist method of seeking systematic interrelations between structural categories is not abandoned but transposed to an investigation of interrelations among processes of structuration.

Comparative structural analysis of a number of distinct, yet interrelated, musical performances seen as multi-

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dimensional processes of structuration is a method for discerning how these processes act together to construct different hierarchical levels of meaning in a single system. The lowest level of the performance system consists of specific performative processes in which empirical processes of cooking or rotting are applied to the experience of individuals and groups. The musical cooking of káridzámai in childbirth rituals, for example, is a way of conceptually organizing the growth of newborn infants into children according to the principle of Kuwái as "all things in one being". At intermediate levels of the system, different performative processes are grouped together into two pairs, one concerned with the empirical process of cooking and the other with that of rotting. The analysis of musical cooking in initiation rituals (Chapter 6) as a transformation of the same process that operates in the musical chants for káridzámai in childbirth rituals is one example of the intermediate level of meaning in the sub-system of sacred musical performances. In one sense, musical cooking is a direct application of conceptual principles from the Kuwái myth cycle to the life experiences of growth and development. In another sense, the two kinds of performance in which musical cooking is used refer to each other as an interrelated pair of performative processes. The musical, primarily rhythmical, technique of bisecting each word of the text acts as a meta-symbolic device that indelibly marks both ritual uses of musical cooking as members of a common set.

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The other example of the intermediate hierarchical level of meaning in the sub-system of sacred musical performances is the pair of musical genres performed in curing rituals. In this case, tonal structure rather than rhythmical organization acts as a meta-symbolic device that refers to a higher level at which the two apparently opposite genres of musical performance can be understood as an interrelated pair of performative processes. The two genres together provide a means for counteracting the empirical process of rotting, seen in symbolic terms as a process of separation between the unconscious líwarúna soul and the conscious likáriwa soul[1].

In still another sense, the two pairs of sacred musical performances based on cooking and rotting also refer to each other as a pair of interrelated operations. This third, or highest, level of meaning completes the sub-system of sacred musical performances by demonstrating that the empirical processes of rotting and cooking are in some ways complementary processes of structuration, even though they forcefully contradict each other at the intermediate level of the system. This third level of meaning is more difficult to analyze than either of the two lower levels because there is no indigenous mythical text that explains how the two pairs of performative processes are interrelated. The unity of the Kuwái myth cycle openly supports an analysis of the two types of musical cooking in childbirth and initiation rituals as an interrelated pair. Likewise, the myth of the origin of evil omens provides strong evidence that the Wakuénai themselves,

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or at least the more learned members of society, view the two genres of musical performance in curing rituals as an interrelated pair. No such integral text exists that can explain how these two pairs of performances are themselves interrelated. Instead, the evidence lies in musical symbolism, song texts, beliefs about sorcery, and fragments of myth episodes that reveal the place of performative processes of musical cooking and rotting in the general scheme of Wakuénai cosmology and cosmic history.

In this chapter, I will review these cultural phenomena in an effort to arrive at an understanding of the sub-system of sacred musical performances as a tri-level hierarchy of meaning. The analysis will lead to a consideration of the role of higher levels of meaning in the sub-system of sacred musical performances in cultivating beliefs in the efficacy of ritual symbols and actions and of the central importance of these beliefs in the creation and maintenance of relatively stable, local ancestral cults with clearly defined leaders and followers. Wakuénai ancestor cults and the ranked, phratric alliances which they collectively make up are a type of socio-religious system that shows a relatively high degree of specialization by indigenous Amazonian standards. Such systems were most likely much more widely distributed in the Amazon Basin prior to the devastation of indigenous Arawakan societies living along the lower Rio Negro. The chapter will conclude with an open-ended discussion of religious and political leadership in traditional villages

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where ritual specialists are also headmen and senior elders who are leaders of non-ritual activities in the community.

Raw, Cooked, and Rotten

Levi-Strauss approaches a more processual view of the structural meaning of raw, cooked, and rotten towards the end of The Raw and the Cooked when he offers a tentative definition of the social meaning of the raw-to-cooked metaphor:

> ". . .the individuals who are "cooked" are those deeply involved in a physiological process: the newborn child, the woman who has just given birth, or the pubescent girl"(1969: 336)[2].

Childbirth and puberty are periods in the life cycle when physiological growth and change are at their maximum. The musical "cooking" of individuals who either directly experience these growth processes or who are closely connected to such experiences (e.g., the parents of newborn infants) is a means of transforming the raw potential of physiological growth and sexual reproduction into orderly growth and transformation controlled by ritual specialists who represent the collective cultural identity of the local sib group. Childbirth and puberty are physiological processes that bring about an overly intimate, or "raw", relationship between the individual, body-shaped soul (likáriwa) of the conscious self and the collective, animal-shaped soul (líwarúna) of the unconscious self. Childbirth and puberty place individuals in contact with animal, natural forces of growth, and musical

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cooking mediates this contact by sorting out and classfying the spirits of natural species, objects, and places according to conceptual principles of sameness or uniqueness, depending on the ritual context.

Sickness and death, on the other hand, are processes of decay that bring about an extraordinary separation between the individual human soul and the collective animal soul. Musical performances in curing rituals aim at reliving the fate of the individual and collective parts of the soul so that the process of destructuration, once established, can be reversed and directly attacked both in music and in other ritual activities. The fundamental distinction with which both musical cooking and its opposite are concerned is that between individual and collective identities. Both terms are equally important to the transformation of natural processes into cultural ones and vice-versa.

Musical cooking differentiates between human individual and collective identities and articulates a relationship between them according to the mythical life cycle of Kuwái. In children, collective identity is primary, whereas in recent-initiates personal, sexual identity predominates. Adults who have become parents or grandparents gradually come to represent a balancing of the individual and collective identities. Musical performances for curing start out with the assumption of a breakdown of the relations between individual and collective identities. The first step in controlling this breakdown is to relive the natural processes of

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decay, or separation, that afflicts the individual identity after death. The collective líwarúna soul is believed to go directly to the celestial paradise after death and does not undergo any major change but continues to exist as a líwarúna soul. The individual, however, suffers a transformation from a conscious self (likáriwa) into a recently-deceased lidánam soul in íyarudáti.

Musical cooking in childbirth and initiation rituals is opposed to the musical journeys that represent decay in curing rituals (hereafter referred to in abbreviated form as musical "rotting") in terms of the dichotomy between cultural and natural processes. Musical cooking classifies and transforms natural processes of growth and reproduction into cultural processes. Musical performances in curing rituals transform cultural processes of sorcery, witchcraft, and evil omens into natural processes of rotting (separation or breakdown), honey production, and hopefully, physiological recovery (see Figure 8.1). Málikai songs for curing go deeper and deeper into natural processes as they name various flower and bee species and finally reach the 'capital' of the Kuwáiñai, or bee-spirits, near the headwaters of the Guainía River. In a parallel manner, the shaman's songs lead him farther into the natural processes of sucking and vomitting by which the external and internal disease-causing agents are combined and extracted. At the same time, the shaman's singing takes him to the region of lidánam souls of the dead.

Reduced to simplest terms, musical "cooking" in child-

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	Natural Processes	⟶	Cultural Processes
Childbirth and Initiation Rituals	childhood growth puberty childbirth		musical cooking (classification and transformation of natural species and objects)

	Cultural Processes	⟶	Natural Processes
Curing Rituals	sorcery (poisoning) witchcraft (dreaming) evil omens (speech acts)		Musical journeys to íyarudáti and mápakwá makákwi Musical production of honey from flowers

Figure 8.1. Musical cooking in childbirth and initiation rituals as a transformation of natural into cultural processes and the opposite transformation in curing rituals.

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birth and initiation rituals is a transformation of natural processes into cultural ones, whereas musical "rotting" in curing rituals is a transformation of cultural processes into natural ones. This opposition between musical processes of cooking and rotting, or structuration and destructuration, is the basis of what I am calling the second, or intermediate, level of meaning in the tri-level hierarchy of meaning which the sub-system of sacred musical performances constructs and applies to the organization of experience. Figure 8.2 illustrates how the processes of cooking and rotting are elaborated and applied to the life cycle in this world (hekwápiríko), the experiences of sickness in the marginal area(s) between this world and the two worlds of the afterlife, and the fate of the soul after death.

The transformation of human individuals (likáriwa) into dead souls (lidánam) after death is in one sense analogous to the transformation of children (yénpiti) into recent-initiates (wálit'áki). Both transformations emphasize the individual likáriwa soul, but they do so in different ways. Initiation brings about a reordering or changing of stress from the unconscious líwarúna soul to the conscious likáriwa soul. Death is a total separation of the two parts of the soul, the human individual and the social animal, rather than a change in their relative emphasis. Nevertheless, the two transformations are associated insofar as initiants are equated with Kuwái at death when they receive ritual advice, káridzámai, and whipping.

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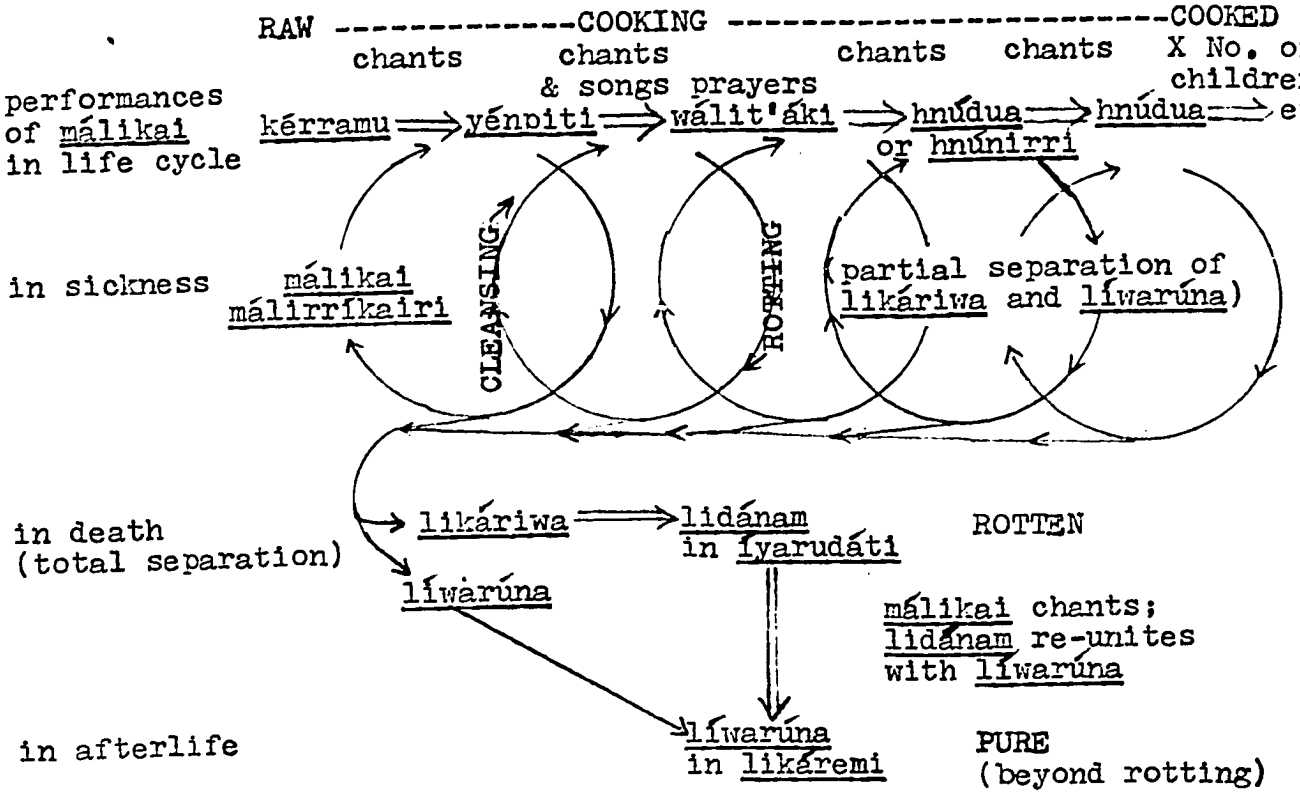


Figure8.2. Diagram showing how cooking and rotting processes are elaborated and applied to development and growth in life cycle, experiences of sickness, and beliefs in the fate of souls after death.

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Comparative Analysis of Cooking and Rotting

The processual opposition between musical cooking and musical rotting generates a relationship of binary opposition between categories of cooking and rotting processes. The category of cooking processes is itself divided into two inverted transformations at the lowest level, but at the intermediate level the two types of musical cooking form a set of performative processes that transform natural processes into cultural ones. The two genres of curing music concerned with processes of rotting contradict the movement from natural to cultural processes which musical cooking accomplishes in childbirth and initiation rituals. Cultural processes such as sorcery and evil omens in which basic culinary and communicative codes have been violated are transformed into natural processes such as the separation of the two parts of the soul and honey production.

In terms of Wakuénai cosmic history, the processual opposition between musical cooking and musical rotting sets up an opposition between the distant, miniature space-time of Iñápirríkuli and the more recent, life-sized space-time of the Kuwái myth cycle. Musical cooking in childbirth and initiation rituals is a performative process that moves individual members of the local sib group through transitional points of the life cycle in this world (hekwápiríko) in terms of conceptual principles implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle. Musical rotting and honey production in curing rituals take individual sib members back towards the distant mythical

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space-time of Iñápirríkuli. These processes move individuals out of the series of life cycle transformations based on the Kuwái myth cycle and take them back towards the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli. The reversal of time in curing music is temporary and incomplete, and the process of separation only reaches to the intermediary, gateway regions between this world and the two worlds of the afterlife. Death, however, brings about a total reversal of mythical time in which individuals eventually return to the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli through the reunification of the two parts of the soul in likáremi, the celestial paradise.

The processual opposition between musical cooking and musical rotting does not set up an absolute, fixed opposition between cultural and natural processes or between the mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli and that of Kuwái. Looking at the two sets of performative processes as a system, certain rough similarities are discernible in the ways they are used to give structure and meaning to experience. These similarities hint at a third, or highest, level of meaning at which there is a correlation of lower level transformations and oppositions into a culturally prescribed pattern of operations. One clue already mentioned in the last chapter is the striking similarity between the málikai prayers for killing harmful spirits in curing rituals and the first set of málikai chants for killing potentially dangerous spirits in childbirth rituals. Another clue is the dual mythical origin

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of mahnéti poison, the instrument of sorcery which the shaman must identify and extract from his patients' bodies by combining it with wáramápwa, the external spirit of sickness. On the one hand, wáramápwa and mahnéti are said to have originated at the time of Kuwái's death in fire, and on the other hand, mahnéti poison is said to have originated in the myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli near the very beginning of Wakuénai cosmic history. This ambiguity associates the shaman's singing and other ritual activities with initiation rituals and at the same time refers to a higher level of meaning that transcends the opposition between the distant mythical space-time of Iñápirríkuli and the more recent space-time of Kuwái.

A similar blurring of the distinction between these two mythical space-times is accomplished in the first part of the myth of evil omens with respect to the competing theories of autochthonous origins versus sexual reproduction. In the myth, Kunáhwerri's daughter tried to seduce Iñápirríkuli in the forest, but he wisely refused her offer, knowing that it was part of a conspiracy to kill him. Like the beginning of the Kuwái myth cycle, the first part of the myth of evil omens establishes sexual intercourse as the prevailing mode of reproduction. However, Iñápirríkuli's refusal to fornicate with Kunáhwerri's daughter eventually led to his slaying of her two brothers. After cutting off their heads, Iñápirríkuli stepped on the two heads and pushed them into the ground, whereupon they instantly grew into large dzápura

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trees. This mythical action brings about a return from imagery of sexual intercourse to that of autochthonous origins, thus transcending the opposition between the distant mythical past and the more recent time of the Kuwái myth cycle.

These fragments of musical performances and myths suggest that a third level of meaning operates beyond the processual opposition between musical cooking and musical rotting and the accompanying opposition between distant and recent mythical pasts. The first step towards reaching this higher level of meaning is to establish an analogical interrelationship between the two pairs of performances that make up the processual opposition at an intermediate level. The analogy reads as follows: málikai chants in childbirth rituals are to málikai chants in initiation rituals as málikai songs in curing rituals are to málirríkairi songs in curing rituals. The reasons for making this analogy become clear through a comparative musical analysis of the four types of performance. In the first place, the fact that the Wakuénai refer to three of the four performance-types as members of the same performance genre, málikai, suggests that the two opposite pairs of performances can be understood as an interrelated whole, notwithstanding the processual opposition between musical cooking and musical rotting. Furthermore, there are specific musical processes that operate in parallel fashion in the two pairs of performance-types.

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Looking first at the transformation of order taking place in the pair of performative processes based on musical cooking, the most striking differences center around the unchanging pitch, rhythm, tempo, and loudness of the chants for *káridzámai* in childbirth rituals and the multiple, rising pitches and temporal acceleration of the chants for káridzámai in initiation rituals. Also, there is a loudness contrast in the initiation chants because the second chanter's voice increases the volume by doubling the lead chanter's voice on the last word of each phrase. The chants for káridzámai in childbirth rituals do not show this kind of contrast in volume, since there is only one chanter. Thus, the two sets of chants in which musical cooking of káridzámai is the main activity portray a transformation from unaltered pitch, tempo, and loudness to variation of these three musical parameters. Only the rhythmical technique of bisecting each word of the chant text remains constant in the two performances of musical cooking.

Turning now to the transformation of order in the two genres of curing music, the musical differences between *málikai* curing songs and *málirríkairi* songs are parallel to the differences between musical cooking in childbirth and initiation rituals. Málikai songs for curing establish a single, four-tone melodic structure and repeat it without variation and with only minor intermissions for blowing smoke. Pitch, tempo, rhythm, and loudness remain constant. In parallel fashion, málikai chants for cooking *káridzámai* in

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childbirth rituals establish a pitch, tempo, rhythm, and loudness and repeat them with little or no variation and with only short breaks for blowing smoke. Málirríkairi curing songs, however, make use of the same tonal structure as málikai curing songs as well as two variant tonal structures and use these latter structures to compose a number of melodies with variations in pitch, tempo, rhythm, and loudness. In between songs, the shaman performs a variety of other ritual activities. Similarly, the málikai chants for cooking káridzámai in initiation rituals allow variations of pitch, tempo, and loudness as well as intermissions for kápetiápani dances or other ritual activities.

There are other musical techniques that re-inforce the analogy between musical cooking and musical rotting. The most obvious of these techniques is the use of percussive instruments to accompany the chanting or singing. Málikai chants for cooking káridzámai in childbirth rituals are solo, vocal performances, whereas málikai chants in initiation rituals are accompanied by the tapping of kadápu whips upon the overturned basked that covers the sacred food. Málikai songs for curing are also solo, vocal performances, yet málirríkairi curing songs are always performed with the accompanying sounds of the sacred rattle (kútirúda). Thus, in both musical cooking and musical rotting, there is a movement from solo voice to voice with instrumental, percussive accompaniment. There is also a movement from solo voice to a pair of lead and second voices. In initiation chants, the lead chanter's

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voice is doubled by a second chanter on the last word of each phrase. Likewise, the shaman's songs echo the last few words of each phrase as if the songs were being sung by two men, a principal singer and an accompanist[3]. Figure 8.3 summarizes the parallel musical processes between the two pairs of performance-types that make up musical cooking and musical rotting. Six out of the seven musical parameters which I have selected for musical analysis are transformed in nearly identical ways in musical cooking and musical rotting. Even the one parameter that is different in the two musical processes is more a reflection of the fact that musical cooking is a form of chanting, whereas musical rotting is a style of singing. By definition, chanting is non-melodic singing, so it is only natural that rhythmical structures play a decisive role in linking together the two types of musical cooking and that tonal structures fulfill the same function for the two types of musical rotting.

Beyond Cooking and Rotting

The analogy between processes of musical cooking and musical rotting is based primarily upon parallel musical processes and is only observable in a weaker form in myths. These musical transformations encompass a broad range of different parameters: tempo, pitch, volume, instrumentation, number of voices, and continuity. Taken as a whole, this set of musical processes acts as a meta-symbolic code for the construction of a third hierarchical level of meaning. The code is a process of coordination that sets up a culturally

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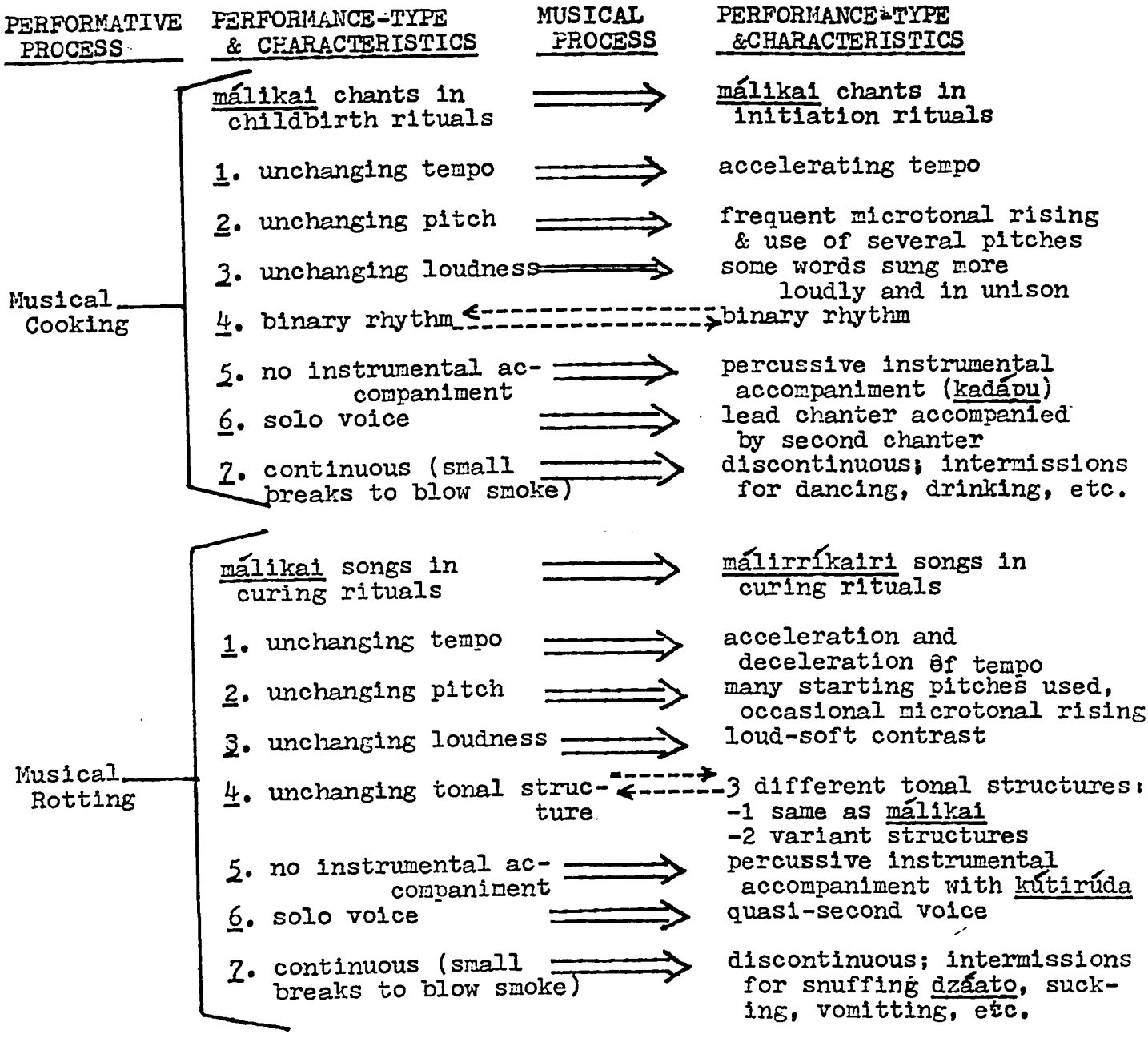


Figure 8.3. Chart showing how six out of seven musical parameters of musical cooking and musical rotting are transformed in nearly identical ways.

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prescribed pattern of correlation among lower level operations. In order to investigate the possible social meanings of the meta-symbolic code which the sub-system of sacred musical performances constructs, it is necessary to look beyond the processes of musical cooking and musical rotting to identify the points at which the two processes converge.

In From Honey to Ashes, Levi-Strauss devotes an entire volume to identifying "technical and cultural activity which lies beyond cooking" (1973: 25). He asserts that there is a second mythological system beyond the 'infra-culinary' one based on the opposition of the two fundamental categories of cooking, the raw and the cooked. This second system centers around the opposition between honey and tobacco and is called 'meta-culinary'. Levi-Strauss's method sharply diverges from the processual structuralism which I am developing here insofar as he attempts to document and analyze the meta-culinary system of honey and tobacco on the basis of myths of the origin of honey, tobacco, and associated cultural artifacts. As I stated earlier, the Wakuénai have no integral myth text explaining how the processes of musical cooking and musical rotting converge at a higher level of meaning that is beyond cooking and rotting. In Wakuénai social life, musical performances and not myths provide the means for communicating this higher level of meaning to ritual participants and to the social groups that make up the villages where ritual performances of music are carried out.

In spite of the widely different emphases of the present

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analysis of Wakuénai sacred musical performances and Levi-Strauss's analysis of mythological systems common to a great many native American societies, Levi-Strauss's dictum on the central importance of tobacco in meta-culinary mythological systems applies with equal accuracy to the sub-system of Wakuénai sacred musical performances.

> "We thus have fresh evidence of the fact that the system revolves round the central theme of tobacco. Only tobacco worthy of the name unites properties that are normally incompatible" (1973: 29).

Ritual blowing of tobacco smoke is the only activity common to every one of the four performance-types which I have discussed in the last three chapters. The objects upon which tobacco smoke is blown vary from the weapons and tools of the fathers of newborn infants, to the mother and her newborn child, to a pot of hot-peppered meat (káridzámai), to a pot of manioc flour in water (pacáka), to the sacred stones and other instruments of shamans, to patients and their families, and to whole groups of people watching the shaman perform his curing magic. The ritual activity of blowing tobacco smoke, therefore, is associated with all four of the performance-types that constitute the lowest level of the performance system.

The central importance of tobacco smoke is equally apparent in the texts of songs, chants, and prayers of all four performance-types. In childbirth rituals, the first set of

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chants repeatedly asks "to give tobacco for the body of the newborn infant" (núwaka lidákewa dzéema). In initiation rituals, the verbal action of "blowing tobacco smoke" (lidzéemá-náwa dzée-má) is frequently chanted in between the naming of places and the spirits of animal, bird, and fish species. In curing rituals, málikai prayers directly invoke the powers of tobacco smoke "to cut into pieces" (n´tedáahe) the paper of Amáru (exogenous diseases) and the generic spirits of animal, bird, and fish species (éenunai, képinai, and umáwari, respectively). Also in curing rituals, the shaman´s málirríkairi songs frequently use the verbal action of "send tobacco" (hútu dzéema). Tobacco is thus the central hub around which the entire sub-system of sacred musical performances revolves both in terms of the physical gestures of the performers and in the verbal actions of song and chant texts.

The musical processes of cooking and rotting each build upon two opposite terms, the raw and the cooked, and the fresh and the rotten, respectively. To look beyond cooking and rotting is to see that each process has a third term when carried to a logical extreme. Figure 8.4 shows that the third term for cooking is the burnt and that the third term for rotting is the pure. Cooking and rotting converge at this level in the indigenous belief that likáremi, the celestial paradise of Iñápirríkuli, is a place of the burnt and the pure. The beliefs in paradise set up a correlation between tobacco (the burnt) and honey (the pure). Paradise is the

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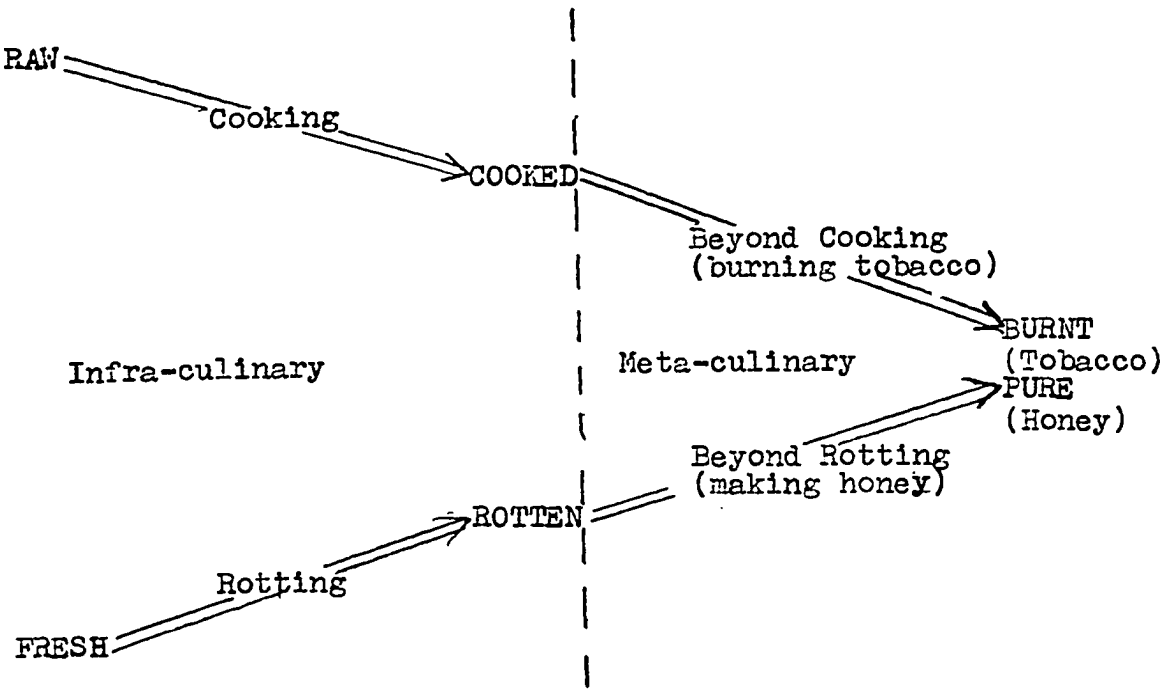


Figure84. The convergence of the natural process of rotting and the cultural process of cooking towards the burnt and the pure.

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home of male and female tobacco spirits given to each sib ancestor spirit (líwarúna) at the time of emergence from the ground in the distant mythical past. Blowing tobacco smoke in rituals is a cultural process of burning that brings the power of ancestral tobacco spirits to bear on living descendants in this world. In childbirth rituals, newborn infants are 'given' the power of tobacco spirits, in initiation rituals this power of tobacco spirits is transformed, and in curing rituals it is restored to patients and employed in the fight against sickness. In the celestial paradise, the cultural process of burning is represented in the belief in ancestral tobacco spirits, and to this belief is added the natural process of burning represented by the unceasing light of the primal sun, or Herri, a younger brother of Iñápirríkuli and the first initiant in myth. The celestial paradise is also the realm of the pure, the category of things or processes that are beyond rotting. The purity of likáremi is communicated in the belief that the food of ancestral souls who live there consists of only the purest honey in copious supply.

Beliefs in likáremi as a realm of both the burnt and the pure are a corollary of the parallel musical processes that show how musical cooking and musical rotting are in many ways nearly identical processes of structuration at a higher level of meaning. The correlation between the burnt and the pure, or between tobacco and honey, collapses the opposition between musical cooking, a cultural process, and musical rot-

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ting, a natural process. Another example of the correlation between tobacco and honey is the musical production of honey in málikai curing songs. The text of these songs is based on the story of Iñápirríkuli's mythical journey up the Negro, Isana, and Guainía rivers to cure his younger brother, Kuwáikanérri. In the first section of the story, before the two brothers enter the realm of Kuwáiñai bee-spirits, Iñápirríkuli produces honey by blowing tobacco smoke over the nectar of flowers that he has harvested from a variety of fruit trees. In this case, the cultural process of burning tobacco is equated with the natural process by which bees make honey. This collapsing of the opposition between natural and cultural processes eventually results in the two brothers' arrival in the realm of the bee-spirits and in a successful curing of the younger brother's deadly, bewitched condition.

One final example of the correlation of tobacco and honey is the practice of burning the hive-material of a species of large bee (éenui) whenever an entire village is threatened by witchcraft in the form of lightning or an epidemic of contagious diseases[4].In this case, a cultural process of burning is applied to beeswax instead of tobacco, and the resulting smoke is believed to have powerful counter-witchcraft effects. Inasmuch as beeswax is the locus of natural processes of honey production, the burning of éenui hives represents a collapsing of the opposition between cultural and natural processes. This correlation between the

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burnt and the pure, or between tobacco and honey, is the basis of beliefs in the efficacy of the technique of burning beehives as a means for counteracting witchcraft.

Human Physiological Processes and Cultural Genesis

To reach an understanding of the wider, contextual implications of the hierarchical system of meaning elaborated and applied in sacred musical performances, it is important to stand back and take an overall perspective of Wakuénai myths and cosmology and not to isolate either the Kuwái myth cycle or the myths of Iñápirríkuli. As indicated earlier (Chapter 5), the two myth cycles form part of a single cosmological history consisting of two basic mythical space-times: the distant, miniature world of Iñápirríkuli and the more recent, expanded world of Kuwái. Actually, the reversal of mythical space-time which the Wakuénai believe takes place in sickness and death means that the complete cosmic history consists of three distinct space-times. Figure 8.5 shows how the reversal of mythical space-time in sickness and death is situated between the mythical space-time of Kuwái and that of Iñápirríkuli in the distant past. The diagram is similar but not identical to the chart of three cosmic regions in Chapter 4 insofar as it adds the reversible space-time of the bee-spirits, or Kuwáiñai. The line between Hápakwá Makákwi (the 'capital' of the bee-spirits) and íyarudáti associates the two places with a single reversible space-time that ambiguously straddles the gap between the two irreversible space-times of Kuwái and Iñápirríkuli.

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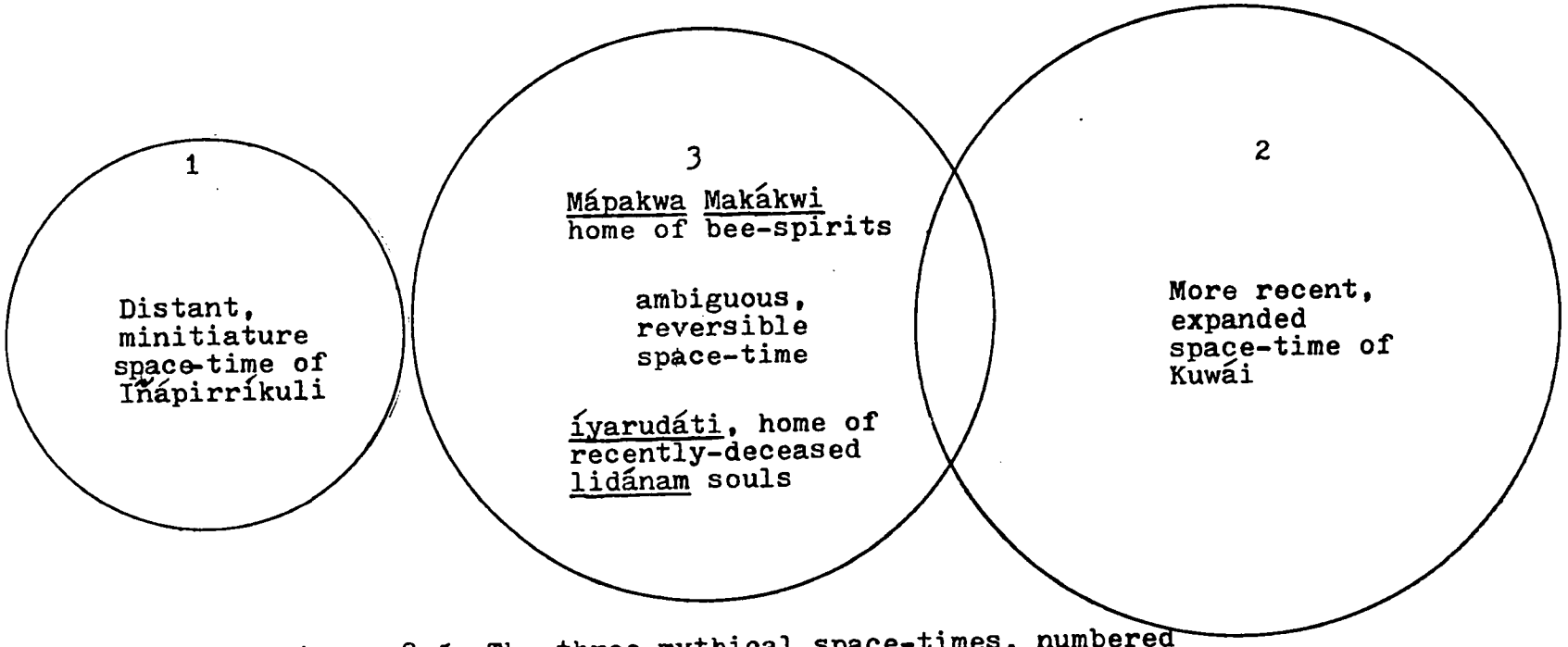


Figure 8.5. The three mythical space-times, numbered in 'chronological' order of Wakuénai cosmic history.

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The three mythical space-times represent three distinct moments in the unfolding of cosmogonic processes of creation. The distant past of Iñápirríkuli is a period of social animals before human individuals came to live in this world. The second mythical space-time is that of Kuwái and is the period of conception, birth, growth, development, and aging in this world. The third and final period is the reversible space-time of decay and decomposition which human individuals undergo as they leave (whether permanently or not) this world for the two worlds of the afterlife where the recently-deceased lidánam souls eventually reunite in paradise with the líwarúna soul in paradise.

The distant mythical past of Iñápirríkuli was a precultural space-time in which no distinction had yet been made between primordial oneness and cultural separateness. Iñápirríkuli, his kinsmen, and his affinal adversaries are pictured in myth as having animal bodies, and growth is seen as a process of transforming through a series of different animal species rather than a series of physiological processes and changes focused on a human body. Even death is seen as a transformation from one species of animal into another. The animals of the precultural past were social beings whose mythical behavior outlined many institutions that are important today among the Wakuénai: patrilocal residence, exogamy, brideservice, and a ranked order among fraternal ancestors. The social animals lived in a state of unceasing conflict between primordial kinsmen and affines. There was

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no end to the scheming and plotting of each side against the other. Iñápirríkuli was the most masterful "rational strategist" of them all, but the fact remained that no matter how ingeniously he defeated his enemies on any given occasion, he always had to develop new strategies to counteract the next conspiracy against him.

The social animals, and Iñápirríkuli in particular, provide insight into how the Wakuénai conceive of the interrelations between their society and nature. The myths view Wakuénai society as part of the precultural, natural environment. In this view, people are like animal species that constantly behave in an adaptive manner to protect their own interests at the expense of other species. Iñápirríkuli's clever behavior is the model for this natural, adaptive behavior. Like Iñápirríkuli, Wakuénai men and women are social animals who must make decisions about how to survive in their everyday lives: how to raise enough garden produce to feed themselves, how to catch fish, how to kill animals and birds in the forest, and how to share enough food with others so that their own needs are met in difficult times. By the same token, the myths portray everyday social relations of kinship and marriage as the result of conflicting interests between social animals. There is no love, either sexual or emotional, since the social animals are pre-sexual and pre-human creatures who can think only in terms of their survival and adaptation. The phratry, or ranked order of fraternal social animals, completes the picture of society as part of the

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natural order of survival and adaptation, since it represents political control by a number of consanguineally related groups over natural resources in a given territory and social opposition to a number of other, affinally-related phratries. The phratry itself is a sort of magnified social animal rather than a cultural group.

The birth of Kuwái introduces human physiological processes of conception and birth and all the ensuing processes of growth, development, and decay that form the basis of cultural differentiation in human society: male vs. female, parent and child, newborn infant and child, child and adolescent, adolescent and adult parent, the healthy and the sick, and the living and the dead. The transition from social, thinking animals to human individuals who can symbolize as well as think centers around the physiological processes of the human body.

> "The body and its processes are not a presymbolic order on which cultural systems were once grafted; it is itself called into being through representations that distinguish cultural from noncultural beings" (Drummond 1981: 646).

Amáru and Kuwái, the primordial mother and son, transform the undifferentiated social animals of the distant mythical past into human individuals who each have a unique personal and sexual identity, or likáriwa, the conscious, human-body soul. Each individual human being develops according to the

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biological processes which he or she embodies, but they are articulated into a system of cultural identity that replaces or overrides the precultural, social-animal identity. The Kuwái myth cycle spells out the transformation from precultural, social animals to sexually differentiated, growing human individuals whose unique personal identities form part of a shared cultural identity.

The bodily processes of growth and development take on enormous, cosmic proportions in the Kuwái myth cycle and are equated with the expansion of the entire natural, physical world to its present size. These physiological, or cosmic, processes must be controlled, or they will simply "eat up" the social animals (like Kuwái ate up three of Iñápirríkuli's young nephews in M4) instead of leading to an orderly, controlled system of processes in which the social animal is not destroyed but transformed into a fully cultural human individual (like Hérri, the younger brother of Iñápirríkuli and the first initiate).

> "It is the transition from one state to another that impels the mind to formulate symbols and thereby brings into being a conceptual order that did not exist previously" (Drummond 1981: 646).

Human bodily processes, and natural processes in general, actually leave no viable alternative but the transition from social thought to cultural differentiation, transformation, and coordination. The Kuwái myth cycle demonstrates this

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dilemma in very clear terms: either use human bodily processes as a way of 'taming' the social animal or be devoured by these same processes.

The control of bodily processes through symbolization requires an adequate means for conceptualizing and communicating processes of change, reordering, and transformation. The Kuwái myth cycle provides the Wakuénai with a double model for communicating these processes: the musical humming and singing of Kuwái and fire. These two associated models of symbolization combine to form musical cooking, an ongoing process of musically re-creating uncontrolled life processes, placing them into a conceptual order, and transforming them at puberty when potential sexual differences become actual processes allowing sexual reproduction. The power of musical cooking as a process of signification capable of communicating many kinds of processes is qualitatively different from everyday uses of language and fire and the ceremonial performance of music in pudáli, all of which had previously existed in the distant past of social animals.

The musical genre of mádzerunái, or dance-music of the pudáli ceremony, had originated before the birth of Kuwái, but its main effect had been to celebrate the success of man as a social animal in nature: the abundance of fish and manioc and social relations between affinally-related phratries. Fire had been taken from yáwari by the alligator and given to Iñápirríkuli so that he would not have to make fires each day by rubbing two sticks together. Fire and music

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did not in themselves bring about the transition from social animals to individual and collective identities. Likewise, the everyday language used by the social animals was primarily a means of furthering competition and conflict through its capacity for deception. After all, each phratry has its own dialect of everyday speech but remains a social group for defining the rule of exogamy and asserting territorial control rather than a cultural group made up of distinct human individuals. Musical cooking is qualitatively different from simple object-naming systems of everyday speech insofar as it combines language with the two highly processual concepts of fire and musical singing and humming. The ritual process of musical cooking puts into action the combined powers of musical singing and humming, fire, and language by equating these three energies with both the mythical expansion of the cosmos in the Kuwái myth cycle and the physiological growth and development of individual human beings at childbirth or puberty.

The processes of physiological growth, and natural processes in general, challenge the thinking social animal to symbolize and control or else succumb to perpetual conflict and disorder. In this respect, processes are not like objects, since they always have a temporal dimension whereas objects can be thought about as if they existed outside time. Fire is understandably an appropriate symbol of process, since it consumes objects, is always in motion, and has no real substance of its own apart from the object of its con-

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sumption. Music is also processual and in constant motion. In fact, Stravinsky has argued in The Poetics of Music (1945: 35-ff) that music is essentially about the way peole conceptually organize time. Wakuénai songs and chants in childbirth and initiation rituals incorporate the concept of human control over fire into the larger concept of human control over biological processes of birth, growth, and development. By harnessing the process of burning in their everyday lives, men and women transform raw meat and plant matter into cooked foods. By incorporating this cooking process into musical performances in ritual contexts, the Wakuénai take control over physiological processes of human sexual reproduction, growth, and development by making them a means for differentiating individuals into cultural categories that are systematically interrelated at higher levels of meaning.

The third mythical space-time is a period of reversible processes of decomposition which individual humans undergo in sickness. Insofar as sickness and ritual curing both begin with movements backwards from the more recent space-time of the Kuwái myth cycle toward the distant mythical past of Iñápirríkuli, they operate in a third space-time that presumes the prior existence of the other two space-times. In curing rituals, the owner of málikai and the shaman (malírri) embark on musical journeys into the reversible space-time of the Kuwáiñai and the recently-deceased lidánam souls. I have called such musical journeying "musical rotting" since it relives the fate of the two parts of the soul in sickness and

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death as a process of separation or alienation between the two parts of the soul. This process of separation is a natural process of decay. Although both genres of curing songs begin by reliving the process of rotting or breaking apart of the individual and collective identities of the sick person, they both end by turning around the direction of the patient's decomposition and establishing a symbolic space-time in which the physiological processes of recovery become intelligible not only to the patient but also to his kinsmen and the larger group of people observing the curing ritual.

The two genres of curing music make sense out of the reciprocal physiological processes of sickness and recovery by using them as the means for building a reversible bridge across what is otherwise an irreversible process of rotting and alienation that ultimately leads to death and a complete separation of the individual and collective identities. In málikai curing songs, a reversible bridge is built out of the actions of blowing tobacco smoke and symbolically producing honey out of flowers as a way of entering into direct contact with the spiritual owners of honey production, the Kuwáiñai. As mentioned earlier, honey production is a metaphor for purification, a process that is beyond rotting. Contact with the bee-spirits in málikai curing songs is an attempt to reverse the physiological processes of sickness and decay. The reversal is communicated in song as a change in the posture of Kuwáikanérri, the mythical victim of witchcraft, from travelling while lying down in a canoe to travelling

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while sitting up and, finally, a return to walking.

The curing songs and other ritual activities of the shaman set up a reversible bridge out of the physiological processes of sucking and vomitting. In this case, the reversal of physiological processes is much more visible, since the aim is to reverse what is believed to be a highly conscious process of eating food that had been poisoned rather than the destruction of a sleeping victim's unconscious líwarúna soul. The shaman's sucking of spirits from the air and of the physical disease-causing agent from the patient's body leads to vomitting, a reversal of the otherwise irreversible process through which the eating of poisoned food is transformed into bodily rotting. The shaman's use of vomitting reinforces the symbolic associations between shamanistic curing and the mythical character of Kuwái at the time of the first initiation ritual. In myth, Kuwái is said to have vomitted up the remains of the three boys who had prematurely broken their ritual fast. After vomitting the boys' remains, Kuwái ate his own vomit. This mythical action associates Kuwái and shamanistic curing with the natural actions of anaconda snakes. When disturbed, these snakes regurgitate prey which they have recently eaten and return to eat the partially digested food when no longer distracted. Drummond has pointed out the importance of the re-eating habits of anacondas for understanding these snakes' utility as mythical symbols that convey a sense of a precultural order in which the "food->feces" process was not

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yet irreversible.

> "They [anacondas] return to their vomit, a rottenness which defies identification with food and therefore defines food as a category of symbolic thought" (1981: 645).

Kuwái's mythical eating, vomitting, and re-eating of the three boys who had broken their ritual fast defines the physiological process of eating, not food itself, as a category of symbolic thought. Kuwái's vomitting and re-eating is opposed to the ability of Hérri, the first initiant, to overcome the biological need to eat. The former results from an inability to withstand hunger, the latter from control over hunger. Yet precisely the failure to withstand hunger and the return to a precultural order in which digestive processes were reversible is the model for shamanistic curing techniques of swallowing, vomitting, and reswallowing the disease-causing agent and the spirit of sickness (<u>wáramápwa</u>). The shaman's musical journeying to <u>íyarudáti</u>, "the place where the sun goes down", relives the return to a precultural order in which the transformation of "eating poisoned food" to "bodily rotting" was reversible.

The coherence of Wakuénai sacred musical performances as a system for elaborating and applying hierarchically structured meaning arises from its consistent use of human bodily processes as a means for ordering, reordering, and restoring the interrelations between individual and collective identities. The musical cooking of the spirits of

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animals, birds, fish, plants, and other objects in málikai chants for childbirth and initiation is generated by the more fundamental process of `cooking' (or classifying) the cultural identities, both individual and collective, of newborn infants and initiants. The Kuwái myth cycle bridges the gap between human bodily processes and the spirit-naming of natural species and objects by equating the character of Kuwái with all natural species and objects and the musical humming and singing of Kuwái with the expansion of the entire physical world. In other words, Levi-Strauss is only partially right when he says that the infra-culinary and meta-culinary mythological systems are a "science of the concrete" based on opposing categories of the raw and the cooked, the fresh and the rotten, and tobacco and honey. The Wakuénai do have a science of the concrete in which these categories serve as a means for elaborating abstract ideas and combining them in the form of propositions. However, these categories are themselves generated by the symbolization of human physiological processes in a musical performance system.

> ". . . it seems inconceivable that a formative intelligence would proceed with the classification of animal and plant species without first directing its symbolizing abilities toward its own bodily processes" (Drummond 1981: 646).

Drummond's criticism of "the structuralist failure in desexualizing and demoralizing myth" (1981: 644) is basically accurate and fair, but he overlooks Levi-Strauss's attempt to

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connect empirical processes of cooking with physiological processes of childbirth and puberty in "The Wedding", the concluding chapter of The Raw and the Cooked (1969: 335-ff). In fairness to Levi-Strauss, he did suggest the 'social meaning' of culinary symbolism in mythology even though he lacked the ethnographic materials with which to fully develop this other, more processual order of meaning.

The ultimate challenge to a performative system of symbolization that is generated by human physiological processes is the dichotomy between life and death: the human individual disappears from this world after death even as the collective identity continues to reproduce itself in the form of living, growing descendants. In the end, death overrides any contradictions between the life processes of orderly growth and development and the breakdown of these processes in illnesses brought on by sorcery and/or witchcraft. Thus, the opposed processes of cooking and rotting converge at a higher level of meaning that lies beyond cooking and rotting. Ritual blowing of tobacco smoke and metaphorical honey production are the symbolic means for communicating the convergence of opposite life processes at a higher level. The male and female tobacco spirits given to each totemic ancestor in the distant past presage the cultural differentiation of sexual identities in the Kuwái myth cycle. In rituals, the invocation of tobacco spirits in music and blowing of tobacco smoke in between songs and chants are symbolic activities that define the collective identity of

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human individuals as a cultural being that transcends the gap between life and death rather than a social animal in which life and death are essentially identical. The symbolization of human bodily processes operates in the mythical space-time of the Kuwái myth cycle and in reversible space-time but not in the distant, precultural past of Iñápirríkuli. Ultimately, the symbolization of processes involving the tobacco spirits are a transposition of human bodily processes that reaches back to the emergence of social-animal ancestors in the precultural past but that also operates at every stage of the life processes in the two later mythical space-times.

Wakuénai Ancestor Cults and Local Leadership

Wakuénai sib groups are culturally defined collective identities that are better understood as local ancestor cults built upon musical and other ritual processes of symbolization than as social or political groups based on received traditions of power and authority. Each childbirth and initiation in the village evokes a corresponding set of ritual processes of cultural differentiation and transformation. These processes of symbolization aim at controlling and making intelligible the physiological changes experienced by individual members of the local ancestor cult by making these life processes the basis of cultural identity. Even death, a process of 'total' rotting that leads to the permanent loss of individual members of the collective identity, is transformed into a process of symbolization that asserts the perpetuation of the sib group through the power of male and

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female tobacco spirits.

The individuals who make the greatest contribution to the perpetuation of the sib identity and to the formation and preservation of individual identities within the sib are the two types of ritual specialists known as málikai-owners and shamans (malírri). Although both types of specialist play indispensible roles in the cultural life of the sib and its members, the málikai-owner has control over a greater range of symbolic processes than the shaman insofar as he controls the means for bringing new individuals into the cultural order of the group as well as the means for going back to retrieve lost souls of individuals who are slipping back to the precultural, mythical past of social animals. The shaman, however, can not bring new cultural order out of natural disorder but controls only the power to restore order to disordered life processes. The greater powers of the málikai-owner are embodied in his use of tobacco and honey as symbols for communicating the transition from nature to culture and back again. Although shamans, too, use tobacco, they are primarily associated with the use of hallucinogenic dzáato snuff and the activities of sucking and vomitting. Perhaps the best way to characterize the differential ritual powers of málikai-owners and shamans is in terms of the greater range of powers wielded by málikai-owners and the more restricted usage of these sacred powers by shamans. The málikai-owner controls both formative and restorative processes, whereas the shaman has only the latter.

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In Wakuénai villages such as Gavilán on the lower Guainía River where both types of specialist sill actively practice traditional rituals, the málikai-owner is regarded as a leader who coordinates decision-making and collective activities in extra-ritual contexts. The collective identity of the village converges in the person of the headman, Hernando Camico, and to a lesser extent in his older brother, Hervilio, the resident shaman. Hernando's leadership in the village is based on a widespread social recognition that he is a `good man' (matsiá átsia) who applies his skill and wisdom as a málikai-owner in ways that protect and benefit everyone else in the village as well as many outsiders. His knowledge of traditional Wakuénai myths, ceremonies, and social customs is unsurpassed by anyone else in the region. In fact, he is a sort of generalist who delights in acquiring new knowledge and skills even as he approaches the ripe age of great-grandfatherhood. In speaking about his childhood, he contrasts his own intellectual curiosity with that of his older brothers. He learned to perform málikai from his father and málirríkairi from one of his paternal uncles, whereas his oldest brother learned neither specialty and his older brother, Hervilio, learned only málirríkairi. Hernando also studied divination from a Hohódeni father-in-law and acquired a superior talent for constructing and playing the various flutes, trumpets, and percussive instruments of the mádzerunái genre.

Hernando's social influence in his village is largely a

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function of his superior intellect, a phenomenon that falsifies sweeping generalizations to the effect that "myths have social power in inverse ratio to the amount of intellectual curiosity present in a society" (Fontenrose 1966: 57). If this were the case, then there would be little or no justification for the entire system of Wakuénai sacred musical performances and the mythological systems which it puts in action. In actual fact, there is a great deal of intellectual curiosity in Wakuénai society, and this cultural attitude directly correlates with the social power of myths as embodied in village leaders. I worked for several months on a daily basis with one such leader and came to see him as a man whose social influence rests upon an ability to explain and interpret his own cultural beliefs and practices in relation to immediate situations with the same facility as a professor of music discoursing on elementary harmony and its influence on 20th Century music.

Hernando's leadership in ritual activities confers sacred meanings on his everyday subsistence and social behavior. However, this transfer of sacred meaning into extra-ritual contexts does not automatically result from the superior intellectual wisdom of the old headman as a ritual specialist but comes about through his role as a model for behavior in his everyday activities. In spite of his age and somewhat declining physical prowess (he has only one broken tooth left in his mouth and what is probably a hernia in his abdomen), Hernando is physically muscular and energetic. When

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he organizes a group of sons and sons-in-law to cut down forest for a new manioc garden, he works with the other men in the tiresome labor of clearing underbrush and felling large trees. When he decided to re-thatch the leaky roof of his house, he coordinated a group of men and actually carried out more than the average amount of climbing, lifting, lashing, and other strenuous tasks[5]. Similarly, he led the men of the village in cutting down the tall weeds and grasses surrounding the village plaza at the end of the wet season. Many of these collective work parties had aesthetic as well as practical motives. Hernando announced that he was ashamed that the villagers could not gather for communal meals in his house on rainy evenings without getting dripped upon, and soon everyone was busy thatching the roof of his house. Similarly, he was ashamed by the unkempt appearance of the village when the weeds were tall, and the other men joined him in cutting them down. Thus, the headman carries over his ritual concern for sacred order through active participation in practical activities and by giving these activities an aesthetic interpretation. His participation transforms mere practical activities such as working and eating into categories of symbolic thought that fit into the overall cultural identity of the village by conferring upon them an aesthetic meaning. Communal meals, for example, are shared in Hernando's house once or twice a day and are more than a survival mechanism of sharing food among different households in the village. They are an expression of cultural etiquette

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and 'table' manners that contribute to the cultural identities, both individual and collective, of men and women in the village[6].

Conclusions and Hypotheses

I do not wish to convey the impression that Gavilán is either typical of Wakuénai villages along the lower Guainía today or in any sense insulated from the effects of missionaries (both Catholic and Protestant), development programs, and other social changes. In other places, I have dealt with some of the latter influences as they have affected the Wakuénai and other indigenous peoples of the lower Guainía and Upper Rio Negro in Venezuela (see Moran and Hill, in review; Hill and Moran, in press). Nevertheless, Gavilán is remarakable for the degree to which traditional culture still flourishes and is thus worthy of study as representative of a type of socio-religious system that is rapidly disappearing and that perhaps prevailed thoughout the entire Rio Negro basin from Manaus to the headwaters of the Guainía River in pre-Columbian times. In commenting on a very abbreviated version of the Kuwái (Jurupari) myth cycle, Levi-Strauss draws a distinction between the complexity of Jurupari myths as a genre and the relatively homogeneous "popular tales" upon which he bases his analysis in From Honey to Ashes (1973). He goes on to speculate about the social meaning of the more complex mythical traditions of the Northwest Amazon region:

". . . the existence of oral traditions whose

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> extreme complexity, artificial composition and mystical tone suggest that they must be attributed to schools of sages and learned men, argues in favor of a much higher level of religious, social, and political organization than anything that has been observed since" (1973: 272).

Levi-Strauss mentions special methods including philology and archeology as a necessary beginning for an analysis of the more complex Jurupari myths as "the remains of a genuine civilization common to the whole of the Amazon basin" (1973: 272). Wright's dissertation (1981) on`Baniwa' history and religion is an outstanding contribution toward an understanding of prehistoric Amazonian civilizations because it fills in much of the large gap between pre-Conquest times and the present and offers the most complete version of the Jurupari (Kuwái) myth cycle in the ethnographic literature. My analysis of Wakuénai ancestor cults is also an attempt to contribute to an appreciation of the little-known Amazonian civilizations of the past through the special methods of ethnomusicology and processual structuralism. The central conclusions of the approach are that the Wakuénai have an hierarchical system of meaning, or `science of the concrete', based on oppositions between the raw and the cooked, the fresh and the rotten, and tobacco and honey, and that this system of meaning is generated by symbolization of human physiological processes in a musical performance system.

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The degree to which these same conclusions might also have applied to other indigenous, Arawak-speaking groups in prehistoric times is not known but could be tested through use of similar fieldwork and analytical methods in other parts of the Amazon basin. As a hypothesis, I suggest that Wakuénai ancestor cults once formed part of a larger system of northern Arawakan cultural identities that extended along the entire length of the Rio Negro and parts of the Upper Amazon. The hypothesis arises from two classes of consideration: 1) the distribution of northern Arawakan languages along the Negro and Upper Amazon rivers in prehistoric times and 2) the regional importance of the Kuwái myth cycle and related rituals among Arawak-speaking groups of the lower Guainía today in spite of linguistic differences and cultural variations among these groups.

The distribution of the northern branch of Arawakan languages in prehistoric times is illustrated in a map on the following page taken from a recent study pulling together linguistic and archeological evidence (Key 1979: 74-75). Since I am not an expert in either of these two disciplines, I restrict myself to a few general comments. First, the map shows a continuous stretch of land approximately 1400 km in length and 300 km in width that was once occupied by Northern Arawak-speaking peoples from the Manao in the southeast to the Achagua in the northwest. Assuming that the map is accurate in its broad outlines, the Wakuénai (shown individually as Ádzanéni, Hohódeni, "Rio Icana Baniwa", etc.) groups of

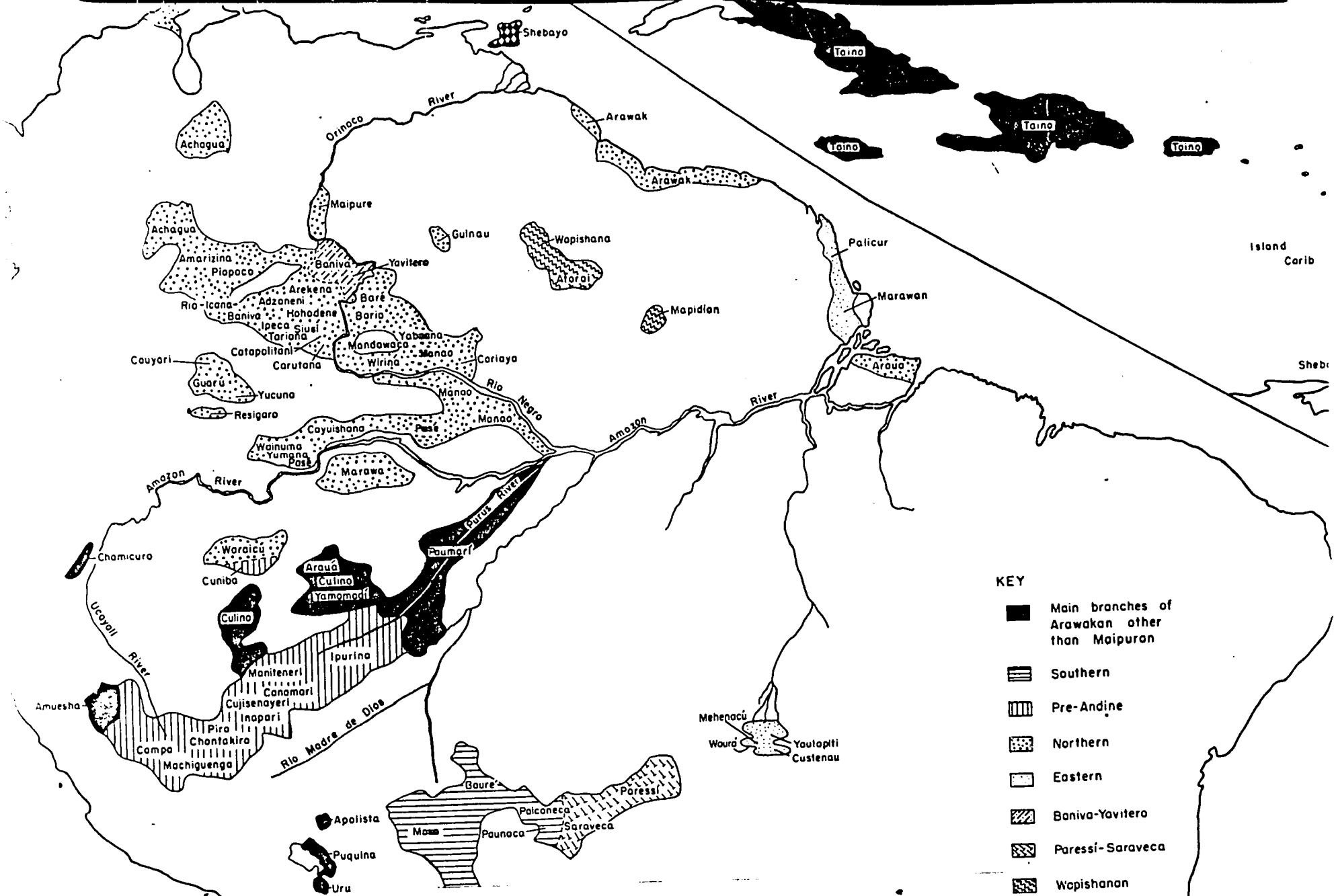
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– – – Approximate area covered by *mâlikai* initiation chants as performed in Gavilán, lower Guainía river, Venezuela.

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MAP 8.1. The geographical distribution of Arawakan languages (from Key 1979:74)

the Isana and Guainía rivers were not in a marginal, isolated region in the prehistoric era as they seemingly are today due to the imposition of two international boundaries. Instead, the Wakuénai occupied a central territory at the crossroads between the Manao and other groups downstream and the Piapoco, Achagua, Maipure, and other groups to the north and west. Looked at on this larger, geographical scale, the Wakuénai belief that their native lands, and in particular Hípana of the Aiarí River, are the center of the world makes more sense.

The journey of Amáru in málikai chants for initiation closely replicates the distribution of Northern Arawak-speaking peoples along the Rio Negro up to the headwaters of the Isana, Guainía, and Guaviare rivers. Beginning at Hípana, the "center of the world", the initiation chants descend the Aiarí and Isana rivers to the confluence of the Vaupés and Negro rivers. From there, the chants ascend the Vaupés (or Cayarí, Yeral), descend the Vaupés to the Negro, and descend the Negro to an undetermined point beyond Manaus. After that, the chants go back up the Rio Negro to the lower Guainía, jump over to the Casiquiare, and then head downstream along the Atabapo and Orinoco rivers to the north. Before returning to the center of the world, the chants name places along the Guaviare up to its headwaters, back downstream along the Inirida, and then return to Wakuénai territory on the Guainía, Cuyari, Isana, and Aiarí rivers. A second map tracing these movements in initiation chants can be overlaid onto the map

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of language-group distributions to show the close degree of correspondence between the two areas.

On a still larger scale, the Northern Arawak-speaking groups form only one branch of a two-pronged 'wedege' of Arawakan cultures that fans out along the major northern and southern tributaries of the Upper Amazon. Without wishing to underestimate the linguistic and cultural diversity in this extensive area of the Upper Amazon basin, I would suggest that they had more in common than simply a 'Proto-Arawakan', ancestral language. There might well have been ecological similarities, such as the combined emphasis on fishing and agriculture[7], or perhaps parallel cultural beliefs about the importance of sacred musical performances in the transition from a precultural, ancestral past to the cultural differentiation of the present era (see Chapter 4). However, there must also have been considerable differences between Northern and Southern Arawak-speaking groups due to contacts with different Andean civilizations. Amuesha social and religious organization, for example, shows evidence of a long history of contact with the Inca Empire and earlier states of the Central Andes (Smith 1977). The Wakuénai, on the other hand, might have undergone a less direct cultural change in prehistoric times through participation in salt trade with the Chibcha of the Northern Andes. Salt is characterized in málikai chants for childbirth as an ancient anaconda spirit (umáwari hwarrúi, the anaconda's teeth) and not a member of the Amáru category of spirits reserved for new objects such

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as steel tools and epidemic diseases brought by Western Europeans and their descendants[8].

Another class of considerations implying that Wakuénai ancestor cults were part of a larger system of Northern Arawakan cultural identities is the regional importance of the Kuwái myth cycle and accompanying rituals among diverse Arawak-speaking groups of the lower Guainía today. Most of these groups are losing their traditional languages and have ceased to practice their traditional rituals over the past few decades, but the myth of Kuwái lives on among them in an abbreviated form (see Gonzalez 1980: 148-ff). Guarequena, Baniwa, and Bare are the three Arawak-speaking groups of the region among whom language and ritual practices are most rapidly disappearing. Other Arawak-speaking groups of the region, such as Yavitero and Mandawaca (or Baria), exist only in the memories of a few elderly persons of the region or in history books. When Matos Arvelo wrote about these groups in the early part of this century, they all had practicing ritual specialists known in Spanish as soplador ('blower') and chupador ('sucker'). To the best of my knowledge, the Guarequena are the only group other than Wakuénai among whom there is still an individual regarded as chupador, but they no longer recognize anyone as a soplador. The man referred to as a chupador among the Guarequena does not really practice his craft any longer, probably because it has lost its traditional significance in the absence of his counterpart, the soplador. Gonzalez claims to have met only one man among the

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Baniwa who received the name Mariri (chupador, or shaman). In any case, it is unlikely that this man is still actively practicing ritual cures along the lower Guainía today, since I never once heard of him.

The handful of Wakuénai villages that have resisted the acute social pressures from Evangelical missionaries and their converts to abandon traditional myths and rituals are the last remaining stronghold of ritual specialists, at least in Venezuela. Guarequena and Baniwa of the lower Guainía are frequent visitors to the Wakuénai of Gavilán, partly for practical reasons such as agricultural and fishing resources shared by all three groups, but also for ritual and ceremonial reasons. The curing powers of Hernando and his brother are the most frequent ritual service sought out by neighboring Guarequena and Baniwa people. They also come to have their newborn children ritually treated and to participate in ceremonial dances from the traditional pudáli. I will take a more forward-looking view of these interethnic, intra-Arawakan developments in a later chapter. Here I am looking at these same phenomena as a possible clue to the historical past among these Arawakan peoples.

Guarequena, Baniwa, and Wakuénai of the lower Guainía today share a common, traditional social and religious organization. All three groups are descendants of what Levi-Strauss has called "a genuine Amazonian civilization" (1973: 272) in which learned men (sopladores and chupadores) acted as both secular and ritual leaders of local ancestor cults.

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These cults were loosely integrated into larger social groups taking the form either of phratric alliances like the dialect-groups of the Wakuénai or of language-groups like the Guarequena and Baniwa. In spite of local variations, Wakuénai, Baniwa, and Guarequena ancestor cults all shared a complex oral tradition based on the transition from a precultural, inchoate past dominated by the trickster-hero, Iñápirríkuli (or Nápiríli in Baniwa and Guarequena), to a more recent, culturally differentiated mythical past of Kuwái (Kúwe in Guarequena; Kuwái in Piapoco; Kátsimánali in Baniwa; Y(J)urupari in lingua geral). Ritual leaders communicated this transition to non-specialists in sacred musical performances and other ritual activities, and they carried this sense of cultural order into their secular lives as model individuals who were in no way exempt from the practical concerns of everyday social and subsistence activities. This pattern of social and religious organization characterized Northern Arawak-speaking groups of the Upper Rio Negro basin in the prehistoric era and might also have prevailed among other Northern Arawakan groups extending from the lower Rio Negro/Upper Amazon region all the way to the headwaters of the Guaviare River to the northwest.

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1. I would distinguish between meta-symbolism and meta-language in the following way: meta-symbolism in musical performances is carried purely through endo-semantic interrelations among the sets of processes making up tonal, rhythmical, and other accoustical dimensions. Meta-language, however, operates with words that have a semantic reference to actual processes outside the specific context of the performance in addition to an implicit, unspoken meaning that goes beyond the overt semantic reference. Musical cooking, for example, refers to an actual process of cooking but also has the implicit meaning of classifying or transforming human, cultural identities. Meta-symbolism in music is analytically separable but is not in practice distinguishable from meta-language in song or chant texts.

2. Levi-Strauss mentions some interesting ethnographic examples of symbolic 'cooking' in other parts of the world. Among those he lists are Southeast Asian customs of placing women who have just given birth on a raised bed or grill over a slow fire and "the habit of various Californian tribes to put women who had just given birth and pubescent girls into ovens, hollowed out in the ground. . . . they were conscientiously "cooked"; the Yurok, incidentally, used the same expression "cooking the pains" to refer to all curative rites" (Levi-Strauss 1969: 335). Here, Levi-Strauss is really

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only one step away from the discovery that symbolic "cooking" of women and pubescent girls is a musical performance process.

3. The shaman's songs (málirríkairi) which I recorded among the Dzáwinai of Gavilán were all sung solo by a single shaman, but they all have an echoing technique that elicits a sense of call and response, or antiphony, between two separate voices. Wright (personal communication) has recorded Hohódeni shamans who work in pairs or even threesomes with one lead singer and one or two shamans singing a response.

4. Although I never actually witnessed this practice, informants in both the Adzanéni village of Punta Bella and the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán assured me that it was widely employed against the 1979-80 measles epidemic that took many lives in the region and would have taken many more were it not for medical assistance and economic aide from the Venezuelan government. The Curripaco-speaking headman of Punta Bella described the practice to me when we saw an éenui beehive while walking through the forest. In Gavilán, Hernando explained the practice to me in nearly identical terms after narrating the story of Kuwáikanérri, the basis of málikai curing songs.

5. Goldman (1963) gave the first detailed account of village headmanship in the Northwest Amazon region and

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stressed the consensual character of leadership in Cubeo villages. The headman coordinates the activities of others while working along side them in collective projects such as house construction. If the men have pressing reasons to be elsewhere or if they simply do not feel like working, the headman is quick to sense the need to temporarily disband the group. In short, headmen are not superordinate in terms of any clear-cut rank and privileges and are sensitive to the attitudes of their co-workers.

6. It is worth contrasting communal meals in Gavilán with the Cena Santa held by evangelical Wakuénai on the first Sunday of each month. If the former expresses cultural etiquette and identity, the latter evidences cultural breakdown and social disharmony. The leaders, or indigenous pastors, who officiate at the Evangelical meals were formerly powerful málikai-owners and shamans of the highest-ranking Dzáwinai sib. Stripped of their tobacco, their sacred songs, and the other means for constructing a moral, cultural order, these old men have become terrifying witches who use the Bible as a weapon against anyone who opposes their will. Their sons and grandchildren are widely regarded as thieves and sorcerers among both Evangelical and traditional Wakuénai. I documented cases of people who were threatened with death over the traditional kin vs. af-

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fine dispute and who permanently fled the region to escape the Evangelicals' curse. I also had my flashlight stolen on a visit to an Evangelical village, whereas among the more traditional Wakuénai I never witnessed or experienced a single act of theft during my fieldwork. One of the most common stories of the mala fama of the Evangelical priests and their sons is about their use of poison (mahnéti) to eliminate their enemies during the Cena Santa. The priests order everyone to close their eyes to say a prayer prior to eating a communal meal of fish and manioc bread. Their sons take advantage of the moment to cast poison into the food of selected enemies.

7. The northern and southern branches of Arawak-speaking peoples corresponds very closely to the area of varzea, or low-lying floodplain, that is somewhat better for agriculture and probably fishing as well. Lathrap's book on the Upper Amazon (1970) makes a clear distinction between this vast, wedge-shaped tract of varzea and the upland forests of the areas outside the wedge. He hypothesizes that a migratory wave of Northern Arawak-speakers expanded up the Rio Negro in search of agricultural lands.

8. The use of Amáru-class spirits will be further discussed in terms of its implications for Wakuénai conceptions of culture change in Chapter 10. I believe

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that the use of Amáru spirits in málikai chants and songs points to a rather different conclusion than the one Kaplan reaches in her review article (1981) of four new books on Amazonian anthropology. While I agree that "in general. . . for the Amerindians of South America social time is not genealogical time", I do not accept her deduction that "time depth is a notion the Amerindians tend to avoid and even war against as a principle dangerous to their own social existence" (Kaplan 1981: 157). The Amáru category of spirits is used to classify more recent phenomena that have reached the Wauenai in historical times and is set in meaningful contrast to the distant, mythical past. Thus, time depth is an important mythical concept for the Wakuénai and not at all a notion "to avoid or war against". Wright's study (1981) of oral histories among the Hohódeni confirm that the Wakuénai have a definite and, for a nonliterate people, relatively sophisticated sense of historical time. The category of Amáru spirits provides a means for distinguishing between historical and mythical time as well as for articulating these two concepts of time. Both processes are highly important in a society that defines itself in terms of the interrelations between deceased ancestors and their living descendants.

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Chapter 9:

"Wakuénai Ceremonial Music: Metamorphosis of the Ceje-Palm Grub (Mútsi)"

Introduction

The Wakuénai draw a sharp distinction between the two musical genres known as mádzerunái and líaka, or dance-music of the pudáli and kwépani ceremonies, respectively. The mádzerunái genre includes kúlirína (raiao catfish) trumpet-dances discussed in Chapter 3 and also a wide range of instrumental and vocal performances that were formerly important in ceremonial exchanges of smoked fish and manioc products. Among the Wakuénai of the lower Guainía today, yapurútu (máwi) flutes, dance stomping tubes (wáana), and whistle-flutes (píti and maváku) are still important in some villages, primarily as a source of secular entertainment but also as symbols of cultural identity.

The current status of kwépani ceremonies and performances of the líaka genre along the lower Guainía is more difficult for me to estimate, since bureaucratic problems prevented me from observing a kwépani ceremony held in Gavilán in 1981. Nevertheless, the village headman sang the most important songs and flute melodies for me and explained in detail the ceremonial exchanges of wild fruits and manioc products that used to take place in kwépani ceremonies. Unlike yapurútu flutes and other instruments of the mádzerunái

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genre, the animal flutes of Kuwái played in kwépani cannot be used in secular contexts but only in kewpani or during male and female initiation rituals. The two genres, mádzerunái and líaka, are on opposite sides of a conceptual boundary that cannot be violated with impunity unless ritual precautions are taken ahead of time. To play yapurútu flutes on the night of a male initiation or kwépani would be to invite witchcraft, sickness, and death into the village. However, if there were a strong public desire to dance with yapurútu flutes during the day, after tha animal flutes of Kuwái had been safely hidden from view, a málikai-owner could chant and blow tobacco smoke over the yapurútu flutes or other mádzerunái instruments to allow their use. The opposition between mádzerunái and líaka is thus both strongly accentuated by a belief that the two have to be kept separate and yet possibly resolved through ritual chanting and observing the rule that one genre be performed only in daylight and the other only at night.

I will focus in this chapter on the contrast, or opposition, between the two genres of Wakuénai ceremonial music as a way of leading up to a more general perspective on how the two genres contribute to the construction and maintenance of a collective identity system based on ceremonial exchanges among a number of local sib groups. For the traditional contexts of both genres, I have to rely on verbal descriptions of traditional ceremonies narrated by older informants in the two villages where I spent most of my time in the field. My

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recordings of mádzerunái performances add up to a sample that is more than sufficient to gain an understanding of how this musical genre fits into and enlarges upon the conceptual framework which ritual specialists elaborate and apply in sacred musical performances. A thorough and complete musicological transcription, analysis, and classification of these recordings is beyond the scope of the present thesis. Instead, I will select specific performances and general features of musical organization that most clearly illustrate the place of mádzerunái in the overall musical performance system of the Wakuénai and in their comsic history. As for the far more limited set of recordings which I have for the líaka genre, I have to deal more in terms of the opposite question of whether or not they constitute a sufficiently broad range of performances to be considered representative of the genre as a whole. The question will in all likelihood remain partially unresolved until such time as I (or another researcher) can return to study the líaka genre in the field.

Pudáli: Ceremonial Exchange in the Natural, Social Order

Pudáli ceremonies were in many ways closely linked with subsistence activities of the yearly agricultural and fishing cycles and with everyday social institutions of kinship and marriage. Seen in this perspective, pudáli and the musical performances of the mádzerunái genre were an expression of the successful synchronization of the timing of human social and ecological activities with the mythical calendar of Káali and his children (Káaliéni), the mythical originators of

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máuzerunái. Basically, pudáli ceremonies were held in two-part cycles between local sib groups of different phratries who were either actually or potentially related to one another as kinsmen to affines.

The wife-giving group initiated a pudáli cycle by offering a large quantity of smoked fish to the wife-taking group in the month of the Pleiades (Waríperí) after the spawning runs of bocachico and other fish species. In these opening pudáli ceremonies, the guest men and women danced around the displayed offering of smoked fish with kúlirína (raiao catfish) trumpets and other instruments of the same genre. The owner of the ceremony (pudalímnali) was considered to be the male guest who formally offered the pile of fish to his "sister" (liwédua), the wife of the hosts' headman (pantímnali, or house-owner). This woman in turn fell under an obligation to return a ceremonial offering of grated, squeezed manioc pulp to her brothers at a closing pudáli ceremony several weeks later. Instead of kúlirína trumpets, the guests arrived at closing ceremonies with dance stomping tubes (wáana) with which they accompanied a series of several songs lasting the entire night. The owner of the first pudáli left visual signs of the woman's duty to act as a pudalímnaru (female owner of pudáli) in the form of his phratric emblem and corresponding manioc grater design painted in red upon the kúlirína trumpets, the only ceremonial instruments given to the hosts at the end of the first pudáli.

The pudáli exchanges celebrated the short-lived supera-

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bundance of fish at the beginning of the long April-July rainy season and also the importance of social customs that regulated marriage (prior to missionary intervention). The custom of brideservice and social respect between affinally-related groups of kinsmen were both given clear expression in the symbolic distancing of hosts and guest in the early stages of pudáli ceremonies. In both male- and female-owned ceremonies, the social respect between affinally-related kin groups was acted out in the opening dances as an opposition between guests who performed outside on the village plaza and hosts who stayed inside until the time for formal speeches of offering and accepting the food. The guests were forbidden to dance with the hosts and vice-versa until after these formal speeches, and the former were banned from entering the hosts' house until or unless they were openly invited by the house-owners (pantímnali and pantímnaru). After the formal speeches, the hosts' headman carried all the smoked fish or grated manioc pulp inside his house and stowed it in the roof beams overhead. The hosts then allowed each family among the guests to enter their house one at a time for a round of fermented fruit and manioc drinks. After all guest families had received drinks from the hosts, the hosts came outside and mingled with the guests on the village plaza. At sunrise, after a night of dancing and drinking, the host headman redistributed the gift of food in equal portions among all families in attendance for a day of feasting and sleeping. Host men were then allowed to dance with guest women and

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vice-versa. Depending on the size of the guests' offering, a pudáli ceremony could last for up to four consecutive nights.

The symbolic distancing between hosts and guests in the early stages of pudáli was a ceremonial expression of social respect between affinally-related, wife-giver and wife-taker groups. The guests' ceremonial offering of meat or manioc to the hosts was a gradual, controlled process of interaction that eventually led to a relaxation of the opposition between hosts and guests. Pudáli exchanges were parallel to the social custom of brideservice, a period of temporary uxorilocal residence in which young men had to demonstrate their skills as providers of food and their attitude of respect as social outsiders. Both pudáli ceremonies and the traditional custom of brideservice expressed Wakuénai views that a successful alliance between affinally-related groups of kinsmen could only be attained through recognition of the social distance between the two groups and a gradual, controlled process of giving and taking[1].

The two-part ceremonial cycle of pudáli was grounded in the custom of brideservice as a social mechanism for creating and maintaining affinal alliances. In male-owned, opening pudáli ceremonies, the wife-givers symbolically acted out their social position by giving smoked fish to their hosts. In return, the wife-givers were compensated in a female-owned, closing pudáli with gifts of processed manioc pulp. The ceremonial cycle expressed the social exchange of women in terms of symbolic categories of food. Giving smoked fish

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was a symbolic enactment of giving up women as childbearers upon whom the continuation of social groups was greatly dependent. Returning processed manioc was a symbolic enactment of the social duty to return in the form of women's economic productivity what had been taken away (i.e., women's sexual reproductivity). The major difference between brideservice as a social mechanism for control over woman-exchange and pudáli as a ceremonial exchange of food was that the former focused solely upon male wife-givers and takers (the FZH/ WBS rivalry), whereas the latter was a balanced exchange between male and female 'owners'.

The pudáli ceremonial cycle was more than a mere reflection of natural and social processes with which it was coordinated. The balancing of male and female ownership in pudáli cycles reconstructed the precultural order of the distant mythical past in which the male versus female dichotomy had not yet emerged except in the latent form of male and female tobacco spirits, the sexual prototypes of the later Kuwái myth cycle. Pudáli was a celebration of the success of the Wakuénai people, regardless of their sex, as social animals whose activities formed part of a social order in nature. Pudáli established a symbolic space-time in which the distinction between social groups and natural species was temporarily collapsed. The dance-music of pudáli expressed a harmonious synchronization of natural and social timing, a return to the precultural, presexual mythical time of Iñápirríkuli's creation.

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The Dzawírra Duet: Performing the Precultural Past

Dzawírra (viejita, Sp., úkarra,Y.;cichlidae famliy, cicholasoma species) is the Wakuénai name for a yapurútu (máwi) flute duet that forms part of a larger class of duets named after animal, fish, and bird species. In traditional pudáli ceremonies, the hosts and guests jointly performed dzawírra and other duets with animal names any time after the redistribution of food on the morning of the second day. Yapurútu duets performed prior to the redistribution of food included only a few set pieces without animal names (see Figure 9.1 for a transcription of the most common of these pieces). In contrast, dzawírra and the other duets with specific animal names showed a great deal more variation in terms of both choreography and music. These performances strongly imply that pudáli ceremonies were far more than a mechanical process of following established rules of respectful giving and taking between affinally-related groups. Beyond its correlations with natural and social timing, pudáli was a collective return to a presexual, precultural past in which both host and guest groups cooperatively participated.

The dzawírra duet acts out a return to the distant, mythical past when people were social animals that behaved in a naturally adaptive manner to protect their own interests. Paradoxically, the performers make use of explicitly sexual symbolism to communicate the idea of the presexual. The following description of dzawírra dances is based on three

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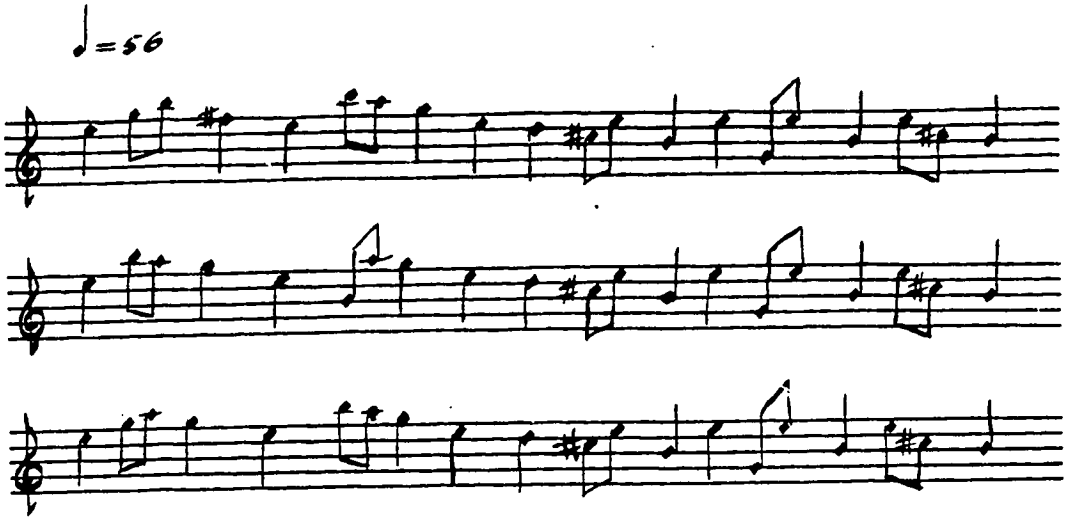


Figure 9.1. Máwi flute duet played in opening dances of pudáli and acccmpanied by other instrumental and vocal music

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separate performances of the same duet in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán. I also observed and recorded the dzawírra duet in an Adzanéni village some 50 km downstream from Gavilán. The frequency with which dzawírra is still performed today even after the breakdown of traditional ceremonial cycles and social customs among the Wakuénai groups of the region suggests that that the performance indeed transcended the rules of social and ceremonial exchange. I have chosen to describe and analyze dzawírra partly for this reason and also because its popularity made it easier for me to study than other pieces that I only heard on one occasion.

The dzawírra duet begins with a pair of male flute players dancing in a circle, just like all yapurútu duets. The men support their instruments with the outside arms and embrace one another around the shoulders with the inside arms. After completing one full circle (or sooner), two women join the pair of male flute-players. One woman dances between the two men, while the other dances on the inside of the circle (to the right). Suddenly, the pair of male and female dancers on the inside of the circle stands still, and the other couple continues on for a few more paces, turns around to face the motionless couple, and then approaches them from the front/right side. They approach until the flute in front of them crosses underneath that of the couple who stands still. Then they back off and approach again. On the third time, the flute player who is standing still raises his instrument up high to allow the other couple to pass under-

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neath. He continues to play the flute in this raised position while the other couple dances in small, counter-closkwise circles around him and his partner. Immediately following this sequence, the roles are reversed and the couple that had been moving around the others in small circles stands still. The couple that had been standing still then goes through the series of approaching and backing-off motions before being allowed to pass several times under the raised flute of the other couple. After the role reversal has been completely acted out, the two couples rejoin and dance in a clockwise direction to the place where the dance had begun on one side of the dancing area. The end of the duet comes with the usual high-pitched, screaching sounds of the two flutes when overblown with maximum force.

According to the Wakuénai, the dzawírra duet portrays a female dzawírra fish protecting a nest of eggs against an enemy. They point out that the dzawírra fish stays with its nest until the eggs are ready to hatch, whereas many other fish species simply lay eggs and abandon them. The approaching and backing-off motions of dancers in the dzawírra duet are said to represent a process of asking the mother fish's permission to 'dance' in a circle over her nest. Similarly, the raising of the yapurútu flute is said to be the mother fish's way of giving approval to the outside intruder to enter her nest. Although this explanation centers around the theme of protection against predators, it also implies a sexual theme of a male fish asking permission to

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'dance' in the female's nest. The spawning runs of fish are generally referred to with the word meaning 'to dance' (lirápaka, he dances), and the emphasis on fish nests and eggs in the dzawírra duet expresses a concern for natural processes of reproduction and their relevance as models for social behavior in the ceremonial context of pudáli.

The dzawírra duet uses the sexual symbolism of the female protector versus the male aggressor to communicate the idea of a natural, presexual reproductive process in which sexuality is reversible. Since both pairs of dancers consist of a man and a woman, the reversal of roles in the dzawírra performance totally blurs the male vs. female dichotomy. First one male-female couple acts as the female protector, then the other. The reversal does not change anything but is an expression of transsexuality, or androgyny. The dzawírra performance communicates a process of spontaneous generativity that predates the dichotomy between male and female and, in the context of traditional pudáli ceremonies, the important disjunction between wife-giving and wife-taking social groups.

This conclusion is paradoxical in the sense that a return to the presexual, mythical past of Iñápirríkuli would apparently bring about chaotic social conditions in which affinally-related kinship groups were constantly at war with one another rather than a resolution of these disharmonius conditions. Looking only at the dzawírra duet within the context of pudáli ceremonies, the participation of women as well

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as men in the dance and the reversal of sex roles clearly demonstrate a collapsing of the male vs. female dichotomy but do not in themselves explain how a return to the presexual past transcends rather than exacerbates the primordial opposition between kin and affines (i.e., ZH and WB or FZH and WBS). In the remainder of this chapter, I will examine the symbolism of musical performances in pudáli and kwépani in order to show how they form part of a system of ceremonial musical performances. For the most part, the synthesis rests upon analyses of general patterns in the organization of music and dancing in the two ceremonies. Occasionally, I will narrow the focus of analysis onto specific musical instruments and performances that illustrate key concepts such as the idea of presexual reproduction in dzawírra duets.

Yapurútu (Mawi) Flutes and the Music of Dzawírra

Yapurútu is the Yeral term for the pairs of long flutes traditionally played in pudáli ceremonies. The Wakuénai term for the flutes is máwi, a term that refers to the type of small tree (mabe, Sp.) from which these flutes and all other aerophones of the mádzerunái genre are constructed. Mabe palms grow in all the forest-types of the region and are often harvested in quantities of twenty to thirty pieces in the process of clearing low vegetation for a new manioc garden[2]. Bundles of mabe poles, each one about 2.5 m long and tapering from 6-7 cm in diameter at the base to 4-5 cm at the top, are brought into the village. The straightness of the mabe poles and the ease with which they can be hollowed out

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make them ideal not only for musical instruments but also for blowguns. The process of hollowing out the poles begins with an overnight soaking in the river that softens the inner pith of the wood, which is then easily removed with long, hard sticks of tirita palm (pwáapwa). To smooth out the interior of the wooden cylinders, a long piece of guambé (adápi), a vine covered with protruding knots, is threaded through the hollow tube of wood and pushed back and forth in a rapid, sawing motion. The hard knots on the guambé vine remove any remaining bits of pith inside the mabe tube. The flute's maker cuts off any excess length and throws it away, making only one instrument from each mabe pole. Larger poles are needed to make máwi (or yapurútu) flutes. The longer, male máwi flutes range from 1.59 to 1.77 m in length, according to the height of the eyebrows of the man who makes them when he is standing upright. The female máwi flutes are about 15 cm, or eight fingers' width, shorter than male flutes and range from 1.44 to 1.62 m in length.

A rectangular, 8 x 1 cm^2 hole is cut from the upper end of the flutes (the end which the player blows into) and is covered with two moistened leaves of cucuritu palm. A plug made of peramá (a natural resin) is molded with a hot knife inside the top end of the instrument so that a condensed air column is channeled up and split against the lower of the two leaves to produce sounds (see Figure 9.2). The upper leaf serves mainly as a tuning device, since by narrowing the aperture between the two leaves, the pitch is raised.

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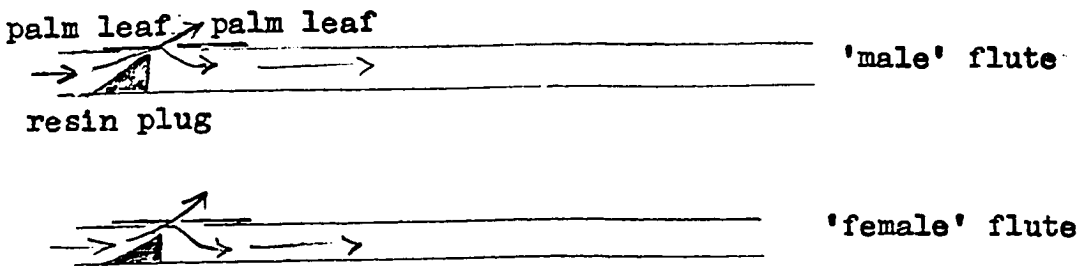


Figure 9.2. Cut-away sketch of máwi, or yápurútú, flutes showing basic features of construction

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However, adjusting the space between the two leaves allows only a slight change of pitch, and when a pair of flutes is badly out of tune, the performers saw off minute slices of the lower end of the instrument that is sounding too flat. The actual pitches produced can vary among different pairs due to differences in the heights of men who make the flutes. What is most important is that the two instruments of each pair be tuned one whole step apart. In all pairs of máwi flutes, the male instrument is tuned one whole step lower than the female one. The instruments must be played in a hocket, or alternating, style in order to produce a melody, since they have no fingerholes for producing melodic intervals. Each máwi flute produces a series of overtones with larger intervals naturally occupying the lower register and smaller intervals of a minor third or less in the higher register. The male flute measuring 1.77 m, for example, produces the series G (below middle C)-D-G-B-F-G-(A)-(C), while its female companion (1.62 m long) produces an identical series of intervals only one whole step higher (i.e., A-E-A-C#-E-G-A- (B)-(D). Each melody consists of a string of notes that are alternately produced on the male and female flutes.

Playing máwi flutes, especially while dancing, requires great practice and skill. Since there are no fingerholes, playing requires a good control over the lips and breath. Lower notes are difficult to produce well because the lips must be relaxed inside the mouthpiece and the attack with air

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from the lungs has to be as slow as possible. This relaxation, or technical deceleration, has to be done very quickly so as not to retard the tempo of the melody and dance. Many pieces require a constant changing from high notes that are produced with tense lips and a quick breath of air down to lower notes that require exactly the opposite technique. The quality of tone produced on máwi flutes varies a great deal from player to player. Beginners and young men who are less experienced have a hard time balancing the volume of low and high notes, often making loud, screaching high notes and weak, airy-sounding low notes. The best players are adult men who have developed a high degree of lip and breath control and can interweave notes into a melody with so much clarity and uniformity of volume that an observer cannot intuitively determine which player is playing which notes.

Mawi flute duets that have animal names, such as the dzawírra, and that were traditionally performed after the redistribution of a ceremonial food-offering in pudáli, make use of musical theme and variation that borders on 'through composition'. Performers take a simple theme and elaborate it into a complex structure with subtle variations. To an untrained or unsympathetic ear, máwi flute duets might sound only repetitive and redundant, but careful scrutiny shows them to be a highly personalized musical medium that allows for the expression of individual musical abilities. The use of theme and variation in máwi flute duets has many parallels in the music and dance of the mádzerunái genre. Before

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turning to these other instruments and performances, I will take a closer look at how theme and variation is used in the dzawírra duet.

The tonal sequences of the two máwi flutes that were played in the particular performance of dzawírra which I have transcribed in Figure 9.3 are 1) A-E-A-C#-E-G-A-(B) for the male (1.59 m long) flute and 2) B-F#-B-D#-F#-A-B-(C) for the female (1.44 m long) flute. The main theme, played right at the outset of the performance, is a 6-note melody plus the 'tail', a 4-beat sustained note (C#) that comes at the end of each phrase in the piece. The tonal structure of this melodic theme is changed to produce ten other variants of the same 6-notes' duration in the course of the piece (see Figures 9.4 and 9.5). The main theme is also lengthened by two beats to make 8-note melodic phrases and shortened by two beats to make 4-note phrases. Both the lengthened (8-note) and shortened (4-note) phrases are altered to produce seven tonal variants each, bringing the total number of variants up to 27, all based on a single theme (2a).

The number of possible combinations and permutations for complete melodic passages is extremely high (28!), but in practice the amount of variation is kept in bounds by the greater number of times that the main theme is played (see numbers in parentheses after listing of each variant in Figure 9.4) and by playing two of the shortened, 4-note melodic phrases to form a sort of cadence. Figure 9.5 indicates the sequence of theme and variation in a complete per-

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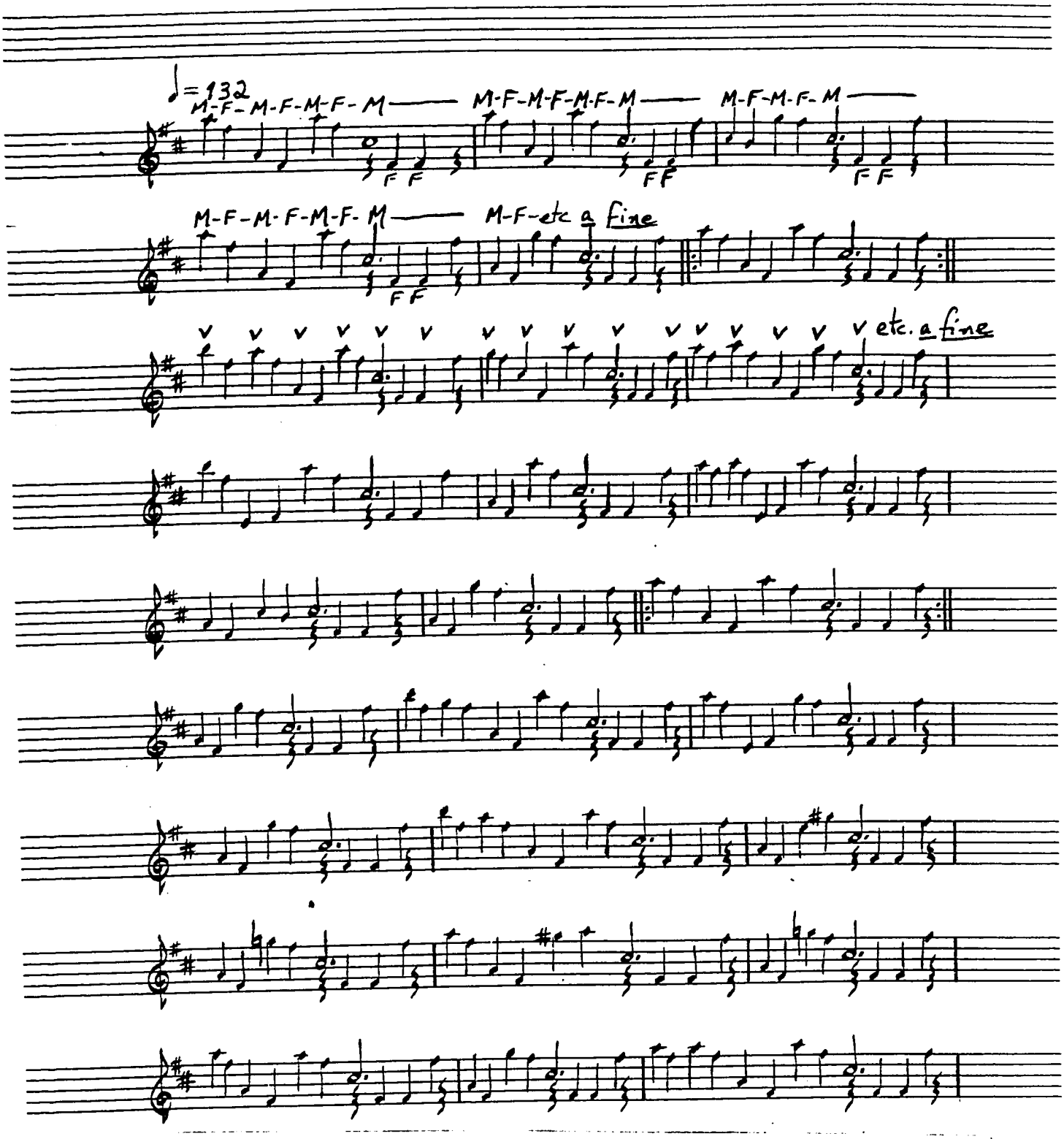


Figure 9.3. Transcription of mawi flute duet called dzawirra. 'M' and 'F' stand for 'Male' and 'Female' flutes; V indicates a rhythmic stomping of the right foot.

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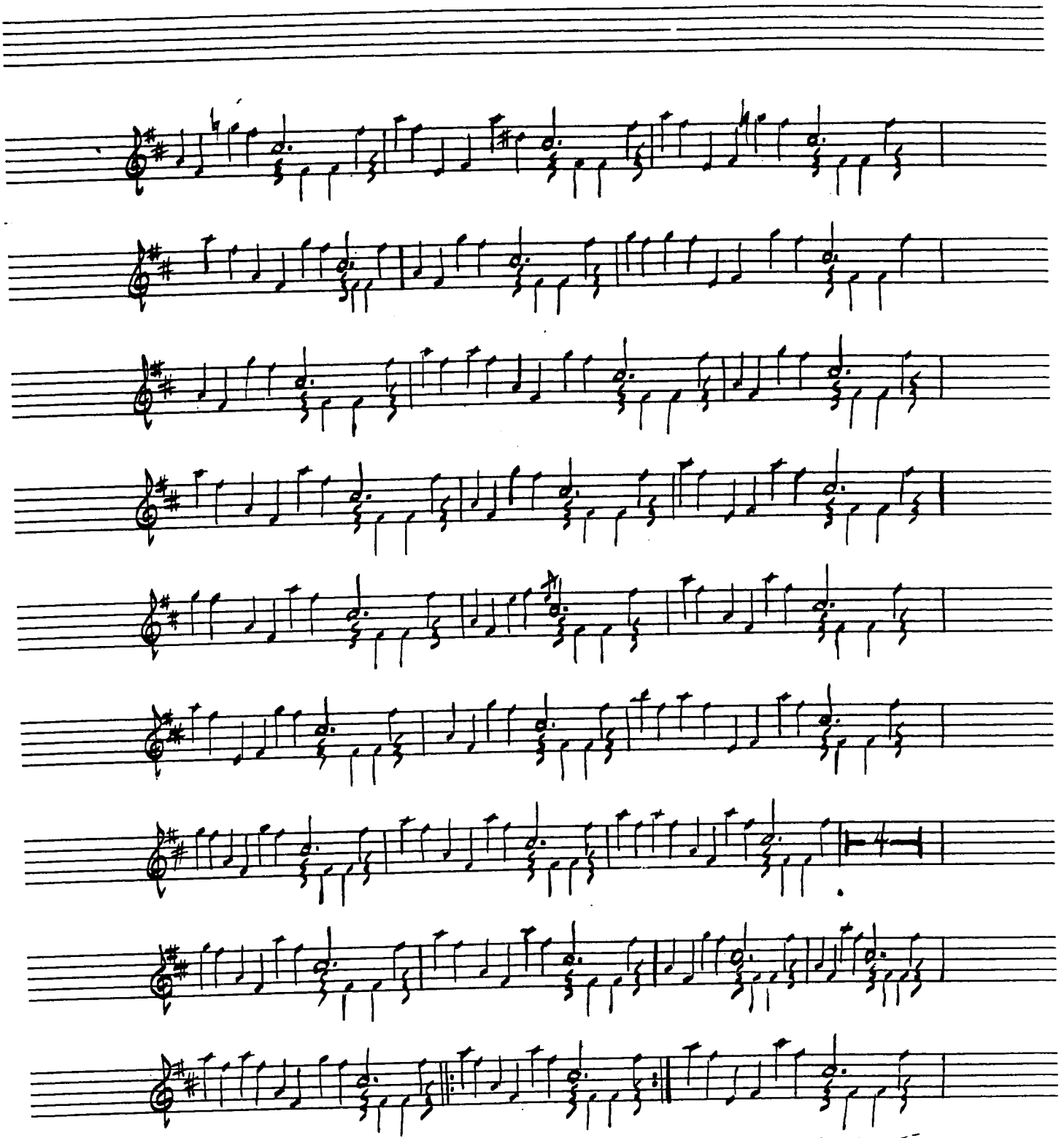


Figure 9.3 (cont.). Transcription of dzawirra duet

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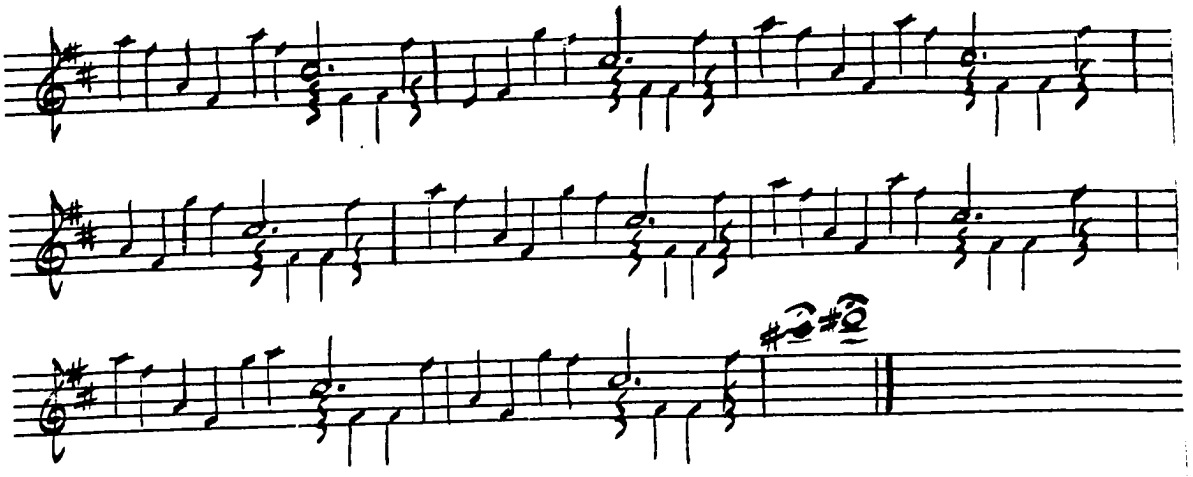


Figure 9.3 (cont.). Transcription of dzawirra duet

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1) Shortened, 4-note phrases

a. A-F-g-f . . .(15)
b. A-F-a-f . . . (2)
c. C-B-g-f . . . (1)
d. A-F-C-B . . . (1)
e. A-F-e-g#. . . (1)
f. A-F-g-f . . . (1)(differs slightly from 1a)
g. A-F-e-f . . . (1)
h. E-F-g-f . . . (1)

2) Main theme & variants (6-note phrases)

a. a-f-A-F-a-f . . . (19)
b. g-f-A-F-a-f . . . (3)
c. b-f-E-F-a-f . . . (1)
d. a-f-E-F-g-f . . . (2)
e. a-f-A-F-g#-a. . . (1)
f. a-f-E-F-a-D#. . . (1)
g. a-f-A-F-g-f . . . (2)
h. a-f-E-F-a-f . . . (2)
i. a-f-E-F-g-f . . . (1)
j. g-f-A-F-g-f . . . (1)
k. a-f-A-F-g-a . . . (1)

3) Lengthened, 8-note phrases

a. b-f-a-f-A-F-a-f . . . (2)
b. a-f-a-f-A-F-g-f . . . (2)
c. a-f-a-f-A-F-a-f . . . (3)
d. b-f-g-f-A-F-a-f . . . (1)
e. g-f-g-f-E-F-g-f . . . (1)
f. b-f-a-f-E-F-a-f . . . (1)
g. a-f-a-f-E-F-g-f . . . (1)
h. a-f-a-f-E-F-a-f . . . (1)

Figure 9.4. Musical analysis of dzawírra flute duet showing frequency of each phrase and its variants in parentheses. Small letters indicate notes in higher register, capital letters are lower notes. All C and F notes are sharp; other notes are natural unless indicated (#). The 'tail', or 4-beat sustained note (C#) at the end of each phrase, is left out in this listing of themes and variants.

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```
Dance   Women join; 'asking permission' to enter nest

Music   Intro-C -1 -C ------- 6 -------- C -1 -C -C-("double cadence")
        6- 6- 4- 6- 4- 6- 6- 8- 6- 8- 6- 4- 8- 4- 4-
        2a-2a-1c-2a-1a-2a-2a-3a-2b-3b-2c-1b-3h-1d-1a-

Dance   Permission given; dance in nest

Music   -2----C---2----C -1 -C -C-
        6- 6- 4- 8- 6- 4- 8- 4- 4-
        2a-2a-1a-3d-2d-1a-3a-1e-1a-

Dance   Sex role reversal; no double cadence

Music   1 -C -1 -C -1 -C ----3---- C -1 -C -1 -C-
        6- 4- 6- 4- 8- 4- 6- 6- 6- 4- 8- 4- 8- 4-
        2e-1a-2a-1f-3e-1a-2f-2i-2g-1a-3e-1a-3b-1a-

Dance                   'asking permission' to enter nest

Music   1--C----2---C---2---C---------------10----------------C--C-
        6- 4- 6- 6- 4- 6- 6- 4- 8- 6- 6- 8- 6- 6- 6- 6- 6- 6- 4- 4-
        2a-1a-2a-2b-1g-2a-2g-1a-3f-2j-2a-3c-2a-2a-2a-2a-2b-2a-1a-1b-

Dance   dance in 'nest';    2 pairs of dancers rejoin,
                                        leave dance ground

Music   -------5-------C -1 -C ----3-----C----E
        8- 6- 6- 6- 6- 4- 6- 4- 6- 6- 6- 4----N
        3g-2a-2a-2g-2a-1h-2a-1a-2g-2a-2k-1a---D
```

Figure 9.5. Alternative transcription of *dzawírra* flute duet in terms of phrase lengths (middle lines) and tonal variants (numbered and lettered according to Figure 4). The top line of each row uses the abbreviation 'C' for 4-note phrases and shows the number of 6- and 8- note phrases in between each pair of 4-note phrases (e.g.,C--2--C).

formance of dzawírra and shows how the use of two consecutive 4-note phrases (shown as `C-C' in the top line of each row) divides the piece into sections that roughly parallel the major divisions of the dancing. No double cadence is played in the middle of the piece when the reversal of sex roles is happening in the dance. Instead, there is a rather symmetrical use of single cadences in alternation with single 6- or 8-note melodic phrases (e.g., C-1-C-1) before and after a central passage of three 6-note melodic phrases. This passage (shown as ---3---/6-6-6/2f-2i-2g) marks a turning point in which the female protector begins to assume the role of male aggressor and vice-versa.

The Three Stages of Pudáli Ceremonies

In traditional pudáli ceremonies, the music and dancing of mádzerunái created an arena in which not only social respect but also cultural identity, both collective and individual, were brought out in fullest array. Dancers wore their most brilliant feather headdresses and painted their bodies with red and black designs. The pudáli-owner and house-owner (pantímnali) covered their bodies with white down feathers (máariye) of the heron, and their kinsmen decorated máwi flutes and other instruments with heron feathers and red, black, and white designs. Although most of the visual and ceramic artistry associated with puadli has disappeared or been replaced by Western clothing styles and manufactured items, the music and dances of pudáli have continued as a form of secular entertainment and cultural identity in

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several of the more traditional villages along the lower Guainía in Venezuela. Looking at these performances as a whole genre and relating them to the progression of events in traditional pudáli ceremonies is a way of discerning the cultural processes that are implicit in the mádzerunái genre of music and dance.

Seen in this broad perspective, the sequence of music and dancing in pudáli outlined a cultural process of breaking down collective identities into a plurality of individuals. The transition from máwi flute duets as relatively set pieces in the early stages of pudáli to máwi duets with animal names allowing a great deal of individual improvisation after the redistribution of food is but one example of a multidimensional process in which musical performances and dances paralleled important social and ceremonial events. Regardless of whether it was male- or female-owned, pudáli was essentially a three-stage process of breaking down collective identities into personal, individual ones. The two key events that marked transitions between the three stages of pudáli were the formal offering and acceptance of food and the redistribution of this food-offering on the following morning. The heaping up and later redistribution of food symbolized a cultural process in which people were massed into clearly-defined host/guest categories that later on broke down into many individuals with no clear collective identity. In between the heaping up of food and its redistribution was a transitional period when the food was stored inside the

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hosts' house. This period lasted from about midnight when the food was taken off the dancing plaza until just before sunrise and the redistribution of food.

In the first stage of pudáli, the guests arrived late in the afternoon and danced in large ensembles around the food. The leaders of the line of guest men and women played máwi flutes. Behind the máwi players came the full 'orchestra' of mádzerunái instruments: tsikóta and déetu flutes, dance-rattles (kutírru), kúlirína trumpets (in male-owned ceremonies), dance-stomping tubes (wáana, in female-owned ceremonies), and maváku and píti whistle- flutes in the rear. Behind the procession of musician/dancers, women carried the offering of food up from the port and displayed it in a pile on the center of the dance ground. The pile of food acted as a central hub around which all musical performers and dancers circulated for several hours, until about midnight when the hosts came outside to accept the food and take it inside. The guests performed dances in large ensembles that emphasized group unity and in which máwi flutes invariably led the other performers. In male-owned ceremonies, several pairs of máwi flute players led twenty or more kúlirína trumpet players, each with female dancing partners, around the pile of smoked fish. These dances, named after three species of bocachico fish, all sounded the same because the máwi players played only one standard, set piece (transcribed in Figure 9.1) and the trumpets make only one low, rumbling bass tone. The only dimension that changed in the series of three bocachico

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dances leading up to the offering of food at midnight were the arrangements of dancers (see Figure 9.6). In female-owned ceremonies, there was likewise little variation and an emphasis on collective unity in the series of three dance-songs performed with stomping tubes (wáana) made of hollowed out cecropia or bamboo[3]. The series of three songs made use of a single melody and only varied in terms of the verses (see Figure 9.7).

The second stage of pudáli began at midnight when the hosts' headman (pantímnali, or house-owner) took the food inside and invited each of the guest families to enter his house for a drink. In place of the pile of food, a large bonfire was built and kept burning for the rest of the night on the dancing plaza. Most musical performances and dances centered around the fire on the plaza, but a special kind of performance on déetu flutes also shifted the focus to the hosts' headman's house and the food and drink inside. The late-night period was a transitional stage in the cultural process of breaking down collective, group identities defined as hosts versus guests into individual identities who transcended this ceremonial dichotomy. Performances on déetu flutes during the late-night period played a pivotal role in communicating this process.

The déetu flutes are named after a black, weevil-like insect that has a long proboscis for sucking sweet sap from trees or other plants. They are attracted to sweet-smelling liquids of any kind and arrive on the scene soon after a ceje

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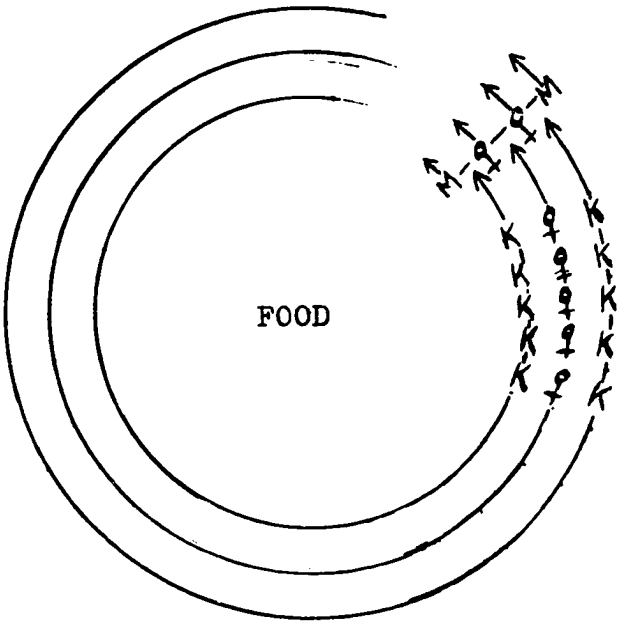


Figure 9.6. táari (white bocachico) dance: two máwi flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead several rows of dancers, each one consisting of three kúlirrína trumpet-players (K) in the center and two partners (♀).

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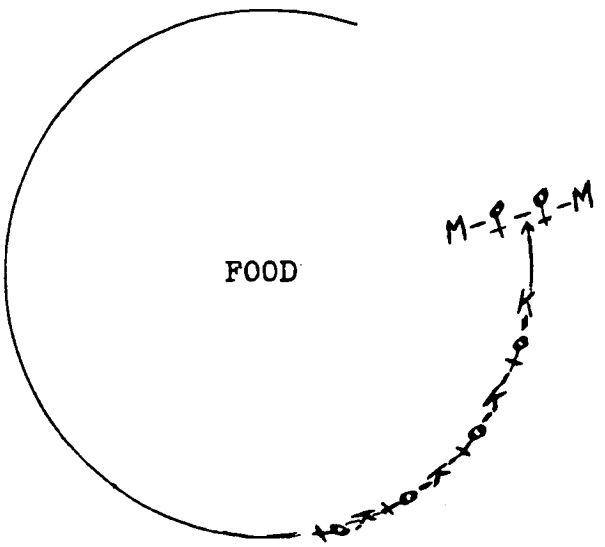


Figure 9.6. (cont.) dúme (spotted bocachico)dance: two máwi flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead a single-file line of kúlirrína trumpet-players (K) and female dance partners.

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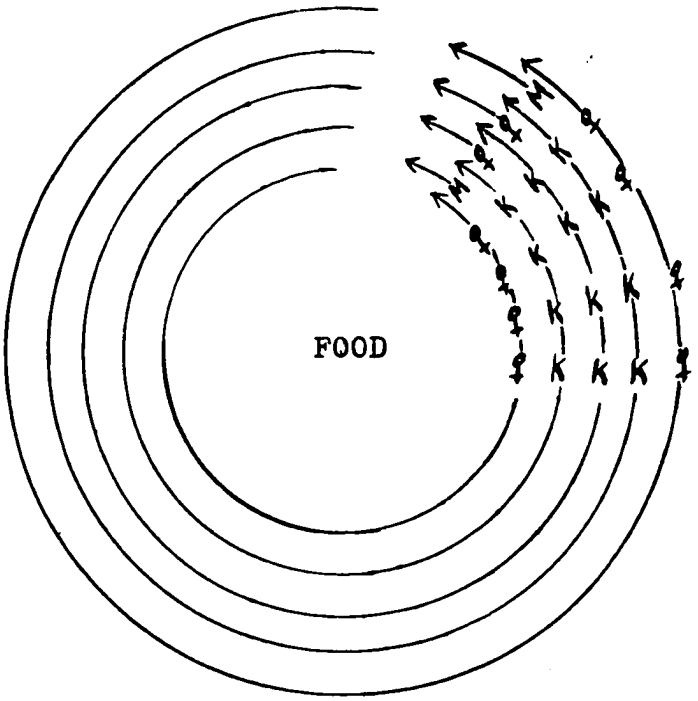


Figure 9.6. (cont.) dúpari (red-tailed bocachico) dance: two máwi flute-players (M) and their female dance partners (♀) lead several rows of dancers, each one consisting of two kúlirrína trumpet players (K) and a single dance partner (♀).

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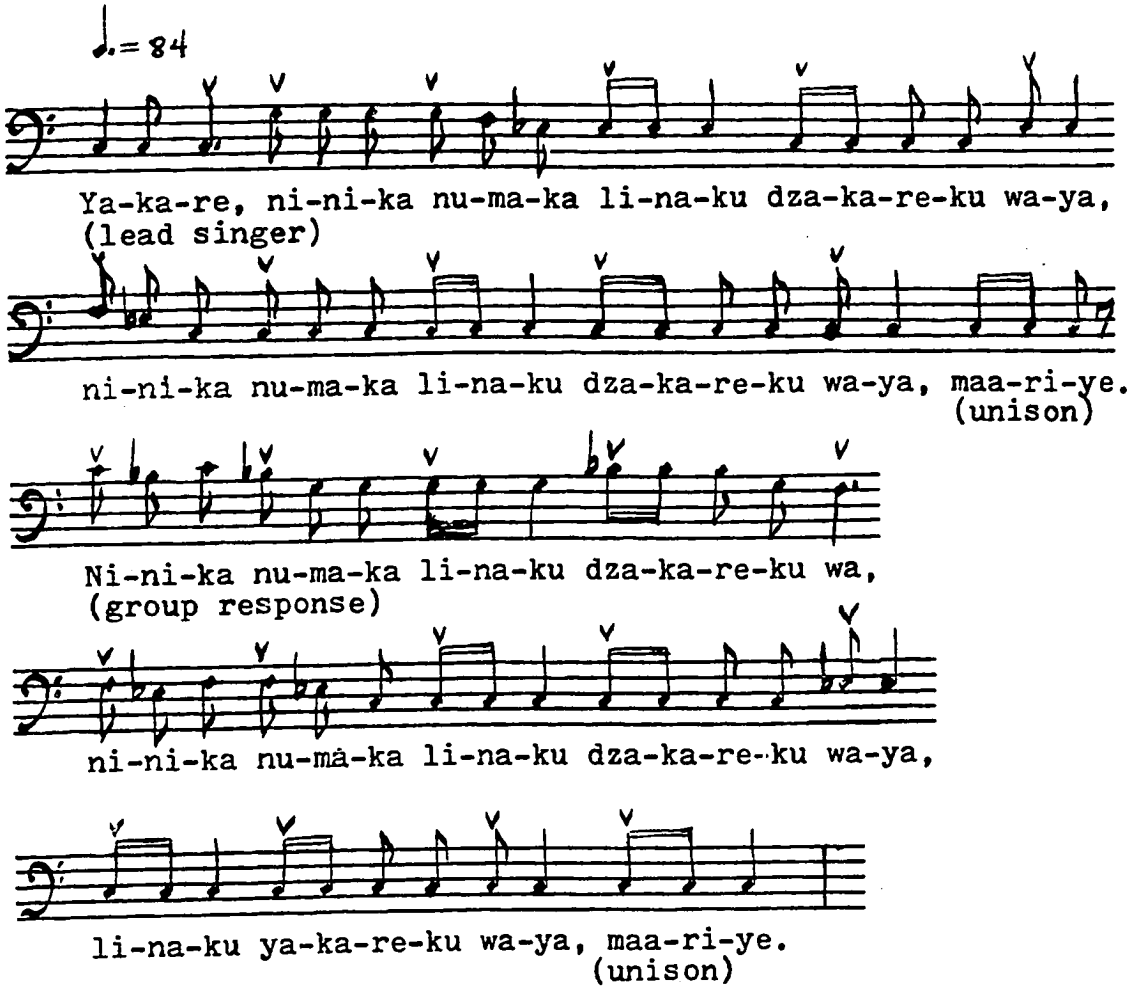


Figure 9.7. Melody of wáana songs performed in pudáli and first verse of opening song

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Opening song of female-owned pudáli:

Nínika númaka línaku dzákarekuwáya, máariye.
(I want us to come into the village like this, house-owner.)

Pímena piúmali línaku yákarekuwáya, máariye.
(You asked to hear us like this in the village.)

Dúpina piúmaka línaku dzákarekuwáya.
(Before you asked for this in this village.)

Nínika mápaima wánuka línaku, wánay-wá.
(We come like this without fear, playing waana.)

Nínika mápuni wánaku kéra-wírru.
(We come here lightly colored with red kérawídzu.)

Song for palm-fruits prior to food exchange:

Nínika númaka línaku wétsirrú, línaku yákarekuwáya, máariye.
(I want cucuritu palm fruits like this here in the village.)

Nínika númaka kámare-rékani wétsirrú.
(I want cucuritu fruits with plenty of flesh.)

Nínika númaka yéemaka wétsirrúli.
(I want the standing cucuritu tree.)

Dzúdzuápani song performed before dawn:

Nínika númaka línaku yúyuwína dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the small round fish net here in this village.)

Nínika númaka túwiripíku, dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the yellow tail feathers of the tuwiru bird.)

Nínika númaka dáipukuliáwa, dzákarekuwáya.
(I want the wheel of dzámakwápi vine.)

Dáikenu liákani, dzákarekuwáya.
(Sleep is arriving here in this village.)

Níni námaru liákaninu yáwinúma.
(We open the jaguar's mouth.)

Nínika yánuwa máaripikúwa.
(I want to gather the whiter heron's tail feathers.)

Nínika númaka tárumi liákani yáwinúma.
(I want to close the jaguar's mouth.)

Figure 9.7 (cont.). Text and translation of wáana songs from female-owned pudáli ceremonies.

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palm has been felled in the forest or when sugar cane has been cut in the gardens (as it is in great quantities when people are preparing fermented manioc and fruit drinks for a ceremony). The déetu flute players directly imitated the sucking and eating behavior of déetu insects during the transitional, late-night period of pudáli (whether male- or female-owned). Several déetu flute players among the guests would surround the host headman's house and hold their flutes up high so that the sound entered the house in the space between the roof overhang and the walls. In this way, they 'asked' for drinks by 'sucking' them out of the house-owner until he could not refuse their request. The house-owner came outside with a gourd dipper and a large pot of fermented drink, offering a generous quantity to each flute player one by one. He grasped the raised flute of one player and lowered it to the ground, signalling that he should drink while the other men continued to play their music. The déetu flute players were expected to drink until they had surpassed the limits of their stomachs and had to vomit[4].

Déetu flute performances of the transitional, late-night period of pudáli ceremonies were a collective enactment of the shaman's reversal of the 'food->feces' process through sucking and vomitting. The house of the hosts' headman and the ceremonial food and drink stored inside it were treated like a patient's body, but instead of sucking to remove a disease-causing agent, the déetu players were sucking fermented drinks (danáka) out of the house. The déetu per-

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formances symbolically transported the entire social gathering of pudáli to a reversible space-time. The wider cultural implications of this reversal and its connections with shamanistic curing rituals will be explored in greater detail in the next section, after a discussion of déetu flutes and two other performances of the second stage of pudáli that completed the transition to the third and final stage.

Déetu flutes are constructed from mabe (máwi, Curricarro) in much the same way as máwi flutes and the tsikóta, a smaller, 96 and 88 cm male and female pair of flutes that are replicas of máwi flutes. The major physical difference between déetu and máwi flutes is that in déetu the two reeds are placed over a rectangular hole that is more distant from the mouthpiece than the hole cut in máwi and tsikóta flutes. In déetu flutes, the distance between the mouthpiece and the aperture between the two reeds is equal to one sixth the entire length of the instruments, whereas in both máwi and tsikóta flutes, the corresponding ratio is one twentieth of the total length. Like the other flutes, the déetu have no fingerholes and can produce only an overtone series of intervals (5th, 4th, M3rd, neutral 3rd, m3rd, and M2nd). However, the déetu flutes come in only one length (1.15 m) and are thus not considered to come in pairs of male and female. They are played in unison rather than an alternating, hocket style, since their tuning is identical rather than staggered by a whole tone difference. Déetu music is not melodic like

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máwi and tsikóta duets but consists of only the relatively large intervals of an overtone series (see Figure 9.8).

In addition to déetu flutes, male- and female-owned pudáli ceremonies each had their respective musical instruments and dances for marking the end of the transitional, late-night period. In male-owned ceremonies, the men played kúlirína trumpets around the fire for a final time in a dance said to represent the cooking of maíni, the resinous substance used to cover the woven resonators. Another name for these trumpets is mainína, or `resin-object', and wamáinina is synonomous with warápaka kúlirína ("We dance with kúlirína trumpets"). This performance was held shortly before sunrise and was the only time during the night that the kúlirína trumpets were played without the accompaniment of máwi and tsikóta flutes. Like déetu flutes, the kúlirína trumpets are not melodic instruments, since they produce only a single base note ("Wa-ra-ka-ka-"). The playing of kúlirína at the end of the night thus parallels the déetu flute performances inasmuch as both instruments were separated off from the máwi and tsikóta flutes with which they had been combined in the first stage of the ceremony. Déetu and kúlirína performances in the second stage of male-owned pudáli ceremonies also expressed a temporary split between two ceremonial foci: the house of the hosts' headman and the fire. After the dance dedicated to maíni, the guests gave their trumpets to the hosts as reminders of their duty to hold a `closing' pudáli in the future. Both the musical performance and the act of

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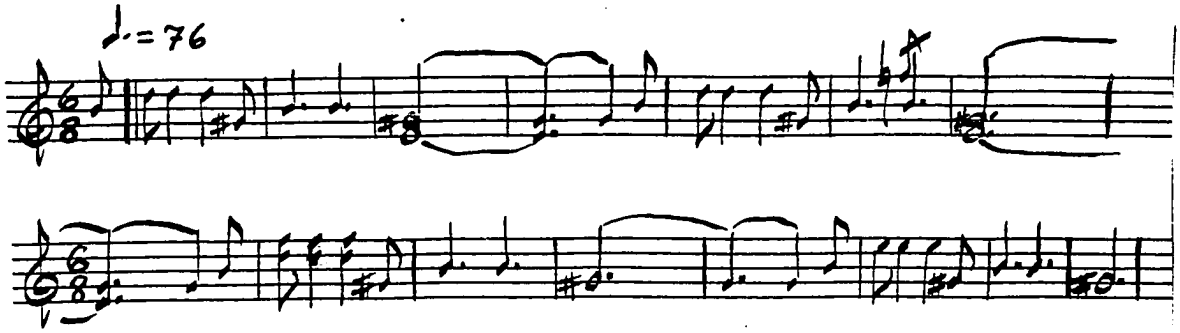


Figure 9.8. Transcription of deetu flutes played without accompaniment; melodic intervals found in mawi flute duets and songs are absent.

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giving away the trumpets shifted the emphasis away from the ceremonial food-offering and onto the musical instruments themselves. In this sense, the second stage of pudáli can be said to have outlined a process of food->musical instruments.

The sexual symbolism of kúlirína trumpets has already been noted in the context of ecological subsistence activities (Chapter 3). The trumpets' construction is a fusion of male and female elements, an insertion of a phallic mabe-palm tube into a uterine-shaped, woven, and maíni-covered resonator. This sexual interpretation is the basis of Wakuénai beliefs that women must not see the closing off of the two elements because their next children would become stuck inside their wombs and cause them to die in childbirth. In the context of everyday subsistence activities, kúlirína trumpets express the complementarity of male and female labor in the basic productive activities of fishing and agriculture. In the ceremonial context of the last kúlirína performance in pudáli, the instruments expressed the idea of spontaneous generativity. Unlike the sexing of máwi and tsikóta flutes into male and female, kúlirína trumpets were a synthesis of masculinity and femininity into a single instrument. And unlike déetu flutes that were neither male nor female, kúlirína trumpets were both male and female. As noted in an earlier analysis of dzawírra performances of the last day of pudáli, máwi flute players paradoxically used sexually explicit imagery to communicate the idea of the presexual. Kúlirína trumpets, when played by themselves in a performance

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dedicated to the material out of which they are made (maíni), communicated the same idea in terms of material elements of construction rather than through a reversal of male aggressor and female protector roles in dancing and music. Reaching the presexual in male-owned pudáli ceremonies was thus a three-step transformation in which attention was shifted from food, to musical instruments, and finally to musical performers.

In female-owned pudáli ceremonies, a series of three dance-songs with wáana stomping tubes took the place of the final kúlirína trumpet dances in male-owned ceremonies. The melody of the three songs did not change from that used in the three related songs performed before the house-owner accepted the food-offering and took it inside. As with the déetu and kúlirína performances of the late-night period, wáana songs performed after the removal of the food from the dancing ground were also separated from the máwi flute music with which they had previously been combined[5]. The series of wáana dance-songs culminated in dzudzuápani, an elaborate dance in which attention focused on a small, wheel-shaped piece of vine called dzúdzumáka. The wheel, also called dáipukulé, was made out of dzámakuápi (lit., dzamáka = two and áapi = snake, or "two snakes"), the same type of vine used for making dancing- whips (kapéti) and also the circular rim onto which tubular mouthpieces of máwi are lashed and inserted into the woven, maíni-covered resonators to create kúlirína trumpets. The term dzúdzumáka refers to the

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circular, wood-framed fish nets for scooping small fish out of streams, and the wheel of dzámakuápi vine used in dzudzuápani performances was a minitiature replica of these hand-held fishing nets. The ceremonial dzúdzumáka were identical in size and material to the wheel (13.5 cm diameter) used to bind together male and female elements within the kúlirína trumpets. The circular wheel of dzúdzumáka also resembled the wheel within kúlirína trumpets in the sense that both the fish net and the large catfish trumpets were symbolic 'small fish catching devices', one a cultural artifact and the other a natural species.

Like the final performance of kúlirína trumpets, the dzudzuápani shifted attention to a material construction that combined male and female elements into a single, ambiguous whole. The dzúdzumáka, however, did not combine maleness and femaleness into a single instrument but linked together two pairs of male and female dancers, one of which sang the 'male', or lead-off lines in the dzudzuápani song, while the other sang the 'female', or response lines. The two pairs of dancers carried long poles in their left hands, and a string connected the raised ends of each pole to the dzúdzumáka in the middle. These two pairs of dancers rapidly circled around the fire and frequently whirled around so that the fish net in the middle often dipped down into the upper flames. The two pairs of singers/dancers had to whirl around at exactly the same moment to prevent the fish net from falling into the fire and burning from having too much slack on the lines. The

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dzúdzumáka, a symbol of the union of male and female elements inside the 'head' of kúlirína trumpets, was transformed in the dzudzuápani dance into a symbolic interconnection between the 'male', lead singer and the 'female', or response singer. The latter was backed up by two columns of response-singers (all male, but with female dancing partners) who stood still and marked time with their stomping tubes (wáana) until the lead-singer sang the verses "to open the jaguar's mouth" (namáru yáwi núma). Then the two lines of response-singers danced backwards until they were several steps apart. A few verses later, they "closed the jaguar's mouth" (tárumi yáwi núma) back up by closing up the space that separated them.

Dzudzuápani marked the end of the second stage of female-owned pudáli ceremonies in a manner that paralleled the final kúlirína trumpet dance of male-owned ceremonies. Both performances employed sexual imagery to convey the idea of the presexual as an inextricable linkage of male and female elements in musical instruments, songs, and dances. Dzudzuápani illustrated the transition between collective performances of the first stage of pudáli and the individual performances of the third stage of pudáli through combining group and individual singing and dancing into a single performance. The dzudzuápani dance, with its dramatic linking together of male and female pairs of male and female dancers was but one step away from the máwi flute duets of the final stage of pudáli, the day after redistribution of the food-offering. I have already given a detailed account of the

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dzawírra duet and dance, a paramount example of máwi flute duets with animal names that were reserved for the day after redistribution. Figure 9.9 summarizes the three stages of pudáli in terms of ceremonial events, the changing foci or central points in music and dancing, the collapsing of male versus female sexuality, and the separation of particular instruments from their combined use in opening dance-processions. All these dimensions of musical, ceremonial processes in pudáli converged onto the male-female pair who 'protect' the nest in the dzawírra dance. In dzawírra dances, the male and female performers occupy the position that had originally been filled by the food and which was later transformed into the house containing food and drink, the fire, and the wheel of dzámakuápi vine dangling over the fire.

Analysis of Mádzerunái and Pudáli as Cultural Process

The cultural process of breaking down collective identities into personal ones in traditional pudáli ceremonies was expressed in the amassing, offering, and redistribution of food and changes in style of musical performance and dancing. The offering of food and its removal from the dancing ground had the effect of shifting pudáli from collective dances centered around food to more individualized dances centered around two separate foci, the house containing food and the fire. In this transitional shift, symbolic processes of reversal and separation brought about a change of emphasis in musical performances and

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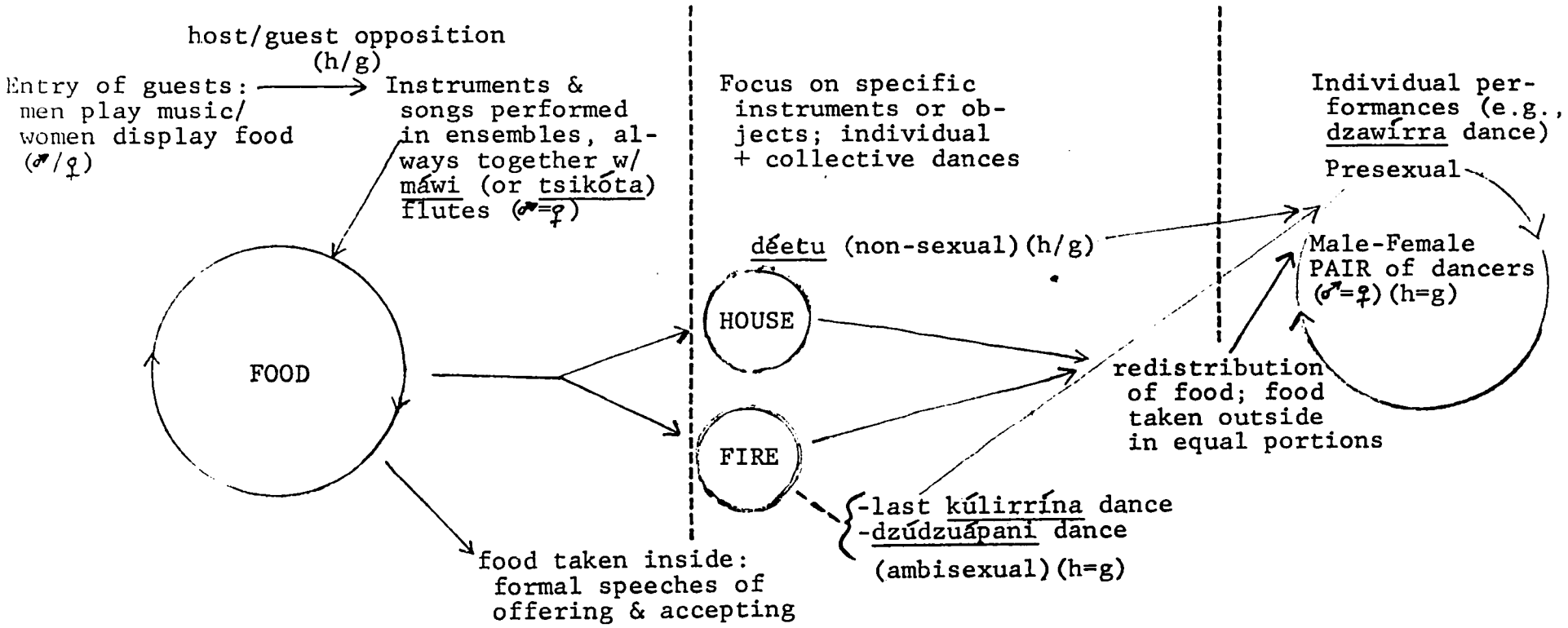


Figure 9.9. Analytical diagram of pudáli ceremonies showing convergence of several dimensions in dzawírra duet and idea of presexuality (h=g + ♂=♀).

dancing from food to material constructions. The sexual symbolism of these ceremonial instruments and objects took the form of non-sexual déetu flutes and later transformed into the ambiguous sexuality of kúlirína trumpets and the dzudzuápani dance with wáana stomping tubes. The final stage of pudáli began after the redistribution of food and marked a return to the presexual past. Pairs of male and female dancers took the place of the fire and the house as the central hub around which performers and dancers circled.

Breaking down, reversal, and separation are all processes that have been shown to operate in shaman's songs (málirríkairi). In addition to the déetu performances in which the shaman's activities of sucking and vomitting were symbolically enacted on a collective scale, a number of Wakuénai myths and verbal beliefs about the fate of dead souls show how pudáli ceremonies were conceptually linked to sickness and death. The most straight-forward illustration of this linkage is the belief that recently-deceased lidánam souls in íyarudáti perform máwi flute duets and other musical dances of the mádzerunái genre and that, although they drink the same alcoholic beverages as people in this world, the food they eat is rotten. Íyarudáti, therefore, is conceived of as a place where drinking, mádzerunái performances, and rottenness are closely associated with one another.

The myth of the origin of death also indicates a connection between pudáli and rottenness, since the first use of mahnéti poison by Kunáhwerri (who was the first victim of

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poisoning in the myth of the origin of Iñápirríkuli) is said to have taken place when Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen were attending a pudáli ceremony at the village of Kunáhwerri. The myth of Káali and his children establishes a link between pudáli and separation, a process that is closely related to rotting in shamanistic curing rituals. On the one hand, the Káali myth relates the origin of mádzerunái songs, dances, and instruments as the ways in which Káali instructed his children to ask the house-owner for drinks in pudáli ceremonies. On the other hand, the myth of Káali begins with a long series of episodes in which Káali leaves his children due to his wife's adultery with other men. His children (Káaliéni) suffered hunger as a result of their separation from Káali, but he returned to give them a secret way of making manioc starch from frog eggs so that they could eat without letting their mother have any of the food. The mythical theme of separation refers to the pain felt by individuals when separated from their fathers and fathers' kinsmen. This separation came about during the life cycle in the period of brideservice for young men and after marriage for women. After death, the souls of both men and women are believed to undergo a period of painful separation from their sib ancestor souls (líwarúna) while in íyarudáti.

Finally, the myth of the origin of bocachico dances with kúlirína trumpets also connects pudáli with the themes of separation and death. In this myth, three bocachico fish invite a man to accompany them to a pudáli being held in the

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wawina fish's village at the bottom of the Isana River. The fish convince the man that they need a fourth máwi flute player to dance around the heap of food that they are preparing to offer to the wawina. They arrive and perform three dances, each one led by a different bocachico fish (táari, dúme, and dúpari). The wawina senses the presence of a man at the gathering and threatens to kill him if he finds out who he is. This news scares the man, and he accidentally coughs after sucking some water into his máwi flute[6]. The bocachico fish cover up the sound of the man's coughing and tell him to keep playing so that he is not discovered by the wawina fish. The man does so, but upon returning to his home in the surface world, his wife smells alcohol on his breath and pesters him into telling her where he had been. The man, of course, is immediately bitten by a snake and 'dies' by turning into a fish and swimming away in the river. Aside from telling the origin of bocachico dances in pudáli, this myth further connects pudáli with the processes of separation and death. The death threats of the wawina fish in myth had a corrolary in the mutual assurances given by the host and guest headmen that they had spoken to their respective groups and forbidden them to throw poison (mahnéti) in the food of the other groups. Such assurances were included in the formal speeches of offering and accepting the ceremonial gift of food.

The performances of déetu flutes as instruments of sucking and vomitting fermented drinks were a form of meta-

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symbolism, or performance about performances. By collectively dramatizing the shaman's activities of sucking and vomitting, déetu flute performances defined pudáli and the full range of mádzerunái performances as a cultural process of breakdown, reversal, and separation applied on a collective scale. The process was homologous to the separation of the two parts of the soul which shamans relived in curing rituals but transposed to the domain of collective identities (i.e., hosts and guests) and the gradual separation of individuals from these two ceremonially-defined groups. Both pudáli and shamanistic curing rituals used processes of symbolic separation and reversal to communicate the painful experiences of sickness and death as discontinuous processes of change. Discontinuous change manifests itself both in the music of shamans (málirríkairi) and in the dance-music of pudáli (mádzerunái) as a process of increasing musical variation and contrast and as part of a more general overstimulation of the senses.

In curing rituals, overloading of the senses is concentrated in the person of the shaman through his use of stimulating dzáato snuff and is communicated in his music to the ritual participants and a wider audience through a variety of musical techniques: loud/soft contrasts (echoing), microtonal raising of pitch, use of various starting pitches and tonal structures, ascending and descending melodies, and the icy sounds of the sacred rattle (kútirúda). In addition, extra-musical techniques such as talking to the sky or to

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thunderstorms, waving cigarettes in circular motions overhead, wielding sacred stones, and repeated sucking and vomitting provided further means for the shaman's conveyance of sensual overloading. In pudáli ceremonies, there was a similar movement toward greater variation and contrast in music and dancing of the mádzerunái genre, culminating in máwi flute duets such as the dzawírra dance.

Since the music and dancing of pudáli is no longer performed in its traditional ceremonial context, the extramusical events that outlined parallel changes are more difficult to evaluate than they are for shamanistic curing rituals that are still performed in more traditional style and setting. Nevertheless, pudáli certainly included a variety of sensual stimuli beyond music and dance that also served to communicate a collective overloading of the senses. One such stimuli, of course, was the collective imbibing of fermented fruit and manioc drinks. These drinks are the highest expression of gustatory pleasure and discrimination in traditional Wakuénai culture. Each adult woman prepared a different type of fermented drink for pudáli, a phenomenon which I had the good fortune to experience in the modern `pudáli' held in honor of the kúlirína trumpets made during my stay in the field. One woman prepared a tangy-sweet pineapple drink, another made a stronger brew based on mashed sugar cane, and a third made an exquisitely nutty-flavored drink from burnt and chewed up manioc breads. In traditional pudáli ceremonies, I was told, the variety of fermented

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drinks served to guests was considerably greater. Preparation of many kinds of fermented drinks was a traditional way for women to demonstrate their talents as individual culinary artists, and the collective consumption of these delicious wines and beers was a gustatory parallel to the increasing variation of music and dancing as the night of pudáli wore on[7].

Another illustration of pudáli as a process of collectively overloading the senses was the use of red body paints (kérawídzu), a custom which I have not observed but that is still remembered in the verses of dance-songs accompanied by stomping tubes (wáana). In the opening song of female-owned ceremonies, the wáana dancers wore only a light coating of red kérawídzu paint on their bodies. "We come, our bodies still only lightly colored with red paint, white-feathered one [house-owner]" (Nínika mápuni wánako kéra-wíru, máariye), goes one line of the opening wáana song. Later in the night, after the food-offering had been stowed away in the hosts' headman's house, the guests painted their bodies bright red with kérawídzu and sang a wáana song called kérawidzuápani (dance with kérawídzu). "We have painted ourselves bright red" (Nínika kérana wánako kérawi). They also compared the color of their bodies with the bright red of kérawídzu leaves after they have been fully sun-dried and made ready for boiling and contrasted this color with the faint reddishness of newly-picked kérawídzu leaves which their bodies had resembled at the beginning of the ceremony. Although I never

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saw body painting associated with wáana dances, I have observed that shamans (malírri) cover their face and hands with red kérawídzu paint in curing rituals. In the days before modern clothing, shamans used to paint red lines and dots all over their chests, backs, shoulders and arms (Matos Arvelo 1912: 52). Thus, the use of body paints, and especially red kérawídzu paint, was a process of intensifying visual stimuli in traditional pudáli ceremonies. The shaman's use of red paint is a similar process of visual stimulation, but his heavy use of hallucinogenic snuff (dzáato) obviates the need to increase the paint's intensity by actually applying more paint.

In conclusion, déetu flute performances acted as a meta-symbolic code for defining mádzerunái and pudáli as collective processes of discontinuous change, or sickness and death as these affect the conscious likáriwa soul in íyarudáti. Pudáli ceremonies transposed shamanistic curing rituals to a collective cultural process in which ceremonially-defined host and guest groups rather than the two parts of the human soul underwent a process of breakdown, reversal, and separation into individual persons. The musical performances and dances of pudáli, or mádzerunái, collectively recreate the musical processes of increasing variation and contrast that are found in shamanistic curing songs (málirríkairi). There is another, higher level at which déetu flute performances act as a meta-symbolic code for defining pudáli as a process of breakdown, reversal, and separation that is in many ways

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analogous to shamanistic curing on a collective scale. This higher level is based on the systematic interrelations between pudáli and kwépani ceremonies, or between mádzerunái and líaka genres of dance-music. The natural life cycle of the déetu bug is the central metaphor for this complex pattern of interrelations.

Kwépani: The Dance of Kuwái

Kwépani ceremonies were social gatherings at which two local sib groups assembled to play the sacred music of the animal flutes of Kuwái and to exchange wild fruits for manioc breads. The owner of kwépani (kwépanímnali) was always the male leader of a guest group bringing a ceremonial offering of wild fruits. The display of wild fruits was directly exchanged for manioc flat-breads on the night of ceremonial music and dancing, in contrast to the delayed exchanges of smoked fish for grated manioc pulp in pudáli ceremonies. Kwépani was thus a complete exchange in one night of ceremonial events rather than a two-part cycle of ceremonial exchanges like pudáli. Kwépani expressed sacred conceptual principles of the Kuwái myth cycle, whereas pudáli in many ways enacted social rules of woman-exchange. Like the Kuwái myth cycle, kwépani began with the dichotomy between male and female.

The male versus female dichotomy was carefully maintained even before ceremonial activities of kwépani got under way. In preparation for the night of music and dancing, the owner of the ceremony organized a harvest of wild fuits

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in the forests near his village. Only men participated in the gathering of wild fruits, the preferred species being ceje grueso (punamá), ceje finito (púperri), and guaco (awíya). Other wild fruit species that were suitable, yet less preferable, for harvest and exchange in kwépani were yuku (hínirri), yurí (dumárri), and manaca (manáke). With the exception of ceje finito (púperri), all these wild fruits ripen in the long wet season of April through July, making the month of June, or Ûpitsína (time of the násа fish trap), the most common time of year for kwépani ceremonies. The ripening of ceje finito (púperri) in February was also an appropriate time for kwépani[8]. After harvesting a large quantity of wild fruits, the men returned to their village and constructed sacred animal flutes of Kuwái which the women were forbidden to see. The instruments had to be transported under a covering of palm leaves (máramápe) in a separate dug-out canoe so that women and children could not see them during the trip to the host village.

When the convoy of the kwépanímnali bearing sacred instruments and wild fruits had reached the final approach to the hosts' village, the boat carrying adult males separated from the rest of the group and waited for them to get far ahead. The women and children arrived in the hosts' village by around four in the afternoon and quickly went inside a house set aside for all women and children. The kwépanímnali and his kinsmen played the sacred animal flutes of Kuwái as they paddled over the last leg of their journey to the hosts'

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village. Entering the village, the guest men danced in a procession and played a number of different instruments. Younger men carried the offering of wild fruits up onto the village plaza and piled it in front of the host men. The three waliáduwa flutes, said to represent the three outer fingers of Kuwái's right hand, always came first, followed by the two máario (white heron) flutes that represent the thumb and forefinger of Kuwái's right hand. The only other wind instrument that was invariably played in kwépani was the molítu (species of small frog) flute. The other wind instruments were named after animal and bird species, and each one also represented a different part of Kuwái's body. The particular flutes and trumpets of this category which the men played in kwépani depended upon the species of wild fruits being offered to the hosts. The dzáte (toucan) flutes, for example, were constructed and played in kwépani only when ceje (either púperri or punamá) was harvested and exchanged, because ceje is known to be the favorite food of toucans. However, if yurí or yuku were being offered in kwépani, then the guest men would construct dápa (paca) flutes representing the upper right arm of Kuwái, since these fruits are preferred food of the paca. Sometimes, only a change of name and decoration was needed to convert one type of flutes into another. The dápa flutes, for example, could be played in kwépani ceremonies in which ceje fruits were exchanged by simply changing their names to tsítsi (a species of monkey).

In the opening dance of kwépani, the host men stood in a

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line, shoulder to shoulder, while the guest men danced in a circle in front of them around the heap of wild fruits. The principal costume of all the men consisted of a crown of ceje-palm leaves with a bundle of wild fruits tied on and hanging down the back. In addition, long strands of sweet-smelling tsipátsi grass were tucked into the headdresses of ceje leaves (púperrípe) and hung down over the men's shoulders. The kwépanímnali and host headman (pantímnali, or house-owner) wore special capes made of various small pieces of animal furs patched together. These capes are said to have represented the skins of all forest animal species and refer to the episode of the Kuwái myth cycle in which Iñápirríkuli used furs of various animal species to trick Amáru into believing that Kuwái's flutes had indeed turned into animal species.

The music of waliáduwa flutes provided the main theme of opening dance-music of the líaka genre in kwépani (see Figure 9.10). The music formed a set piece that was invariably played in the opening dances. Waliáduwa is the only type of wind instrument in the líaka genre that is not named after a forest animal or bird species. Wáli- is a prefix meaning 'new' or 'newly', and -áduwa is an adjectival suffix widely used in málikai chants for the sacred food (káridzámai) of newborn infants and their parents. The suffix -áduwa is used there to make up spirit-names of animal and fish species, such as kúlikuliáduwa, or parakeet (kúlikúli) -like (-áduwa), referring to cabezón turtles. The prefix wáli- is also fre-

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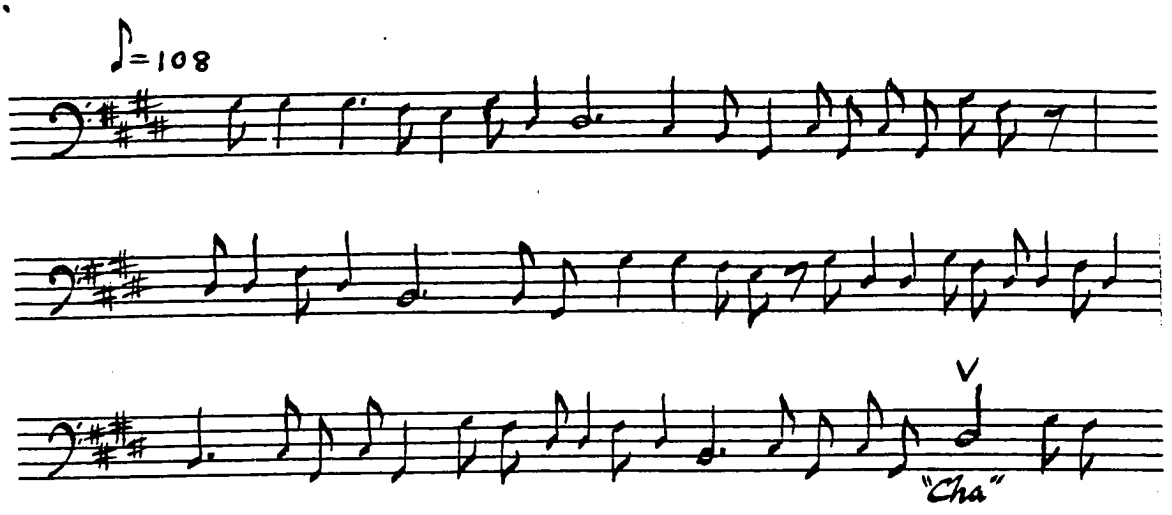


Figure 9.10. Transcription of the waliáduwa flute melody from the opening dances of kwépani; melody sung by headman of Gavilán. "Cha" is a vocal representation of the sound of kapéti whips as they strike male dancers.

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quently used in málikai chants for káridzámai in childbirth rituals and in kapetiápani dance-songs for male and female initiation rituals to refer to individuals who have entered a new status: válikáni-rú ("her new one", or the mother's new-born infant), válimerú (newly initiated girl), and válit'áki (newly-fasted one). The term waliáduwa, used in kwépani ceremonies to refer to the most important set of flutes, is said to refer also to an old woman. The paradoxical juxtaposition of opposite meanings attributed to the term waliáduwa is a key to understanding ceremonial behavior in kwépani. Waliáduwa literally means `new-like' and yet carries an implicit meaning of `elderly' because waliáduwa performances were a renewal process in which all adult men past the age of initiation collectively administered and received lashings with dance-whips (kapéti). While the host men watched, the guest men dancing immediately behind the waliáduwa players at the front of the procession lashed them with kapéti whips (made of dzámakuápi vines or other material but not from kadápu wood used to make initiation whips). The loud sounds of the whips striking across the waliáduwa players' backs punctuated the mournful sounding melody which they played on their flutes. Male human bodies were thus transformed into the ultimate percussive instruments in waliáduwa flute music, a transformation that constituted the final link in a chain of sacred musical performances using whips as a rhythm instrument: from the metaphorical use of whips to beat the rawness out of food by naming líwanápu éenu

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in childbirth rituals, to the actual use of whips to beat out the binary rhythm of chants in initiation rituals and to lash the initiants, and finally to the lashing of male human bodies with whips as part of a collective musical performance and dance.

After completing their opening waliáduwa dance, the guest men each gave two ritual lashes to the host men, who raised their arms overhead and received the lashes without revealing any of the pain that they felt. The same waliáduwa dance was then repeated, only with the host men playing the flutes and doing the whipping while the guest men silently observed the dance and then received two lashes each. The reversal of male roles in waliáduwa and the collective whipping ceremony led to a set of kapetiápani dance-songs that started outside on the village plaza and gradually penetrated inside the house where women and children waited in total seclusion. While most of the men participated in kapetiápani, two men were assigned the duty of removing the sacred flutes from the dancing ground to a port at the river's edge designated as off limits to women and children. The sets of instruments belonging to hosts and guests were deliberately mixed up in a single heap so that in later dances there would be no distinction between flutes made by the host and guest men. The two men stood guard over the pile of flutes until the next dance. Meanwhile, the other men had entered the women's house to dance with them and sing the song of kapetiápani for kwépani and male initiation. A dis-

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tinctly different song of kapetiápani is sung in female initiation rituals during interludes between málikai chants for káridzámai. Both songs (see Figure 9.11) are accompanied by a rhythmical beating of the handle of kapéti whips against the ground as the dancers heavily step down on the right foot.

At the end of kapetiápani inside the women's house, the host headman (pantímnali) announced that women could go to bathe or fetch water from the main port, as long as they were careful not to go near the secondary port where the pile of sacred flutes was being guarded. The hosts and guests mingled on the village plaza while their two headmen stood facing one another across the displayed pile of wild fruits. The kwépanímnali made a formal speech of offering, and the pantímnali politely accepted the fruits, saying that he was grateful for all the hard work his guests had done to collect the fruits. The fruits were then stowed away inside the host headman's house, and the hosts then brought out a large display of manioc flat-breads as a return offering to their guests. When the food had been stowed away, the kwépanímnali asked his hosts for fermented manioc and fruit drinks. After a round of drinking on the plaza that lasted until about eleven at night, the women and children were sent back into seclusion, and the men went down to the river to bring out the sacred flutes for a second time.

During the hour before midnight, men played special performances on the molítu flutes in which they communicated in a semi-verbal, semi-instrumental speech form with women in-

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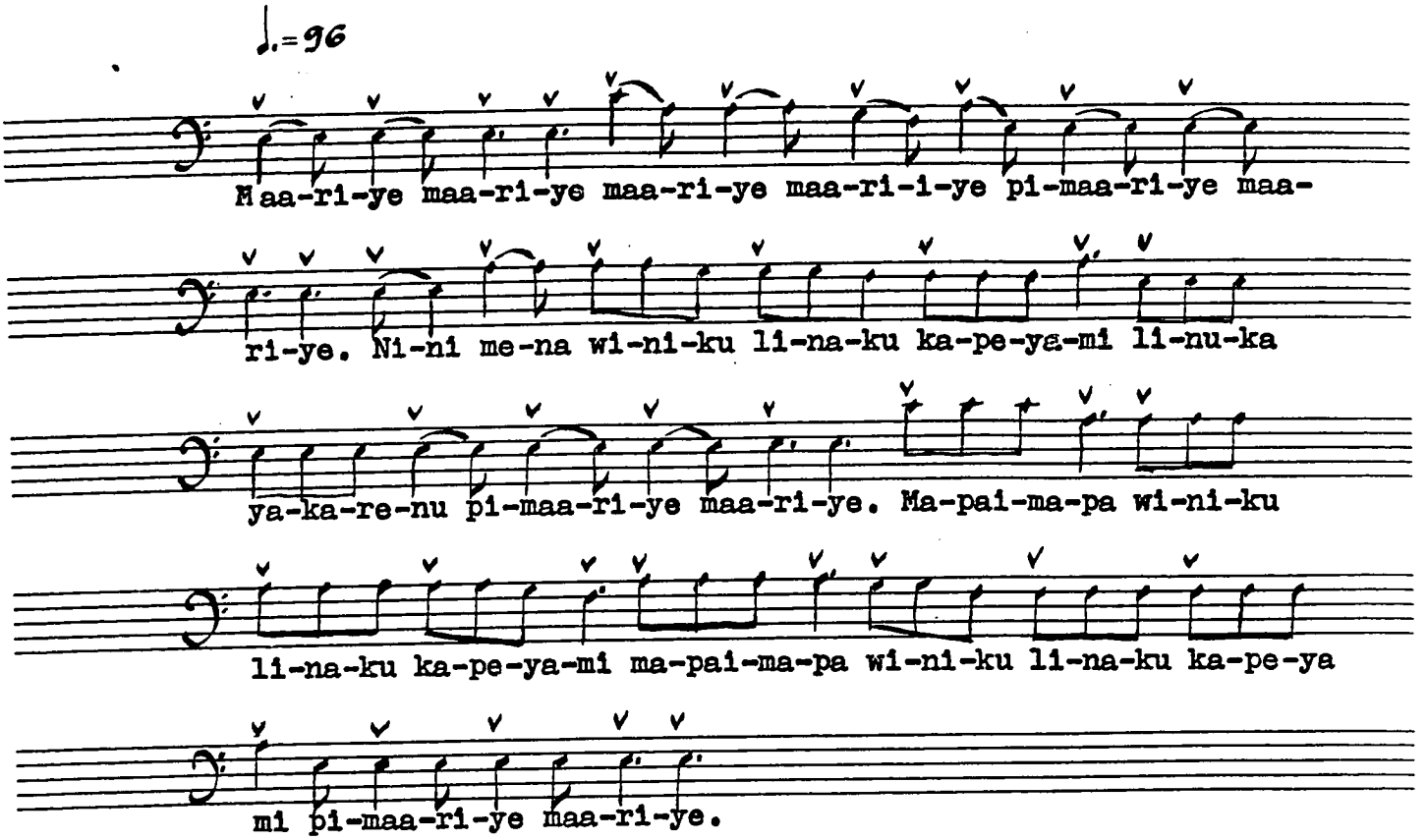


Figure 9.11. Transcription of melody and verses from kapetiapani song-dance performed in kwepani and male initiation rituals. Rhythmical beats of kapeti whips against ground are denoted by V .

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Máariye, máariye.
(White-feathered one, or headman.)

Úpaimapá wíniku línaku kápeyamí.
(We dance with kapeti without shame.)

Mápaimapá wíniku línaku, yákare-nú.
(We are without fear here in my village.)

Mápaiména línuka kúreyunú.
(He comes without fear of the whip.)

Mápimapá wíniku línaku yúliapumí.
(Without fear we are here with sweet-smelling whips.)

Mápaimapá wánuka línaku kápeyamí.
(Without fear we come here to dance kapeti.)

Wíči-wíčí wánuka línaku kápeyamí.
(We come here to play kapeti.)

Mápaiména línuka wáminalí yákare-nú.
(Without fear our master Kuwai comes to my village.)

Nínina mápaiména liyénaka liukénam.
(We are without fear of the standing yebaro tree.)

Níni pína liúmeni liúnuka wáminalí.
(Our master, [Kuwái], comes smelling sweetly.)

Kúyuríma púmeni yúnuka wáminalí.
(Like the sweet-smelling kúyuríma tree, our master comes.)

Wáména wánuka wápuniwá línuka yákare-nú.
(We come drinking liquor; he comes to my village.)

Níni núma kápuni wáminalí.
(I want liquor for our master.)

Níni yúripatá, línuka yúliapumí.
(He comes to the sweet-smelling whips.)

Figure 9.11 (cont.). Text and translation of kapetiápani song from kwépani and male initiation rituals.

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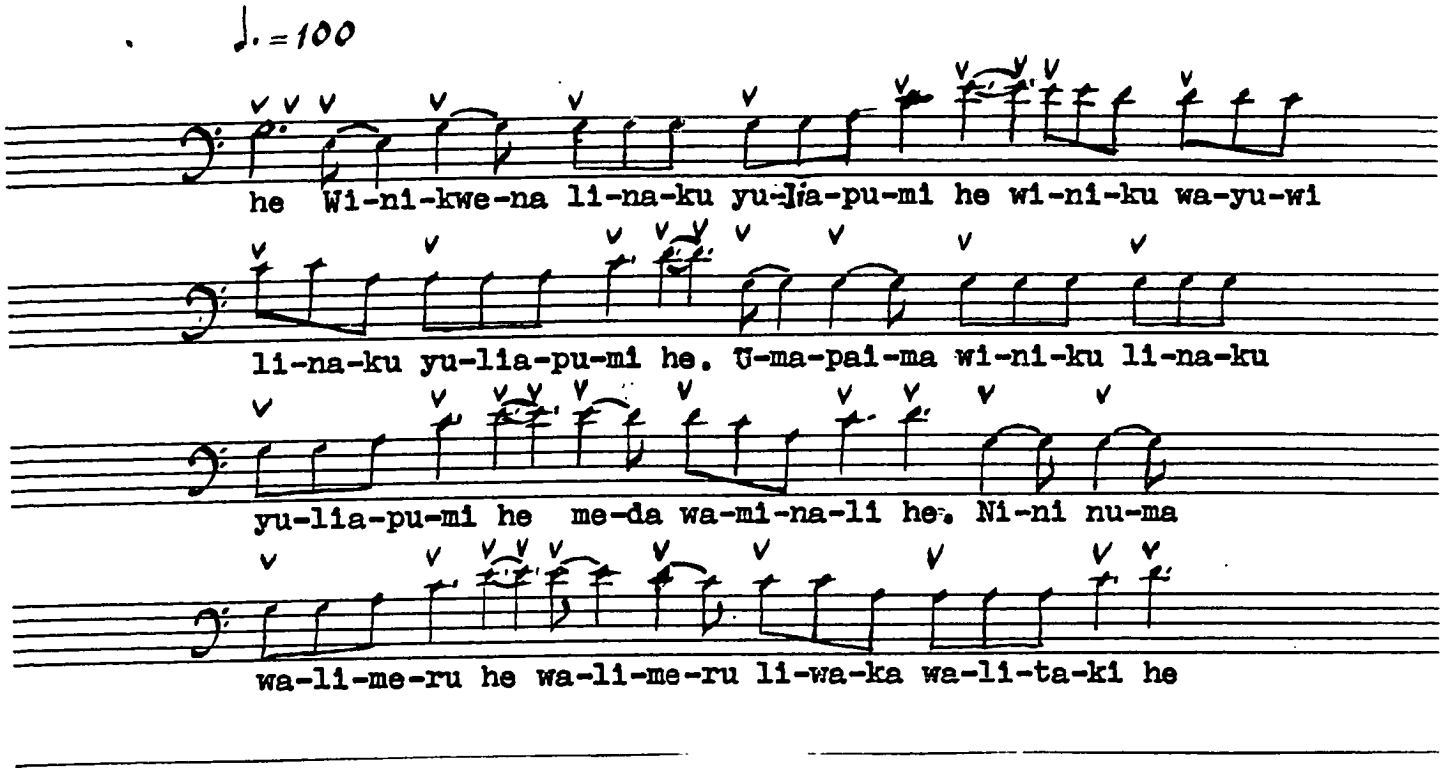


Figure 9.11 (cont.). Transcription of melody and verses from kapetiapani song-dance performed in female initiation rituals. Rhythmical beats of kapeti whips against ground are denoted by V .

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Níni númaka wálimerú, wálit'aki.
(I want the girl-initiant, the newly fasted one.)

Níni núminalí, Kuwáikamésha-mí.
(My master, Kuwai's sacred flutes.)

Níni númaka puménika túre pána numá.
(I want the palm-leaf door of seclusion to be sweet-smelling.)

Níni númaka kátima wánuka-wá, túre pána numá.
(I want us to be happy as we arrive at the door of the girl's seclusion hut.)

Níni númaka yúpuni wálimerú.
(I want liquor for the girl-initiant.)

Figure 9.11 (cont.). Text and translation from kapétiapani song performed only in female initiation rituals.

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side the seclusion house. When the women heard a molítu flute player, they asked him who was his 'owner'. The man playing the flute could not answer with his own name but had to give aother man's name to protect his own identity. The molítu flute, which I never actually observed, was a short, thick piece of macanilla palmwood that produced only a single tone. By holding one hand over the opening of the flute opposite the mouthpiece, a performer could produce semi-distinct syllables and words. Releasing his hand quickly at each 'word', he spoke into the flute by forming the appropriate lip and mouth shapes as he blew air into the instrument without actually voicing any of the syllables, for to do so might give away his personal identity and ruin the effectiveness of the performance. Once the molítu player had passed the test of disguising his identity from the women, he transformed into a sort of musical oracle to which pregnant women could address the question of whether their unborn children would turn out to be male or female. The molítu player's answer was believed to invariably come true[9]. Figure 9.12 is a transcription of some question and answer dialogues between women and molítu flute players which I elicited from Hernando Camico in a taped interview.

At midnight, the men performed a second waliáduwa dance and whipping ceremony, this time in a somewhat more cheerful melody with dotted rhythms (see Figure 9.13). Like the opening waliáduwa dance, the second dance was played with the shorter, 'male' flute accompanied by the longest of the three

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Women: Molítu?

Molitu: Mu.

Women: Kwáka lipítana limínali?
(What is the name of your owner?)

Molitu: Juan, Mu, Muan, Mu.

Women: Kwámi?
(What?)
Molitu: Juan, Mu.

Women: Óh-hon.
(Yes, OK).

Women: Molítu? Kwáka ruénipe sruátaha kewédani?
(Molitu? What sex will her unborn child have?)

Molitu: Ínarruátsa, ínarruátsa, mu.
(female)
Women: Kwámi?
(what?)
Molitu: Ínarruátsa.

Molitu: Mu, mu, mu. Mu-tu-ru-ru.

Women: Pímaka píra turúru, molítu?
(Do you want to drink liquor, molitu?)
Molitu: Oh-hon, mu, óh-hon.
(Yes, yes.)

Figure 9.12. Transcription of dialogues between mólitu flute player and women during kwépani.

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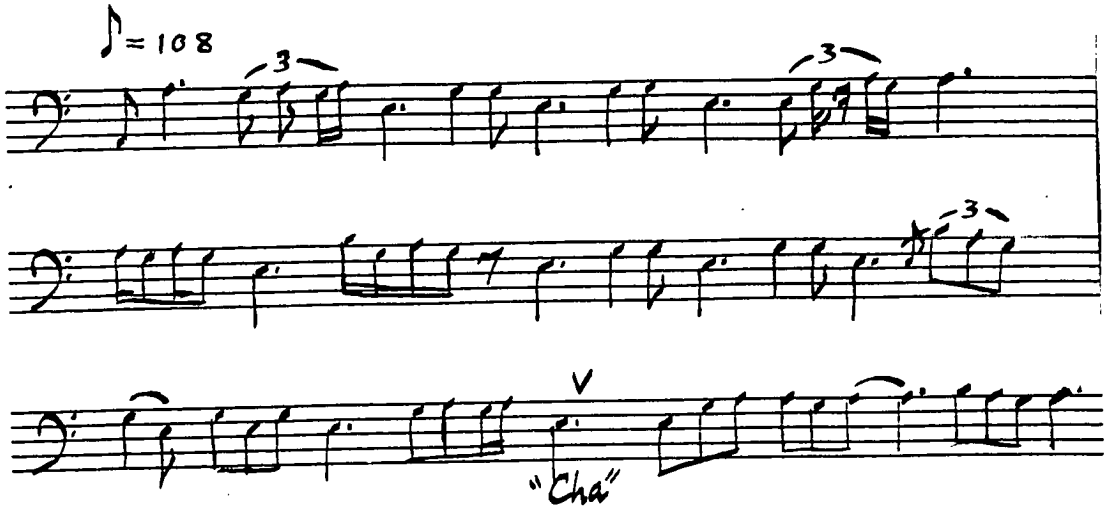


Figure 9.13. Transcription of the waliáduwa flute melody played in kwépani at midnight (demonstration sung by headman of Gavilán).

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flutes, considered to have no specific sex. In both waliáduwa dances, the middle-sized, `female' flute was carried by a third dancer but not played. Again, male human bodies were struck with kapéti whips during the dancing and music, punctuating the music with a sharp percussive sound like a clashing of cymbals. After midnight, a period of drinking and kapetiápani dance-songs (the same song as in the early evening) lasted until shortly before dawn. The molítu flute players were no longer asked questions but became instruments for asking women for fermented drinks. The molítu player named a woman inside the house, and she was obliged to slip a pot of wine or beer to the flute player outside through a partially opened door. Giving liquor in this fashion was an act requiring bravery and care on the woman's part, since she had to be careful not to see even the hand of the flute player receiving the drink for fear of learning his identity.

The molítu players' asking for drinks from women was an important symbolic act that led up to the third and final dance with the sacred flutes. This dance, called tsépani, commemorated the mythical act in which Kuwái ate Máarinárièni, one of the three young nephews of Iñápirríkuli who broke his fast by eating guaco (awíya) fruits[10]. The music and dancing were led by two máario (white heron) flute players (see Figure 9.14) and later joined by two men playing a melodic passage on the middle-sized, or `female', and the longest, or `non-sexed', waliáduwa flutes. Tsépani marked the end of kwépani, and both hosts and guests were allowed to eat

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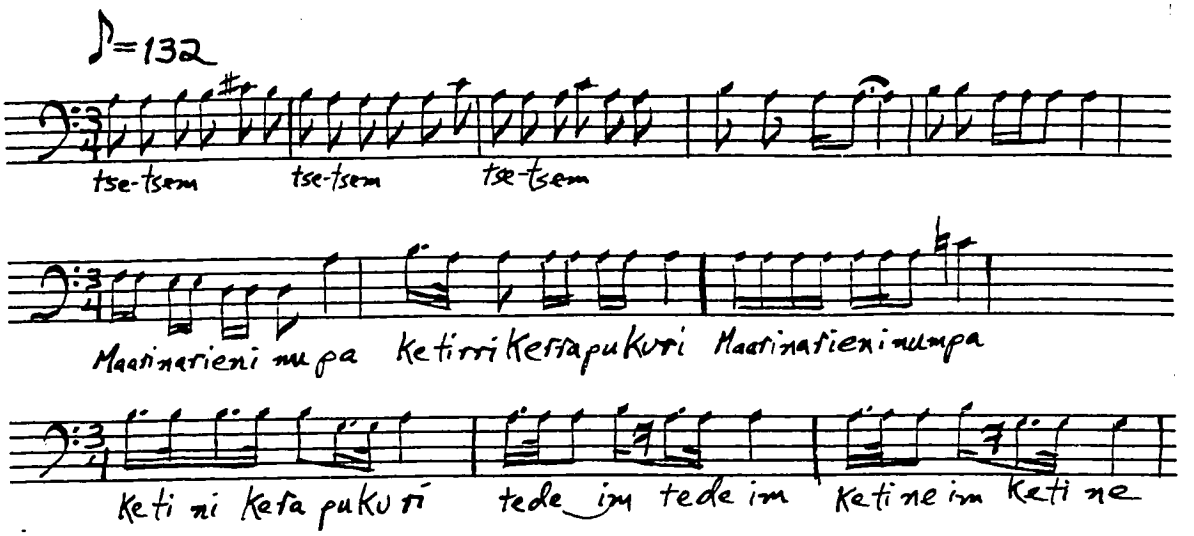


Figure 9.14. Transcription of máario flute melody from the closing dance in kwépani, called tsépani. The verses refer to Máarinári éni, a nephew of Iñápirríkuli who prematurely broke his ritual fast by eating fish (kérrapú-kurri) and who was in turn eaten by Kuwái.

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again after a night of fasting and drinking. Tsépani-kwá dzákaré is a location along the upper Isana River named in the final chants of initiation rituals and is the place where Kuwái is believed to have performed the first tsépani in myth prior to eating the three boys who had broken their ritual fast. Later, Kuwái vomited the three boys' remains onto the rocks at a rapids named after him (Raudal Yurupari, or Kuwái) farther upstream on the Isana than Tsépani-kwá dzákaré.

Analysis of Kwépani and the Líaka Genre of Musical Performance

Earlier I noted that the double meaning of the term waliáduwa is a key to understanding ceremonial behavior in traditional kwépani ceremonies. The paradoxical juxtaposition of the literal meaning, `new-like', and the implicit meaning, `elderly', suggest that the collective whipping in waliáduwa dances was a cultural process of collective renewal rather than a transformation of personal identity as in the whipping of male and female initiants. One indication of the difference between kwépani as a process of collective renewal and initiation as a process of personal transformation (or musical `cooking') is the distinction between kapéti dance-whips used in kwépani and the kadápu whips used in initiation rituals. Kapéti dance-whips are made from dzámakuápi vines or any similar type of wood, whereas kadápu whips are made only from the type of wood called kadápu, the only material considered appropriate for beating the`rawness' out of initiants. By implication, kapéti are not as powerful as kadápu

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whips insofar as they are considered unusable for effecting the transformational `cooking' of personal identities in initiation rituals. Thus, although the collective whippings in waliáduwa dances of kwépani superficially resembled a collective enactment of initiation whippings, the distinction between ceremonial kapéti whips and sacred kadápu whips implies that waliáduwa dances were concerned with a related, yet quite different, cultural process.

The double meaning of waliáduwa as `new-like' and `elderly' is a juxtaposition implying that kwépani ceremonies were essentially concerned with childbirth as a physiological process that has double cultural interpretations. For the `new-like' child (kérramu), childbirth is the beginning of rapid growth processes that are put into an order of sameness through musical `cooking' in childbirth rituals. For the `elderly' parents (kinénerri and kinédua), childbirth is the continuation of an aging process through which parents gradually become grandparents or great-grandparents and, in doing so, are moved into an increasingly close identification with the mythical sib ancestor spirits (líwarúna) in the celestial paradise. Both childhood growth and the aging process that results from repeated childbirths are continuous processes of change, whereas initiation and the fate of the conscious, human body-shaped souls (likáriwa) after death are discontinuous processes of change. The juxtaposition of new and old in the term waliáduwa is related to the bee-spirits (Kuwáiñai) in the myth in which they are portrayed as old men

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who are no taller than pubescent boys. The bee-spirits are gatekeepers to the celestial paradise for the líwarúna souls after death. The journey of líwarúna souls after death is a continuous process of change insofar as they are not believed to suffer a painful period of separation in íyarudáti as are the recently-deceased lidánam souls. Ultimately, waliáduwa performances in traditional kwépani ceremonies were a cultural process of collective renewal based on the paradoxical juxtaposition of childhood growth and death.

The dual concern with childhood growth and death in kwépani was most clearly discernible in the transition from the late-night performances on molítu flutes to the final dance, called tsépani. The molítu flute performances in which pregnant women asked whether their children would be born male or female acted as a meta-symbolic code, or musical performance about performances, that defined kwépani and the líaka genre of dance-music as a cultural process of orderly, collectively controlled growth. The molítu flute player spoke for men as a group and their power to control processes of gestation, childbirth, and growth. In initiation rituals, incidentally, the molítu flute performances embodied a parallel meta-symbolism only with respect to individual male control, in the person of the málikai-owner, over the personal transformation of pubescent girls. The girl's mother asked the molítu flute player if the málikai-owner had done a good job of chanting and blowing tobacco smoke over her daughter's sacred food (káridzámai). The molítu player, of course, in-

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variably sang back, "Oh-hon, oh-hon" ("Yes, yes"), assuring the woman that her daughter's spiritual transformation was in good hands. In kwépani, the belief that pregnant women can determine the sex of their unborn children by asking the molítu flute player was an assurance of collective, male control over the processes of gestation, childbirth, and childhood growth. In the Kuwái myth cycle, Iñápirríkuli stole the animal flutes of Kuwái back from Amáru and the women with the help of an army of kinsmen who came disguised as molítu frogs. Thus, molítu frogs are important in both myth and ritual as symbols of collective, male control over Kuwái and the processes of human conception, birth, and growth which he embodies.

The connection between childbirth and death in kwépani ceremonies was acted out in the transformation of molítu flute players after the second waliáduwa dance and ceremonial whipping at midnight. Whereas prior to the second waliáduwa dance the molítu flute players asserted collective male control over childbirth, afterwards they transformed into a mere spokesmen for the men's desire to drink. This drastic reduction in the power attributed to molítu flute players was a total reversal from activity to passivity, from a control over vital life processes to a submisson to the women's control. The final dance of kwépani, or tsépani, centered around the mythical death of Máarinárieni, a symbol of childhood growth in conjunction with death. The movement from male control over childbirth and related physiological processes to

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female control was also evident in the changing of `sex' in waliáduwa flutes. In tsépani, only the middle-sized, or `female', flute was played with the longest, or `non-sexed', flute, whereas in the first two waliáduwa dances, the male rather than the female flute had been played with the non-sexed flute. Tsépani equated the loss of male control over childbirth and childhood growth with the fate of Máarinárièni, who was eaten alive by Kuwái, thereby short-circuiting the male-owned process of transformation through initiaton rituals.

Tsépani brought kwépani ceremonies to an abrupt ending just at the point of departure between male control over the transformation of childhood growth through initiation rituals and female control that was symbolically equated with childhood death through being swallowed up, a return ab origine into the womb of Amáru or the belly of Kuwái. Tsépani stopped just short of Kuwái's mythical vomitting of the three boys' remains and his return to teach the sacred songs and chants of initiation rituals. To invoke these mythical images would have brought kwépani into the realm of the presexual in which sexual differences are reversible if not even insignificant, the way they are portrayed in dzawírra dances in the final stage of pudáli ceremonies. Kwépani expressed the sexual dichotomy in frightening clarity: male control over reproductive and growth processes could only be reversed or relinquished at the cost of childhood death.

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Comparative Analysis of Líaka and Mádzerunái

As was the case with the déetu flutes of pudáli, the molítu flutes of kwépani had no particular sex attributed to them and were used in performances as pivotal, meta-symbolic devices, or musical performances about other musical performances of the same genre, including themselves. In kwépani ceremonies, the molítu flute players were transformed from symbols of collective male control over sexual reproduction and childhood growth into symbols of childhood death as a result of the loss of collective male control to females. The transformation of molítu flute players in kwépani ceremonies constructed an interpretive framework within which childbirth and death were intelligible as continuous processes of change as a consequence of the opposition between the sexes as groups. The perspective on childbirth and death in kwépani was diametrically opposed to the expression of presexual, spontaneous generativity in pudáli ceremonies. There, déetu flute performances collectively acted out the shaman's activities of sucking and vomitting and defined pudáli and the mádzerunái genre of dance-music as a discontinuous process of breakdown, reversal, and separation in which male and female sexuality became thoroughly intertwined, indistinguishable, and insignificant. Although both molítu and déetu flutes were regarded as not having a sex and both played pivotal, transformative roles in the respective ceremonies, their uses resulted in diametrically opposed views of human reproduction, growth, and death.

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The opposition between molítu flutes of kwépani and déetu flutes of pudáli was part of a larger set of oppositions between the musical instruments, performances, and dances of the líaka and mádzerunái genres, all of which gravitated around the underlying opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change. First, the sexing of flutes according to relative length is opposite in the two musical genres. In mádzerunái, the longer, thicker máwi and tsikóta flutes are considered to be male, whereas the shorter, slightly thinner flutes of each pair are regarded as female. However, waliáduwa and máario flutes of the líaka genre are sexed in accordance with exactly the opposite rule: male flutes are shorter and slightly thinner, whereas the longer, thicker flutes are female. The fact that the longest of the three flutes of waliáduwa is said to have no sex at all is an extension of the reversal of the long=male, short=female rule of mádzerunái, provided that the assumption that the non-sexed waliáduwa flute corresponds to the unborn child (whose sex is `determined' by asking the molítu flute) is accepted. The importance of these rules of sexing as a key to understanding the opposition between líaka and mádzerunái genres of ceremonial dance-music is reflected in the special category of nominal classifiers reserved only for flutes that come in male and female pairs (see Chapter 5).

Another dimension of the opposition between the sacred animal flutes of Kuwái and the máwi flutes of pudáli is the

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way in which palmwoods are used in constructing the two categories of instruments. I never saw the sacred animal flutes of Kuwái because I was unable to be in the field during the season of their construction and use. However, I learned that each pair or set of the instruments has to be constructed out of a single, continuous section of hollowed-out macanilla wood. The three waliáduwa flutes, for example, are always made from the trunk of a single palmtree, and the men must avoid cutting away any of the wood between each of the three logs. A clean cut must be made in between each log so that the mouthpiece of the longer and thicker, female flute is identical in circumference to the lower end of the shorter and thinner, male flute. Thus, each set of waliáduwa, máario, or other flutes of the líaka genre constituted a material symbol of continuous plant growth when played together in kwépani. In opposition to this symbolism, each individual máwi, tsikóta, déetu, or other flute of the mádzerunái genre has to be cut from the trunk of a separate mabe (máwi) tree, a practice which I observed several times during my fieldwork. Thus, flutes of the líaka genre use plant materials to convey an idea of continuous processes of growth, whereas flutes of the mádzerunái genre use such materials to communicate the opposite sense of discontinuous, separate processes of growth.

Another way in which the líaka genre of performances communicated continuous processes of change was through musical instrumentation. The waliáduwa flutes were played in

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the opening dances, the second dance at midnight after the exchange of wild fruits and manioc products, and finally in the last dance, tsépani. In spite of the important transition from use of the male to the female flute between the second and third dances, the use of the non-sexed flute to play a bass-note accompaniment in all three dances rendered the set of three waliáduwa flutes an ideal symbolic mechanism for conveying a continuous process of change. Also, a third man always carried the flute not being used in any given dance so that all three flutes were present in all three dances, even if not all played at once. The three waliáduwa dances actually outlined an additive, continuous process of change by sequentially combining melodic passages on the máario and waliáduwa flutes in the final dance, or tsépani. The only instrument played separately in kwépani was the molítu flute, and these solo performances acted as a special kind of meta-symbolic code for the interpretation of other musical performances during the night of kwépani. The molítu flute performances were in a class by themselves because they brought about the transition from the use of male waliáduwa flutes in the second dance to the use of female ones in tsépani.

Opposite to the continuous use of waliáduwa flutes in kwépani ceremonies was the process of separating déetu flutes, kúlirína trumpets, and wáana dance-songs from their combined use with máwi and tsikóta flutes in the first stage of pudáli ceremonies. The performances of mádzerunái in pudáli communicated a discontinuous process of change through

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removal of the máwi and tsikóta flutes during performances in the late-night period when the food-offering was stowed inside the hosts' house. Pudáli culminated in performances by separate pairs of máwi flutes, such as the dzawírra duets after the redistribution of the food-offering. Pudáli and the mádzerunái genre of ceremonial music thus outlined a discontinuous process of separation, or subtraction, whereas kwépani and the líaka genre described a continuous process of combination, or addition, of musical instruments.

The same opposition between líaka and mádzerunái was evident in the difference between kapetiápani dance-songs in kwépani and the wáana dance-songs of pudáli. In kwépani, men sang the exact same song of kapetiápani in the evening prior to the ceremonial exchange of wild fruits and manioc breads and in the late-night period after midnight, between the second waliáduwa dance and tsépani. The melody, verses, rhythm, and choreography remained unchanged in the earlier and later performances of kapetiápani in kwépani. Also, the melody of this kapetiápani song was nearly identical to the melody played on male and non-sexed waliáduwa flutes in the opening dance of kwépani (see Figures 9.10 and 9.11). Thus, kapetiápani added an additional, musical sense of continuous processes of change in kwépani ceremonies by carrying over the same melodic themes, song text, and dance from the early evening to the late-night period. The wáana dance-songs of pudáli ceremonies also carried over a musical melody from the first stage of the ceremony until the end of the late-night

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period. However, wáana song texts completely transformed in the course of pudáli, and these changes were accompanied by changes in body-painting, style of dancing, and other dimensions of performance. The dzudzuápani dance-song sharply diverged from all the earlier wáana dances by literally tying together a male and female pair of dancers with strings connected to long, hand-held poles and a miniature 'fish net' held over the fire.

In more general terms, music of the líaka genre performed in kwépani followed a relatively fixed order of change in which there was little room for variation or contrast. In the second and third waliáduwa dances, the music changed considerably but without showing any increased variation. Even in the final dance, tsépani, where there was a musical contrast between the higher-pitched melody of the two máario flutes and the deeper melody of waliáduwa flutes, neither melody demonstrated any elaboration of a single theme into multiple variations but simply repeated a single theme with little alteration (see Figure 9.14). In short, music of the líaka genre did not include anything nearly as complex and varied as máwi flute duets, such as the dzawírra dance, that were performed in the final stage of pudáli (see Figures 9.2, 9.3, and 9.4).

Finally, kwépani and pudáli ceremonies, seen as whole events, acted out an opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change in terms of the exchange of food products and other objects. The kwépanímnali offered

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wild fruits to the hosts' headman, or pantímnali, and in return was directly repaid with manioc breads. The exchange of food was direct and reciprocal in kwépani ceremonies, and the food ceased to be an object of symbolic thought or action immediately after the exchange. The two headmen simply took the food away, and that was the end of its importance in the ceremony. In pudáli ceremonies, however, the food-offering continued to play an important role as a symbol of the disintegration process even after it had been stowed away inside the house of the pantímnali. The redistribution of the food in the early morning symbolized the breakdown of collective host versus guest identities in the final stage of pudáli and marked the beginning of individualized máwi flute duets with animal names. Of course, pudáli also conveyed the sense of discontinuous exchanges through the delaying of a closing, female-owned ceremony for a period of several weeks. The pudalímnaru (female owner of pudáli) organized a reciprocal offering of grated manioc pulp, but not until a few weeks had elapsed during which she and her husband's kinsmen remained indebted to the male-owner of the first ceremony.

Simultaneous with the exchange of food in kwépani and pudáli ceremonies, hosts and guests exchanged a variety of cultural artifacts. Exchanges of musical instruments were perhaps the most closely tied to the symbolism of food exchanges. In kwépani, the sacred animal flutes of Kuwái belonging to the guest and host men were all heaped into a single pile and mixed around so that after the food exchange,

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there was no longer any distinction made between instruments belonging to the guests and those owned by the hosts. In pudáli ceremonies, however, musical instruments were never mixed up in this manner but were always kept in separate locations by their respective owners. At the end of pudáli, the guest men took home all their musical instruments and ceremonial headdresses except for the kúlirína trumpets, which the guests formally offered to the hosts at the end of the late-night period in male-owned ceremonies. The kúlirína trumpets thus acted as a key symbol of the discontinuity of exchange in pudáli cycles, since the instrument served as a constant reminder to the hosts of the opening ceremony that they had an obligation to reciprocate in a later,female-owned ceremony. No musical instruments were given to the hosts in closing, female-owned ceremonies, since the exchange cycle was formally 'squared' through the offering of grated manioc pulp. In traditional pudáli cycles, a number of cultural artifacts aside from musical instruments were also exchanged. Male owners of pudáli frequently added woven articles, such as colorful baskets and manioc presses (tírurrípi), to make the display of smoked fish more attractive and impressive. Weaving is generally a male activity that was traditionally taught to male initiants during their month-long ritual fast at puberty. The kúlirína trumpets are also largely a woven artifact made by men, and the resonators very much resemble manioc presses until a thick layer of boiled maíni resin is applied. Female- owners of pudáli enhanced their offering of

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grated manioc pulp with decorated pottery[11] and hammocks made from the strands of a cultivated plant species (S.,Bromelia).

In both kwépani and pudáli ceremonies, exchanges of food and cultural artifacts paralleled cultural processes that more directly affected personal and collective identities. In kwépani, the guest and host men exchanged lashes across their backs with kapéti dance-whips. The collective giving and taking of pain was the price men paid for being the 'controllers' of human reproductive and growth processes. Like the ceremonial exchange of foods in kwépani, the whipping lasted only in the first part of the ceremony, up through the second waliáduwa dance at midnight. This dance symbolized the completion of the host and guest men's exchange of pain through whipping, since they no longer made any distinction between guest- and host-owned Kuwái flutes. The second waliáduwa dance was the highest expression of male solidarity in kwépani. Afterwards, the men's loss of control over the flutes, acted out in the transformation of molítu flute performances, resulted in the juxtaposition of childhood growth and death in tsépani. There was no whipping, or collective exchange of pain, in tsépani because the men no longer 'owned' (symbolically controlled) the sacred flutes of Kuwái but had lost control to the women. In tsépani, the men had lost the need to pay the price for owning Kuwái.

In pudáli ceremonies, the exchange process centered around female dancers rather than male pain. The hosts and guest remained separate during the opening dances, prior to

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the formal offering of food. However, in the late-night period, the two groups danced together around the fire. After the redistribution of food in the early morning, individual women of the guest group were allowed to dance as partners of male flute players from the host group and vice-versa. The symbolic exchange of female dancers in pudáli ceremonies was a gradual, indirect process that only reached open expression on the day after the redistribution of food. The cultural exchange process in pudáli was thus in total opposition to the collective exchange of pain in kwépani ceremonies insofar as the latter was enacted at the very beginning of ceremonial events and had concluded when these events were still only half-finished at midnight.

Metamorphosis of the Ceje-Palm Grub (Mútsi)

The líaka and mádzerunái genres of ceremonial musical performance employed a variety of musical and choreographic symbolism in traditional kwépani and pudáli ceremonies that set up an opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of (ex-) change. Líaka and mádzerunái constructed on a collective scale the same opposition between the principles of sameness and uniqueness found in musical `cooking´ and between the unchanging journey of Kuwáikanérri and the changing journey of shamans (malírri) found in musical `rotting´. Figure 9.15 shows how líaka and mádzerunái reproduce the opposition between processes that operate also in musical `cooking´ and `rotting´ only on a different scale. The ceremonial musical performance genres act on collective

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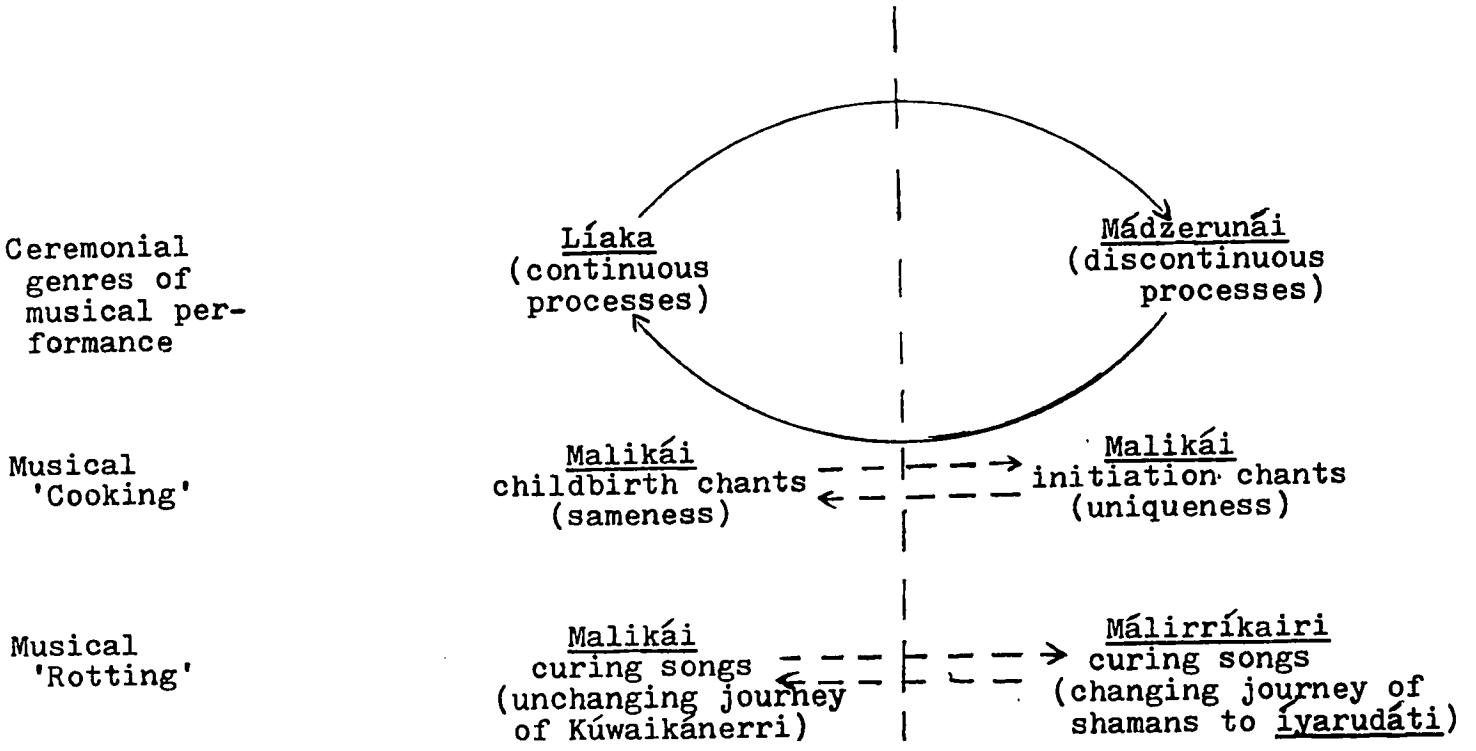


Figure 9.15. An 'etic' classification of sacred and ceremonial genres of Wakuénai musical performances based on underlying opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes

identities of different local sib groups, whereas the sacred genres (málikai and málirríkairi) are concerned with the formation and maintenance of personal identities within a single local sib group. The opposition between líaka and mádzerunái genres makes clear the opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change in a way that the two types of musical 'cooking' do not, since both childbirth and initiation chants are part of the same genre, málikai, and they sound deceptively alike on first hearing.

Beyond making clear the opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change, líaka and mádzerunái also demonstrate how these two opposing classes of process form parts of a hierarchical system of meaning in which lower level oppositions are coordinated at the highest level. The opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change, and the accompanying social opposition between male/female and host/guest (kin/affine) relations, is mediated at the highest level in such a way that the unchanging and the changing, the continuous and the discontinuous, and the sexual and the presexual are all articulated into a single, ambiguous whole. As might be expected, the transitional, meta-symbolic molítu and déetu flute performances provided the points of intersection between the otherwise opposed líaka and mádzerunái genres. Both molítu and déetu flutes are considered to be 'non-sexed' instruments, and their use in traditional kwépani and pudáli ceremonies came at critical transitions in the flow of ceremonial events.

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The coordinating effect of molítu flute performances arose from the dual symbolic importance of molítu frogs in Wakuénai culture. On the one hand, molítu frogs symbolized the regaining of male control over Kuwái and the life processes which he embodies. Iñápirríkuli's kinsmen disguised themselves as molítu frogs when they went to Amáru's home at Mútsipáni (dance of the ceje-palm grub) in order to take the Kuwái flutes away from the women . On the other hand, molítu frogs acted as an important ecological indicator of the annual cycle of agricultural activities (see Chapter 3) and for this reason were regarded as the children of Káali, the mythical owner and originator of manioc and all other cultivated plant species. The molítu frog is symbolically classified as a Káaliéni, the same mythical category to which máwi flutes, kúlirína trumpets, déetu flutes, and all the other musical instruments, songs, melodies, and dances of the mádzerunái genre are assigned. The ambiguity of molítu flutes thus extends far beyond its indeterminate 'sex' in kwépani ceremonies and transcends the whole range of oppositions between the líaka genre, of which it is a member, and mádzerunái, of which it is also a member only in a different sense.

Molítu flute performances in kwépani ceremonies also referred specifically to the déetu flute performances of the late-night, transitional period of pudáli. In both cases, the meaning of the performance was the same at the highest level: to ask for fermented drinks. Of course, within each of the

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two ceremonial contexts, the manner of asking for drinks worked in opposite ways. However, this opposition is transcended when molítu frogs are treated as a symbol that is equally associated with both contexts, that is both a Kuwái flute of the líaka genre and a child of Káali (Káaliéni) like the dance-music of pudáli. Molítu frogs acted as a meta-symbolic code in kwépani that coordinated situationally-defined meanings in opposing ritual and ceremonial contexts.

Déetu flute performances in pudáli ceremonies also had coordinating effects on the symbolic opposition between mádzerunái and líaka genres of ceremonial music. In déetu performances, guest men `asked' for fermented drinks from their hosts by using their flutes to imitate the sucking, eating behavior of shiny black, adult déetu insects. Beyond their more direct association with the shaman's activities of sucking and vomitting, the déetu flutes also symbolized the end result of a natural process of metamorphosis through which the shiny black déetu bugs miraculously emerge out of their immature forms as oily, white grubs of the ceje palm (mútsi). The entire life cycle of déetu bugs is centered around the ceje palm (Jessenia bataua). When a number of the trees are cut down in preparation for kwépani ceremonies or an initiation ritual, the déetu bugs arrive within minutes to suck up the oily sap and to deposit and fertilize their eggs in the soft, inner pith of the felled ceje logs. A by-product from the harvesting of ceje fruits for kwépani was a harvestable supply of protein in the form of white mútsi

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grubs that hatched and grew to edible size in less than one month. When fried or roasted in their own juices, mútsi puffed up into a crunchy meal that was traditionally regarded as a special culinary treat. If not harvested within about six weeks, mútsi grubs left their 'nest' in the rotting ceje logs and metamorphosized into mature déetu bugs, and the whole cycle repeated itself. The déetu flute performances evoked imagery of the whole life cycle through imitating the mature insects' sucking of sweet juices, for precisely the moment of sucking ceje sap is the time when déetu bugs produce and fertilize eggs to create a new generation of mútsi grubs. In other words, the sucking of fermented drinks by déetu flute players in pudáli ceremonies was an action that simultaneously communicated a reversal of the food/feces process and sexual reproduction based on metamorphosis.

The ceje palm is the external womb or nest in which déetu bugs deposit their fertilized eggs and provides both food and shelter for the young, developing mútsi grubs. In kwépani, men traditionally dressed themselves in crowns of ceje palm leaves and hung bunches of ceje fruit down their backs, thus symbolically equating their bodies with the trunks of ceje palms. They also wore sweet-smelling grasses in their headdresses. The symbolism of attractive male body smells in kwépani ambiguously referred to two processes, one natural and the other mythical. On the one hand, making the smell of men's bodies attractive referred to the natural attraction of déetu bugs to the sweet sap of ceje palms when

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felled for harvesting (and thus also to the déetu flute performances of pudáli). On the other hand, the men made their bodies smell attractively to invite Kuwái into the village. In myth, Iñápirríkuli lured Kuwái into his village by sending up a messenger who brought mútsi grubs to him, and the smell of the grubs was so irresistible to Kuwái that he agreed to come down to Iñápirríkuli's village even though he knew that to do so would mean his death. The dual symbolism of male bodies in kwépani ceremonies connected Kuwái with the déetu bug: both were attracted to the ceje palm, one by the smell of mútsi grubs and the other by the smell of sweet, oozing sap. The Kuwái-déetu ambiguity also hints at a later development in kwépani, the re-enactment of Kuwái's eating of Máarinárièni in tsépani. For if Kuwái is in a sense equivalent to the déetu insects, then his overpowering desire to eat mútsi grubs is also a wish to eat his own offspring. The metamorphosis of the ceje palm grub is thus a coordinating process of symbolization that transcends the opposition between eating and reproductive processes. At the same time, the metamorphosis of mútsi into déetu and back again also serves as a model for coordinating the oppositions between the presexual and the sexual and between discontinuous and continuous processes of change.

The metamorphosis of mútsi grubs into déetu bugs and back again also links déetu flute performances of pudáli to the molítu flute performances of kwépani in a more specific way. The name of Amáru's home in myth, Mútsipáni, means

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`dance of the mútsi grubs'. Mútsipáni is where Amáru and the women danced with Kuwái's flutes before Iñápirríkuli and his kinsmen, disguised as molítu frogs, came and took the flutes of Kuwái away from them. This confrontation, or juxtaposition, of mútsi grubs and molítu frogs in myth expresses a quadruple ambiguity: at that mythical moment, molítu as a symbol of collective male control of Kuwái and as Káaliéni collided with mútsi as a symbol of female control and prototype of déetu. The mythical confrontation of molítu and mútsi resulted in the transformation from female-controlled mútsi dances (Mútsipáni) into male-owned dances of Kuwái (Kwépani).

Líaka and mádzerunái form part of a musical performance system that both clearly recognizes an opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change and symbolically coordinates this opposition at the highest level. This level, symbolically encoded in the metamorphosis of the ceje grub, resolves the paradoxical juxtaposition of childhood growth and death in kwépani through a collapsing of the opposition between alimentary and reproductive processes. The metamorphosis of the ceje palm grub also suggests an answer to the paradoxical conclusion that the collective return to a presexual, precultural past in pudáli resulted in a harmonizing of, or breaking down of the dichotomy between, affinally-related groups rather than a re-entry into the violent conflicts between kin and affine of the distant mythical past. Through the interlocking ambiguity of per-

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formances on non-sexed *déetu* and *molítu* flutes, *pudáli* was bound together with *kwépani*, the conceptual principles implicit in the Kuwái myth cycle, and the two-fold movement from a natural, social chaos to a sacred, cosmological order.

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1. Traditional pudáli ceremonies among the Wakuénai starkly contrasted with the food-exchange ceremony mentioned by Reichel-Dolmatoff (1971: 237). "With laughter and violent gestures, the men then penetrate into the maloca of the hosts carrying smoked meat and pursue the women and girls, attempting to strike them over their backs with the meat. In this manner woman-exchange is shown in the symbolic enactment of sexual aggression." The Desana and other Tukano-speaking groups of the Northwest Amazon region practice wife-raiding and either real or mock conflicts between wife-takers and the bride's kinsmen. Wakuénai brideservice was almost a reversal of Desana marriage customs insofar as it placed far more social weighting on the wife-giving group's rights to evaluate prospective sons-in-law and decide if they were acceptable.
2. I am not sure if mabe (Astrostydium schomburgkii, alma de cerbatana) is used as a marker for choosing agricultural plots in the forest but have only the indirect evidence that mabe is harvested from new garden lands prior to cutting high vegetation. Given the use of mabe to make Káali's flutes, I suspect that mabe palms might serve an ecological purpose in selecting new sites for manioc gardens.
3. Traditional stomping tubes (wáana) were made from a broad-leaved species of cecropia called kéwikáni (Cur-

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ricarro dialect) by burning out the center. The tree was considered ready for use in wáana construction when it began to flower. The burning-out process was long and slow compared to the overnight soaking of mabe logs to make flutes of the mádzerunái genre. Although I observed wáana made from kéwikáni in a dance festival held along the Rio Negro, the tubes had not been fully hollowed out at the time of the festival, and their sound was not at all loud or musical. Along the lower Guainía, the men claimed that the variety of cecropia called kéwikáni does not naturally grow, so they improvised wáana made from thick bamboo trunks with the septa removed. These instruments made a fairly loud sound, and each produced a slightly different bass tone according to its dimensions. The tubes are generally about 1 m in length and 15 cm in diameter, but sizes vary according to the heights of men's and boys' waists and the natural thickness of the bamboo logs.

4. Matos Arvelo has vividly documented the tradition of drinking yaraque (fermented drinks) and vomitting in a Wakuénai (Curripaco) ceremony. "Mas apenas ha devuelto el envase a su dueña, diciéndole también: "ája", cuando rapidamente se volte e introduciéndose el dedo índice hasta la garganta, expele en vários vómitos consecutivos todo el yaraque tomado; y vuelve. . . a receibir la segunda totuma, cuyo contenido, también,

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apura para vomitarlo en seguida" (1912:176). ("But hardly had the vessel been returned to its owner, saying to her also: "Yes" [Curripaco dialect], when it is rapidly returned and, sticking his index finger into his throat, he [the guest] vomits several times until all the yaraque is expelled, and he returns. . . to receive a second gourd-dipper, the contents of which he also hurries to vomit up soon thereafter." Translation mine.) Nowadays, the only remaining trace of this custom is a code of politeness surrounding the acceptance of an alcoholic drink: to refuse is to socially reject the donor.

5. I will not discuss all six wáana songs (three before taking the food off the dance plaza and three after) here, partly for reasons of space and partly because I do not have full-length recordings of all six songs. Figure 9.7 shows the melody of wáana songs, and there are no variations on this melodic theme throughout the six songs. All complete verses which I was able to record are included in Figure 9.7.

6. The man's coughing is an action that implies sorcery, or poisoning with mahnéti. A person who eats poisoned food is believed to cough and make choking sounds because the hair-like mahnéti poison is caught in his or her throat.

7. American Protestant missionaries of the New Tribes Mis-

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sion discouraged and prohibited their converts among the Wakuénai from preparing fermented fruit and manioc drinks and have substituted a non-alcoholic beverage for use as 'wine' in Communion. However, the disruption of traditional Wakuénai fermentation methods has led to the opposite effect from what the New Tribes missionaries had envisioned. Young people no longer have knowledge of traditional fermentation methods and have turned to drinking cheap, bottled rum made in Brazil and Colombia. Alcoholism is becoming a very serious problem in some villages (including Evangelical ones) along the lower Guainía and in towns like Maroa and San Carlos, at least in part because traditional, milder beverages have been replaced by modern, high-proof liquors. In San Carlos, where the National Guard outlawed a traditional Baré still some 20 years ago, the problem has reached crisis proportions in recent years: five young men died of excessive drinking in the latter half of 1981, and many others spend most of their time in drunkenness.

8. According to men in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán, they had performed kwépani in the village (without guests) in February and June of 1981. Unfortunately, I did not arrive in Gavilán until July due to a problem of access to the field in March through June.

9. Matos Arvelo (1912:180) has described the behavior of

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women secluded inside a separate house during traditional kwépani ceremonies but without reference to molítu flutes. According to him, pregnant women inside the house acted out the process of childbirth even if the time of partition was still weeks or months away, believing that their 'rehearsal' in kwépani would act in combination with the music of the sacred flutes of Kuwái to make their eventual labor pains as slight as possible and to prevent any other complications at birth. Other women grated manioc tubers inside their house in the belief that their work would be easier in the future. "Todas las mujeres, pués, aprovechan tan bella ocasión para hacer en pequeño sus próximos trabajos con la arraigada creencia de que con esa formula sus faenas venideras serán faciles y beneficiosas" (1912:180). ("All the women thus profitted from the beautiful occasion to perform in miniature their future labors in the deep-rooted belief that their up-coming tasks would be easy and beneficial by following such a procedure." Translation mine.)

10. In myth, the three boys eat guaco fruits that Kuwái has allowed to fall into their seclusion hut. In the song of tsépani, the verses refer to kérapúkurri as the food eaten by Máarinárièni that caused Kuwái to eat him. According to Wright (1982, personal communication), this ambiguity refers to a parallel ambiguity in the more

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detailed variant of the Kuwái myth cycle narrated to him by the Hohodene of the Aiari River in Brazil.

11. In Beyond the Milky Way (1978:24), Reichel-Dolmatoff includes photographs of traditional Wakuénai (Curripaco) pottery as evidence of his theory that indigenous visual arts in the Northwest Amazon region all made use of designs related to hallucinogenic drug experiences and phosphene patterns in visual perception. While I am impressed by the beauty of painting shown in these photographs of Wakuénai and Tukanoan pottery, I very strongly doubt that the designs on Wakuénai pottery were in any way related to hallucinogenic drug use, since the Wakuénai and other Arawak-speaking groups of the region do not practice any collective hallucinogenic drug use in their ceremonies. Only shamans used hallucinogens among the Wakuénai, and then only in the form of virola snuff rather than the more powerful Tukanoan concoctions based on banisteriopsis caapi.

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Chapter 10:

"Structuralism and History: Wakuénai Musical Performances and the Emergent Cultural Identity"

Introduction

In this concluding chapter, I will take a wider historical perspective of the musical performance system of the Wakuénai in order to explore its role in the perpetuation of traditional modes of categorization and in an emerging, pan-Arawakan cultural identity in the Venezuelan Amazon. The first goal is to examine how traditional musical performances have contributed to structural reproduction, or the maintenance of "structures of the long run" (Sahlins 1981: 9-ff). This endeavor will include some comparison of Wakuénai ritual specialists with those of other Amazonian societies and an evaluation of certain historical and geographical circumstances that allowed the Wakuénai to successfully incorporate historical events in their traditional cosmology without effecting any major transformation up until the last few decades. The second goal is to determine some of the major factors of the post-WW II years that have led to a reordering process that, although unfolding through traditional modes of categorization and structural reproduction, has at the same time transformed them. The Wakuénai of

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Venezuela provide some concrete, ethnographic answers to the more general problem which Sahlins has posed in the question, "How does the reproduction of a structure become its transformation?" (1981: 8).

Concepts of Time and Change in Amazonian Societies

That the Wakuénai have perpetuated many traditional processes of categorization throughout the three centuries of historical contact with non-indigenous societies does not imply that they are incapable of transforming their traditional cultural identity and therefore doomed to assimilation and extinction. Sahlins (1976, 1981) has noted that the characteristic mode of interpreting and responding to historical events among traditional Pacific Island societies has been to place these events into mythical, ritual frameworks of space-time from the very beginning of contact with literate societies. This interpretive process is based on a long tradition of cultural variation among societies of the same region rather than the sort of cumulative, internal variation that characterizes our own and other societies with a written historical record.

> "History is always structured by society: there are only more or less dynamic modes of effecting this. Nor do the principles of historical structuration differ so much in kind as locus. The tribal peoples are capable of the very same transpositions and reformulations of the symbolic code, the generation of new op-

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> positions out of old -- only there it goes on mainly between societies and so appears as simple variation, whereas here it goes on within the one system and thus presents a compounded growth ("development")" (Sahlins 1976: 220).

The tendency of nonliterate societies toward reciprocal, egalitarian social relations and continuity, or stability, does not mean that such societies are inevitably or invariable `cold' or that "time depth is a notion that Amerindians tend to avoid and even war against as a principle dangerous to their own social existence" (Kaplan 1981: 151)[1]. To say this is to deny these societies any sense of historical, discontinuous processes of change and, by the same token, to deny them any future in a world dominated by societies that possess a written historical record. If indigenous Amazonian societies are viewed as `cold', or frozen, structures incapable of their own form of cultural and historical development, then it follows that they must all be smashed to bits like so many glass objects or `melted' in the boiling-pot histories of the developing and developed nations.

The time-reckoning methods of Ge-speaking societies in Central Brazil show that even the most flexible, egalitarian societies of the Amazon Basin possess concepts of historical time. Maybury-Lewis found that the Shavante age-set and initiation systems served as a model for the passing of time as a discontinuous flow of individuals and events. "Shavante are fully conscious of the cyclical nature of the age-set system

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and will, if pressed, explain that time passes in a series of such cycles, expressing its passage by a series of circles drawn on the ground" (1967: 154). At the time of Maybury-Lewis's fieldwork among the Shavante, their society had as yet had only a very brief period of contact with non-indigenous outsiders, and they displayed a nearly total lack of interest in historical time even though they had a means for expressing it. Their main interest was in seniority and relative age within each local group and in the coordination of this relative sense of time among a number of widely-dispersed communities.

> "It is a curious fact that, in spite of the absence of tribal ceremonial or even of consultations on an intercommunity level, age-sets throughout Shavante-land seem to be at approximately the same stage of the age-set cycle at any given moment" (Maybury-Lewis 1967: 155).

Shavante time-reckoning thus illustrated in very clear terms that the primary locus of historical change in indigenous Amazonian societies was in variation between societies. Within each society, there was little interest in expressing the passage of historical time, although such expressions were not unknown.

Through increased contact with non-indigenous peoples, societies like the Shavante have learned to take a greater interest in the passage of historical time even as they have retained a primary concern for relatively short periods of

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time embodied in concrete natural phenomena and cosmological ideas. Seeger has documented the Suya practice of differentiating an ambiguous concept of "in the past" according to historical events.

> "The historic events used by the Suya to date other events include village sites (where the Suya were living when a certain event occurred), the massacre of the Suya by the Juruna and their rubber tapper allies, and the peaceful contact made by the Villas Boas brothers, which marked the start of their association with non-Indians" (1981: 61).

The study of time-reckoning among Ge-speaking and other Amazonian societies that have only entered into permanent relations with non-Indians in the latter half of this century is important for understanding the "special capacity to absorb perturbations introduced by the event with a minimum of systematic deformation" (Sahlins 1976: 23). Among the Wakuénai and other indigenous societies of the Northwest Amazon region, this process has gone on for almost three centuries.

The traditional musical performance system of the Wakuénai gave concrete expression to the opposing concepts of time as a continuous process of structural reproduction and as a discontinuous flow of individuals and events. The two myth cycles of Iñápirríkuli and Kuwái also endowed the Wakuénai with a cultural means for viewing and controlling

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the dialectical opposition between continuous and discontinuous processes of change. However, myth is always negotiable and subject to manipulation according to the varying social situations of its narrators, a fact which the Wakuénai implicitly recognize through the lack of any specialists called 'myth-owners'. Ceremonies (pudáli and kwépani), houses, and sacred songs all have owners (limínali or limínaru; -mnali, -nai(nai)) but not myths. Musical performance has outlived the ceremonial exchange activities of pudáli and kwépani and has weathered the changing contents which individual, historical events have injected into mythical beliefs and texts.

In the remainder of this chapter, I will examine structural dimensions of Wakuénai musical performers and perfomances and some of the historical circumstances that have contributed to the ability of Wakuénai society to withstand a long and violent history of contact with non-Indians with a minimal loss of traditional cultural identity. However, the Wakuénai have experienced a qualitatively distinct type of historical contact with non-Indians in the post-WW II era, and the resulting cultural transformation has become far more radical than a mere transposition or reproduction of past structures with some minor additions. Traditional Wakuénai musical performances are gaining new significance today as a means not only for continuing traditional processes of categorization but also for expressing the cultural identity of various Northern Arawak-speaking societies that together

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share a common cultural and historical heritage. The traditional categorization of experience goes on, but after reaching a certain level of inconsistency, the mythical framework of space-time is itself transformed by historical events.

The Absorption of Historical Events

One way in which Wakuénai ritual specialists have accounted for new technological and environmental realities without disrupting the underlying logic of sacred musical performances is through expanding the category of spirit-names belonging to Amáru, the mythical mother of Kuwái. Steel tools, guns, motors, and other manufactured items are all placed under the category of 'hot things' that belong to Amáru. In childbirth rituals, the málikai-owner puts this category to work in his construction of the metaphorical, internal umbilical cord that binds together the newborn infant (kérramu) and its father (kinénerri) in the first week after birth. In curing rituals, the málikai-owner aims at controlling another 'hot thing' brought to the region by non-Indians, the epidemics of smallpox, measles, colds, flus and other diseases. In this case, the spirit of fever or sickness is envisioned as 'the paper of Amáru' (rupápera sAmáru), and the chant-owner asserts a symbolic control over it in his music by ripping up Amáru's paper with the force of his tobacco smoke. The uses of Amáru's spirits in performances of málikai illustrate how the Wakuénai have grafted 'hot' items of exogenous origins onto the indigenous concept of female

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'heat' (i.e., Amáru's menstruation) as the first step out of natural, social chaos of the presexual past and into a sacred, cultural order. Even the terribly destructive diseases that reached Wakuénai territory in early colonial times are made to fit into the indigenous categorization.

The epidemic diseases that accompanied the penetration of non-Indians into the Amazon Basin have had, and are still today having, devastating consequences not only for the biological survival of indigenous populations but also for their cultural survival as autonomous societies. In many Amazonian societies, shamans are believed to be both curers and killers (sorcerers or witches), and an epidemic can lead to more and more frequent revenge-killings against shamans until the people have eliminated all their ritual specialists (Wagley 1977: 187-90). The Wakuénai have historically undergone the effects of severe epidemics of measles, virola, and other diseases beginning at least as early as the late 18th Century (Wright 1981: 148-54) but have not suffered the same cultural self-destruction through revenge-killings against shamans that has been documented among other Amazonian societies. Wakuénai shamans (malírri) are not generally suspected of killing other people through sorcery, and málikai-owners are still less likely than shamans to be blamed for deaths due to sorcery. If a victim dies during a curing ritual, the curers do not receive any payment but are not held responsible for the death. A measles epidemic had killed an adult man in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán in

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early 1980, yet both types of ritual specialist who live in the village continued to work without interruption or fear of recrimination as soon as the epidemic had subsided. The only type of traditional specialist whose powers were believed to attack innocent as well as guilty persons were the master shamans, or dzáwináitairi, and this type of specialist is rapidly disappearing among the Wakuénai today even as the other classes of specialist continue to perform ritual cures and traditional rites of passage.

The geographical location of Wakuénai territory also contributed to the ability "to absorb perturbations introduced by the events of history with a minimum of systematic deformation" (Sahlins 1976: 23). Wakuénai territory centers along the Isana and Guainía rivers and their tributaries, and today these two rivers form internatonal boundaries between Brazil, Colombia, and Venezuela. Throughout the 18th, 19th, and early 20th Centuries, the dispersion of Wakuénai sibs and phratries in three countries was adaptively advantageous insofar as the groups could temporarily migrate out of the path of danger and return in a later generation to live on their sacred ancestral lands. Wright (1981) has documented this strategy of migratory flight and return in response to Brazilian descimentos (forced labor campaigns) and guerras de rescate (hostage or revenge warfare) of the late 18th and 19th Centuries. In addition, the strategy was employed as a means for escaping epidemic diseases coming from downstream along the Rio Negro.

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"Hohodene oral histories tell of a great epidemic in the past from which many people fled up the Rio Negro" (Wright 1981: 152). Permanent villages and lands along the main channels of the Isana or Guainía were quickly abandoned for hunting and fishing camps located in safer areas surrounded by impenetrable forests and swamps[2] that lay beyond one or two international borders from the source of danger. During the 1920s, Wakuénai groups living along the lower Guainía fled from the terrorism of the Funes regime up the Guainía and its tributaries, such as the Tomo and Aki, that extend almost to the Cuyarí and Xié rivers in Brazil. Other Arawakan societies, including the Baré, Baniwa, Mandahuaca, and Yavitero, whose native territories happened to lie predominantly or exclusively within Venezuela, suffered almost total annihilation during the Funes regime of terror. The rise and fall of the rubber baron turned dictator, Tomas Funes, was the culmination of Rubber Boom politics that decimated whole indigenous societies almost overnight.

In spite of a long history of rubber trading in the region, the picture of Wakuénai and other Arawak-speaking societies along the lower Guainía at the end of the last century was one of relatively successful adjustment to historical events. Matos Arvelo (1912) portrayed a cluster of Arawak-speaking societies that were still very much 'alive' in the vicinity of Maroa during his term as Prefect there. By that time, the Wakuénai had cultivated a profound sense of distrust for non-Indians that extended even to the moral

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teachings given to male initiants as ritual advice.

> "The White men are thieves who buy our wares cheap and sell their merchandise to us at high prices. That is why they are rich and we are poor. Know that the Whites are your enemies. Hide your hate because it's strong and treat the Whites with distrust because they are traitors" (Matos Arvelo 1912: 86, translation mine[3]).

Messianic movements of the 19th Century are still commemorated in legends and a shrine on the Aki River honoring Venancio Cristo, a Baniwa prophet who led the Wakuénai of Brazil in an uprising against White rule in the 1860s (Wright 1981, vol. 1). The messianic movements and other cultural expressions antagonistic to non-Indians reinforced rather than undermined traditional religious beliefs and practice, but they differed from the more general strategy of maintaining cultural and geographical distance from the non-Indians insofar as they led to confrontation with the superior military forces of the White men and certain defeat. For the most part, however, the Wakuénai managed to resolve the 'heat' of historical events by avoiding open confrontations with non-Indians and making distrust of the 'enemy' a secret moral obligation. The traditional ancestor cult persisted in traditional style and also as a cult of historical opposition to non-Indian intruders.

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Boundaries and Missionaries

Historical events qualitatively changed during the second Rubber Boom of the 1940s. Among other things, the search for natural rubber supplies during World War II meant the building of a new road into Wakuénai territory from the Colombian side. The War also brought attention to the strategic value of the Amazon as a tropical route to North Africa and Asia that avoided the dangerous North Atlantic Ocean, and all three nations with territory in the Northwest Amazon region began taking a more serious interest in developing their frontiers. Administrative, military, and economic institutions multiplied and pervaded the region, and the borders between Venezuela, Brazil, and Colombia soon became obstacles to the mobility and survival of Wakuénai sibs instead of an adaptive safety-mechanism for escaping external dangers. The two principal rivers of Wakuénai territory, the Isana and the Guainía, have turned into international boundaries in the modern, space age sense. Now each group must choose which country it will formally join, even if their village is ambiguously situated on an island (as is Gavilán) half-way between the shores of two countries. The tightening of international boundaries has led to greater interethnic marriage with other Indian societies in each of the three countries because traditional alliances among the various Wakuénai phratries criss-crossed the two formerly open boundary lines.

Since the late 1940s, American Protestant missionaries

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affiliated with the New Tribes Mission (and other Evangelical organizations) have worked among the Wakuénai in all three countries and have used their influence among converted Indians as a weapon for systematically destroying Wakuénai social rules and cultural beliefs and practices. The missionaries prohibited brideservice and cross-cousin marriage among their converts and declared all marriages with non-Evangelical Indians to be evil and against the divine will of God. These traditional marriage customs had been key components in the balancing of reciprocal and hierarchical social relations, and their demise essentially undermined respectful behavior and attitudes between affinally-related sib groups. At the same time, the New Tribes missionaries worked to ostracize the remaining Wakuénai ritual specialists who chose not to accept the new faith[4] and mounted a campaign to subvert beliefs in the efficacy of traditional ritual symbols, such as sacred music and tobacco, and mediums of ceremonial exchange, such as dancing and fermented drinks.

In the last decade, the missionaries' strategy has taken two major steps to further undermine the traditional leadership of ritual specialists and other elders in Wakuénai society: the establishment of new missions in semi-urban areas outside of Wakuénai territory and publication of the New Testament in the Curripaco dialect. The new missions are located near towns, such as San Fernando de Atabapo, and are inducing Wakuénai families to migrate out of their villages along the frontier and into more urbanized communities. At

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the same time, the missionaries have continued to use indigenous pastors and other converts among the Wakuénai to harass and threaten non-Evangelical Indians in particular and, through periodic leafleting and word-of-mouth broadcasting, to destabilize the indigenous population of the entire region with gloomy prophecies to the effect that the world is due to end in 1983. Evangelical Indians, the self-proclaimed pastors of the new faith, are trained to constantly monitor the activities of the few groups of people who have obstinately refused to join in the cultural suicide. The pastors are in the habit of reading out loud from their Bibles on visits to non-Evangelical villages, always eager to convey `Dona Sofia's' wisdom on the absolute evilness of shamans and chant-owners, or smoking tobacco and dancing.

The translation of the New Testament in Curripaco is contradictory to Wakuénai religious principles even without all the political maneuvering of the missionaries and their obedient followers. The transition to a written mythical system from an oral one elevates myth to the level of a non-negotiable, fixed reality, at least in the eyes of pious believers in the `literal' Truth of the New Testament or of people in a nonliterate society who have not even been shown the minimal courtesy of writing down some of their own cultural texts in their own language before being hit over the head with a religious text lifted out of entirely different cultural and historical contexts. A literalist, Christian faith denies the validity of traditional Wakuénai

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beliefs in the creative and transformative powers of Kuwái's music as manifested in performances by experienced ritual specialists. Beliefs in the efficacy of Kuwái's music are grounded in the ability to symbolically collapse the distinctions between the body of Kuwái and his musical instruments and between the growth and transformation of Kuwái and the chant-owner's voice. Each childbirth is equated in sacred málikai chants with the growth and expansion of the entire cosmos out of a long presexual, precultural past in which there were no differences between human and animal beings. Malikai songs and chants of initiation rituals equate each male or female initiant with the sum total of his or her ancestors' cultural and historical experience as adult individuals who suffered the pain of separation from their kinsmen in order to uphold the moral laws of brideservice, exogamy, and patrilocality. Kuwái's music contains within itself the 'heat' of cooking fire, hot pepper, burnt tobacco, and the kadápu whip. The missionaries have translated the New Testament into one of the Wakuénai dialects and taught a literalist interpretation of the Bible that pretends to freeze out any historical understanding. Ironically, the missionaries rather than the Wakuénai are more appropriately characterized by the "kind of thinking . . . typical of a Levi-Straussian 'cold' society'" (Kaplan 1981: 159).

The Fragmentation of Wakuénai Society

The missionary policy of encouraging interethnic marriages so long as both the bride's and groom's families were

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Protestant has gone hand in hand with the breakdown of Wakuénai phratries and sibs into three different cultural identities. The three emerging identities are best seen as different cultural orientations leading to different directions of historical change rather than as social groups. Villages representing each of the three orientations are located today along the lower Guainía, Casiquiare, and San Miguel rivers in Venezuela, but there are distinct linguistic and cultural reasons promoting a far greater level of social interaction and cohesion within each of the three cultural identities than among them. The three identities roughly correspond to the three national territories among which Wakuénai lands are divided and to the other indigenous societies in each of the theee countries with whom the missionaries have encouraged the Wakuénai to intermarry.

The Yeral/Wakuénai, or Southern Wakuénai, identity consists primarily of Yeral-speaking Indians who are intermarried with the Wakuénai.In the great majority of cases, Yeral-speaking men are married to Wakuénai women, indicating a potentially assymetrical relationship of wife-taker to more highly `ranked´ wife-givers between the two groups. Many of the Yeral-speakers were formerly members of Wakuénai sibs along the lower Isana river, but others are descendants of Tukano-speaking groups or caboclo (mestizo) families. Both patrilocal and uxorilocal residence are common in Yeral/Wakuénai villages. The most strongly patrilocal villages are as a rule the most strongly Evangelical Christian, whereas

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the nominally Catholic villages display a mixture, sometimes uneasy and sometimes balanced, or patri- and uxorilocal marriages. The Yeral-speakers in general have little or no concept of traditional Wakuénai attitudes and behavior of social respect between affinal kinsmen, nor of the deep-seated Wakuénai belief that non-Indians are untrustworthy, except in a very few cases. Wakuénai fathers-in-law still expect deference from their sons-in-law, in spite of the fact that traditional brideservice customs are no longer observed. Conflicts between senior Wakuénai men and their Yeral-speaking sons-in-law arise from opposing views of marriage customs and affinal relations. Traditional Tukanoan views on marriage are derived from the traditional practice of wife-raiding and ceremonial aggression between affinal kinsmen, and such behavior is unthinkable to the Wakuénai except in terms of precultural social animals of the distant mythical past. For the most part, Yeral/Wakuénai villages are clustered around the mouth of the Casiquiare River and nearby areas along the Negro-Guainía River. The Yeral/Wakuénai identity is difficult to generalize about because Yeral-speakers are a very diverse category of indigenous and semi-indigenous people, Tukano and Arawak descendants, and Evangelical and Catholic affiliates.

The Puinave/Curripaco, or Northern Wakuénai, identity consists of Curripaco-speaking sibs from the upper Guainía (e.g., Adzanéni, Tokédakéna, and Móriwéni) intermarried with sibs of the Waríperídakéna phratry from the Cuyarí River and with other Arawak-speaking groups from the region of the In-

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irida and Guaviare rivers immediately to the north of Wakuénai lands on the upper Guainía. Puinave and, to a lesser extent Piapoco, are the most important of these other Arawakan societies, but the amount of intermarriage with Wakuénai is difficult to judge, since only two or three villages representative of this cultural orientation are living in the Casiquiare and lower Guainía region of Venezuela. Also, Puinave and Piapoco men and women married to Wakuénai spouses have become Curripaco-speakers and teach their children to speak this dialect so that they can be instructed in the teachings of the New Testament as translated by Sophia Muller. Puinave/Curripaco villages are strongly Evangelical, and their principal objective is to seek social isolation from both neighboring, non-Evangelical Indians and the Catholic criollo population who inhabit the towns of the region[5]. Their villages are located in remote sites along the Casiquiare and San Miguel rivers, far away from the main channel of the Negro-Guainía River and closer to the New Tribes Mission headquarters at Tamatama on the Orinoco River.

The third cultural identity consists of a variety of Wakuénai sibs that formerly belonged to the Dzáwinai, Ádzanéni, and Waríperídakéna phratries and that today are in the process of creating new social ties with Guarequena and Baniwa neighbors along the lower Guainía in Venezuela. For lack of another name for this cultural identity, I will call it the Eastern Wakuénai to distinguish it from the other two identities. The Eastern Wakuénai have maintained a more

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traditional sense of social and cultural diversity among themselves and have not extensively intermarried with their Baniwa and Guarequena neighbors. They are more traditional in their linguistic variation as well and include about even numbers of Curripaco and Curricarro-speakers together with a smaller number of the "Óh-hon" dialect from the Cuyarí region. They live in villages along the lower Guainía between Maroa and the mouth of the Casiquiare River and are interspersed with small Baniwa settlements and the large Guarequena village of Sebucán. Their current territory thus overlaps that of the Baniwa and Guarequena, and the three Arawak-speaking societies share access to hunting and fishing resources along the San Miguel and other, smaller tributaries of the lower Guainía. Although there is still a lingering sense of hostility among some Baniwa families of the area who feel that the Eastern Wakuénai are immigrants 'squatting' on Baniwa lands, for the most part there is an understanding that the Wakuénai inhabited the lower Guainía in past historical eras (prior to the Funes dictatorship of the 1920s) and that they have merely returned over the past 30 years to reclaim their traditional rights. Beyond sharing of ecological resources, the Eastern Wakuénai have become the focus of an emerging, Arawak-speaking cultural identity through participation of Baniwa, Guarequena, and the Wakuénai themselves in traditional Wakuénai rituals and ceremonial dance-music.

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The Wakuénai Musical Performance System: An Indigenous Model for Historical Change

The Wakuénai musical performance system has survived the social fragmentation of recent decades relatively intact among the Eastern Wakuénai and is currently the driving force in the formation of a pan-Arawakan cultural identity in the Venezuelan Amazon. The traditional beliefs in music as a creative, transformative agent in the shaping of natural and social phenomena into a cultural order have taken on new meaning in their present cultural and historical contexts. The sacred chants and songs of málikai-owners and shamans are more than simply a perpetuation of traditional classificatory processes; they are also an expression of a cultural history shared by Wakuénai, Guarequena, and Baniwa alike. Ceremonial exchanges of food have disappeared along with changes in traditional marriage customs such as brideservice, yet the dance-music of pudáli is becoming increasingly important as a key symbolic medium for expressing the new cultural identity. The power of málikai-owners and shamans is gaining renewed respect, even among the staunchest Indian supporters of Evangelical Christian faith, and there is a movement away from Evangelical Christianity among the Southern and Eastern Wakuénai of the lower Guainía region today.

As one village headman explained to me, "People believed the missionaries when they came and said that all shamans are devils, but now they are beginning to realize that this is a lie. The shamans do many good thing for people and can cure

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them." The revitalization of Wakuénai shamanism is taking place at the same time in history that shamanism is disappearing among the Guarequena and Baniwa. In the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán, Baniwa and Guarequena families from Maroa, Sebucan, and other settlements as far away as the Upper Orinoco came for ritual treatment of medical problems during the time of my fieldwork. Thus, the performance of málikai and málirríkairi music by Wakuénai chant-owners and shamans is a way of articulating interethnic ties with other Arawakan groups of the region who have retained much of their traditional belief systems but no longer have any active religious practitioners.

The shaman's curing songs (málirríkairi) are more than a reliving of the painful separation of the two parts of a patient's, or victim's, soul, for in his songs the shaman travels to the collective homes of recently-deceased lidánam souls in íyarudáti. The houses belonging to each sib are believed to have definite geographical locations within the native territory of the phratry. The social fragmentation of recent decades has resulted in a collective separation of the majority of Wakuénai phratries and sibs from their native territories. Shamanistic curing songs today have taken on this new sense of expressing collective separation from sacred ancestral lands at the same time as they perpetuate traditional beliefs in the fate of individual, human body-shaped souls (likáriwa) after death. The shaman's musical journeys to the houses of recently deceased lidánam souls in

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<u>íyarudáti</u> are at one and the same time a way of organizing and communicating the experience of pain suffered by afflicted individuals and an historical metaphor for the collective suffering of a people (or peoples) who have lost social and political control over their own lands but who have nevertheless refused to give up symbolic control.

The shaman's musical journey as historical metaphor transcends traditional social and linguistic differences among the Wakuénai, Guarequena, and Baniwa, for all these Arawak-speaking societies have experienced a historical removal from their respective native territories in one form or another. Guarequena history is strikingly parallel to that of the Wakuénai, only for them the separation from native lands happened in the 19th Century.

> "The Arekena (Uarekena, Arequena, Uerequena, Guariquena) lived originally on the Icana and Xié Rivers (lat.2^0 n., long.67^0 - 68^0 W.) but were subsequently removed by missionaries in the middle of the 19th century" (Goldman 1948: 767).

While there is not any similar evidence suggesting that the Baniwa experienced such a removal from their lands, a comparison of the ethnographic description of Baniwa society provided by Matos Arvelo (1912) with their current situation leaves little doubt that they underwent a swift and terrible 'de-structuration' in the intervening period, probably in the 1920s during the Funes dictatorship.

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The musical journey of Kuwáikanérri in curing songs performed by málikai-owners is not so much an historical metaphor as the affirmation of a mythical reality, of the sacred unity of Wakuénai territories extending from the area of São Gabriel near the confluence of the Vaupés and Negro Rivers up to the headwaters of the Icana and Guainía Rivers in the north and up to the headwaters of the Cayarí River in the south and west. The area covered by Kuwáikanérri's mythical voyage with Iñápirríkuli overlaps with native Guarequena territory along the lower Icana and Xié Rivers and with Baniwa lands along the Guainía River. The málikai-owner's musical reconstruction of this journey symbolically asserts the continuity of mythical ties linking together not only the various Wakuénai phratries but also the Arawak-speaking societies whose native lands bordered on, and to some extent overlapped with, those of the Wakuénai phratries[6]. The musical journey of the málikai-owner in curing songs places the contemporary situation of Guarequena, Baniwa, and Wakuénai people living in Venezuela into the framework of an ancient mythical reality in which the gathering together of members from these Arawakan societies is only the most recent enactment of a continuous process that had gone on for centuries prior to the disruptive events of more recent historical times.

The participation of Guarequena and Baniwa families in childbirth rituals performed by Wakuénai málikai-owners is a further demonstration of how traditional Wakuénai music can

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act to establish a common mythical reality in which these three Arawak-speaking socieities are seen as part of a continuous process of creation. The málikai chants for childbirth connect Baniwa and Guarequena ritual participants not only with the mythical expansion of the world according to the sacred principles of Kuwái's singing and humming but also to the mythical emergence of Wakuénai sib ancestor spirits in the distant past of Iñápirríkuli. For the ancestor spirits of Baniwa and Guarequena are said to have emerged from the same place as the ancestors of Wakuénai sibs, only they did not receive male and female tobacco spirits at that time because Iñápirríkuli had given all these spirits away to Wakuénai sib ancestor spirits that had already emerged from the ground. Accordingly, the málikai-owner names the spirit of "White man's tobacco" in his chants for the newborn son of Baniwa and Guarequena parents and explains that the Baniwa and Guarequena, like non-Indians, only received tobacco spirit from Iñápirríkuli in more recent times. Malikai chants performed in childbirth rituals thus place the Baniwa and Guarequena into a mythical framework in which Iñápirríkuli created these two groups as part of a continuous process of emergence that had started with Wakuénai sibs and phratries. However, by identifying Baniwa and Guarequena tobacco spirits as a more recent phenomenon linked to the historical arrival of non-Indians, the chants outline a complex process in which the mythical continuity of Wakuénai, Guarequena, and Baniwa emergence took place through the historical dislocations ex-

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perienced by the three societies.

Wakuénai ceremonial music of the mádzerunái genre (dance-music of the pudáli ceremony) has also taken on new significance as the expression of an emerging, pan-arawakan cultural identity in the Venezuelan Amazon. The instrumental music of this genre crosses linguistic and social boundaries with greater facility than sacred vocal music of the málikai and málirríkairi genres which only Wakuénai specialists know how to perform. The Guarequena and Baniwa both had traditional instruments with nearly identical construction and symbolism as the Wakuénai flutes called máwi, tsikóta, and déetu, the kúlirína trumpets, wáana dance stomping tubes, kutírru dance-rattles, and maváku and píti whistle-flutes. Even many Yeral-speaking groups, none of whom had shamans or other ritual specialists, know how to construct and play Arawakan musical instruments. Like everything else, the instruments have been renamed in Yeral: máwi flutes are called yapurútu, kúlirína trumpets are surubí (the Yeral term denoting the species of large catfish called kulírri in Wakuénai dialects), and wáana stomping tubes are umbaíwa ("pestle").

The kúlirína trumpet is the most complex instrument of the mádzerunái genre, both in terms of its material construction and the symbolism of its construction and sounds. The construction of five of these instruments in the Dzáwinai village of Gavilán brought together a large number of Baniwa, Guarequena, and Wakuénai groups of the lower Guainía region

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and a smaller number of Yeral families. They all came out of a curiosity to hear the kúlirína trumpets and to see them played with máwi flutes in traditional dances named after the bocachico fish species. This amount of attention lavished upon a musical instrument has its roots in the importance of kúlirína trumpets in traditional pudáli cycles as symbols of exchange between affinally-related groups. In the new context, however, the amount of social attention focused upon the trumpets expressed a growing sense of cultural and historical identity shared by all the Arawakan societies of the lower Guainía region, including the Guarequena and Baniwa, various Wakuénai sibs, and even some Yeral-speaking families who are (or claim to be) of Arawakan descent.

The kúlirína trumpet-dances in particular, and dance-music of pudáli in general, act as an indigenous model for historical change because they embody in concrete forms certain basic mythical and historical ideas common to all the Arawakan societies along the lower Guainía in Venezuela. The dance-music of pudáli is a symbolic return to the presexual, undifferentiated mythic past and thus serves as a collective, conceptual point of re-entry into the process of creating a cultural order of individual and collective identities out of natural, social chaos. In traditional pudáli ceremonies, the process was one of breaking down the ceremonial opposition of affinally-related host and guest groups. In current practice, dance-music of pudáli transposes the symbolic process of breaking down collective identities to the relations among a

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number of different Arawak-speaking societies instead of two Wakuénai sib groups belonging to different exogamous phratries. However, the aim of ceremonial musical performances has totally changed insofar as ceremonial gatherings are no longer coordinated with exchanges of food and women but are an expression of a pan-Arawakan cultural identity. The emerging cultural identity rests on social recognition of the historical dislocation and separation that all Arawakan peoples of the region have experienced. Ceremonial dance-music of pudáli, and especially the kúlirína trumpet-dances, are concrete, collective enactments of this social recognition of common cultural and historical origins and a model for the direction of historical change in future generations.

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1. There is even an element of ethnic stereotyping in Kaplan's review article. "This kind of thinking is typical of the ideology of a Levi-Straussian 'cold society'. . . a mythic timeless order is in each generation re-established" (1981:159). Anthropologists working in developing and developed countries need to become more sensitive to the political implications of their research. A static view of indigenous Amazonian societies only plays into the hands of missionaries and other critics who charge that anthropologists are romantic idealists who want to see indigenous societies preserved in pristine, Stone Age conditions.
2. The Wakuénai of the lower Guainía and Casiquiare today maintain remote camps for hunting and fishing along the San Miguel and tributaries of the Casiquiare River. These camps are also seen as refuge areas to which groups living along the main channel of the Guainía can flee in times of epidemics or other dangers.
3. "El yaranabe es un ladrón, que se ha usurpado nuestras tierras y roba nuestro trabajo; él compra barato el producto de nuestra indústria y nos vende caro sus mercancías; y por eso, porque él esta rico y es que nosotros estamos pobres. Cuando tu mires a un blanco estás mirando a un enimigo de tu raza y de tu gente. Disimúlale tu enemistad porque es fuerte y trátale con disconfianza porque es traidor"(Matos Arvelo 1912:86).

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4. Both the Ádzanéni and Dzáwinai villages in which I spent most of my time in the field had been thrown off their ancestral lands by opposing factions of kinsmen who had converted to Evangelical Christianity.

5. The Evangelical Curripaco villages are classic illustrations of the four-stage process of social change developed by Hagen (1962). The process begins with use of violent force by an outside, conquering group and leads through intermediate stages called 'denigration of status values' and 'inconsistency of status values' to reach a final stage called 'non-acceptance in a new society'.

6. The main Arawak-speaking society of the Cayarí River is the Tariana, or Taariéni ("Children of (-éni) the white bocachico (táari) fish), and these people were victims of a guerra de resgate in the 19th Century (see Wright 1981, Vol. 1). The survivors of the massacre have become highly "tukanoized" through intermarriage (Reichel-Dolmatoff 1971:15).

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